

LEARN TO PLAY BRIDGE LIKE A BOSS

MASTER THE FUNDAMENTALS OF BRIDGE QUICKLY AND
EASILY WITH STRATEGIES FROM A SEASONED PRO!

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by H. Anthony Medley



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HOW TO USE THIS eBook

Preferred application settings

For the best reading experience, the following application settings are recommended:

- Color theme: White background
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Introduction

I've played them all, baseball, football, basketball, tennis, golf. Without any question, bridge tops them all. For one thing, you don't have to worry much about spraining ankles, pulling Achilles tendons, getting tennis elbow, or anything like that. I've played poker, gin rummy, canasta, and pinochle. Bridge beats them, too.

While it might not be as physically challenging as the active sports, it keeps your brain cells moving, and as you age that might be more important than your muscles and tendons.

It beats the other card games because bridge is first and foremost a partnership game. You don't play it alone, so it teaches patience, compassion, and how to get along with others.

When you play bridge, all your troubles melt away because you are deep in thought about how to bid and then how to play the hand. Another beauty of bridge is that no two hands are alike. Because they vary, each presents challenges unique to that hand. You often find yourself in a pickle you haven't faced before, but you have to determine how to handle it right then. It's not going to go away.

Be forewarned, however: bridge is an addiction. When you find a partner you like, you'll want to play it more and more. Nowadays, you can even play on the internet. I don't do that much, if at all, because I like the social aspects of the game, getting out with people. It doesn't matter whether you agree on sports, arts, or politics, if they are bridge players, they are comrades. Everything else goes away while you're at the table.

Why This Book Is Different from the Others

This is not your standard “how to play bridge” book. While its basic purpose is to teach you how to easily play the game starting from scratch, what makes it unique is that it doesn’t stop there. It continues from teaching you the basic game to also teaching you advanced techniques used by experts.

Not only will you learn the basic game of “Standard American,” you will also learn “Two Over One,” a system used by many of the best players today. In addition to learning standard bidding and carding techniques, you’ll also learn advanced bidding techniques like “Weak Twos”, “New Minor Forcing”, “Negative Doubles”, “Jacoby Transfers”, “Jacoby Two No Trump”, “Splinters”, and many more advanced methods of communicating with your partner that you won’t find in most basic bridge books.

While learning basic playing techniques like the finesse, you’ll also learn advanced ways to play the cards like “Ducking”, “the Strip and End Play”, and numerous other techniques used by advanced players. It’s all here in one easy-to-read simple book.

Furthermore, most of the hands used in the book are actual hands that I have played, not hands drafted to show a specific point.

How This Book Is Organized

I've broken this book into the following parts:

In **Part 1, Introduction to Bridge**, I offer an easy-to-understand explanation of the game and rules of bridge, introduce you to basic bridge terminology, and teach you how to score. After reading these chapters, you should be able to sit down at the table with three other people and play some hands. Readers who know the basic game may skip these chapters.

Part 2, Opening Bids, focuses exclusively on the opening bidder, the first person to make a bid. The chapters in this part tell you how to evaluate your hand in order to determine whether or not you should be the first bidder and describe the different ways you can open the bidding.

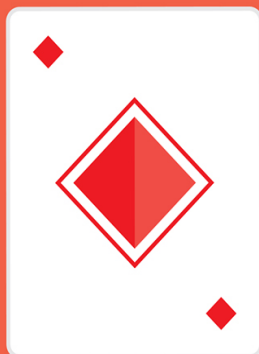
Part 3, Weak Twos and Responses to Opening Bids, introduces the modern bidding technique of Weak Twos and how to respond to them and bid against them. It then switches focus to the partner of the player who opens the bidding. Here you find out how to evaluate your hand after your partner has opened so that you can make a decision on how to bid. Your aim is to give your partner as much information about your hand as you can with a single bid.

Part 4, Rebids, Overcalls, and Doubles, pushes deeper into the nuances of bidding. You find out how the opening bidder makes the first rebid after hearing her partner's response, and how that responder should in turn rebid. This part also explores the fun concept of slam, which is when you take all or all but one of the tricks. Next, we talk about how to bid if your opponents open the bidding, how to make an overcall or a takeout double, and how to respond if your opponents do the same. We tell you all about takeout doubles, defensive bidding, and penalty doubles. Finally, we touch on the all-important topic of partnership etiquette.

Part 5, Defense, Play of the Hand, and Two Over One, is devoted to the play of the hand after the bidding has been completed. It details how a declarer plays the hand and how defenders defend the hand, and explains specific techniques—like taking a finesse, counting points in partner's hand from the bidding, and defending after the opening lead. It concludes with a chapter on the basics of how to play Two Over One, a system that has become immensely popular.

Part 1

INTRODUCTION TO BRIDGE



Be forewarned, bridge is an addictive game. Once you get your first taste of how much fun you can have playing it, you might very well be hooked for life. In this part, I whet your appetite by introducing you to the basics of the game. Bridge has its own unique language, which you will begin to grasp as you find out about the bidding process and how to play a hand. After you finish reading these four short, easy-to-read and easy-to-understand chapters, bridge will no longer be a mystery, and you'll be firmly on the road to becoming a bridge player.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 1

Welcome to Bridge!

Can you add to 40? Can you count to 13? If you can do these two things, you can play bridge.

Card games have been around for at least a millennium. Bridge is a fast-paced four-player card game played with a standard 52-card deck. Its reliance on concentration and skill has made it popular with all ages for more than 75 years. This chapter gives you a brief history of how contract bridge came to be, and what you need to play the game.

Bridge Basics

Bridge is played by four people, comprised of two pairs. You and your partner play against two other people. At the table, you are positioned opposite your partner while your opponents sit on either side of you.

By the way, in the examples throughout this book, your partner will be female and your opponents will be male, so references to your partner will be to “she” and “her” and references to your opponents will be “he” and “him.” I’ve adopted this convention to keep from getting twisted up in the pronouns, but of course you can play bridge with any combination of either sex!

In bridge terminology, you are sitting in directions named after points on the compass. So, if you and your partner are sitting North-South, your opponents are sitting East-West, and vice versa. These are just terms and have no relevance to true magnetic north.

The Cards

Bridge is played with regular playing card decks, consisting of 52 cards. It is standard practice to have two decks on a table; while the dealer is dealing, his or her partner shuffles the other deck to prepare it for play in the next hand.

Suits and Card Ranks

Playing cards were known in China as long ago as 979 C.E. Decks were divided into 4 suits of 14 cards each. Today’s decks have only 13 cards per suit.

The four playing card suits, as you probably already know, are spades (♠), hearts (♥), diamonds (♦), and clubs (♣).

Each suit has 13 cards, but they aren’t numbered 1 through 13. The numbers 2 through 10 are indeed numbered 2 through 10. The jack, queen, and king, in that order, are 11, 12, and 13. The ace is 1, and it’s the highest-ranking card, even higher than the king! That’s an important point to keep in mind: The ace is the strongest card in the suit, not the weakest.

So, here’s how the cards rank in bridge in descending order of importance:

Number	Name	Number	Name
1	Ace	7	7
13	King	6	6
12	Queen	5	5
11	Jack	4	4
10	10	3	3 or Trey
9	9	2	2 or Deuce
8	8		

Rank of the Suits

In bridge all suits are not equal. In fact, they are, by definition, unequal. Following are the suits, ranked in descending order of importance:

- ♠ Spades
- ♥ Hearts
- ♦ Diamonds
- ♣ Clubs

An easy way to remember which suits rank where is simply to think of them in alphabetical order: C-D-H-S. Clubs is the weakest suit, whereas spades is the strongest.

The Shuffle

Before you deal the cards, you must mix, or shuffle, them so they are in random order. You shuffle the cards by dividing them into two approximately equal piles and mixing them together. Do this several times, at least three, after each hand. It is said that shuffling the cards seven times will result in the most random deal, but that many shuffles is not necessary.

Choosing Partners and the Dealer

If you don't have established partners, spread the cards out on the table, face down. Each player picks a card and turns it over. The players with the two highest-ranking cards become a partnership, and the players with the two lowest-ranking cards become a partnership for the first rubber. A *rubber* is a unit of measurement. When one pair has won two games, the rubber is ended. The winner of the rubber is the pair with the most points when the rubber ends. (Rubber and game are explained in more detail in [Chapter 4](#).) The player with the highest-ranking card is the dealer for the first hand. After the rubber ends, you can choose partners again in the same way.

The Deal

After you've shuffled the cards, one person distributes them to each player, delivering one card to each player face down in turn, clockwise, until they have all been distributed. This is called the deal or dealing the cards. The person who deals is called the dealer. The deal rotates in a clockwise manner. If you deal first, the person on your left deals next, then your partner, the person on her left, and so on.

You generally play with two decks of cards. You should use decks with different colors or markings so it's easy to differentiate one deck from the other. When you are dealing, your partner is making the other deck. This means that she is shuffling the cards for the next dealer. When the deck is made, it is placed to the maker's right.

The Cut

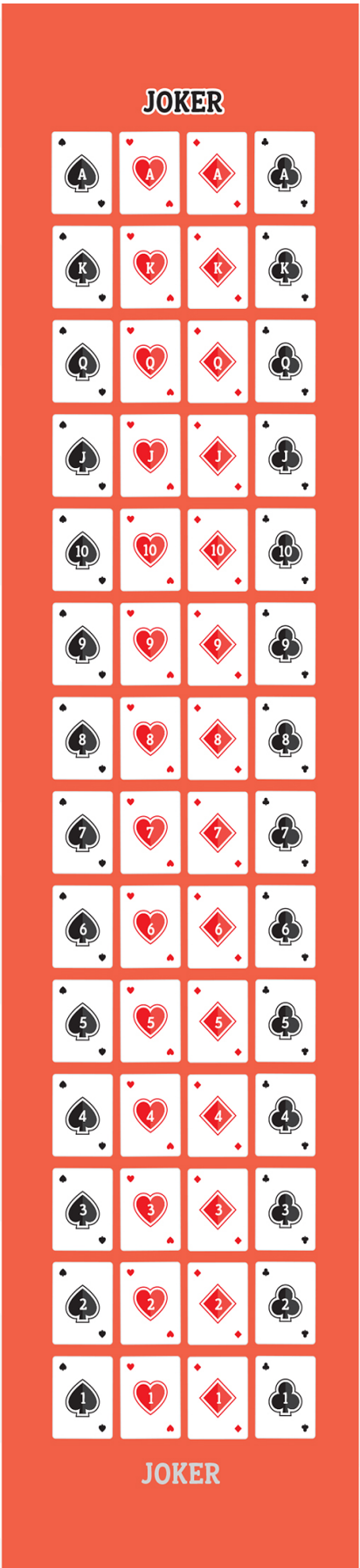
When the hand is over, the next dealer, the person on the previous dealer's left, picks up the cards on his left, where the maker has left them, and offers them to the player on his right to cut. Note that it is card-playing etiquette, not just bridge etiquette, to place the cut toward the dealer. This allows the dealer to always place the correct cards on top without having to ask, "Which way did you cut?"

To cut the cards, you pick up approximately half of them and place them toward the new dealer. He then picks up the rest of the deck and places it on top of the part that you took off, or cut. You don't have to cut the deck exactly in half. You can cut it to any depth you wish.

If the bottom card has been exposed during the making, your cut puts the bottom card somewhere in the middle of the deck. If the cards aren't cut and someone saw the bottom card, that player would know at least one card in the dealer's hand, because the dealer always gets the last card. That may not seem too important now, but as you get more proficient at the game, knowing where any card is can be very valuable.

He then deals the cards while his partner makes the deck with which you just played. This speeds up the game and gets rid of the dead space that can occur while the old cards are being shuffled and dealt. The dealer's partner always makes the cards while his partner is dealing.

Now you know what a deck of cards is, how they are evaluated, and how they are used to play the game of bridge. You also know the methodology of playing the game. In the next chapter, you'll learn the basics of bridge.



Chapter 2

**Basic
Bridge Skills**

Every card game is different. In poker, for example, the game is based on nerve. Each player bets that he has the best or worst hand at the table. The game is grounded on winning and losing money. In gin rummy, each player tries to accumulate groups of three or more cards of the same rank or a sequence of three or more cards in the same suit and be the first to meld all his cards. These games are both extremely simple to learn and understand. You can play either with virtually no introduction, and just a short explanation. You might not be good at them, but you can play them.

Bridge, however, has a reputation for being difficult to learn. Although it is not as simple as poker or gin rummy, its basic principles are extremely easy to comprehend. However, bridge is like poker and gin rummy in that knowing how to play and knowing how to play well are two entirely different things.

I'm going to teach you the rules of bridge, so that you will know how to play. Getting to the point of playing well will be entirely up to you. Be warned, however—I am teaching you an addiction. When you know how to play bridge, you will be hooked. It's more fun than you can possibly imagine.

The basics of bridge are very simple. This chapter explains what these basics are. When you're finished with this chapter and the next two, which are fairly short, you will be able to play the game. As you read subsequent chapters, you will get even better. By the time you finish this book, you should be able to sit down with your bridge-playing friends without trepidation.

Tricks

When you deal the cards and start to play, the entire concept of the game is predicting how many tricks you or your opponents can take. What's a trick? Well, it's not a prank. A trick is of the very essence of bridge. If you play a card, everyone else plays a card, too, starting with the person on your left and going clockwise. Each of you has played a card. That's a trick. Each person can play only one card to a trick. Each person must play in order, clockwise from the person who led.

Each hand consists of 13 tricks. Why? Because each person starts with 13 cards. The hand is over when each person is out of cards, which should happen simultaneously. If it doesn't, something is dreadfully wrong. There may have been a misdeal, or perhaps two cards stuck together and were played as one. If a determination of what happened can be made, appropriate bridge laws apply. Otherwise, the hand is voided and redealt, which is what normally happens in rubber bridge.

The term *lead* means to play the first card played to a trick. So when someone asks, "Is it my lead?" he is asking if he is supposed to start the trick. If you tell someone, "It's your play," it means that someone has led the first card of the trick and it is his turn to play a card to it.

In bridge, the person sitting on your left is referred to as your left-hand opponent (LHO). The person sitting on your right is referred to as your right-hand opponent (RHO).

Playing Tricks

The highest card played of the suit led wins the trick. So let's say, for example, that you lead and you play the 2 of hearts. Let's say your LHO plays the 3 of hearts. Now it's your partner's turn. So, let's say your partner plays the 8 of hearts. That leaves your RHO, who is sitting to your partner's left, to play. And let's say he plays the 5 of hearts.

Because your pair has played the highest card in the suit on this trick (your partner's 8 of hearts), your pair wins the trick. But you no longer have the lead. Why? One of the rules of bridge is that the person who plays the highest card in the suit (and who, thus, wins the trick) also wins the lead. So your partner, who won the trick with the 8 of hearts, now gets to lead.

And she can lead anything she wants. She can lead another heart, or any other suit. If she leads the king of spades and your RHO plays the ace of spades and you play the 7 of spades and your LHO plays the 6 of spades, then your RHO has won the trick

because the ace is the strongest card in the suit. Because your RHO has won the trick, it is his lead.

Keeping Track of Tricks

The person who wins the trick takes all the cards played on that trick and places them in front of her, all four cards in a unit, so that they look like one card. One player from each team keeps all the tricks for that team. It doesn't matter which one does it.

When you win one trick, place all the cards sideways. Then when you win another trick, place that trick on top of the last trick you won, but slightly to the right of it, and at right angles to it. That way it's easy to differentiate one trick from another and to keep count of how many tricks your side has won. Keep doing this with each subsequent trick.

That's the gist of the game. It occurs 13 times each hand, because there are 13 tricks. When the last card has been played, you count the tricks you've taken, and the tricks your opponents have taken, and that's the result of the hand. If you've played correctly, the total should add up to 13.

Two Rules on Tricks

There are a couple of rules you should know. First, you must follow suit. That means that if someone leads a heart, for instance, and you have a heart, you must play it. You can't play a spade or any other card from any other suit if you have a heart when a heart is led. This is called following suit. If you have a heart but play a card from another suit instead of a heart, you are said to have reneged or revoked, and there are penalties for that.

A revoke is established when someone on the offending pair has led or played to the next trick. Here are the penalties for a revoke:

1. If the revoking pair took the trick on which the revoke occurred and no other tricks, the penalty is one trick.
2. If the revoking pair took the trick on which the revoke occurred and another trick, the penalty is two tricks.
3. If the revoking pair did not take the trick on which the revoke occurred, but did take a trick afterward, the penalty is one trick.
4. If the revoking pair did not take the trick on which the revoke occurred, but did take a trick afterward, and then took another trick with a card that it could legally have been played to the revoke trick, the penalty is two tricks.

For example, if the revoking team took eight tricks during the play of the hand, when the hand is completed it only gets credit for taking six or seven tricks, depending on the circumstances above.

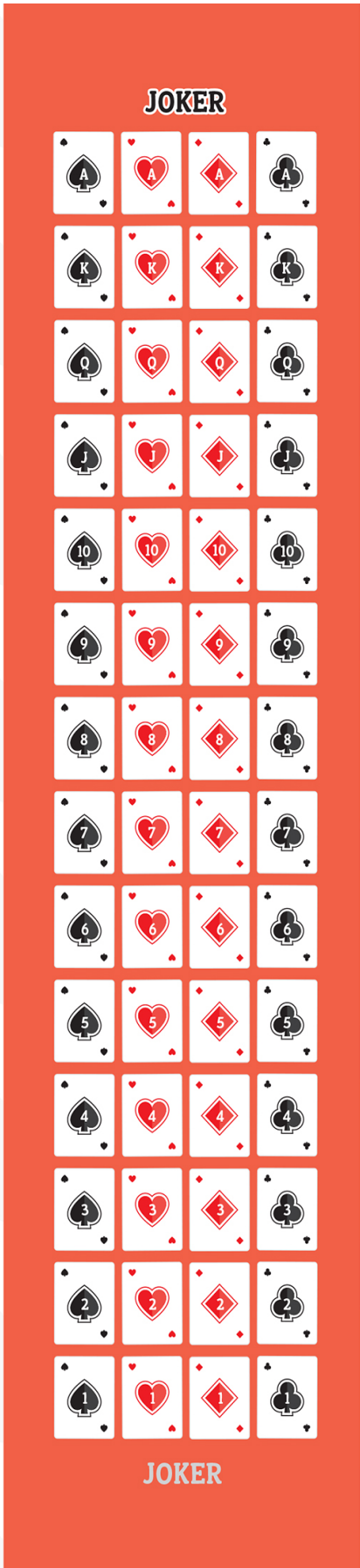
If you revoke and you realize what you have done before your pair leads to the next trick, you can bring your revoke to everyone's attention and withdraw it by playing a card from the suit led. The players who played to the trick after you are then given the right to withdraw the card they played to that trick and substitute a different card.

Second, if you don't have a card from the suit led, you can play any card from any suit you like. This is called a discard. But that card is worthless as far as taking the trick is concerned. If your opponent leads the 2 of hearts and you don't have any hearts, you can play the ace of spades if you like. But the ace of spades can't take the current trick. When a heart is led, the 2 of hearts is more powerful than the ace of spades.

Because an ace may very well take a later trick, it would be better strategy to discard a low-ranking card in a suit other than the one led if you are unable to follow suit. In choosing discards, you want to pick your least important card unless you are using a discard as a signal to your partner. But I'll cover that in [Chapter 25](#).

Now you know how tricks are played, so stop and play some. Deal out some hands and play the tricks. It's better if you have three companions, so each of you can have a hand. But if you don't, you can do it open-handed. Just deal out four hands and play

the tricks looking at each hand in turn. Do this until you're comfortable with the concept of tricks and how they're played.



Chapter 3

**The Language
of Bridge**

Now that you know how the hands are played, you need to discover how you actually get into playing the tricks. This is the essence of bridge. The communication between the partners really sets bridge apart from other card games.

It's such a wonderful feeling to look at the 13 cards in your hand and communicate with your partner through bidding and playing. You tell her what you have in your hand without saying, "Partner, I have the ace of spades and the 2 of hearts." Based on her response, you may be able to infer that she has the king of clubs, without her saying, "Partner, I have the king of clubs."

By polishing your bidding (communication) with your partner, you'll learn to assess the number of tricks your side can win. This is your first major step toward becoming a bridge player. In this chapter, you start learning how to communicate with your partner.

Bidding

When you're comfortable with tricks, try to predict how many tricks you're going to take before you play. Start with you leading first, and predict the number of tricks you think you can take just by looking at your hand. Then play the hand out and see how you did. Then let your left-hand opponent (LHO) predict how many he and his partner will take, and play that hand out.

After you do this a few times, try this: Let the dealer make a verbal prediction of the number of tricks she and her partner will take. After she makes a prediction, the dealer's LHO will make a prediction, then the dealer's partner, and then the dealer's right-hand opponent (RHO). Then play the hand, with the dealer leading first, and see how you did. These predictions by each player are called bids.

If you don't take the number of tricks you predicted, you are set or down. That means that your opponents get a score based on the number of tricks you took under what you predicted. So if you predicted you'd make eight tricks and only made seven, you

are said to be set 1 or down 1, and your opponents get points for each trick under your prediction, or bid.

Eventually, you will see that your prediction can help your partner make her prediction! If you predicted that you can take three tricks, she can look at her hand, add what you predicted to what she can take in her own hand, and increase your team's bid. Similarly, the second of your opponents to bid will have the benefit of his partner's prediction in estimating how many tricks they will take. As you continue to do this, you'll get more accurate in your predictions.

Winning the Auction

Congratulations. As you do this predicting, or bidding, you've started to play contract bridge! Your prediction of how many tricks you think you can take is called an auction. You win the auction by predicting that you can take more tricks than your opponents predict they can take. If you finally say that you can take 10 tricks and your opponents don't think they can take more, they pass, in effect saying, "Okay, go ahead and try." You win the auction.

Winning the auction doesn't necessarily mean you won the hand. All it means is that you get to name the trump suit (explained shortly) and play the hand as declarer. (The opponents play the hand as defenders.) If you and your partner win the auction, you must take at least the number of tricks you predicted in order to win the hand. Otherwise you will be set, and that's not good—the opponents will receive a numerical score in their favor.

Think of the auction as a conversation using a different language. You are communicating to your partner what you have in your hand by the way you bid. Instead of saying, "Partner, I have five spades in my hand," your bid communicates this by simply mentioning a number (not five, ironically enough) and the word spades. Similarly, you can communicate to your partner how strong your hand is through this language of bridge.

Six Tricks Makes Declarer's Book

During the auction, however, you have to know something else. Scoring in bridge is not just saying, “I can take seven tricks.” When you score in bridge, as declarer, the person who won the auction, you don’t get credit for any tricks until you’ve taken six tricks. After you’ve taken six tricks, you then start to count. Every trick over six is credited to you. So if you think you can take seven tricks, you don’t say, “I think I can take seven tricks.” Instead, you say, “I think I can take one trick.”

You’re probably thinking, “That doesn’t make any sense.” Well, it does. Because for the declarer, bridge only scores the tricks over the first six. The first six tricks taken by the declarer is called book. So if you say you can take one trick, you mean you can take six (book) plus one additional.

In the previous example, when you thought you could take 10 tricks, you don’t say, “I can take 10 tricks.” Instead, you say, “I can take four tricks” (book, six, plus an additional four). If you don’t think you and your partner can take more than six tricks, then you don’t have any business making an estimate. (See the following section.)

Pass

If you don’t have the qualities to bid (more about this in [Part 2](#)), you must say, “Pass.” This means, “I don’t have a suit I want to bid at this time, so I’m passing the bid to my LHO.” You may, however, change your mind and make a bid later when it’s your turn again. It communicates a lot to your partner. After you’ve passed, you can’t bid again until all three other players have bid or passed.

The Trump Suit

Now that you’re familiar with tricks and how they are played, let me introduce you to a new concept, trump. The trump suit, for the duration of the hand, outranks all other suits. A deuce (2) of trump will win a trick over the ace of a no trump suit.

What's trump? Simply, it's the suit in which you want to play the hand, which is generally the suit you and your partner think you have the most of between you. Because you have more cards in this suit than any other, it's to your great advantage to promote it to be the highest ranking.

Getting to name trump is what the auction is all about. That's what you're bidding for. Your pair might have a lot of hearts, and your opponents might have a lot of spades, so you're dueling to see who thinks they can make the most tricks if they name trump.

During the auction, if you want to make hearts trump, you don't just say, "I think I can take seven tricks." Instead, you say, "I think I can take seven tricks if hearts is trump." The way you say this is very simple. When it's your turn to bid, you just say, "1 heart." This means, "I can take seven tricks, book (six) plus one additional, if hearts is trump."

When estimating how many tricks you can take, keep in mind that you can't just play a trump card whenever you please. You can't play trump when another suit is led unless you don't have any of that suit. If clubs is trump and someone leads the ace of hearts, for example, you can't play the 2 of clubs to win the trick unless you are out of hearts (also called being void in hearts). So, if your opponents lead the ace of hearts and you have a heart, you must play it to follow suit.

A *contract* is the final bid, the undertaking by the pair that wins the auction that they will take the specified number of tricks they bid at their final bid.

Now that you know about trump and bidding, let's try it. For the following contracts, convert them into bridge lingo by saying how you would bid:

1. 11 tricks in spades
2. 7 tricks in hearts
3. 9 tricks in diamonds
4. 5 tricks in clubs

Number 1 is bid by saying, "5 spades" (book plus 5).

Number 2 is bid by saying, “1 heart” (book plus 1).

Number 3 is bid by saying, “3 diamonds” (book plus 3).

Number 4? Were you tricked? You don’t have a bid. If you don’t think you can at least make book plus one, you shouldn’t bid. Each bid means “I can take six tricks plus the number I bid.” Making the first six tricks is a condition of you making your bid. So your bid for Number 4 is “Pass.”

The Auction Revisited

To understand the following, you need to understand the word “open.” Open means the first person to bid in the auction. It doesn’t have to be the dealer necessarily, although the dealer gets the first chance at it. Let’s say you are in third position from the dealer and both the dealer and your RHO pass. If you bid 1 spade, you have opened.

After the bidding has been opened, all bidding ends after three consecutive passes. So, if you open and it is followed by three passes, you don’t get another chance to bid.

In the prior auction, when your partner opens 1 heart, your LHO might think he can take seven tricks if spades are trump. So, he would bid 1 spade.

What, however, if your LHO thinks he can take seven tricks if clubs is trump?

Remember the rank of the suits we learned in [Chapter 1](#)? Hearts outranks clubs. That means that he can’t bid 1 club if you have already bid 1 heart. If you bid 1 heart before him, he must bid 2 clubs if he wants clubs to be trump.

You can’t bid an inferior suit over a superior suit at the same numerical level. You can bid 1 heart over a 1 club bid, but you can’t bid 1 club over 1 heart. So, if he thinks he can do better than you if clubs is trump, and if he thinks he can take eight tricks, he says, “2 clubs” after you’ve said, “1 heart.”

Your partner has been sitting there listening to the two of you. She looks at her hand and sees that she has four hearts! If you think that the two of you can make 1 heart without knowing what's in her hand, and she has almost a third of the hearts in the whole deck, there's a good chance that her hand can help you make one or two more tricks. She looks at her clubs and they're weak. If clubs is trump, the opponents might be able to make their 2 clubs bid. But if hearts is trump, she thinks you can make 2 hearts, so she bids "2 hearts," saying to you, basically, "Partner, if you think you can take seven tricks, I have at least one additional trick in my hand, so together we should be able to take eight tricks."

Your RHO has been listening to this, too. He looks at his hand and sees he has four clubs. He says to himself, "If my partner thinks he can make 2 clubs all by himself, I bet he can make at least one more with my four clubs to contribute." Based on this reasoning, he bids "3 clubs."

You listen to all this and say to yourself, "Wait a minute. I thought I could take 1 heart all by myself, but my partner has at least one trick in her hand. And I thought I could probably make 2 hearts before I heard her bid. So, if she has enough to tell me she thinks we can make 2 hearts, I think we can make 3 hearts," so you bid "3 hearts."

Well, the bidding has gotten a little high, and your LHO looks at his hand and says, "I don't think my partner and I can make 4 clubs," so he passes. Your partner is satisfied, so she passes, too. Your RHO is also a little doubtful about making 4 clubs, so he passes.

There it is! An auction! And a contract! The bid has been auctioned. You've won the right to name trump. You and your partner have entered into a contract in which you are going to try to make 3 hearts. This is what contract bridge is all about.

The Dummy and the Declarer

No, no, this is not a newly discovered novel by Dostoyevsky. The dummy is the hand held by the partner of the player who won the auction. Because it was a team effort,

how do you decide which of you actually won it? Well, the person who wins the auction is the person who first bid the suit that ended up as trump. In the preceding example, the trump suit was hearts because 3 hearts was the winning bid. The first person to bid hearts was you, so you would play the hand as declarer.

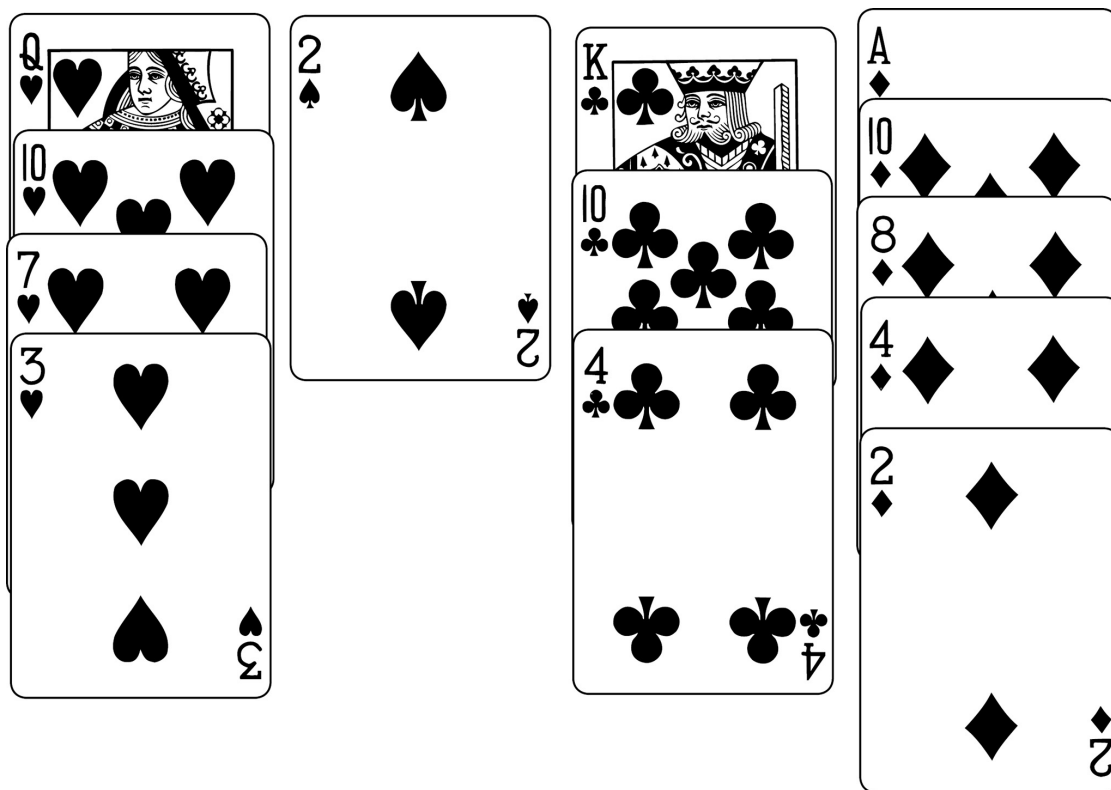
The declarer is the first person of the partnership to bid the suit in which the final bid is made that won the auction. The dummy is the partner of the declarer. So you are declarer and your partner is dummy for this hand only.

After the auction is over, it's time to play. Declarer's LHO always has the opening lead. After that opening lead, dummy puts her cards face up on the table, with trumps placed on the dummy's right, declarer's left. The cards are placed with the highest ranking on the top as declarer is looking at them, and in descending order. Most people, when they are dummy, place the cards in alternating order of color—red, black, red, black—but this is not a rule. You can place them in any order, as long as trump is on declarer's left as declarer looks at the cards.

Trump, which in this instance is hearts, is on declarer's left as she looks at dummy, or on dummy's right. The rest of the cards are laid out so everyone at the table can see each card, its suit, and denomination. While the hand is being played, dummy cannot collaborate with declarer on the correct play of the hand.

Play of the Hand

There are two options to play the hand. The first, and better way, is during the play of the hand, declarer calls the card she wants played from dummy and dummy follows her instructions and plays the card. So, in playing the hand you see spread in the following illustration, if declarer led a low heart from her hand and her LHO played the 9 of hearts, declarer would call out the card she wanted played, without touching it, like, “queen of hearts.” Dummy would then play the queen of hearts.



This is the way a dummy's hand looks to the declarer.

The previous figure is a graphical representation of a typical bridge hand. The following is the notation for that same hand:

♠ 2
 ♥ Q1073
 ♦ A10842
 ♣ K104

For the purposes of displaying hands in this book, the hands will always be arranged in descending order of the rank of the suits, spades first, followed by hearts, diamonds, and clubs, in that order. Although this notation may take some getting used to, it's a common and fairly intuitive method for displaying card hands and one that I'll be using throughout the book.

The second way, and the way most rubber bridge players play, is for declarer to actually play the card from dummy. In this example, dummy just sits there and watches, while declarer does all the work. I suggest that you learn the first way, with dummy playing the card under declarer's direction. There are several advantages to this. The first is

that it involves dummy in the play of the hand. If she's playing the cards, she has a chore to do and feels that she's still a part of the game.

The second advantage to dummy playing the cards under declarer's direction is that this is the way cards are played in duplicate bridge. Although I'm teaching you rubber bridge in this book, it is inevitable that many of you will become so enamored of the game that you will want to progress into duplicate, which is competitive, social, and more fun than a barrel of monkeys. It's better practice to learn good habits now, when you are a novice. If you learn to play dummy's cards yourself when you are declarer, it will be harder for you to unlearn if you advance into duplicate.

In rubber bridge, the object is to win the rubber and the bonus points awarded. It's been called the most popular form of contract bridge. In duplicate bridge, each hand is separate and stands on its own. At the end of a duplicate game, the pair that has the best overall score on all the hands is the winner.

No Trump: The Fifth Suit

Thought you had it all, didn't you? Well, I sort of tricked you. You thought the only suits you had to remember were spades, hearts, diamonds, and clubs. Well, it's not quite that simple.

Sometimes people who have what they think are balanced hands want to play a hand without any trump. When this first started, it took years before players could figure out what to call it. Finally, they took the problem to the top of a mountain and asked the bridge guru. Since then it has been called no trump. Was that genius or what?

The point is that you don't always have to play the hand with a trump suit. If you play it in no trump, you get more points for your tricks than if you played it with a suit as trump. This fifth suit makes the rankings of the suits as follows, with the strongest on top:

No trump (NT)



So, as you've learned, you can bid 1 heart over 1 club, but if 1 heart has already been bid, you can't bid 1 club over 1 heart. If you want clubs as trump in this scenario, you have to bid at least 2 clubs.

But what if you want to play the hand without anything being trump? Then you bid 1 no trump. And you can bid 1 no trump over any suit bid at the 1 level. So, if your opponents have bid 1 spade, heretofore the most powerful bid at the 1 level, you can still stay at the 1 level by bidding 1 no trump.

If you win the auction with a no trump bid, you will be playing the hand without any suit being trump, kind of like you did when you learned about tricks and were just playing the cards to see how it went.

Let's go over the bidding again. Deal some hands and bid them, allowing the dealer to bid first, then proceeding clockwise around the table. Bid, enter into the contract or let your opponents take the contract, lay down the dummy hand, and play the cards.

If you can do this, you're playing bridge! The rest of the book will tell you how to improve. But as you read you should continue to play. Each time you read, try to play in addition to reading. Each time you play you will improve and learn. Playing is as important as reading.

This chapter has just set forth the basics of the game. If you're comfortable with the concepts of shuffling, dealing, bidding, and playing, you're ready to go on to the next chapter, which will teach you how to communicate with your partner through the bidding process. This communication helps you make informed decisions about what suit should be trump (if any), at what level you should be playing the contract, and whether you should let your opponents play the contract with you defending.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 4

What Do I Have and What Does It Mean?

Now that you have started to communicate with your partner, you need to know how to evaluate your hand so you can tell your partner what you have. If one of you has the ace of spades, what does that mean to you? Does that mean anything more than that you might be able to take one spade trick?

You bet your sweet bippy it does. This is where it begins to get fun. In this chapter, you're going to learn if you have anything in your hand that you want to tell your partner.

You're also going to learn something about how to score the game, because if you don't know how the game is scored, you won't have any idea what your evaluation of your hand really means. So, I'm going to tell you a little bit about what your goals are when you play bridge.

Sorting by Suit

When you pick up your cards, they are mixed or shuffled, and in no particular order. The first thing you do is arrange your hand by suit. Most people alternate the colors—red, black, red, black. This helps distinguish one suit from another and avoids confusing similar cards, such as the 2 of clubs and the 2 of spades.

Sorting by Rank

Most players also arrange the cards by rank, with the highest card in a suit on the left, and then in descending order. Again, this is done mainly so you are less apt to play the wrong card. If you want to play the queen of clubs, for example, and you have the suit sorted as follows, AQ943, you know exactly where the queen is. But if you have them arranged randomly, you are more liable to pick out the wrong card and play it.

There's a disadvantage to sorting by suit and rank, however. A very astute player can watch you play and may be able to make judgments about how many cards you have in a suit and what their ranks are. I have seen players just pick up their cards, bid, and play them as they were dealt. For me, this makes it too confusing and inordinately

difficult to play. I remember watching a guy who played like this; I asked him why. He replied that he did it so no one could determine what was in his hand. The problem was that *he* was included in that group. I watched him make some mistakes, and I thought they were because he didn't arrange his cards. I strongly advise against randomly arranged hands and encourage you to always sort your hand immediately by suit and rank.

Counting High-Card Points

After you've picked up your cards and sorted them, it's time to evaluate your hand. Are you going to bid or pass? What are you going to tell your partner about your hand?

In bridge each card in each suit has a high-card point (HCP) value. These points have no bearing on scoring, which you will soon learn, but are used solely to evaluate your hand. The values, or points, are as follows:

Card	Points	Card	Points
Ace	4	Jack	1
King	3	Everything else (2-10)	0
Queen	2		

The 10, jack, queen, king, and ace are called honors. When someone asks you how many honors you have in a suit, you count each of these cards as one honor. For example, if you have AQ1074 in a suit, you have three honors: the ace, the queen, and the 10.

Whenever I give you a hand in this book, the suits are listed in order of rank. The first suit is always spades, the second suit hearts, the third listed is diamonds, and the last listed suit is clubs. This is standard in the world of bridge.

Even though 10s and 9s aren't assigned numerical values, they are far better than lower spot cards. For example, AQ1098 is a better suit than AQ432. So, 10s and 9s sprinkled

around the hand are at least worth a plus value, if for no other reason than they may eventually take tricks ahead of lower spot cards.

Let's take a little test. Count the HCP in the following hands. Cover up the answers that follow the hands.

1. ♠ 742
♥ AK52
♦ QJ9
♣ 432

2. ♠ 743
♥ J53
♦ AJ52
♣ Q107

3. ♠ AKQ7
♥ KQJ
♦ QJ10
♣ KJ9

4. ♠ 10987
♥ 864
♦ 974
♣ 1075

Hand 1: 10 points. 4 for the ace of hearts, 3 for the king of hearts, 2 for the queen of diamonds, and 1 for the jack of diamonds.

Hand 2: 8 points. 1 for the jack of hearts, 4 for the ace of diamonds, 1 for the jack of diamonds, and 2 for the queen of clubs. (Remember, 10s, although they are honors, still are worth 0 points in HCP.)

Hand 3: 22 points (a powerful hand). 9 for the ace, king, and queen of spades (4 plus 3 plus 2); 6 for the king, queen, and jack of hearts (3 plus 2 plus 1); 3 for the queen and jack of diamonds (2 plus 1); and 4 for the king and jack of clubs (3 plus 1).

Hand 4: 0 points.

Shortage points or shortness are sometimes referred to as distribution points throughout this book.

A fit is said to occur between you and your partner if you have at least eight cards between you in the trump suit.

Counting Distribution Points

Now you know how to count HCP. But hands can also have distribution points.

Distribution points are determined two ways, either by adding points for length in suits, or adding points for shortage in suits. Advanced players generally use length points

to determine whether to open a hand and then shortage points later in the auction after a trump fit has been established. For your benefit, I’m going to teach you the way I learned, by using only shortage points (also referred to as shortness or as distribution points). So for now, forget that length points even exist.

Shortage points are as follows:

Number of Cards in Suit	Points	Number of Cards in Suit	Points
3 to 13	0	1 (singleton)	2
2 (doubleton)	1	0 (void)	3

If you open up a hand and see 13 cards in the same suit, after you bid it and play it, stop the game, take a picture, and save the hand. Thirteen cards in a suit in one hand is rarer than hen’s teeth.

Now, count the shortage points in the following hands.

1. ♠ A

♥ J9875

♦ Q9432

♣ 87
2. ♠ 782

♥ AKQ

♦ AKQ

♣ 8642
3. ♠ J97

♥ Void

♦ 98743

♣ AKQJ9
4. ♠ 109873

♥ 853

♦ 3

♣ J987

Hand 1: 3 shortage points, 2 for the singleton spade (it doesn’t matter that it’s an ace), and 1 for the doubleton club.

Hand 2: 0 shortage points. This is called a 4-3-3-3 distribution.

Hand 3: 3 shortage points for the void in hearts.

Hand 4: 2 shortage points for the singleton diamond.

You give yourself distribution points because long and short suits have definite value as you play a hand. As you will learn when I discuss trump, if you have a singleton heart and your opponents have the ace, king, and queen of hearts and clubs is trump, you can trump two of their apparent winners, the king of hearts and the queen of hearts. So

your singleton has a value, even if it's only a deuce. Counting distribution points in this way gives you a way to evaluate the worth of the shortness as you communicate with your partner.

When reading bridge hands, it's common usage to list any card below honor rank as x when the actual rank of the card is unimportant to the discussion. Sometimes you will see a hand that looks like this—AKxxx—meaning a five-card suit headed by the ace and king with three cards under the rank of 10.

Combine your knowledge that you just gained and count the last four hands for both distribution and HCP.

Hand 1: 10 total points. 7 HCP (4 for the ace of spades, 1 for the jack of hearts, and 2 for the queen of diamonds) and 3 distribution points.

Hand 2: 18 total points. 18 HCP (2 ace, king, queen combinations) and 0 distribution points because of its 4–3–3–3 distribution.

Hand 3: 14 total points. 11 HCP (10 for the ace, king, queen, and jack of clubs and 1 for the jack of spades) and 3 distribution points for the heart void.

Hand 4: 3 total points. 1 HCP (the jack of clubs) and 2 distribution points for the diamond singleton.

Quick Tricks

Another concept to consider when evaluating your hand is called quick tricks. A quick trick is a card or combination of cards that will probably win a trick. An ace is a quick trick. A king and a queen in the same suit are a single quick trick. Why? Because the ace can only take one of them. After the ace is played, the other, either the king or the queen, whichever was not played when the ace was played, will win the trick for certain because it's the highest card left in the suit. The following table shows a list of quick tricks. The card(s) listed are always in the same suit.

Card(s)	Quick Tricks	Card(s)	Quick Tricks
Ace	1	AQ	1½
K (singleton)	0	AK	2
KQ	1	Kx	½

A general rule of thumb is to consider opening a hand if it contains three quick tricks, even though it might not meet the other requirements for opening (discussed in [Chapter 6](#)).

Making Game

You're probably thinking, "So, now I know how many points my hand has, so what?" You're asking this question because you don't know why you're trying to take tricks. Let me explain.

What you're trying to do is make game. Game is when one team has made a certain number of scoring points (not HCP). You get scoring points by the number of tricks you take as declarer, and whether or not you have successfully contracted to take that number of tricks.

Scoring is heavily weighted toward accurately predicting how many tricks you'll make. If you take all the tricks available (13), you've made seven (book, plus seven). But if you only contracted to make three, the four additional tricks you actually made are much less valuable than if you had contracted to make seven.

Scoring per Trick

The value of each trick varies depending on the contract. If you're playing in hearts or spades, called major suits, the tricks are more valuable than if you're playing in clubs or diamonds, the minor suits. If you're playing in no trump, the first trick is more valuable than if you are playing in a major suit.

The following table lists the values of tricks in each suit.

Suit	Points
♠ and ♥	30 per trick
♣ and ♦	20 per trick
NT	40 for first trick, 30 per trick thereafter

Note, throughout the book, the following will be used: ♠ (spades), ♥ (hearts), ♦ (diamonds), ♣ (clubs), NT (no trump), Dbl (double), and P (pass).

Game is when you’ve made 100 points below the line (explained in the “Scoring” section later in this chapter). But you have to convert that into a number of tricks.

Making Game in a Major Suit

If you are playing with spades or hearts as trump, you must make four tricks over book to exceed 100 (at 30 points per trick), so you have to take 10 tricks. If you make exactly four hearts or spades and bid it, your score is 120. You don’t get anything for the six tricks you took to make book; you start scoring after you’ve made book. Then, if you’re playing in a major suit, you get 30 points per trick; so four tricks over book would be 120—what you need for game.

Making Game in a Minor Suit

If you’re playing in a minor suit, clubs or diamonds, you must take an extra trick to reach 100. You must take five tricks over book or 11 tricks total, because minor-suit tricks are only worth 20 points each, not the 30 you get if you’re playing in a major.

Trump determines how much each trick is worth. If you’re playing a contract of 5 diamonds, and you lead a spade and everyone follows suit and you win the trick, you only get 20 points for that trick, even though it’s a spade trick. When the contract is reached, if it’s in clubs or diamonds, declarer only gets 20 points per trick, regardless of the suit led. If the contract is in a major suit, hearts or spades, each trick is worth 30 points, even if it’s a minor-suit trick. You only get these points for each trick over book.

Making Game in No Trump

If you're playing in no trump, you only need to take three tricks over book to reach 100, a total of nine tricks. Why? Because the first trick you take over book in no trump is worth 40, then each succeeding trick is worth 30. So, if you make three no trump, you get 40 for the first trick over book and 30 for the other two, for a total of 100. This is one of the advantages of playing in no trump: You need one less trick to make game.

Scoring

But it's not quite that easy. You get different types of points: points above the line and points below the line. What's the line?

The line is what separates above the line from below the line. A rubber bridge scoresheet looks like this:

We	They

You write the score for the tricks you contracted to take below the line and the score for the tricks you took over and above what you contracted for above the line. Only scores below the line are counted in determining whether or not you make game.

If you don't bid game, but make a partial, you are said to have a partscore. This is referred to as having so many points on. So, if you bid 2 spades and make 3 spades, you get 60 points below the line and 30 points above the line. You are said to be 60 on.

So, if your contract was 2 spades, and you made 3 spades, your score would be 60 points below the line (for the 2 spades you contracted and made) and 30 points above

the line for the extra trick you made over and above what you contracted. This extra trick is called an overtrick. The score below the line, if it's less than 100 is called a partial. You keep scoring until one team has 100 total points below the line. It doesn't matter how many points you have above the line when determining game.

After one pair has won a game, another line is drawn under all the points each pair scored below the line and the new game is scored below that line.

Defensive Scoring

If you don't make your contract, your opponents get points instead of you. Generally, the defenders get 50 points for each trick you fail to take under your contract. So, if you bid 4 spades and only made 2 spades, the defenders would get 100 points: 50 points per trick. All defenders' points are above the line. If declarer is vulnerable (see later in this chapter), defenders get 100 points per trick for every trick you fail to make under your contract.

The Rubber

When one pair wins two games, that constitutes a rubber. One pair must score 100 points below the line twice in order for them to win the rubber. Winning the rubber entitles a pair to bonus points. If one pair wins a rubber without the other pair making a game, it gets 700 points bonus. If a pair wins a rubber after their opponents have made one game, the winning pair only gets 500 bonus points. Bonus points are above the line.

At the end of the rubber you add up all the points, above and below the line, and whoever has the most is the overall winner. It's possible to win the rubber but not be the overall winner.

Rubber Bridge Score Sheet

A rubber bridge score sheet might look like this:

PLAYERS	YOU	PARTNER	YOUR RHO	YOUR LHO
FIRST RUBBER	870	870	250	250
SECOND RUBBER				
THIRD RUBBER				
TOTALS				

WE	THEY	WE	THEY	WE	THEY
⑪ 500 ⑦ 60 ② 30	④ 20 ③ 50				
② 60 ⑤ 40	④ 80	⑥ ⑨			
⑦ 60	⑧ 100				
⑩ 120					
870	250				

①

Explanation:

1. This is the *line* that separates above the line from below the line.
2. This means that you (“we”) were in a major-suit contract at the 2 level and made
 3. For that you got 60 points below the line for the 2 you bid and made, and 30 points above the line for the overtrick.
3. Apparently you also bid a contract and went down 1; that is represented by the 50 your opponents have above the line.

4. Your opponents then bid 4 clubs or 4 diamonds and made 5. They got 80 points below the line for the 4 that they bid and 20 points above the line for the overtrick they made.
5. On the next hand, you either bid and made 1 no trump for 40 or 2 in a minor suit, which would also be 40. You did not make an overtrick because you got nothing further above the line.
6. Because you made game, 100 points below the line (60 on the first hand plus 40 on the third hand), you drew a line under those hands and started another game.
7. You then bid 2 of a major suit and made 4. For this you got 60 points below the line for the 2 you bid and made, and 60 points above the line for the two overtricks.
8. Your opponents then made game, either bidding and making 3 no trump or 5 of a minor, because both of those contracts get the bidders 100 points. They did not make an overtrick, so they got nothing above the line.
9. You then drew another line, like you did in number 6, and started another game. Remember, a rubber continues until one pair makes two games.
10. Then, you bid game in a major suit, either 4 hearts or 4 spades, and made it exactly, so you got 120 below the line for bidding and making your 4. You did not make an overtrick, so you got nothing further above the line.
11. Because you won two games in the rubber, you won the rubber, so you got a 500-point bonus. Had you won the rubber without your opponents making a game you would have received a 700-point bonus.

You then add up your points. You and your partner were the overall winners because you had the most points. You move the points up to keep the running score of *each player* at the top. You can then change partners, if you want, and play another rubber and put those scores next to the boxes for the second rubber. Then if you want to change partners again, you do it all over for the third rubber. Then, if you want to quit, you add up everyone's points and find out who was the overall winner for the entire match.

If declarer was doubled (see [Chapter 21](#) for details), the points received by defenders are substantially increased if they defeat the contract. If defenders don't defeat the contract, declarer's score is increased.

What It Means to Be Vulnerable

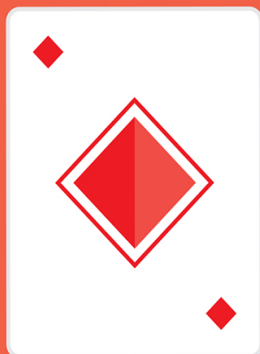
If you have won a game (you have more than 100 points below the line), you are said to be vulnerable. This means that if you go set (don't make your contract), your penalty is twice as severe. If you go set nonvulnerable, your penalty is 50 points for each trick you are short of your contract. So, if your contract is 2 spades and you only make 1 spade, you are one trick short and your penalty is 50 points. These points go to your opponents above the line.

However, if you go set when you are vulnerable, your penalty is doubled. So, if your contract is 2 spades and you only make 1 spade, you are said to be down 1 and that penalty, instead of being 50 points, is doubled to 100. Again, those points go to your opponents above the line.

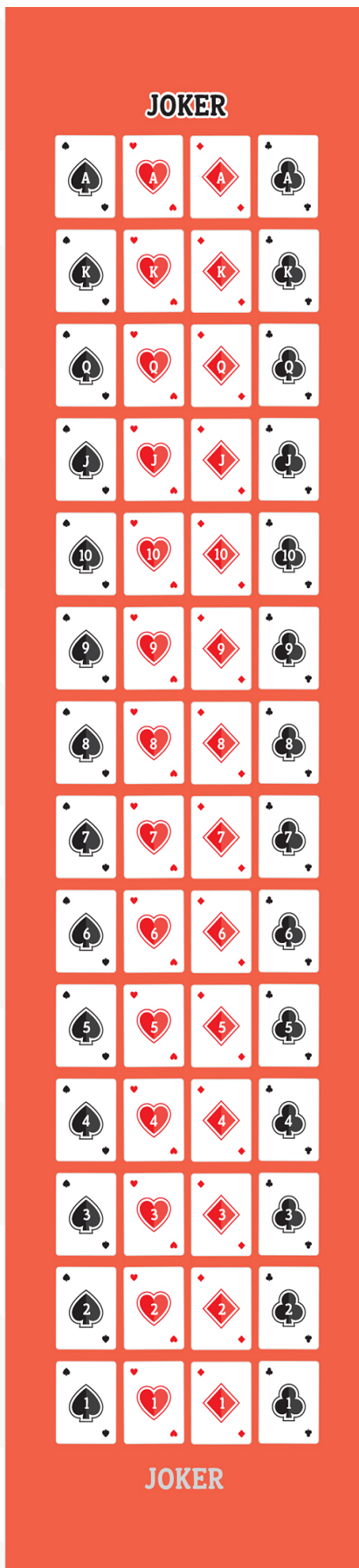
Stop reading now and, using what you've learned in Chapters 1 through 4, play some hands before moving on to the next chapter.

Part 2

OPENING BIDS



In bridge, you want to avoid the famous admonition to Cool Hand Luke, “What we have here is a failure to communicate!” Bridge is based on effective communication between partners. In this part, I show you how to evaluate your hand for the purposes of making an opening bid. Then I walk you through the many different types of bids that you can make to describe your hand to your partner. I also show you how to determine whether you or your partner is the captain of your pair. The strategies you discover in this part will not only help you communicate what you have to your partner, but will also enable you to interfere with your opponents’ ability to communicate with one another.



Chapter 5

Opening No Trump Bids

By now, you should be getting the feeling for what we’re doing. Now you know how to count your hand. But this is just knowledge that you have. You have to communicate this to your partner in a way that allows her to make some determination of what the two of you can accomplish in this hand.

In this chapter, you’re going to learn how to tell your partner what you have in your hand. She can convert what you tell her into a mathematical formula that will enable her to make a fairly accurate estimate of the number of tricks you can take.

You’re also going to learn how to start bidding a hand that is a very good hand, indeed—a no trump opening. When you finish this chapter, you’ll be well on your way to being a bridge player.

Relating Points to Goals

There are 40 total HCP in each hand, distributed among the four players. When you bid, you are basically telling your partner how many of those points you have. She listens to your bid, looks at her hand, adds her points to yours, and tries to determine how many tricks the two of you can take. How does she do this? The gods of bridge have realized over the years that if a pair has a certain number of points, it will probably take a certain number of tricks. The following table presents a generalized list showing how many total points it takes to make game.

Contract Suit	Points Required
♥ and ♠	26 (HCP plus distribution points)
♣ and ♦	28 (HCP plus distribution points)
NT	25 (HCP only)

Why the difference? Simple. You can make game in no trump by only taking nine total tricks, so you only need 25 of the total 40 points available. If you’re playing with hearts or spades as trump, you need to take one additional trick over what you would need to take in no trump, so you need a more powerful hand, more points. You need at least

26 points. As you'll soon see, however, having this many points doesn't *guarantee* you can make game; it's just a very good indication.

If you're playing in a minor suit, diamonds or clubs, you need yet another trick to make game, 5 above book or 11 total. This means that you need to take all the tricks but two. For this you need 28 points or more.

Your Opening Bid

Your opening bid is the first communication you have with your partner. You want to communicate as much to her as you can when you state your bid. After you have arranged your cards and counted your points, you should know what your opening bid is going to be.

Opening bids of one of a suit may have as little as 12 HCP and meet suit distribution requirements. (You'll learn about these in [Chapter 6](#).) But what if you have more than 14 points? If you just opened every hand with more than 12 points, 1 of a suit, your partner wouldn't know if you had 12 points or 25. Opening bidding has been refined so there are many bids you can make that describe the strength of your hand.

Opening 1 No Trump

If you have a fairly balanced hand, no voids or singletons, and more than 14 points, you want to communicate this to your partner in your first bid. With a hand containing 15 to 17 HCP, no singletons or voids, and no more than two doubletons, you can open 1 no trump. This says, "Partner, I have 15 to 17 HCP in my hand, no singletons or voids, and no more than two doubletons."

Many rubber bridge players play that an opening of 1 no trump promises 16 to 18 HCP. Although the modern trend is for a 15 to 17 HCP no trump range, many of the people with whom you play rubber bridge will be playing 16 to 18. Discuss this with your partner before you play to make sure you're on the same wavelength.

This is enormously helpful information to your partner because it limits your hand. You have at least 37 percent of the total HCP available; in addition, you have at least two cards in each suit! Further, you have limited your hand by telling your partner that you have less than 42 percent of the total HCP available. So, she knows you have 37 to 42 percent of the total HCP available. And you've told her all this in just one bid!

Because she knows that you need 25 to 26 points to make game, if she has just 10 points in her hand, she knows that you should probably be playing this hand in game somewhere.

When you open 1 no trump, you designate your partner as the captain of the team for the hand. Why? Because she knows an incredible amount about your hand, whereas you know virtually nothing about hers. She may want to determine if the two of you have enough cards in any suit to qualify it as trump. On many hands she will merely choose to play the hand in no trump. You can just sit back, answer her questions, and let her place the contract for the partnership.

Specific Description of High-Card Points

When you open 1 no trump, you are giving your partner a specific description of how many HCP you have in your hand. You have between 15 to 17 HCP—no more, no less. If you have 14, you will probably open 1 of a suit. If you have 18, you will treat the hand differently. If you open an 18-point hand 1 no trump, you are giving misinformation to your partner, and that's a cardinal sin in bridge. I remember the last time I opened an 18-point hand 1 no trump. It turned into a disaster, and it was all my fault. I was dealt an 18-point hand with perfect no trump distribution, 4-3-3-3. I thought, "Well, there's only 1-point difference, and I do have perfect distribution, so I'll lie a little," and opened 1 no trump.

To my dismay, the hand was passed out, meaning everyone else passed, leaving me to play the hand in 1 no trump. My partner came down with 7 HCP. My 18 plus her 7 equaled 25, which is enough to make game, and I did make game, 3. But because we

only bid 1, we got a very poor score because the other two tricks were above the line—we missed an easy game.

Had I opened 1 club, which is what I should have done, my partner would have been forced to respond with her longest suit, showing me at least 6 points. I would then have jumped to 2 no trump, showing at least 18 points, and my partner would have added her 7 to my 18, gotten 25, and bid game, 3 no trump.

A *response* is generally a bid by a player whose partner has opened. A *responder* is the person making the response. A *jump* is a bid that skips a level of bidding. [Chapter 14](#) covers jump bidding.

So, you must be extremely disciplined. It's very important that you don't lie to your partner. If you open 1 no trump, saying you have 15 to 17 HCP, then that's what you had better have, or you will be in trouble!

The Distribution

An opening of 1 no trump not only describes the HCP in your hand, but it also promises your partner that you have a very specific distribution in your hand. It promises, basically, that you have at least two cards in each suit. You cannot open 1 no trump if you have a void in a suit, a singleton in a suit, or more than two doubletons.

If you have 15 to 17 HCP, but have a hand with a singleton or void, then you have to find another bid to make other than 1 no trump. We'll discuss this situation in [Chapter 6](#).

What is called perfect no trump distribution is a hand that contains four cards in one suit and three cards in every other suit, which is what 4-3-3-3 refers to. This doesn't mean that you *must* have 4-3-3-3 distribution to open 1 no trump, however. You may open any 15- to 17-point hand without voids, singletons, or more than two doubletons 1 no trump, with one or two exceptions. This means that you might have a hand with 5-4-2-2 distribution and open it 1 no trump.

The reason for this is that it communicates the strength of your hand to your partner in one bid. Just because you open 1 no trump doesn't mean that you are going to end up playing in no trump! Remember that when you open 1 no trump, you designate your partner as the captain of the hand. It's up to her to determine whether it's better to play the hand in no trump or a suit, or to defend if your opponents enter the bidding.

Stoppers

A *stopper* is a card or distribution of cards that enables you to take a trick in the suit. An ace is a definite stopper. A king and a queen comprise a stopper because even though the opponents may lead an ace, it will only take the queen, and you'll still have the king to take a trick. Kx and Qxx are full stoppers, in spite of what might happen. Partial stoppers are Jxx or Qx.

A king and one card in a suit is a stopper. It's true that if your RHO gets the lead and he leads that suit, and your LHO has the ace and the queen, your king will be dead as a doornail. Why? Well, what are you going to play when your RHO leads the suit in which you have Kx? If you play the king, your LHO will play the ace and then you won't have a stopper. If you play low, your LHO will play the queen and then the ace will take your king. Only if your LHO leads the suit will your king be a stopper. But Kx and Qxx are considered full stoppers for bidding purposes.

Have you figured out why the king is a stopper only if your LHO leads the suit? Think about it. If the LHO leads the suit, he's leading into your hand, because your hand will be the last one to play to the trick. So, if the LHO leads, no matter what he leads, and no matter what your RHO plays on the trick, your king will be a definite winner at some point. If the RHO plays the ace, your king is the high card out. If the RHO ducks, you can win the trick with the king. (To duck means to refuse to win a trick or play a higher card when you have the capability to play low. Ducking is covered in detail in Chapters 22 through 23, on play of the hand.) You'll be in trouble if they get the lead again and attack the suit, because your stopper will be gone. But that's why bridge is such a challenge.

The same is true of a queen and 2 in a suit. Your opponents, if the ace and the king are in alternate hands, can lead through your queen and you can lose it. How? Well, let's say your LHO has the lead and he leads low. Your RHO has the ace and plays it and returns the same suit, through your queen. If you play the queen, your LHO will take it with his king. If you play low, your LHO may take it with a lower card, then lead the king and your queen will fall. But it's still considered a full stopper.

The term *partial stopper* is defined in bridge language as Qx or Jxx or T9xx (rare). Think in terms of the lead coming from declarer's left: Kx is a stopper; Qx or Jxx requires help from your partner. (True that the lead may be a side suit to RHO's ace, then back through our Kx, but this isn't a consideration when determining stoppers for no trump purposes.)

The Kx is a better stopper than the Qxx, because the Kx is a definite stopper if your LHO is on lead and leads the suit. Then, no matter what your RHO does, your king will take a trick. With the Qxx, however, even if your LHO is on lead, you can be left without a stopper if your opponents defend correctly.

Exceptions to Opening 1 No Trump with 15 to 17 HCP

There are two basic exceptions where you should consider not opening a balanced 15 to 17 HCP hand 1 no trump.

1. Don't open a hand 1 no trump if you have two suits without stoppers. Especially, if you're opening a hand with two doubletons, you should have stoppers in the two doubletons. Sometimes you'll have to open a hand 1 no trump with one suit unstopped.
2. Don't open a hand 1 no trump if you're 5-4 or 4-5 in the majors. If you have five cards in one major and four cards in the other, it's better to open the bidding by bidding your five-card major. If your partner doesn't support you, you can then rebid your four-card major. More on opening in your major suits in [Chapter 6](#).

Opening 2 No Trump

You aren't limited to opening the bidding at the 1 level. You can open a hand at any level you like. But each opening transmits specific information to your partner. If opening 1 no trump shows a balanced hand with 15 to 17 points, what would a 2 no trump open show?

It doesn't show the next level up, 18 to 20, which is what you probably thought. (Another series of bids describes hands that have 18 to 19 points.) When you open 2 no trump you're telling your partner that your distribution is the same as if you opened 1 no trump, no voids or singletons, and no more than two doubletons. But your HCP are much higher. **A 2 no trump opening tells your partner that you have 20 to 21 HCP.** Following are some typical 2 no trump openings:

1. ♠ AKQ	2. ♠ J109	3. ♠ 83	4. ♠ QJ1072
♥ KJ95	♥ KQ2	♥ Q64	♥ AQ
♦ A75	♦ KQ5	♦ AKJ10	♦ KJ
♣ K84	♣ AKQ3	♣ AKQJ	♣ AQJ6

The first two hands are no-brainers. You have 20 HCP and perfect 4–3–3–3 no trump distribution. The third hand gives pause because you have a doubleton—spades—unstopped. But you have 20 HCP, all but 2 in the minors. By opening 2 no trump, you describe your strength to your partner and you take away your opponents' bidding room and limit their flexibility to see if they have a major suit fit.

In the fourth hand, you have a five-card major (spades); some players don't like to open no trump with a five-card major. But the problem with not opening this hand 2 no trump is that you mislead your partner in your opening bid, by either initially describing a hand that is weaker than you have, or one that is stronger. This five-card major is far too weak to even think about opening anything other than 2 no trump. If the spades were AKQJx instead of QJ10xx, then it might give you some pause. But with a weak five-card major, 20 points, and no voids or singletons and no more than two doubletons, you should always open 2 no trump.

Opening 3 No Trump

By now you've probably gotten the drift of this. Logic would say that a 3 no trump open would be 22 to 24 HCP. Wrong! There's another bid for that hand, regardless of its distribution. It's called a Strong Two bid, and I cover it in [Chapter 7](#).

If you have 25 to 26 points and no voids or singletons, and no more than two doubletons and stoppers in all suits, you can open 3 no trump. This tells your partner that you really don't need her, you have everything you need to make game in your own hand. It invites her to explore for *slam*, or place the contract in a major suit if she has a long one. The hand is the same as the 2 no trump open, except it has more HCP.

A slam is when you bid and make six or seven, which means that you bid and take all tricks but one in the case of a six bid (a small slam) and when you bid and take all the tricks in the case of a seven bid (a grand slam). That's the best thing that can happen offensively in bridge. You'll learn more about slams in [Chapter 18](#).

Now deal out some hands and bid and play them in accord with what you've learned in Chapters 1 through 5.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 6

Opening 1 of a Suit

So, now you know how to open a very good hand, one with between 37 percent and 42 percent of the HCP in it. But what if you don't have that type of hand? In this chapter, you learn the requirements for opening 1 of a suit. As you will see, you can open 1 of a suit with a weaker hand than required for opening 1 no trump.

You also learn that it matters where you are sitting in relationship to the dealer. Your evaluation of your hand changes depending on whether you are the first or second player to make a call, or the third or fourth. A *call* is any bid, double, redouble, or pass made by a player. You will learn about doubles and redoubles in [Chapter 21](#).

Ah, the wonders of bridge. It's so varied.

Point Requirements for Suit Bids

To open 1 of a suit, you must meet specific point count and suit length requirements. You should have a minimum of 12 points, combining HCP and distribution points, to open 1 of a suit. Generally speaking, an opening of 1 of a suit indicates a hand of 12 to 14 points. There are exceptions to this rule, however, depending on distribution. As we've seen in 1 no trump openings, you can't open 1 no trump if you have more than 17 HCP, and you can't open 2 no trump if you have less than 20 HCP, so what do you do with 18– to 19–point hands? We'll cover that in [Chapter 16](#).

You can open 1 of a suit with a hand that's too strong or too distributional to open 1 no trump. For example, you could have 15 to 17 HCP but a singleton or void. You can't open that 1 no trump, but you must open it. I'll cover that in [Chapter 16](#). For now, just remember that an opening of 1 in a suit does not limit the hand to 14 points. It could have more.

Many experts suggest that you add or deduct if you have all or no aces in your hand. You deduct a point if you have no aces and you add a point if you have all four aces. So, it would be unwise to open in the following hand:

♠ 1064

♥ J84

♦ KQ7
♣ KQJ3

There are 12 HCP. But if you deduct a point for no aces you're down to 11 HCP. That's not attractive enough to take a chance.

Adding a point for all four aces is a good technique because aces tend to be slightly undervalued. But subtracting a point for no aces should be limited to hands with 4–3–3–3 distribution. So, passing the example hand above is correct. But the following hand should be opened 1 diamond because, although it is ace-less, it is not 4–3–3–3 distribution:

♠ J104
♥ J8
♦ KQ107
♣ KQJ3

Hand evaluation is not a computer science. As you learn the game, you'll develop a feel for borderline openings. At this stage, to generalize, ace-less hands and 4–3–3–3 distributed hands suggest underbidding your values, whereas hands with, for example, J109, are more valuable than a holding of J32.

Suit Length Requirements for Suit Bids

You should have at least five cards in the suit if it is a major (hearts or spades). The modern trend is to open a major only if you have a minimum of five cards in it. The older style was to open any suit if it had four cards. I'm going to teach you the newer, *five-card major* style of bidding. This means, for example, that if you have 12 points, but you don't have a five-card major, then you must open a minor suit (clubs or diamonds), even though you may not have any honors in that suit.

Remember, when you play a bidding system, your bids promise your partner that your hand contains what you say it does. So, if you open 1 spade, you're promising your partner that you have at least five spades in your hand. She'll make her bid based on

that commitment. Accepting the concept of commitment is very important in the formation of a bridge partnership. Nothing is more critical than trusting your partner.

If you have fewer than five spades in your hand, it will mislead her and her reply could mislead you. You'll be progressing rapidly down the road to ruin on this hand. So when you agree to play a system, like the five-card major system I'm teaching here, stick with it and don't deviate. In other words, if you agree that your opening bid of 1 spade promises at least five spades, don't later decide that, for one hand, you can open 1 spade with only four spades. You must exert discipline in your bidding.

There are innumerable bidding systems. The *Official Encyclopedia of Bridge* lists 54 different systems. In this book, you are first learning *Standard American*, the most widely used system in America. If you sit down at a table, despite what system your opponents are actually using, it would be unusual if they hadn't learned Standard American first. Regardless of what system your opponents are using, you and your partner must use the same system in order to communicate. Then later in the book I will teach you what is now the more popular 2/1 system.

Opening

But, you ask, what if I have 12 points, but no five-card major? Good question. If you have a five-card minor (clubs or diamonds), open that. But, often you have one or both four-card majors and no five-card minor. What then?

Because you can't open a four-card major, you are allowed to open a minor, even if it is only three cards in length.

For starters, here are the basic rules of opening 1 of a suit:

- + You should have at least 12 points (there are exceptions which we will cover later).
- + An opening bid in a major suit, hearts or spades, promises at least five cards in the suit.
- + If you have 12 points but no five-card major, open your longest minor.
- + If both minors are four cards in length, open 1 diamond.

- + If both minors are three cards in length, open 1 club.
- + Generally speaking, 90 percent of the time that you open 1 diamond you will have at least four of them. In fact, the only time you will open 1 diamond with only three diamonds in your hand is if your distribution is exactly 4432 (4 spades, 4 hearts, 3 diamonds, and 2 clubs; whenever distribution is shown with four consecutive numbers like here the numbers correspond to spades, hearts, diamonds, and clubs in that order). This only occurs approximately 10 percent of the time.

That's it for opening 1 bids. Following are some hands. Determine whether or not you would open each, and if so, what your opening bid would be.

1. ♠ AK982
♥ Q1054
♦ K5
♣ J3

2. ♠ 763
♥ AK75
♦ 74
♣ 8754

3. ♠ J1042
♥ AK642
♦ 87
♣ 64

4. ♠ 976
♥ AKQJ
♦ A62
♣ 632

One of the worst things you can do in bidding in bridge is to make a *unilateral* bid, saying to yourself, "I like this hand and I'm going to bid it. The heck with what my partner thinks or has in her hand." When you do this—and a lot of players do—you're just begging for trouble.

Hand 1: A clear 1 spade open. You have 13 HCP and a good five-card spade suit.

Hand 2: Pass. Not enough points.

Hand 3: Pass, even though you have a nice five-card heart suit. You only have 8 HCP, 10 total points with distribution, and that's not enough to open. If you open this hand you're telling your partner you have at least 12 points, and even though your heart suit is very attractive, you would be lying to your partner.

Hand 4: Open 1 club. Sure, your hearts are terrific, but there are only four of them. If you open 1 heart, you're telling your partner you have at least five hearts, and you

don't. Whatever you do, you don't want to lie to your partner, because she's relying on you for accurate information in evaluating her hand and making her bid.

Opening 1 club doesn't necessarily guide the partnership toward a final club contract. You may easily end up in hearts, your best suit, or even no trump. Subsequent bidding will determine this (discussed in Chapters 9–14).

Determining Which Suit to Open

Okay, so far it has been pretty easy. The sample hands have had fairly obvious answers. Alas, bridge is not that cooperative. Generally your hands are thinkers, because they contain elements that vary from the rules. So, let's start with some right now. What do you do if you have two five-card majors? Which suit do you open? Look at these hands:

1. ♠ AK964
♥ AK865
♦ 76
♣ 7

2. ♠ J10865
♥ AKQ53
♦ 3
♣ 96

3. ♠ 98642
♥ AJ1076
♦ AK
♣ 4

4. ♠ 98632
♥ Q10852
♦ A
♣ AK

How would you open each? I know that you don't know any of the rules yet, but just use your common sense and write down how you'd open each.

Now for the answers. 1 spade.

What? Which hand are you talking about? What do you mean 1 spade? Well, the answer to all four hands is 1 spade. When you have two five-card suits in a hand, major or minor, you always open the higher-ranking suit. This is true when both five-card suits are majors. So, if you have five hearts and five spades, you open 1 spade, even if the heart suit is much, much stronger than the spade suit.

Why? The answer to this is a little complicated. Let's assume the bidding goes as follows.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♠	2 ♣	P	P
2 ♥	P		

This tells your partner that you have at least five spades and at least four hearts. If your partner likes spades more than hearts, she can still remain at the 2 level by choosing the appropriate suit.

Think about what would happen if you had hand 2, 3, or 4 and opened hearts first. The bidding would have gone as follows.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♥	2 ♣	P	P
2 ♠	P		

Now, what if your partner is void in spades, but has three little hearts and only 4 points? Obviously, you should be playing in hearts, but she has to go to the 3 level with her terrible hand. What to do? She's in a quandary.

If you open 1 spade, even though your spades are much weaker than your hearts, and then rebid 2 hearts, she could pass, showing her preference to play in hearts, and you're at a much safer and lower 2 level instead of 3 level. If her holding is reversed, and she has three spades and a heart void, she could just simply bid 2 spades over your 2 hearts, telling you, "Partner, my hand stinks, but I'd rather you play this in spades than hearts."

Keep in mind that at all times during an auction each partner is called on to make decisions. When your partner shows two suits, she is asking you to choose which of her suits you prefer. Even though the choice is not always pleasant, you must make a choice. I will repeat this concept frequently.

Regardless of how strong your hearts are, you're better off playing in a suit in which you and your partner have eight cards between you than a suit in which you only have five or six cards between you.

Open Your Longest Suit

When opening, you should open your longest suit, regardless of its high-card strength. If you have a six-card minor and a five-card major, open the minor. Look at the following hands:

1. ♠ AKQJ10
♥ 8
♦ QJ10987
♣ 7

2. ♠ 987654
♥ AKQJ10
♦ 7
♣ 8

Hand 1: 1 diamond. Your spades are nice and you should be able to show them at a subsequent bid. But, you have to tell your partner that your diamonds are longer. If you open 1 spade and then rebid diamonds, you're telling your partner that your spades are longer than your diamonds or that they are of equal five-card length.

Hand 2: 1 spade. Again, even though your hearts have a lot of high-card strength, your spades are longer. If your partner has two hearts and two spades, your spades are your stronger suit and should be the trump suit. Note that even though this hand only has 10 HCP, it has 14 total points given two points for each of the two singletons, so it's a hand that must be opened.

Rule of 20

When you have a distributional hand you may sometimes open in first or second seat with less than 12 HCP. The "Rule of 20" states that if you add your HCP to the number of cards in your two longest suits and the answer is at least 20, you may open the hand. To put it simply, if you have two five-card suits and 10 HCP, that totals 20 so you may make an opening bid. To be reasonable, however, your HCP should be in your long suits. If you have two weak suits and the HCP are in the short suits, the rule is not as effective. Here are some examples:

Hand 1

♠ AK763
 ♥ K9842
 ♦ 76
 ♣ 74

Hand 2

♠ 98542
 ♥ 76432
 ♦ AK
 ♣ K

Hand 3

♠ Void
 ♥ Q10
 ♦ AQJ432
 ♣ 108654

Hand 1: Perfect for the Rule of 20. You have two five-card suits, 10 HCP, and they are all in your two five-card suits. Open 1 spade.

Hand 2: You have two five-card suits and 10 HCP, but the HCP are all in your short suits. Worse, the club king is a singleton, which decreases its value. Don't open this hand.

Hand 3: You only have 9 HCP and two of them are in one of your short suits. But you are 6-5, so you have 11 cards in your two longest suits. $11+9=20$, and seven of your HCP are in one of your long suits. You may open this hand 1 diamond. Some might consider opening it 2 diamonds (a Weak Two bid, see [Chapter 9](#)) but that would preclude finding a possible club fit. Here is the four hand layout of the actual hand and how the bidding should go:

North

♠ K976
 ♥ AKJ54
 ♦ 5
 ♣ K3

West

♠ Void
 ♥ Q10
 ♦ AQJ432
 ♣ 108654

East

♠ AQJ1052
 ♥ 82
 ♦ K96
 ♣ QJ

South

♠ 843
 ♥ 963
 ♦ 1087
 ♣ A972

Although there are lots of points here that you won't learn until you read subsequent chapters, here's how the bidding should proceed with South dealer and EW

vulnerable:

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
♠ P	♠ 1D	♠ 1H	♠ 1S
♥ 2H	♥ 3C	♥ 3H	♥ 3S
♦ P	♦ 4D	♦ P	♦ P
♣ P			

Explanation of the bidding:

West's 1D opening only promises at least three diamonds.

North's 1H overcall promises at least five hearts.

East's 1S promises at least five spades. (You will learn how to show spades when you only have four of them in this auction later.)

South's 2H raise should promise at least three hearts and at least 6 HCP.

West's 3C rebid promises at least four clubs.

North's 3H is merely competitive, saying he doesn't want to sell out to 3C.

East's 3S rebid promises at least six spades.

South's pass says she's done bidding and that she has a minimum hand.

West's 4D rebid says several things. First, he has zero or one spade. If he had two he could support East's rebid that promised six spades at least. Second, he probably has six diamonds. You don't make a rebid of a suit at the 4 level of a suit that your partner has not supported without at least six cards in it. It doesn't reveal anything about clubs, though. It could still be a four-card suit. However, the rebid of diamonds strongly indicates that his hand is wildly distributional and the supposition is that he's 6-5 in diamonds and clubs, which he is. He could pass 3S because his partner could be void in diamonds as he is in spades.

In the actual hand, East, an experienced player, jumped to 4S after North made his 1H overcall. The hand was passed out and she was down three tricks for minus 150. Had the bidding proceeded properly, as set forth above, East would know that West had zero or one spade because he denied spades after she bid them twice, which promises at least six cards in the suit. West could have supported East's bid if he had two card support. But with a void he went to 4D, which should promise six cards in the suit. If North had bid 4 hearts, East's only choice would be to pass or bid 5D since she had good three card support to the king. That would be a tough decision. In fact, the hand can only make 3H, so she should pass because EW would be down two in 5D, but only one in 4D. If West passes 3S, East will be down two.

You will learn about responses and overcalls in subsequent chapters. Suffice it to say here that normally South needs at least 6 HCP and three card support for her partner's suit to make a raise to 2H. She has the three card support but only 4 HCP. However, that four points is an ace, which is a sure trick, so she stretched to support her partner's 1H overcall.

This hand and the bidding exemplify what is so fascinating about bridge. There are so many decisions to be made and any or all of them may be correct, to wit, West could pass 3S, which would be all right. Bidding 4D was all right. North could bid 4H and be down one, which would be all right. If North passes, either decision East makes, raising to 5D or passing 4D would be all right. The only decision that would be all wrong would be for East to rebid 4S with her hand after being denied twice by her partner. That would most definitely *not* be all right!

Opening Based on Quick Tricks

Regardless of the number of points in your hand, if you have three quick tricks in your hand, you have enough to open, even if you have less than 12 HCP. An easy example is shown below:

North

♠ Q73
♥ KQ
♦ 7432
♣ K842

West

♠ J82
♥ A943
♦ KJ96
♣ AQ

East

♠ 10964
♥ J765
♦ Q105
♣ J3

South

♠ AK5
♥ 1082
♦ A8
♣ 109765

South was an experienced player and passed this hand that had three quick tricks in first seat. The result was that West opened 1NT and it was passed out. West was down 1, but it was a terrible score for NS because NS (North/South) can make one or two NT and four clubs. South must open this hand 1C with three quick tricks and a five-card suit. The hand was played 15 times in a duplicate game, and on more than half it was played by NS either in no trump or clubs, always making the contract. (A duplicate game is a form of bridge where there's more than one table and everybody plays the same hands.)

Opening in Third Position

When you are in the first or the second bidding seat, your evaluation of your hand is different from when you are in the third or fourth seat. In the first and second seats, you have not heard from your partner yet. In the first seat, you haven't heard from anyone. You will be the first to describe your hand to everyone else.

First seat is synonymous with first position. Both mean the first player to make a call. The dealer is always in first seat; dealer's LHO is in second seat; dealer's partner is in third seat; dealer's RHO is in fourth seat.

When you're in second seat, although you haven't heard from your partner, you have heard from your RHO. If your RHO has passed, you know that he probably has fewer than 12 points. This tells you something, but not too much, about what everyone else is holding.

But when you're in second seat and your RHO has opened the bidding, you not only know something about his hand, you know a lot about the hands of everyone else. From the RHO's bid, you know the placement of a substantial number of the cards in the deck.

If your RHO has opened 1 of a suit, or 1 no trump, you know approximately how many HCP are in his hand. Let's say he opens 1 no trump, and that you have 12 points in your hand. You know you and your RHO hold between 27 and 29 of the total of 40 points in the hand. That means that your partner and your LHO have a total of 11 to 12 points between them.

But when you are in third seat and your partner and your RHO have passed, you can ease the stringent requirements to open your hand. Why? Because you know that neither your partner nor your RHO have an opening hand. So, if you have a minimum opening hand, you and your partner probably don't have game, because her maximum holding should be 12 points. If you have 12 points, you may have a maximum total of 24 points between you, not enough for game. If you don't bid, you will be abandoning an opportunity to tell your partner something about your hand with very little risk involved.

There is a further advantage to bidding in third seat with a less than opening hand. It is the only chance you will have to give your partner a suggestion of an opening lead in case you are defending. What if you're sitting there with the AKJxxx of clubs, and nothing much else? If you open 1 club and your LHO does have a powerhouse and ends up playing a contract, your partner will know that you want her to lead a club. If you don't make your third seat opening bid, she'll be in the dark about your hand.

Of course, you're guessing whether your partner had a hand close to opening, like 10 to 12 points, or a *Yarborough* (a 4333 hand containing no points, a disaster). You are also in the dark about your RHO's hand. Does he have 12 points, or 0? This lack of knowledge about two hands at the table leaves you in the dark about your LHO's hand.

Yarborough was named after an English lord who would give odds of 1,000 to 1 against someone coming up with such a hand, which was defined as a hand with no card higher than a 9. The actual odds are 1,827 to 1, so, as with most bookies, he had a nice edge.

Are you saying to yourself, "How can I bid with only 8 points?" Realize that if you have a six-card suit, headed by the AKJ, you must have a hand that contains at least 10 points, because a hand with a six-card suit must have at least either a singleton or two doubletons in its 12 total cards.

If both your partner and your RHO have Yarborough hands and you have a minimum opening, your LHO could be sitting there with a powerhouse. So, if you want to get in a bid, now is the time to do it. Maybe you have a good spade suit and little else, maybe 10 points. What to do? Answer: Make a tactical light opening in the third seat.

Rules for Light Third Seat Open

If you are opening in third seat, you should have the following at a minimum:

- + At least 10 points
- + A good suit, headed by the AK or KQJ, for lead-directing purposes

Look at the following hands:

1. ♠ 975
♥ 873
♦ 7
♣ AKJ1075

2. ♠ QJ2
♥ QJ3
♦ 6
♣ QJ6432

Hand 1: 1 club. You have 10 points, but a terrific club suit. If your LHO gets the bid, you definitely want your partner to lead a club. This is your only chance to tell her. If

you get the contract in 1 club, you won't be hurt too much. If your partner raises clubs, or bids either of the majors, you have minimal support. If she bids diamonds, you can rebid your club suit.

Hand 2: Pass. This hand contains 11 points, but has no lead-directing values. If your LHO gets the contract, do you want your partner to lead a club? If your LHO bids a major and your partner bids 2 diamonds, what are you going to do? You certainly don't want to be playing this in 3 clubs if your partner doesn't have support for you.

Your partner should be aware that you might be opening light in third seat, so she should not jump to optimistic conclusions if she's holding a hand with just slightly less than opening values. If she has 12 points and she hears you open, she should proceed with caution, knowing that you might be opening a 10-point hand for lead-directing purposes.

Opening in Fourth Position

Things change again when you are sitting in fourth position. If all three players pass the bid around to you, you know that nobody has an opening hand. You may also assume that your RHO is not very close to an opening hand because he might have opened light in the third seat.

But when the bid is passed around to fourth seat, and you are sitting with a little less than an opening hand, the odds are against you opening, because your two opponents probably have 9 to 11 points in each of their hands. Your partner might be sitting there with 5 or 6 points.

You need a full opening hand in fourth seat. If you don't have a full opening hand, it is wiser to pass and deal again.

The danger of opening a marginal hand in fourth seat is that you might give your opponents the opportunity to get a plus score when they are ready to pass the hand out. You don't have game. What's the point of bidding in the blind hope that you have

a fit with your partner or your partner is sitting there with some points to help you out?

The situation is completely different from what you faced in third seat. There, you don't know what your opponent in the fourth seat has in his hand. He could have a powerhouse. That could be your only chance to bid a suit that is headed by the ace-king.

In fourth seat, however, you have no worry about someone bidding behind you with a powerhouse, leaving you without a bid. If you pass, the hand will be passed out. In rubber bridge that can never really hurt you, whereas bidding on a marginal hand and allowing your opponents to find a partial will definitely hurt you.

Rule of 20 (Pearson Points)

This is another method of hand evaluation that is generally used in fourth seat when the bidding is passed around to you. It says that if you add up your HCP and the number of spades in your hand and the total is 15, you may open. So, if you have a five-card spade suit and 10 HCP, that's an opening hand.

Fourth Seat Opening at the 2 Level

When there are three passes to you it gives you another use for opening at the 2 level. If you play Weak Twos, there is no reason to open with a weak bid in fourth seat because the entire purpose of the preemptive bid is to hinder the communication of opponents who have more powerful hands than you and your partner. Since they have both passed, opening a Weak Two in fourth seat has no purpose.

Therefore, the 2 level bid is available to convey information to your partner. I use it to show an opening hand of 12-15 HCP and a six-card suit. So, if it goes P-P-P to me, and I open 2H, my partner knows that in addition to a legitimate opening hand, I have at least a six-card suit. If I only had a five-card suit I would open 1H. This is crucial information for my partner because if opponents compete, she can support me with two cards in my suit, something she could not do if I opened 1H.

Opening Hands with Unusual Distribution

One of the wonders of bridge is that you can set forth all these rules, but you will constantly get hands that tax your ingenuity in applying the rules. In fact, you will rarely get a hand that will not cause you to think, and that's why bridge is so challenging and so much fun.

What we've said so far is pretty straightforward, and the hands we've given you as examples comply with the rules we've given you. But there are literally billions of combinations of cards that you can get in a bridge hand.

So, how would you open the following hands, applying the rules you just learned?

1. ♠ KQJ1076

♥ 6

♦ KQ105

♣ 64

2. ♠ 97654

♥ Q10985

♦ A

♣ A7

3. ♠ 6

♥ 8

♦ KQJ865

♣ KQ1042

4. ♠ 754

♥ Void

♦ QJ1032

♣ AQJ107

Clearly, these hands do not follow the norm. And clearly, even without much help from your partner, you'll make book and then some if you play these hands.

Hand 3 only has 11 HCP, but conceivably you could lose only four tricks and make three with your partner sitting there with a Yarborough. If things are right—and they don't need to be unusually right—you lose all four aces and that's it. If you get a favorable lead, like the ace of clubs, you might make more. And if your partner has something, you might make game. Clearly, you must open this hand.

All these hands have potential, but they illustrate the value of distributional hands. You'd feel very uncomfortable passing any of them, even if you're in first seat, despite their minimal HCP holdings.

Hand 1: 1 spade. You have 11 HCP, a singleton, and a doubleton. That's 14 points.

Hand 2: 1 spade. You have 10 HCP and a singleton and doubleton for 13 points, a minimal opening hand.

Hand 3: 1 diamond. Again, you have 11 HCP and two singletons, still enough to open 1 diamond with 15 total points.

Hand 4: You have 10 HCP and a void. That's 13 points. But let's take a look at this hand and see what happens if you open a two-suited hand when the suits are relatively weak.

Let's say you open 1 diamond, which this hand calls for (the higher ranking of two five-card suits, remember?). What's your partner going to bid? Right, almost definitely when you have a hand like this and you open your partner bids your void. So, she bids 1 heart. What now? Well, you mention your other five-card suit, and bid 2 clubs.

What does she do? Because the gods of bridge are perverse, she will almost definitely repeat her hearts, showing six hearts. (You'll learn about that in [Chapter 16](#).) Now your hand is extremely diminished in value. Not only is your void in hearts not going to give you any *ruffing* power if hearts is trump, but you don't have anywhere to go. She might be six hearts, four spades, and two and one in your suits. And you certainly don't want to play at the 3 level in a 5–1 fit. You're left having to pass her out at 2 hearts with your void. Therefore, Hand 4 is a hand you may choose to pass, even though you have 13 total points.

Ruff is another word for trump used as a verb. To trump or ruff simply means that you have taken a no trump trick by playing a trump, which, as you remember, you can't do unless you're void in the suit led. If clubs or diamonds is trump in Hand 4, you can ruff, or trump, any heart that is led. Theoretically you can't lose a heart trick. But if your partner's suit is hearts, your ruffing power is greatly diminished because she probably won't have a lot of heart losers anyway.

Opening a 15 to 17 HCP Hand with a Five-Card Major

Many players don't like to open a hand in no trump with a five-card major. Some limit this to not opening no trump with a *good* five-card major. How you open a hand and who plays the hand can have a major determination on your result.

For the purposes of your learning, you should adopt a consistent rule to play with your partner. If you have a 15 to 17 HCP, balanced hand with a five-card major:

- + Open in 1 of your five-card major if you have an unstopped doubleton.
- + Open 1 no trump if you have all the suits stopped.

Look at the following hands:

1. ♠ KQJ85

♥ AQ3

♦ K73

♣ 75

2. ♠ QJ1085

♥ A103

♦ KQ3

♣ K5

Hand 1: 1 spade. You have a good five-card spade suit and you have an unstopped doubleton club.

Hand 2: 1 no trump. Your spade suit isn't that great and you have all the suits stopped.

The point of which you should be aware is that if you open up a 15 to 17 HCP hand with your five-card major and your partner doesn't have support, your pair will conceivably end up playing the contract in no trump. However, your partner could easily be the one to bid the no trump, so the strong hand will be displayed as dummy whereas the weak hand will be playing it. This is not a disaster, but it's better to have the strong hand concealed.

Alternatively, if you open up 1 no trump, and your partner has a weak hand but three in your major, you're not going to find your eight-card major suit fit; so, you'll be playing the hand in the wrong contract. This is the beauty of bridge. Sometimes what you do is correct. Another time with the same hand it might be incorrect.

Play with consistency. If you choose to open all hands with a five-card major with 1 of the major, then do so, but then you should always open a hand with five-card majors the same way. One of the worst things you can do is be inconsistent. As long as your partner knows what she can count on when you bid, you should be okay.

Now, stop reading. Deal, bid, and play some hands, using what you have learned in Chapters 1 through 6.

JOKER



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Chapter 7

Strong Twos

Now you know how to open hands that contain 15 to 17 HCP, 20 to 21 HCP, and hands that contain at least 12 points but fewer than 22 points. As Peggy Lee asked, “Is that all there is?”

No, Peggy, there’s more. Sometimes you get hands that contain more than 21 points. Statistically you’ll get a hand like this, with more than 21 points, about one hand out of every 200 you play. That sounds like a lot, but it really isn’t. I play approximately 100 hands a week. You might not play as often as I do, but the game is going to grab you and you’ll play hundreds, if not thousands, of hands a year. You’re going to get hands like these occasionally, and you have to know how to handle them.

There are two basic ways to handle big hands: Weak Two and Strong Two. When Charles Goren wrote his last, huge volume on the game in 1985, he incorporated the five-card major bidding system you’re learning here. He also incorporated the Weak Two bidding system.

Because there are so many different systems, whenever you play with a new partner or new opponents, it is wise to ask them what systems they play before the game starts. That way you will know in advance what their bids mean, or if they mean something different than what your bids mean.

In this chapter, you’re going to learn the Strong Two system for showing big hands. Most modern players use Weak Twos, but many rubber bridge players play Strong Twos. In case you want to learn Weak Twos as well, I’ve included [Chapter 9](#) on the Weak Two system. Because most of the players you will encounter in rubber bridge will be playing Strong Twos, it’s better for you to learn Strong Twos now and Weak Twos later. If you only know Weak Twos, it will limit the number of partners with whom you can play. However, if you are reading this book in order to play duplicate bridge, you probably don’t need to learn Strong Twos because I don’t know any duplicate players who play them.

Definition of a Strong Two

A *Strong Two* is sometimes referred to as a *demand bid*, meaning that opener is demanding that your partner keep the bidding open. Some people refer to it as a *two demand*.

A Strong Two is a hand that is of one of two types. It is either ...

- + A hand containing at least 22 points; or
- + A hand that guarantees $8\frac{1}{2}$ tricks if trump is a major suit or $9\frac{1}{2}$ tricks if trump is a minor suit. Put another way, if you have a hand with which you know you can make at least one trick less than game with no help from your partner, you should open it with a Strong Two, regardless of the number of points you hold.

When you open a Strong Two, your partner is required to keep bidding until one of you bids game, unless you rebid your opening suit. In that case, your partner may pass. This prevents your partner from passing the hand out short of game, thereby emasculating your big, 1-in-200 hand by playing it in a partscore.

Hands Containing 22 Points with a Five-Card Suit

If you open a Strong Two in diamonds, hearts, or spades, you are guaranteeing that your suit contains at least five cards, and that your hand contains at least 22 points. Look at the following hand:

♠ AKQJ109
♥ AKQJ
♦ A8
♣ 7

This is a Strong Two spade opening hand.

You might be looking at this hand, remembering what you've learned, and asking yourself, "This hand is *cold* (a slang term meaning an easily makeable contract) for 4 spades. Why not just open 4 spades? Why open at a lower level?"

If you asked yourself this question, I like the way you're thinking. But there are reasons why you don't just open 4 spades with this hand. One is that an opening of 4 spades

shows a different hand, as you will learn in the next chapter.

Another reason is something we've hinted at before—the possibility of *slam*. Sure, 4 spades is cold. But you might be able to make more. If your partner has the ace of clubs or the king of diamonds, 6 spades is cold. If she has both, 7 spades is cold. So, why bid 4 spades, a bid that your partner can pass? The opening bid of 2 spades basically tells your partner, “Look, pard, I can make 4 spades pretty easily with only a little help from you. I want you to tell me about your hand to see if we can make slam.”

Another reason is something we'll discuss in detail in the next chapter. You don't want to constrain your ability to communicate with your partner by getting the bidding too high when you might be able to make slam with a little communication between you.

A more typical 2-level opening would be the following hand:

♠ AKQ42
♥ AKQ
♦ A106
♣ 83

That's a 23-point hand, but if your partner has a Yarborough and is short in spades, you only have seven cold tricks, although with a five-card spade suit like this you can generally count on at least four spades, which would elevate it to eight tricks. You have to open this 2 spades. Game is not cold. You need information from your partner. But you don't want your partner to pass. Maybe your partner has five clubs including the queen-jack along with four diamonds. If that's all she has, you should make 3 no trump if she doesn't have three spades in her hand.

The point is this: You must tell her what you have so she can evaluate her hand and tell you whether or not she has a trick or two, or three spades in her hand, or both. An opening at the 2 level allows your partner to reevaluate her hand. A hand that looked terrible when she first looked at it can suddenly look surprisingly powerful when her partner opens with a Strong Two. Look at the following hand in responder:

North

♠ AKQ42

♥ AKQ

♦ A106

♣ 83

South (Responder)

♠ J32

♥ 985

♦ K652

♣ 542

Is that a stinkeroo, or what? But look at the first hand I described, the 27-point hand that opened 2 spades. Your king of diamonds and jack of spades make this hand cold for 6 spades! Because you have three spades to the jack in your hand, it's almost certain your partner won't lose a spade trick. She can't lose a heart trick. Your king of diamonds ensures she won't lose a diamond trick. Her only loser is her singleton club.

A 2 spades opening allows you to say, "Hey, this stinkeroo is starting to smell like Joy perfume! I've got three of my partner's trump with an honor, and the king of diamonds. We could be going someplace here!" Without the 2 spades opening, just hope you get the contract in as low a spade bid as you can.

Balanced Hands with 22 or More Points

If you open a Strong Two in clubs, your hand either contains 22 points and five clubs, or it contains 22 points and is balanced, without a five-card suit. If it contains five clubs, it's no different from the spade hands discussed earlier, and the bidding is made the same way.

A hand with 24 HCP and 27 total points can't really be thought of as typical. A 24 HCP hand occurs approximately once out of every 2,000 hands.

But if it's balanced without a five-card suit, there's an entirely different way to bid this. Take the following hand as an example:

♠ AQJ
♥ AK53
♦ AQ87
♣ K6

You can't open this hand in any of the no trump bids we've discussed. Do you remember why? *You can't lie to your partner*, that's why. You've agreed with your partner that an opening bid of 1 no trump promises between 15 to 17 HCP, no more, no less. An opening bid of 2 no trump promises between 20 to 21 HCP, no more, no less. An opening bid of 3 no trump promises between 25 to 26 HCP. When you make a no trump opening, you cannot be outside the range promised, either below *or* above.

This hand has 23 HCP, 24 total points with the doubleton club. You cannot open it in no trump. You cannot open it in any other suit bid because any opening in diamonds, hearts, or spades at the 2 level promises a five-card suit.

This is where the Strong Two club bid comes into play. You open this hand 2 clubs. Then, if your partner responds with a suit you can't support, you respond 2 no trump. I'll cover responses to Strong Two openings in the next section of this chapter.

An opening bid of 2 clubs, followed by a fairly standard response of 2 diamonds, a *waiting bid* (explained below), and a rebid of 2 no trump tells your partner that opener has a balanced, 22– to 24–point hand with no singletons or voids and no more than two doubletons.

A *waiting bid* is one that says nothing about the suit bid, but is forced by your partner's opening bid. A response of 2 diamonds to a Strong Two club open just says to your partner, "I don't have a five-card suit headed by the king-jack, so tell me more about your hand."

Now bid the following hands:

1. ♠ AKQJ874	2. ♠ J7	3. ♠ A	4. ♠ A	5. ♠ 86
♥ A6	♥ AKQJ	♥ 86	♥ KQJ10	♥ KQ10
♦ A5	♦ AKQJ	♦ AKQ109874	♦ 865	♦ AKQ
♣ 87	♣ J76	♣ A8	♣ AKQJ8	♣ KQJ98

Hand 1: 2 spades. Even though this hand only contains 21 points, you can take nine tricks—seven spade tricks and your two aces—so it can be opened at 2 spades.

Hand 2: 2 clubs. You have 22 points, but no five-card suit. So, open 2 clubs and rebid 2 no trump if your partner bids a suit you can't support.

Hand 3: 2 diamonds. Like Hand 1, this contains only 21 points, but you can take 10 tricks—8 diamonds and your 2 aces.

Hand 4: 2 clubs. You can open 2 clubs with a five-card club suit. You tell your partner that you are not opening up a balanced hand without a five-card suit at 2 clubs by not bidding 2 no trump at your next bid. Instead you will bid your other suit of four cards or better, 2 hearts, promising your partner at least four hearts and that your club suit is longer than your heart suit. You'll learn more about opener's rebids in [Chapter 15](#).

Hand 5: 2 no trump. This is a 21-point hand with 20 HCP. You can't make a two demand because you don't have enough points.

The difference between opening 2 of a suit and opening 2 no trump is that 2 no trump is not a *demand bid*. Your partner may pass an opening bid of 2 no trump, but she may not pass an opening bid of 2 in a suit.

Responding to Strong Two Openings

First rule: You may not pass after your partner opens a Strong Two bid if your RHO has passed. If you value your life, you won't pass. I once opened 2 spades. My LHO passed. My partner passed! My RHO passed. I almost fell off my chair. "You can't pass when I open 2 spades," I said. "But I only had 1 point," my partner replied. "I had 25

points, you had one. 25 plus 1 equals 26. 26 equals game.” “I’m never going to bid a 1 point hand,” she replied. We never played together again. Bridge players take this commitment seriously.

Think about it, gentle reader. If your partner has a huge hand, more than half the points in the deck, you probably won’t have much. But that doesn’t mean that you don’t have much between you. As I told my ex-partner, $25 + 1 = \text{game}$. *When your partner opens a 2-level bid, you don’t need much to make game.*

So, when are you off the hook? When may you pass? Answer:

- + You may pass when the partnership has bid game; or
- + When opener rebids her suit; or
- + When opener rebids 2NT.

The corollary to this rule is this: *If opener bids a new suit, partner must bid again.*

Opener is definitely in control of this hand. Responder must respect opener’s bidding. No matter how terrible responder’s hand, unless opener lets her off the hook by bidding game or by rebidding her suit, responder must keep the bidding open.

Responder may bid her own suit, but she must have a five-card suit with at least king-jack. However, if she responds to an opening 2-level bid with a suit bid of her own (other than a 2 diamonds response to a 2 clubs open, which is a semiautomatic bid that both have agreed says nothing about diamonds, which I’ll explain later), she is making a 100 percent game-forcing bid. Whereas a Strong Two opener can stop short of game by rebidding her suit, if you, as responder, bid a new suit at your first bid, you and your partner have agreed you will not stop short of game.

A *forcing bid* is a bid that requires your partner to make a bid other than Pass if there is no intervening bid. It forces your partner to keep the bidding open so you can make another bid when it comes back to you.

Weak Response to Opening 2 Bids in Diamonds, Hearts, and Spades

If you have absolutely nothing, you respond to your partner's Strong Two opening bid in diamonds, hearts, or spades with a bid of 2 no trump. This implies that it is a negative response, so your partner immediately suspects you are holding dreck. She doesn't know it for sure, but it's a strong suspicion.

Opener *cannot pass* a 2 no trump response by you. This is important because a 2 no trump response does not absolutely promise a terrible hand. You might have a balanced hand with some points but without trump support for your partner's opening bid.

What then? You would have to respond 2 no trump. So, 2 no trump is a bid that warns your partner you might not have much, but still holds out the hope that you do have something. This is why your partner must bid again. A response of 2 no trump can be interpreted as asking your partner to bid her second suit if she has one. But it must be a four-card suit. Let's look at a hand held by responder:

♠ 53
♥ 9864
♦ 765
♣ 8742

Phew! But your partner opens 2 spades—your worst fear. Not much to think about, right? You respond 2 no trump, saying, “My hand smells to high heaven, but do you have another suit because a five-card spade suit won't work?”

Your partner rebids 3 hearts, telling you she has at least four hearts (and probably denying that she has six spades, because, as you will learn in the section on rebids by opening bidder later in this chapter, she can rebid a six-card suit). Hearts is a new suit, so you have to bid again. Since you do have heart support, and you know you have at least eight hearts between you, you can bid 4 hearts.

Rules for Responding to Strong Two Opening Bids in Diamonds, Hearts, or Spades

There are at least seven things you should know about responding to a Strong Two opening bid in diamonds, hearts, or spades.

- + You cannot pass.
- + If you have a five-card suit headed by the king and jack, you should bid it.
- + If you do not have a five-card suit but you do have at least one king, and if you also have three-card support for your partner's opening suit, you should raise immediately. It is worth noting here that when you have a fit, a singleton in an outside suit becomes as valuable as a king. You'll learn more about responding in [Chapter 11](#).
- + The only circumstance under which you may pass after your first response is if you respond 2 no trump and your partner rebids her opening suit.
- + If you bid your own suit in response to your partner's opening bid you must keep the bidding open to game, even if your partner rebids her suit.
- + You cannot support opener's second suit unless you have at least four cards in it.
- + If your RHO bids, you may pass.

Bid these hands with your partner opening 2 diamonds:

1. ♠ KJ863	2. ♠ 86	3. ♠ KJ76	4. ♠ A4	5. ♠ 9865
♥ 863	♥ Q10742	♥ 874	♥ 109632	♥ Q63
♦ J74	♦ 98	♦ J109	♦ J103	♦ 42
♣ 107	♣ QJ104	♣ 842	♣ 632	♣ 8542

Hand 1: 2 spades. You have a five-card spade suit headed by the king-jack and 6 points. This is a perfect hand with which to make a positive response. Your partner is promising at least 22 points, and you have 6 points. You should have game somewhere, so your bid forces opener to keep the bidding open to game, and you promise the opener that you'll keep the bidding open to game.

Hand 2: 2 no trump. Even though you have 7 points, you can't bid your five-card heart suit because it is headed by less than the king-jack. You have a very good hand and intend to tell your partner about it after her rebid. Remember, a 2 no trump response does not promise a terrible hand; it only implies it. Opener cannot pass your bid of 2 no trump.

Hand 3: 3 diamonds. You can't bid your spades because you don't have five. But you do have three-card support for opener's suit, so you should tell her this.

Hand 4: 3 diamonds again. You can't bid your hearts because they aren't strong enough, but you do have three diamonds and an ace.

Hand 5: 2 no trump. This is a stinkeroo. The only thing that could save it would be for her to rebid her diamonds, in which case you could pass, or for her to bid spades at her second bid, in which case you could go to 4 spades because you'd be assured of a 4-4 spade fit.

Bidding Sequence

Let's look at a bidding sequence when responder has a Yarborough. This is your hand when you hear your partner open 2 spades:

♠ 986
♥ 875
♦ 954
♣ 9832

Partner

2 ♠ (1)

3 ♦ (3)

4 ♣ (5)

P (7)

You

2 NT (2)

3 ♠ (4)

4 ♠ (6)

1. I've got a *great* hand with at least five spades.
2. I'm glad yours is good. Mine stinks.
3. I've also got a diamond suit. At least four of them. I don't care how bad your hand is, I *insist* you bid again.
4. Okay. I do have some support for your spade suit. I'm still not happy about this and would like to pass next time. Can I pass?
5. I'm glad to hear about your spade support. I've also got something in clubs. No, you can't pass because we can definitely make at least game. Can you give me any

help? We may have a slam!

6. If I've said this once, I've said it a million times. I have absolutely no interest in slam. So far as I can tell we can't make anything. I have no help for you except three spades. Please, can we pass?
7. Pass. Okay, pard. I trust you.

This was your partner's hand:

♠ AKQJ10

♥ A

♦ AKJ7

♣ AK8

She bid it well. She communicated with you as agreed. She could continue to bid with complete confidence that you would not pass her out in either of her secondary suits, diamonds and clubs, so long as she continued to bid new suits.

After you had established spades as your agreed-upon trump, all of your partner's remaining bids were simply to tell you that she had strength in these suits. If you had anything at all in those suits, you would have supported them and she would have ended up in slam. All you needed was the queen of clubs or the queen of diamonds and the hand was cold for 6 spades.

This is a classic example of how partners must trust one another. Your partner trusted you to continue to bid as long as she bid a new suit. She could bid a four-card suit, diamonds, knowing that you'd bid again. She could bid a three-card suit, clubs, knowing that you'd bid again. See what a disaster it would have been if you had four clubs and passed her 4 club bid because you thought your hand was terrible and wanted to "save" her?

You trusted her by continuing to bid. Your hand was awful, but you continued to bid in response to her forcing bids. That was your agreement. You cannot make unilateral decisions and nullify your agreements with your partner. If you've agreed upon a system, like continuing to bid when your partner opens a Strong Two whenever your

partner bids a new suit, you must comply with that agreement, regardless of your interpretation of the strength of your hand.

Finally, she trusted your weak responses and closed out at 4 spades. Many people with less trust in their partners would ignore all the negative information you had transmitted, and *unilaterally* gone on to slam by themselves, to their ultimate chagrin.

Response to Strong Two Club Opening

When your partner opens a Strong Two in clubs, your responses change. You can still bid a decent five-card suit headed by at least the king-jack. But your negative, or *waiting* response is now 2 diamonds, not 2 no trump.

The reason 2 diamonds is used as a waiting bid is to keep the bidding low so opener can describe her hand at the lowest level possible. Because opener would have opened with a bid of her five-card suit, her response is almost always 2 no trump when you bid 2 diamonds. About the only time her response is not 2 no trump is when she has opened a five-card or better club suit.

Rules for Responding to Strong Two Club Opening Bid

The following list explains what you should know about responding to the Strong Two club opening bid:

- + You cannot pass an opening bid of 2 clubs.
- + If you have a five-card suit headed by the king-jack or better, you should bid it.
- + If you don't have a five-card suit headed by the king-jack, you must bid 2 diamonds as a waiting bid, regardless of the strength or length of your diamond suit.
- + If opener rebids 2 no trump, she is telling you she has a balanced hand with 22 to 24 points. You may pass with less than 3 points.
- + As long as opener bids a new suit, you must continue bidding if your RHO passes the bid to you.
- + If RHO bids, you may pass.

- + You cannot support opener's second suit unless you have at least four cards in it.
- + If opener responds 2 no trump to your 2 diamonds waiting bid, the hand is treated as if opener opened a no trump bid, and you respond in accordance with [Chapter 10](#) on no trump responses.
- + Make a note here that no trump response systems are on when opener rebids 2 no trump after a Strong Two clubs open. You don't know what this means yet. You will learn about this in [Chapter 17](#), and at that time this will make sense to you.

If opener opens 2 clubs and then bids a new suit after you make your 2 diamonds waiting bid, what does that tell you about her hand? Think about it before you answer, because this is the type of question you should always be asking yourself in bridge.

What does it tell you? It tells you that she opened up a club suit with at least five cards in it, that she probably has at least four of the suit she bid at her second opportunity, and that she has more clubs than she has of her second suit. She has not opened up a balanced 22+ point hand. That's quite a lot of information, don't you think?

Example Hands Responding to Strong Two Club Opening Bid

Your partner opens with a bid of 2 clubs. How do you respond with the following hands?

1. ♠ KJ75	2. ♠ 10974	3. ♠ KJ983	4. ♠ 3	5. ♠ 87
♥ Q10864	♥ QJ97	♥ 986	♥ 9854	♥ 863
♦ KJ7	♦ 4	♦ 96	♦ 973	♦ 109865
♣ 9	♣ QJ98	♣ K108	♣ KQ965	♣ 983

Hand 1: 2 diamonds. You don't have a five-card suit headed by the king-jack, so 2 diamonds is your only bid. Your heart suit, which has five cards headed by two honors (the queen–10), isn't strong enough, and your spade suit, headed by the king-jack, isn't long enough. So, 2 diamonds just says, "I'm here. Tell me more."

Hand 2: 2 diamonds. This bid says nothing about your diamond suit. It just says that you are complying with your agreement to keep the bidding open, but denies that you have a five-card suit headed by the king-jack.

A 2 diamond response to an opening bid of 2 clubs is automatic if you don't have a five-card suit headed by the king-jack. It can be negative or neutral. It just keeps the bidding open for your partner to further describe her hand.

Hand 3: 2 spades. You have a good five-card suit headed by the king-jack and 8 points. That's plenty good enough to tell your partner what you have.

Hand 4: 3 clubs. Any five-card suit headed by two of the top three honors is worth an immediate bid even if it's clubs. The reason: If you bid 2 diamonds first, planning on showing 3 clubs later, the Strong Two bidder won't realize your suit is this good! You may be bidding 3 clubs for lack of anything better on QJ10x4, or K109xx.

Hand 5: 2 diamonds. You're not bidding your five-card diamond suit. You're just keeping the bidding open. If your RHO bids after your partner's 2 clubs opening bid, you should pass because you have no obligation to make a free bid (discussed in [Chapter 10](#)) that would indicate a fairly good hand. The obligation to bid only arises in the situation where opener's bid could be passed around to her. Because opener will have another opportunity to bid over RHO's bid, you need not bid. Your pass after RHO's bid communicates your weakness to her.

Rebids by Strong Two Bidder in Diamonds, Hearts, or Spades

After you've opened a Strong Two bid, you must continue to describe your hand to your partner until the two of you have arrived at a decision as to what the best contract is. Because the bidding has started at a high level, however, there isn't a lot of bidding space for you to communicate.

So, the first thing you do is evaluate your partner's response:

- + Did she bid a new suit? If so, you know she has at least a five-card suit headed by at least the king-jack.
- + Did she raise your suit? If so, you know she's probably working on a minimum, which, at this level, isn't much, but she has at least three cards in your suit.

- + Did she bid 2 no trump? Then you know that she probably (but not definitely) has a hand without an ace or a king and she has less than 4 points. With a Yarborough—no card higher than a 9—but three-card support for your partner's suit, after a Strong Two opening, don't raise your partner's suit. Bid 2 no trump first, then show your support for your partner's suit at your second response. Raising immediately to 3 spades shows that you have a little something in addition to your three-card support. So, you must evaluate what you know from your partner's response.

Some Rules for Rebids

Here are two rules for rebid by opener in 2 diamonds, hearts, or spades:

1. If your partner has given you a positive response by bidding a new suit, it is forcing to game, so you can never pass until game is reached. Even rebidding your suit is forcing your partner to bid because she has made the bid that forces your pair to game.
2. If you bid a new suit, it is forcing on your partner for one round. The only time your partner may pass you is if you rebid no trump or rebid your own suit.

Here are two rules for rebid by Strong Two club opener:

1. If your partner has made a 2 diamond waiting bid, any bid of a suit by you shows a second suit equal to or shorter than your club suit. The second suit may be only four cards in length. If it is higher ranking (like opening 2H and then rebidding 3S), it almost certainly shows 6-5 or 7-6 in length of the two suits.
2. A response of 2 no trump shows 22 to 24 HCP and a balanced hand, whereas a response of 3 no trump shows 27 to 28 HCP and a balanced hand. Any no trump rebid by a 2 club opener usually implies that opener doesn't have a long club suit.

With this in mind, look at the following hand:

♠ AKQJ104

♥ AKQ7

♦ A8

♣ 4

After your 2 spades opening bid, your partner responds 2 no trump. Now what? If you rebid your strong six-card spade suit, your partner may pass. You don't want that to occur because you have a cold game in your hand.

You can bid 4 spades, but you don't need to do that yet. Remember, *you are in control*. Your partner may not pass if you bid a new suit. And you have a four-card major you can bid, hearts. So, you bid 3 hearts. This bid is forcing, but it only promises a four-card suit. (To *pull trump* or to *draw trump* means for declarer to lead trump until opponents have no more trump in their hands. It's a standard method of playing a hand, and you'll learn all about it in [Chapter 23](#).)

If your partner raises your hearts, she is promising a four-card suit. *Responder cannot raise opener's second suit without at least four cards in it*. If she raises hearts, then just play it in 4 hearts and don't worry about your six spades. They'll come in very handy after you *pull trump*.

If your partner responds 3 no trump or 4 of a minor to your heart bid, you can return to 4 spades at that time. That puts you in game and is a bid that your partner may pass.

Playing 3 No Trump After Opening a Strong Two Bid in Diamonds, Hearts, or Spades

Sometimes when you have a long suit and an unbalanced hand, 3 no trump is still your best contract. Look at the following:

♠ 9

♥ AKQ76

♦ AQJ10

♣ AK6

Partner

2♥ (1)

3♦ (3)

3NT (5)

You

2♠ (2)

3♥ (4)

P (6)

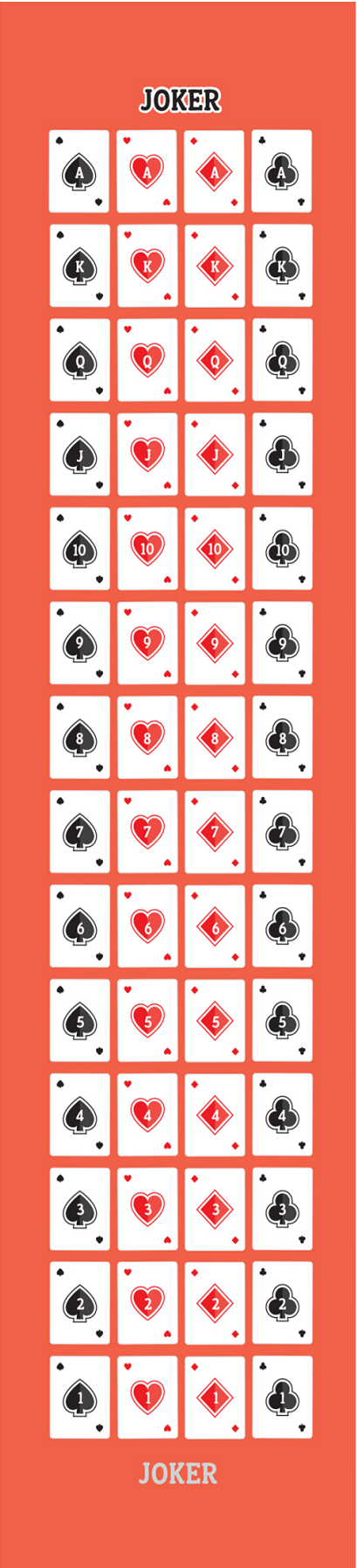
1. I've got a *terrific* hand with at least five hearts.
2. I've got something. In fact, I've got at least five spades and they are headed by not less than the king-jack.
3. I've got at least four diamonds. Do we have a fit in either hearts or diamonds?
Give me a preference.
4. Okay, of the two suits, I prefer hearts to diamonds, but I'm not promising great heart support, maybe only two.
5. I've shown you everything I have. Your five-card spade suit is interesting but I don't have more than two. I don't know how many hearts you have. I'm satisfied to play this in 3 no trump but if you have three hearts, take the bid to 4 hearts. Because you know my hand is exceptionally good, I am relying on you to take it to a higher level if you have more in your hand than the decent spade suit you have already told me about.
6. I've told you all I can. I only have two hearts. Let's play it in 3 no trump.

Your partner's hand?

♠ KQ986
♥ 75
♦ 97
♣ Q873

In 3 no trump you have three heart tricks, three diamond tricks, three club tricks, and spades stopped twice. You should make at least 4 no trump, but you will definitely make 3.

Stop reading. Deal, bid, and play some hands, using what you've learned in Chapters 1 through 7.



Chapter 8

**Preemptive
Openings**

In the previous chapters, I showed you how to evaluate and open hands that contain at least 12 High-Card Points (HCP). However, sometimes you have a hand that doesn't have 12 HCP but contains qualities that you want to communicate to your partner. This chapter tells you what these hands are, how to evaluate them, and how to bid them.

We're talking preempts now! This is real down and dirty because a preempt is a defensive bid. Essentially, you're trying to foul-up your opponents. Basically, you don't have a very good hand, but your hand does possess the qualities that can allow you to throw a monkey wrench into your opponents' bidding. Ah, preempts are a lot of fun!

A Concise Description of a Nonopening Hand

You should now be able to deduce what kind of hand *not* to open at the 1 level. You shouldn't open if you don't have at least 12 HCP (there are exceptions to this which I will explain later). If you pick up your cards and count your HCP and they don't add up to at least 12, you're probably going to pass.

But what if you have a long suit, and not much else? Is there any value in communicating this to your partner? And if so, how do you do it? "Pass" doesn't tell her much, except that you don't have 12 HCP.

But what happens if one of your opponents has 12 HCP and a five-card club suit headed by the ace-king, and you open 3 diamonds in front of him? He had a hand that he would have clearly opened 1 club; but you've bid 3 diamonds! What's he to do? Is his hand worth bidding 4 clubs when he has no idea what his partner has? It puts him in a terrible dilemma. You could steal a bid at 3 diamonds when they could, conceivably, have a game. You've kept them from finding the game by starting the bidding at a level that makes it dangerous for them to bid.

What Is a Preempt?

A *preemptive bid* is one that's made at a high level. It's made with a hand with a long suit and not many HCP. Its purpose is to constrict opponents, who may have most of the HCP, and make it more difficult for them to find their contract. Plus, if your partner has the right cards, a preempt can let you play a game your way!

Point and Suit Quality Requirements

When you're in first or second seat, your preempts should be fairly disciplined. You should promise at least a good suit, headed by two of the top five honors in the suit, and some values, but not much.

You shouldn't preempt when you have more than 9 HCP. Why? What you've learned here is that you should open a hand at the 1 level if you have 12 HCP. If you have a seven-card suit and 10 HCP, you must have at least 12 points counting distribution, which would require an opening at the 1 level instead of a preempt. Look at the following hand:

♠ AKQJ873
♥ 87
♦ 75
♣ 52

You have 10 HCP. You have three doubletons, each of which is worth a point. That's 13 points. Open 1 spade. Even if the six non-spades cards are changed around so you have a different combination of singletons and voids, your hand will always add up to 13 points. A hand with 10 HCP that includes a seven-card suit will always have 13 total points. Thus any hand with a seven-card suit and 10 HCP must be opened at the 1 level. Look at your partner's possible hand:

♠ 973
♥ AK432
♦ 9
♣ 9876

That's only 9 points, so she passed originally. If you open 3 spades, she'll probably pass again. If you open 1 spade, however, she's going to support you because she has 9 points

and 3 spades. And you're cold for 4 spades. If you bid your 10-point hand preemptively, you're preempting yourselves out of a cold game. You must have all of the following in order to open a suit at the 3 level:

- + A seven-card suit
- + A suit headed by at least the queen-10
- + 4 to 9 HCP
- + No *outside* ace (Any honor in a suit other than your long suit is said to be outside. So, if your long suit is hearts and you have the ace of spades, it's an outside ace.)
- + Not more than one outside king
- + When opening in a minor suit, no four-card major

Making an Opponent's Life Miserable with Preempts

Think how you feel when you look at a terrific, 15-point hand with five hearts. You're in the second seat and you're just salivating to get into this hand, when you hear your RHO say, "3 spades." Wow! What do you do? You know he's weak with seven spades, but where are the HCP in this hand? Do you just bid 4 hearts—game—with 15 points? Maybe your LHO is sitting there with 15 points, too, and he's just waiting to pounce on you.

This is an example of how preempting can really throw the next bidder (in this case, you) for a loop! Your RHO really caught you off guard; you're not sure what to do now.

That's the value of a 3 level preempt. It makes life miserable for the opponents because it raises the level of the bidding so high. Because you are opening on a seven-card suit, and some values, you might be set a couple of tricks if you get the contract. But you might find your partner with some values, and make three, stealing a game from your opponents.

First Position Opening

Any preemptive bid constrains subsequent bidders, including your partner. When you're in first seat, you should be aware that nobody—including your partner—has bid yet. So, if you make a preemptive bid, you're not only constraining your opponents, but your partner as well.

As former UCLA and Los Angeles Rams football coach, Tommy Prothro once said, “When you put the ball in the air, three things can happen, and two of them are *bad* for your side.” When you are in first seat, the odds are at least two-to-one that a substantial portion of the remaining points are in your opponents' hands. Therefore, you have more to gain by making a preemptive bid when you're in first seat than when you're in second seat.

Second Position Opening

The numbers change when you're in second seat and your RHO has passed. Now you are preempting only two people, one of whom is your partner. You know that your RHO doesn't have 12 HCP, and you have a weak hand, so there are probably at least 25 HCP distributed in the two remaining hands, one of whom is your loving partner. She might be waiting over there across the table from you, eager to open this hand 1 no trump, or maybe even a Strong Two demand. Can you imagine the look you're going to get when you preempt *her* and open 3 diamonds? Because you already know that one of your opponents, your RHO, has less than an opening hand, a preempt in second seat is less effective than a preempt in first seat. You can do it, but be prepared for your partner's reaction if she's the one with the points.

Third Position Opening

Here's where you can really take a chance. Your partner has already passed, so you know she doesn't have an opening hand. She was in first position and didn't bid. So, if your RHO has passed, and you have a seven-card suit and only 5 HCP, you can rest assured that your LHO has a very good hand indeed. While it's true that both your

partner and RHO might have passed 11-point hands, it's not highly probable. So, this is where your 3 level preempt is called for, no matter what the strength of your suit.

In third position, the only person you're constraining is your LHO. You need have no fear that your partner is sitting there with a good hand because she's already told you she doesn't have one. So basically, the sky's the limit. The weaker your hand in the third seat, the more incentive you should have to make a preemptive bid.

Let's say that you're looking at a hand with 4 HCP and seven spades headed by the queen-10. How many points are in the other three hands? Did you say 36, subtracting your 4 HCP from the total of 40 HCP? Well, if you did, you were wrong. You forgot to distinguish between distribution points and HCP.

Sure, there are 40 HCP in a hand, but if you have seven spades (or seven of any suit), then there are 3 extra distribution points spread around the table. There are only six spades spread among three hands. That's an average of two per hand. So, how many points does that give each of the three other players? If they're evenly divided, 2 spades per hand (each of the other players will have 1 HCP point and 1 distribution point). No matter how you divide the cards among the other three players, there must be 3 distribution points in this hand, in addition to the HCP, if you have seven cards in one suit.

So, there are 39 points divided among the other three players. Because your partner and RHO have passed, they can't have more than 11 HCP points each—a total of 22. This means that your LHO must have at least 17 points in his hand (39 minus 22). What a great time to preempt!

Fourth Position Opening

All the rules change in fourth position. There's no need to preempt because nobody has much of a hand. So, why open up a weak hand at the 3 level when you might go set? Why open up at all? If you open at the 1 level you might force your opponents into bidding, and they might find a partscore. Better to pass the hand out. When you're

in fourth seat and nobody has opened in front of you, you have total control of the hand. If you bid, bidding continues and your opponents will each have another opportunity to discover a contract with their sub-opening hands. If you pass, however, the hand is over; nobody will have another chance to bid. Remember this rule: *Don't open in the fourth seat unless you have a legitimate opening hand*. A corollary to the rule is this: *Don't preempt in fourth seat*.

Preemptive Openings at the 4 Level

If you need a seven-card suit to open a weak hand at the 3 level, how long must your suit be to open at the 4 level? Did you say eight cards? Right on!

You can open any eight-card suit at the 4 level if it meets all of the following requirements:

- + At least eight cards in length (is this redundant, or what?)
- + At least two of the top four honors (at least king–jack) in your long suit
- + 4 to 9 HCP
- + No outside ace
- + Only one outside king
- + If opening a minor suit, no four-card major

Again, you must be sensitive to the seat in which you're sitting. In the first or second seat you'll be preempting your partner, as well as your opponents, so you must tell her what you have. There's no problem with preempting at the 4 level in first or second position—just be certain that you have what you say you have. If your partner has a big hand, she can decide whether or not to make a higher bid.

Possible Double

One thing you should be sensitive to when opening at the 4 level in hearts or spades is that opponents are more liable to *double* you than if you open at the 3 level. When you open at the 3 level, they would be *doubling you into game*, which, if you made it, would give you a huge bonus.

Double is a call that increases the scoring value of the number of tricks declarer is set or the number of tricks he makes. You make it when you believe the opponents have bid too high and that you can set them.

Doubling into game means that your opponents have doubled what would only be a partial, like two hearts. If you make it, you get the equivalent of 4 hearts, which makes game. Doubling into game is risky, and the penalties for failure are severe. For details on doubling, see [Chapter 21](#).

There is no such fear if you open up in a major at the 4 level because you're bidding game, so the penalty to the opponents for failure is much less. For example, if you're nonvulnerable and bid and make three hearts, if doubled, you would get 530 points above and below the line. Whereas if you were undoubled, you would only get 90 points below the line—a difference of 440 points!

However, if you bid and make 4 hearts doubled you would get 590 points above and below the line, versus 420 above and below the line undoubled—which is only 170 points more. So, the difference between *doubling into game* versus doubling a game bid is huge. If you open up a preemptive hand at the 3 level, your opponents will be reluctant to double you because of the huge penalty they will suffer if you make your contract. But if you open up a preemptive hand at the 4 level in a major suit, your opponents will feel freer to double because the penalty for failure is much less. The risk of being doubled is something you should take far more seriously when you open up a preemptive hand in game than if you preempt below game.

Why the requirement that the hand be weak to open up at high levels (4 level for majors and 5 level for minors), especially when you're opening at game? The reason is because of the possibility of a slam. You don't want to preempt your partner because you don't want to preempt yourselves out of finding a slam.

Preemptive Openings at the 5 Level

Okay, class, if you need a seven-card suit to open a weak hand at the 3 level, and an eight-card suit to open a weak hand at the 4 level, how long must your suit be to open at the 5 level? Can you say “nine cards”?

Well if you did, you should have qualified it. You can open preemptively at the 5 level only in a minor suit. You shouldn't open a major suit at the 5 level preemptively. Why? Because game in a major suit is only four, so if you have a nine-card major suit and otherwise satisfy the requirements for a 5-level opening, just open at the 4 level. Why overbid if you don't have to?

Requirements to open a suit at the 5 level are as follows:

- + Must be clubs or diamonds
- + Nine-card suit
- + Suit must be headed by at least two of the top four honors (at least king–jack)
- + 4 to 9 HCP
- + No outside ace
- + Only one outside king

Rule of Two, Three, and Four

One simple way of determining whether or not to make a preemptive opening is to count your tricks. The *rule of two, three, and four* may be used as a guide for you; here's how it works:

If you're vulnerable and your opponents aren't (this is called *unfavorable vulnerability*), you can overbid your hand by two tricks. That is, if your hand shows that you can take seven tricks with your long suit as trump, you can make a preemptive 3 level opening.

If you and your opponents both have the same vulnerability—either you're both vulnerable or you are both nonvulnerable (this is called *equal vulnerability*)—you can overbid your hand by three tricks. That is, if your hand

shows that you can take six tricks with your long suit as trump, you can make a preemptive 3 level opening.

If you aren't vulnerable and your opponents are (this is called *favorable vulnerability*), you can overbid your hand by four tricks. That is, if your hand shows you can take five tricks with your long suit as trump, you can make a preemptive 3 level opening.

As a general rule of thumb, you can figure that a good seven-card suit should take five tricks, and eight- and nine-card suits should have a maximum of two losers, regardless of their high-card strength. So, an eight-card suit should take six tricks, and a nine-card suit should take seven tricks. It doesn't always work out like that, but it will most of the time.

Example hands follow:

Unfavorable Vulnerability	Equal Vulnerability	Favorable Vulnerability
♠ 98	♠ QJ109874	♠ QJ109852
♥ 7	♥ KQ	♥ J85
♦ QJ109642	♦ 865	♦ 74
♣ KQJ	♣ 6	♣ 3

In the unfavorable vulnerability hand, you should have five diamonds tricks and two clubs tricks. That's seven tricks, so you can open 3 diamonds in any seat.

In the equal hand, you have five spades tricks and a hearts trick for six total tricks, so you can open 3 spades.

In the favorable vulnerability hand, even though you only have 4 HCP, and only 7 total points, you should have five spades tricks, so open this hand with 3 spades. There are 36 HCP spread among the other hands. If your partner has a substantial number, she knows that you have seven spades and can go to 4 spades if she has outside power and even as little as one spade in her hand. If the points are in your opponents' hands, however, you have constrained their bidding substantially. The worst that can happen is

that you miss making your contract by two tricks (called being “down 2” or “set 2”), for 100 points above the line for them, undoubled.

Counting Sure Tricks

A *sure trick* is a trick you know you will definitely take, like the ace of trump. You count sure tricks the same way you count quick tricks (see [Chapter 4](#)). But in this instance, for the purposes of evaluating your hand under the rule of two, three, and four, you can also count any four-card suit as a trick. So, look at the following hand:

♠ Q1097653
♥ 74
♦ 8754
♣ Q

This has 4 HCP, but you can count your seven-card trump suit as capable of producing five tricks, and your four-card suit should produce an additional trick, so this should be a six-trick hand that you can open 3 spades with favorable or equal vulnerability. In fact, in third seat, you shouldn't hesitate to open this 3 spades, because it could cause your RHO in fourth seat, who is undoubtedly salivating to open his huge hand with a demand bid, to go ballistic.

Opener's Subsequent Bidding

Under no circumstances should a preemptive opener bid again unless your partner makes a forcing bid. You've described your hand to your partner. You have no idea what's in her hand. She knows your hand much better than you know hers. You've told your story. Leave it up to her. If she bids, fine. If she bids a new suit below game, you are forced to bid. Otherwise, stay out of it! It's up to her to place the contract. If she doubles opponents, trust her. If you haven't lied to her, she should know what to do.

Let's try bidding some hands:

1. ♠ 5	2. ♠ 75	3. ♠ 873	4. ♠ QJ98643	5. ♠ J876543
♥ 9832	♥ 84	♥ KJ985432	♥ 76	♥ KQ
♦ KQJ9832	♦ 6	♦ KJ	♦ Void	♦ 97
♣ 7	♣ KJ986532	♣ Void	♣ KQ87	♣ 87

Remember that whenever you make a preemptive bid, even if you're bidding game, you are showing a weak hand, a hand that doesn't have enough points to open at the 1 level.

Hand 1: Pass in the first or second seat because you have a four-card major. However, I'd open 3 diamonds in third seat. You have 4 hearts, but only 6 HCP. In third seat your LHO probably has a good hand. It's worth the risk that you and your partner might miss a heart fit to preempt this hand in third seat only. There is a total of 37 points—34 HCP and at least 3 distribution points—in the other three hands. If your partner and RHO have the maximum of 11 each, that leaves 14 for LHO. But the odds are that both your partner and LHO don't have 11 each, so your LHO is sitting there with a big hand. Hit him with a preempt now while you can.

Hand 2: 4 clubs. Again, count the points. There are 36 HCP and 4 distribution points in the other three hands (five clubs distributed among three hands equals 4 distribution points no matter how you slice it). So, that's 40 points in the other three hands. Because you know your partner and RHO can't have more than 11 each, that leaves a minimum of 17 points in your LHO's hand. Your LHO is undoubtedly sitting there with a big hand.

Hand 3: 4 hearts. The difference between this hand and Hand 2 is that this hand has *side strength*. And you're opening up in game. Side strength means strength in a suit other than the trump suit or the suit you are bidding. For instance, if you're bidding clubs, the ace of hearts would be side strength in hearts.

Hand 4: Open this 3 spades at all levels of vulnerability and in all seats. This is a maximum preempt, because you have 8 HCP and 4 distribution points (1 for the doubleton and 3 for the void) for 12 total points. You don't need much help from your partner for game. If your partner has only the ace of hearts and the jack of clubs, you

have a very good shot at game. But if you open 1 spade, you'd be lying to your partner because you don't have 12 points. A danger in opening Hand 4 with 1 spade is not that you don't have ample "playing tricks" to make some number of spades, but that, when the opponents compete, which they surely will, your partner will "double" them, counting on you for more defensive values.

Hand 5: Pass in first and second seats. Open 3 spades with equal or favorable vulnerability in third seat. Pass with unfavorable vulnerability. Your suit is very weak, but you can still count on five tricks from it, plus a heart trick.

Everyone listens to the bidding. When you make a preemptive opening you tell *everybody*, not just your partner, that you have a weak hand. So, what you have is no secret.

Responses to Preemptive Openings

How do you respond if your partner makes a preemptive opening? Because responses to preempts are completely different from responses to normal openings, I explain them here.

If your partner opens with a preemptive bid and you bid anything other than game or to support her suit, she should bid again. If you bid game in a major or 3 no trump, your partner should pass. If you raise her suit, she can pass. In other words, a raise is the only nonforcing bid (RONF) you can make when your partner opens with a preemptive bid. That's all you need to know. Next subject.

Okay, okay, I'll show you some hands, because you can get into real trouble when you have a good hand and your partner opens with a preempt, especially when it's short of game. In the following hands, your partner opens 3 diamonds:

1. ♠ KQ73 ♥ KQ73 ♦ 7 ♣ KQ83	2. ♠ K87 ♥ QJ10 ♦ A73 ♣ QJ83	3. ♠ AKJ863 ♥ AK984 ♦ 8 ♣ 7	4. ♠ K84 ♥ 83 ♦ 983 ♣ QJ1094
5. ♠ KJ98653 ♥ Q73 ♦ Void ♣ Q93	6. ♠ 8 ♥ KJ84 ♦ J52 ♣ Q10942		

Hand 1: Pass. Surprised? Are you saying to yourself, “Wait a minute, I have 15 HCP. This is a terrific hand. I’ve got all the other suits stopped twice! We can make 3 no trump.” If this is what you’re saying, then you have a lot of company. I have partners today who would want to bid 3 no trump with this hand; but it would be a big, big mistake. Why? Because you have no source of tricks from your partner, that’s why. Are you saying, “But she opened 3 diamonds! She’s got diamonds tricks!”? Wrong! She is telling you she has a *weak* hand! Because she opened in first or second seat (you would have opened if you were bidding before her!), she is only promising you a suit headed by the king–jack and 4 points. That’s her minimum. Would you want to play this in 3 no trump and see the following hand from her?

♠ 652
♥ 8
♦ KJ86542
♣ 62

Can you make 3 no trump with these two hands? If so, you’re ready for the Bridge Hall of Fame. But this hand is all your partner is promising you when she opens 3 diamonds in first seat. Never lose sight of the fact that the primary message your partner is sending you when she makes a preemptive opening is “My hand is *weak!*” She might be at the top of her bid, 9 points, but you can’t count on that. You have to count on her having a minimum when you respond.

In addition to the fact that you will have a hard time making 3 no trump, you’ve got a terrific defensive hand. If opponents compete and bid anything else at the 3 or 4 level, you have a great chance of setting them because you’ve got length and strength in all

the other suits. So, just sit back and reap the rewards! This is a hand where you pass and pray that your opponents bid. You want them playing this hand.

Hand 2: 3 no trump. Fooled you! Now you must really be confused. Why can't you bid 3 no trump on the first hand, that has 15 HCP, but can bid 3 no trump on this hand with only 14 HCP? The answer is because you have good diamonds support for partner's bid. She has promised *at least* KJxxxxx of diamonds. You have Axx. You should be able to take at least six diamond tricks, probably seven if the rest of the diamonds don't split 3–0 between your opponents. And you have *transportation*, because, in addition to the ace of diamonds, you have two small diamonds to lead to dummy.

Transportation is the ability to get the lead back and forth between declarer's hand and the dummy. In Hand 1 you have no transportation to dummy, because you only have one diamond and no other way to get back to dummy, because dummy has no other entries.

An *entry* is a card that enables you to get the lead into a specific hand.

Hand 3: 3 spades. This is a hand where you want to contract to play in game, either 4 hearts or 4 spades. So, you bid 3 spades. This forces your partner to bid again because if you bid a new suit it is *forcing*, remember? Therefore, unless your partner bids 4 spades, you're going to bid 4 hearts at your next call. This tells your partner, "I want to play this in 4 hearts or 4 spades, so take your pick." If she has two in one suit and one in the other, she'll pick the one in which she has two. If her best suit is hearts, she passes 4 hearts. If it's spades, she bids 4 spades. If she has relatively equivalent holdings in both, she should choose your first bid suit—spades—because you should have an equal number or longer spades. Under no circumstances can she take the contract to 5 diamonds.

Hand 4: 4 diamonds. Remember that a raise is the only nonforcing bid when your partner makes a preemptive opening. You have a five-card club suit that might be able to be developed as a source for tricks; shortness in hearts; the king of spades; and three

trumps. Therefore, you should make a competitive bid to restrict your opponents' bidding space. And your partner has a fair chance of making it.

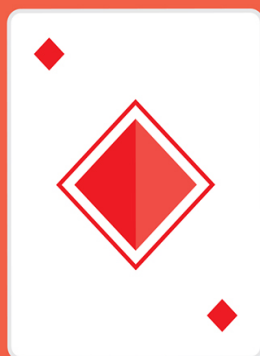
Hand 5: Pass. Sure, you'd rather play this as 3 spades than 3 diamonds. But you can't make a preemptive bid over your partner's preemptive opening. If you bid 3 spades, it's a forcing bid that tells your partner you have a big hand. You don't. That's the risk one takes when making a preemptive opening. Your partner may have a better preempt. If your partner makes a preemptive opening and you have this type of hand, you just have to ride it out and let her play it in a less favorable contract.

Hand 6: 4 diamonds. There are two instances in which a raise of her suit is a good idea. The first was Hand 4, where you had a nice outside five-card suit you might be able to develop and three-card trump support. The second is if you have a singleton with at least three trump, which is what you have here in Hand 6. Shortness in an outside suit doesn't help you much if you're also short in trump. But if you have at least three trump, your partner should be able to get at least one, maybe two tricks by trumping your short suit in dummy.

How to preempt and how to handle preempts is not only important, it is very gratifying when what you do works!

Part 3

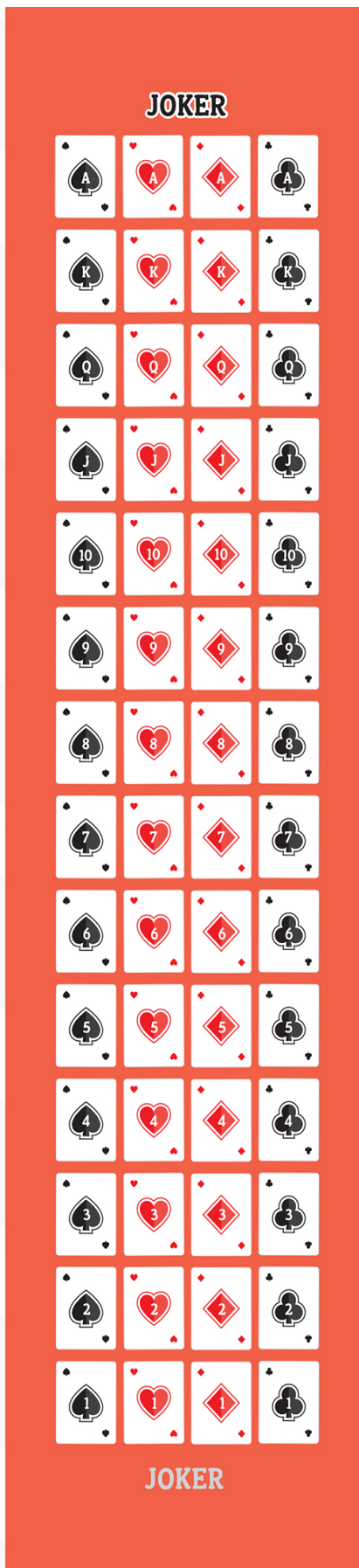
WEAK TWOS AND RESPONSES TO OPENING BIDS



After your partner has made her initial description of her hand, it's up to you to respond.

If her opening bid is a no trump bid, your response tells her that you have taken control of the hand. Instead of telling her what you have, you'll be asking her for a more specific description of her hand so that you can place the final contract. This part explains how to evaluate your hand in light of her opening no trump bid.

If your partner's opening bid is in a suit, the purpose of your response is to tell her the most about your hand that you can with one bid. You will find out how you must respond depending on the values in your hand and the opening bid she has made. You'll also learn about forcing bids, weak bids, bids that show support for your partner's opening bid, and bids that deny support.



Chapter 9

Opening, Responding to, and Bidding Against Weak Two Bids

It used to be that if you opened a suit at the 2 level you were showing a huge hand. As discussed in [Chapter 7](#), there is a better way to show your strong hands: You can open them with 2 clubs, which gives your partnership more room to bid.

If you use a 2 clubs opening bid to show all of your big hands (this includes big balanced hands and strong hands with long suits and good distribution), even those that contain major suits with five or more cards, you now have your other opening 2-level bids available for something else. It took a while to figure out the best treatment, but with time one became available and has become popular with almost everyone. Curiously, it is the exact opposite of Strong Two bids. The replacement is Weak Two bids.

What Is a Weak Two Bid?

A Weak Two bid is a 2 bid in diamonds, hearts, or spades, in which you promise exactly six cards in the suit. There are different HCP requirements, depending on your vulnerability:

- + **Not vulnerable:** 6 to 10 HCP
- + **Vulnerable:** 7 to 11 HCP

Weak Two Bids in First or Second Seat

The following list details the values required to make a Weak Two opening bid in the first or second seat. In first or second seats, your Weak Two bids must follow these guidelines. The reason is that your partner is not a passed hand. If your partner has a good hand and chooses to bid, she must be able to count on you to have certain values. If you make a Weak Two bid, even if it's a little less than classic, your partner will have a better idea of what your side can make than either of the opponents. Because it's harder to bid against preempts, you have a lot to gain when you open a Weak Two bid and not that much to lose. Winners preempt a lot. Be a preemptor.

- + **A six-card suit.**

- + **A good suit.** Some players say you need three of the top five honors, others say that virtually any six cards headed by the ace, king, or queen is okay. Others take a middle ground. Experts generally suggest that you bid aggressively.
- + **No side four-card major.** You may miss a good major suit fit if you have four cards in a major.
- + **No side five-card minor.** Your wild distribution will be too big a surprise for your partner to judge the hands well.
- + **No void.** If you have a void, it means that you have good trump support for other suits. It may be that another suit would be a better trump suit.
- + **No seven-card suit.** Your seventh card will be unexpected, and this extra card will cloud your partner's judgment.

Bidding Weak Two When You're Not Vulnerable

Consider the following: You're in first or second seat and not vulnerable. You get to open the bidding if you want. Remember that a Weak Two bid not vulnerable shows 6 to 10 high-card points. How would you play the following hands?

- | | | | |
|-------------|--------------|-------------|-------------|
| 1. ♠ QJ9843 | 2. ♠ K107632 | 3. ♠ AQJ874 | 4. ♠ KJ9732 |
| ♥ K3 | ♥ Q8 | ♥ J983 | ♥ 32 |
| ♦ K2 | ♦ Q8 | ♦ 73 | ♦ A762 |
| ♣ 873 | ♣ J63 | ♣ 3 | ♣ 8 |
| 5. ♠ 73 | 6. ♠ 7 | | |
| ♥ KQ108763 | ♥ AQ10984 | | |
| ♦ Q84 | ♦ 8743 | | |
| ♣ 6 | ♣ 94 | | |

Hand 1: 2 spades. When you bid a Weak Two, your partner learns you have a six-card suit and 5 to 10 points. The points you have are nice quality, and your spade suit, even though missing the ace and king, is nice. All you need from your partner is two spades, or perhaps even just the 10 of spades, to make this a playable trump suit. That isn't asking for too much. Keep in mind that if you pass and later bid spades, your partner will not know you have six of them. She will suspect that you have five. Further, by passing first, you give the opponents room to do some cheap bidding.

Hand 2: Pass. You have poor spade spots and, importantly, you have high cards on the side that may be useless if you are declarer in spades.

Hand 3: Pass. This has a perfect spade suit for a Weak Two bid, and it has the right number of points, but it has four hearts. That is a serious warning sign.

Hand 4: 2 spades. All of its points are working and it has nice distribution.

Hand 5: 3 hearts. This is not a 2 heart opening bid. Don't make a Weak Two bid with a seven-card suit. When you're playing Weak Twos, a 3-level opening bid promises a 7-card suit.

Hand 6: 2 hearts. This is a rare 6-point Weak Two. When you make a Weak Two on a minimum hand, be sure you have all of your points in the trump suit.

Bidding Weak Two When You're Vulnerable

Consider the following situation: You are in first or second seat, vulnerable. You get to open the bidding if you wish. Remember that a Weak Two bid vulnerable shows 7 to 11 HCP. High cards that have no obvious value such as Qx or Jxx are called *soft points* or *bad points*. When you preempt, you want to have as few bad points as possible. You would rather have six good points than four good points and four bad points. How would you play the following hands?

1. ♠ 74
♥ KQJ874
♦ Q8
♣ K32

2. ♠ AJ10864
♥ 2
♦ K105
♣ K52

3. ♠ KJ8753
♥ K42
♦ 42
♣ 82

4. ♠ 82
♥ 83
♦ AKJ876
♣ 83

Hand 1: 2 hearts. This is a maximum Weak Two bid. Note, however, that the quality of the 11 HCP isn't that good. The queen of diamonds is suspect because it's a doubleton, so it doesn't indicate trick-taking capability unless your partner has the ace or king or jack fourth. If not, you could have two immediate diamond losers and no winners.

Hand 2: 1 spade. When you have a really nice 11 HCP plus good distribution and a fine six-card suit, your hand is really worth close to 13 points because of your singleton. Open with a 1 bid.

Hand 3: Pass. This is tempting, but because you're vulnerable, it's okay to be cautious. If you were not vulnerable, you'd open this in 2 spades in a flash.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. You have close to a minimum in terms of HCP but your suit is outstanding. Note that if you pass you may not get to bid your diamonds later.

Weak Two Bids in Third Seat

In third seat, you're in a different situation. Your partner has passed, so you know that she doesn't have an opening hand. If you have a weak hand yourself, you can count on your LHO being ready to bid something. In third seat, it is a proven strategy to open aggressive Weak Two bids.

Weak Two Bids in Fourth Seat

This is an odd situation. If the bidding is passed to you in fourth seat, you don't really have a reason to open a weak hand. You can pass it out and avoid getting a negative score. This allows you to use a 2-level bid to provide different information to your partner. If you do open with a 2 bid other than clubs, the hand you show should be dramatically different. Instead of being weak, your 2 bid is descriptive, saying that you have a six-card suit and about 11 to 15 points. The reason for this is that you get to describe your hand exactly while at the same time making it hard for the opponents to have second thoughts. One example of a fourth seat 2 bid is as follows:

♠ 83
♥ KQJ984
♦ KJ4
♣ QJ

This hand has 13 HCP, but they aren't terribly good ones. If you open 1 heart, you give opponents bidding space to find a fit in another suit. By opening 2 hearts, you tell

your partner exactly what you have and at the same time you suppress the opponents' bidding. The key to this bid is that you tell your partner two things. First, you tell her that you have an opening hand. Second, you tell her that you have a six-card suit. This is important information, something she wouldn't know if you opened it at the 1 level. The fact that you're opening in fourth seat gives you the opportunity to convey this information to your partner in just one bid. Be sure you discuss this with your partner because not everybody uses this system.

Responding to Weak Two Bids

Responding to your partner's opening with a Weak Two bid is totally different from responding to her opening with a 1 bid. Here are some rules that will get you off to a good start; you can respond to a Weak Two bid ...

- + **If you, as responder, bid a new suit.** If you bid a new suit, it is a forcing bid. You tend to deny support for your partner's suit and you show enough points that you hope for a game. This means you need around 15 HCP and a good suit.
- + **If you have a fit and enough for game.** Bid game if you have game points. Keep in mind that your partner has a six-card suit. You can raise to four of partner's major with only two-card support.
- + **If you have a fit and you think you have enough for slam.** (Slam bidding is covered in [Chapter 18](#); when you bid and make 6, taking all tricks but one, it's called a "small slam," and when you bid and make 7, taking every trick, it's called a "grand slam.")
- + **If your hand is invitational.** If you are not sure whether you have enough for game and want to find out more about your partner's hand, you can bid 2 no trump to ask the opener for more information. A 2 no trump bid can ask the opener for different information, depending on the agreement of the partnership, but this is the simplest. You are asking your partner to bid an ace or a king, called a *feature*, in a suit outside the trump suit, if she has it, regardless of what else she has in that suit. So, if she has opened 2 hearts in Hand 1, and you bid 2 no trump, she would respond 3 clubs, showing she had the king of clubs. If she has no outside ace or king, she rebids her opening suit.

+ If you know your side doesn't have a game. In this case, you usually pass. If you have support for your partner, however, you can raise to the 3 level if you have three- or four-card support. In fact, if you have four-card support and two doubletons or four-card support and a singleton and not much else, it's wise to bid game in the expectation that the opponents may have a contract of their own. The reason for this is that if you don't have much, you're just cooperating with your partner's preempt by squeezing your opponents further and giving them less room in which to communicate. If your partner opens 2 spades and you raise to 3 spades, opponents must start communicating at the 4 level.

Consider the following hand: Your partner opens 2 hearts with no one vulnerable. She has 6 to 10 points. With these hands, what do you respond?

1. ♠ QJ873 ♥ K ♦ KQJ ♣ K878	2. ♠ A84 ♥ J83 ♦ Q8762 ♣ 72	3. ♠ QJ3 ♥ 8 ♦ AKQJ872 ♣ AJ	4. ♠ 8 ♥ Q873 ♦ K10987 ♣ 873
5. ♠ AK3 ♥ 103 ♦ A1087 ♣ KJ64	6. ♠ AQJ986 ♥ 3 ♦ 8 ♣ J10875		

Hand 1: Pass. You have 15 points, but they are poor-quality points. You have only one heart, so the hands are something of a misfit. Best is if you pass smoothly. Perhaps the next opponent will decide to bid something. You would like it if he bid spades.

Hand 2: 3 hearts. The idea is that you're making the bidding a little more difficult for the opponents.

Hand 3: 3 no trump. You don't want to play in hearts but you would like to take a chance on game. Bid 3 no trump without showing diamonds and without asking questions with 2 no trump.

Hand 4: 4 hearts. You won't make it, but you won't be down a lot either. The idea is that you're making life very tough for the player on your left. Clearly opponents have

the bulk of the points. Your partner has less than 12 and you only have 5; that means that opponents have a minimum of 24 points between them, and if your partner only has the minimum, 5 points, then they have 30 points between them. Clearly, it should be their hand to play. By jumping to 4 hearts, you make it very difficult for them to find their fit.

Hand 5: 2 no trump. You have a good hand that's not quite good enough to bid game. Bid 2 no trump and find out whether your partner has the king of diamonds or the ace of clubs. If so, you should bid 4 hearts knowing that her six hearts and your two hearts are fine for game. If not, pass her 3 hearts rebid.

Hand 6: Pass. 2 spades would be forcing. You need around 15 good points to bid a new suit. Your partner, remember, may not pass your bid. It is forcing, and she will always bid again, compounding your problems if you have bid with a weak hand.

Strong Two Clubs Bid

Because the modern trend is to use an opening bid at the 2 level as weak, a bid at a reasonable level was needed to show a very strong hand—stronger than 1 no trump and 2 no trump. So, the 2 clubs opening bid was reserved for a strong hand, replacing strong bids of 2S, 2H, and 2D, discussed previously.

Requirements for a Strong Two Clubs Open

The requirements for a hand to open 2 clubs are as follows:

- + 22 or more HCP; or
- + $8\frac{1}{2}$ tricks

So, a Strong Two clubs bid either shows a lot of points, or an unbalanced hand with enough trick-taking capability that you're assured of taking more than eight tricks in your own hand. Look at the following hands—all of these hands qualify for an opening bid of 2 clubs:

1. ♠ AK74
♥ KQJ6
♦ AK
♣ QJ6

2. ♠ AKQJ643
♥ AK
♦ Q43
♣ 3

3. ♠ Q8653
♥ AKQJ
♦ AKQJ
♣ Void

4. ♠ AK
♥ 65
♦ KQJ2
♣ AKQJ

Hand 1: Contains 23 HCP and is balanced.

Hand 2: Contains only 19 HCP, 21 total points; if spades is trump, however, you have nine tricks in your hand, so that qualifies.

Hand 3: Contains 22 HCP and 3 distribution points.

Hand 4: Contains 23 HCP, 24 total points. Regardless of the terrible hearts, this is a 23-HCP hand and must be opened 2 clubs.

The 2 clubs open is an *artificial* bid. That means that it says nothing about the suit bid, clubs. So, you can open all four hands 2 clubs, even though Hand 2 only has one club and Hand 3 is void of clubs.

Responses to Strong Two Club Opening

Unless you have a strong five-card major, or a balanced hand with 7 or more points, you *must* bid 2 diamonds when your partner opens 2 clubs. This is called a waiting bid. It's conventional, in that it says nothing about diamonds. You must bid 2 diamonds even if you're void in diamonds. All it says to your partner is, "Okay, partner, I hear you. You have 22+ points or eight-and-a-half tricks in your hand. Tell me more."

You must remember two other rules when you're responding to your partner's opening bid of 2 clubs:

- + When your partner opens 2 clubs, you're required to keep the bidding open to either 2 no trump or until she bids one of her suits for the second time. So, even if you have a Yarborough, you must keep bidding if your partner opens 2 clubs, until she either gets to 2 no trump or bids one of her suits a second time.

+ Whenever your partner bids a new suit, you must bid again. Bidding a new suit by your partner who has opened 2 clubs is *forcing for one round* on responder. Of course, if your RHO interferes and bids before you, you need not bid. Your pass will tell her something about your hand.

This is true regardless of the weakness of your hand.

What is your partner telling you when she bids 2 clubs?

Don't pass! That's the main thing she's telling you. There's a famous story about the police being called to a bridge club to find a player dead, shot through the heart. The police asked what happened and one of the players responded, "The deceased's partner opened 2 clubs and the bidding went Pass, Pass, Pass, Bang! Bang! Bang!" Don't let this happen to you. If you pass a Strong Two club opening, you had better have a bodyguard available when the hand's over. If not, you could be shot through the heart; if there are any bridge players on the jury, your partner will probably get off with justifiable homicide.

Your partner is telling you she has a huge hand and she's not just interested in game, she's interested in slam if you have any kind of support at all.

Another thing she's telling you by her bid is that you should bid slowly and communicate. There's absolutely no reason for you to give some kind of a jump response telling her about your hand. You have time. Although the 2 clubs opening crowds the bidding a little, you haven't given up much space, and you still have a lot of time to talk to each other.

So, just be patient. Use the system you've agreed on to describe your hands to each other. What you're learning in this book is the most standard system used by players. It's the one I use. But there are a lot of different systems that require different responses to an opening of 2 clubs. Although you might be aware of them, you shouldn't concern yourself too much with what they are because the system you're learning works just fine.

Weak Responses with a Cheaper Minor

So, how do you tell your partner that your hand stinks? What if you have a Yarborough? How can you tell her if you're required to bid?

The answer to this question is that, at your next bid, if you bid the cheaper minor available to you at the 3 level, it tells her that your hand has 3 points or less in it.

So, if she opens 2 clubs and you respond 2 diamonds, and she bids 2 spades, what do you think you bid to show her a terrible hand?

Answer. Your bid is 3 clubs (artificial). That's the *cheaper minor*—that is, the lowest minor suit you can bid at that point.

Rules for responding with cheaper minor are as follows:

Partner's First Rebid	Your Response
2 ♥ or 2 ♠	3 ♣
2NT	P
3 ♣	3 ♦
3 ♦	3NT

All of these responses show a bad hand with no more than 3 points.

This is the basic, standard way to show a weak hand. There are alternatives. Some people play responder shows a weak hand by bidding 2 no trump. Others play that the response to show a weak hand after partner's first rebid is 3 diamonds is to bid 3 hearts, the cheapest suit available. I recommend you start playing it the way shown above. As you become more advanced, you may want to change. For the record, the way I'm teaching it is still the way I play.

Positive Responses Besides 2 Diamonds

You don't absolutely, positively *have* to bid 2 diamonds in response to your partner's Strong Two clubs opening. There are times when you have something, too, and you

want to let her know about it as soon as possible. The following are allowed responses:

- + **2 of a major or 3 of a minor.** This shows you with a good five-card suit or a six-card suit and at least 6 HCP. A *good* five-card suit should be one headed by two of the top three honors, or three of the top five honors. Don't forget that your partner is the one with the big hand. She probably has a suit she wants to promote. So, you don't want to tell her that you have the suit in which you should be playing unless it's a very good suit. A five-card suit headed by the king-jack, for instance, just isn't good enough.
- + **2 no trump.** This shows at least 7 HCP and denies a four-card major with no voids, singletons, and not more than two doubletons.
- + **Jump to 3 of a major.** This shows at least a six-card suit with three of the top four honors.

Bidding When Opponents Open a Weak Two Bid or Higher Preempt

When your RHO opens a Weak Two bid, you will often have the urge to bid something. Certain care has to be taken when bidding against a preempt because it is forcing you to bid at a high level, and at the same time it is warning you that there could be some bad distribution to contend with. The more you play bridge, the more you will hate bidding against preempts. There is something to be learned from this. If you hate bidding when an opponent preempts, think about how much fun your opponents are having when you are the preemptor. Hint: Preempt as often as you dare.

Here are some general guidelines:

- + If you're thinking of making a takeout double, you need support for the unbid suits and at least the following:
 - + 12 HCP if you're doubling a Weak Two bid.
 - + 14 HCP if you're doubling a Weak Three bid.
 - + 16 HCP if you're doubling an opening 4 bid. Note that a double of a 4-level preempt can be played as penalty or takeout, depending on partnership agreement.

A better way to play a double of an opening 4 bid in a major suit is that a double of 4 hearts is takeout while a double of 4 spades is penalty. If you play this way, if you want to make a takeout bid over the 4 spades opener, you bid 4 no trump. That asks your partner to bid her longest suit.

+ If you are thinking of overcalling in a suit, you need a good suit in all cases.

Following are point requirements for bidding at the various levels, in addition to having at least five cards in the suit:

+ **2 level.** 13 good-quality HCP

+ **3 level.** 15 good-quality HCP

+ **4 level.** 17 good-quality HCP, and usually a six-card suit

All no trump overcalls at the 2 or 3 level against a preempt are natural. If they open a Weak Two bid and you bid 2 no trump, you are showing 15 to 18 HCP with a stopper in their suit. This is *not* an unusual no trump overcall. With 19 or more balanced points, you usually bid 3 no trump, although a double first is fine if you have good distribution for it. If they open with a 3-level preempt, you can bid 3 no trump with a variety of hands. Typically you have at least 16 HCP. This is not always a safe bid, but they have made life difficult for you and the only way to get what you deserve is to take an occasional risk. However, if you do this, you should have at least one stopper in their suit, preferably two.

Balancing When Opponents Open a Weak Two Bid or Higher Preempt

If your LHO opened the Weak Two and the bidding is passed around to you, you can be aggressive to the extent that you need 2 fewer points for your bid. Previously I suggested that you can double a Weak Two bid with 13 HCP and proper distribution. If a Weak Two is passed around to you, it is acceptable to double with 2 fewer points, 11 in this case, as long as you have support for the missing suits. You can deduct 2 points for the requirements for balancing at the 3 and 4 levels as well (13 HCP for the 3 level and 15 HCP for the 4 level). Be careful that you do not deduct more, though. If you get in the habit of being aggressive on the theory that the opponents are

showing a weak hand, you will be caught speeding now and then and there will be a stiff price to pay.

When you make a balancing double with a weak hand, it is essential that you have support for all three unbid suits. If you do it with a doubleton in an unbid suit, your partner could find herself playing in a 4–2 fit, and she won't be happy.

Another System for Bidding Against A Weak Two Opening Bid

The beauty of bridge is that there are more ways to skin a cat than just one. While what's discussed previously is the way a lot of people play bidding against a Weak Two opening bid, there are other ways, too. Following is the way I like to play it.

Your RHO opens 2 spades. Here's your hand:

♠ K972
♥ K1032
♦ Q5
♣ A75

What's your call? Many experienced players, counting the points and seeing opening hand values, will take action by making a takeout double, as explained in the previous section. When this occurred and the player with the actual hand doubled, doubler's partner jumped to 4 diamonds (the jump showed at least 10 HCP), the only suit for which doubler did not really have support, so he passed. Here's the entire layout:

North

♠ 6
♥ QJ654
♦ 10953
♣ J98

West

♠ K972
♥ K1032
♦ Q5
♣ A75

East

♠ Q8
♥ A8
♦ AK842
♣ KQ32

South (Dealer)

♠ AJ10543
♥ 97
♦ J7
♣ 1064

EW didn't find their cold games because they didn't bid in a way that would allow them to bid over the Weak Two, so the Weak Two did what it was created to do, squeezed the bidding range so opponents failed to communicate. There are many different methods of bidding in the direct seat over a Weak Two, so I'm going to tell you the one I use and I think it's the best.

The key is that if your RHO opens a Weak Two, you only make a call if you have extra values, which means at least 15 HCP, or a good 14 HCP (like a six-card major headed by the AKQ and five other points scattered around) or six losers or less. With less, like with a typical opening hand with 12-14 HCP, you pass.

This means that if the Weak Two opening is passed around to fourth seat, the player in the fourth seat must make some kind of call with at least 10 HCP. With 9 HCP or less, she passes. With 10 HCP she must take action to protect her partner who may have passed a minimum opening hand.

So here, after South opens 2S, West must pass with his 12 HCP. Here's how the bidding should go:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
			2 ♠
P	P	Dbl	P
3 ♥	P	4 ♦	P
5 ♦	P	P	P

★ *at least 17 HCP*

I have to digress here to discuss takeout doubles which is covered in detail in [Chapter 19](#). Generally, if a player doubles an opponent's opening bid, she is not doubling for penalty; she's doubling for takeout, asking her partner to bid her longest suit. A takeout double promises either 1) one unbid four-card major with shape or near opening values and support for all three unbid suits, or 2) a big hand if she doubles and then bids her own suit. So, an auction of 1H-Dbl-P-2C-P-2D (by doubler) would mean that the doubler had at least a five-card diamond suit and at least 17 HCP.

But, savvy players today play that a double in this instance and then a bid of new suit shows one of two hands, either the big hand referenced above, or a simple opening hand with one four-card major and a five-card minor. If partner bids the four-card major, doubler will either pass or support the major, depending on the strength of his hand. If doubler bids a new minor suit, he's promising no more than an opening hand with five cards in the suit he bids.

The point of the double is to discover whether or not partner has the same four-card major that doubler has. If he doesn't, then doubler bids his five-card minor. He could still have the big hand, but he might not. You won't know unless you continue bidding. However, this bid does not absolutely promise at least 17 HCP.

In this hand, East's double of the major suit opening of 2S, and subsequent bid of her own suit after her partner bid the other major, hearts, showed a hand of at least 17 HCP, so West, with at least 29 HCP points between them (his 12 and partner's 17), can go to 5D with only two diamonds, since one of them is the all-important queen.

What if the East and West hands had been reversed with West holding the 18 HCP hand:

North

♠ 6
♥ QJ654
♦ 10953
♣ J98

West

♠ Q8
♥ A8
♦ AK842
♣ KQ32

East

♠ K972
♥ K1032
♦ Q5
♣ A75

South (Dealer)

♠ AJ10543
♥ 97
♦ J7
♣ 1064

West

3 ♦
P

North

P
P

East

3NT

South

2 ♠
P

West would bid 3D over South's weak 2S opening bid, showing extra values. Since East knows that West is showing extra values, and since East has four cards in South's suit, including the king, it's pretty much a no-brainer to bid 3NT, since you have at least 27 HCP between you (West's minimum of 15 and your 12). This is the great value of only bidding in the direct seat if you have extra values.

Assuming South leads the jack of spades, declarer takes it with the queen in dummy. Declarer knows that his RHO is out of spades at this point because if South had six to make her Weak Two, declarer and dummy have six between them, leaving only one in North's hand, so she need not worry about losing a trick to North and having a spade led back through her king. She tries the diamonds and finds that North has four diamonds, so she leads the AKQ and then throws North in with a diamond, setting up

her fifth diamond in dummy. Clubs split, so she gets four clubs, four diamonds, two hearts, and one spade, making five.

Either way, this hand must be in game and using this technique ensures game being bid. One important proviso. This is a special method of dealing with this problem and you must have a clear understanding between you and your partner. It won't work if one person isn't playing the same system.

Here's another hand I just played that validates this style. Here's your hand sitting North:

♠ 6
♥ AJ5
♦ KJ853
♣ J863

Here's the bidding:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
P	P	2 ♠	3 ♥
P	?		

What's your call? If you play the way I originally explained, you are between a rock and a hard place. Did your partner overcall with 12 HCP? If so, then you must pass. Does she have extra values with six losers or less? If so, you must go to 4H. My partner, a student, and I had just had this conversation and agreed to play that she would not take a call in direct seat over a Weak Two unless she had extra values, six losers or less. Since that was our agreement, my bid was easy. I had an eight loser hand, so the losing trick count ($8 + 6 = 14$; $24 - 14 = 10$, the number of tricks we should take) said we should be in game and I bid 4H. She made five. Here are the four hands (she actually had a four loser hand):

North

♠ 6
♥ AJ5
♦ KJ853
♣ J863

West

♠ 82
♥ 97
♦ AQ9764
♠ 102
♣ 1075

East

♠ KQJ975
♥ Q108
♣ 92

South (Dealer)

♠ A1043
♥ K6432
♦ Void
♣ AKQ4

This hand was played 15 times. Only one other pair got to the right contract, 4H. Several were in 3H because they don't handle bidding over Weak Twos the way we do.

However, this hand is a teacher's delight, so let's go through the bidding in more detail. You might have noted that West passed a hand that seemed ideal for a Weak 2D opening bid. I have no idea why he passed this hand. For those who did open it 2D, some of the results were disastrous because this is how their bidding went:

West

2♦
P

North

P
P***

East

P*
P

South

Dbl**

**East holds a hand that would justify a Weak 2S opening bid. She can't bid it because they play RONF (Raise is the Only Nonforcing Bid). If she bid 2S, West must bid again, so she passed.*

***South with a huge hand, void in diamonds and at least four card support for anything partner bids makes a takeout double, choosing not to overcall with her Weak five-card heart suit.*

****South's takeout double is discretionary for North. He can either bid his longest suit, or sit for the double if he thinks he can set it. With five diamonds headed by the KJ, he*

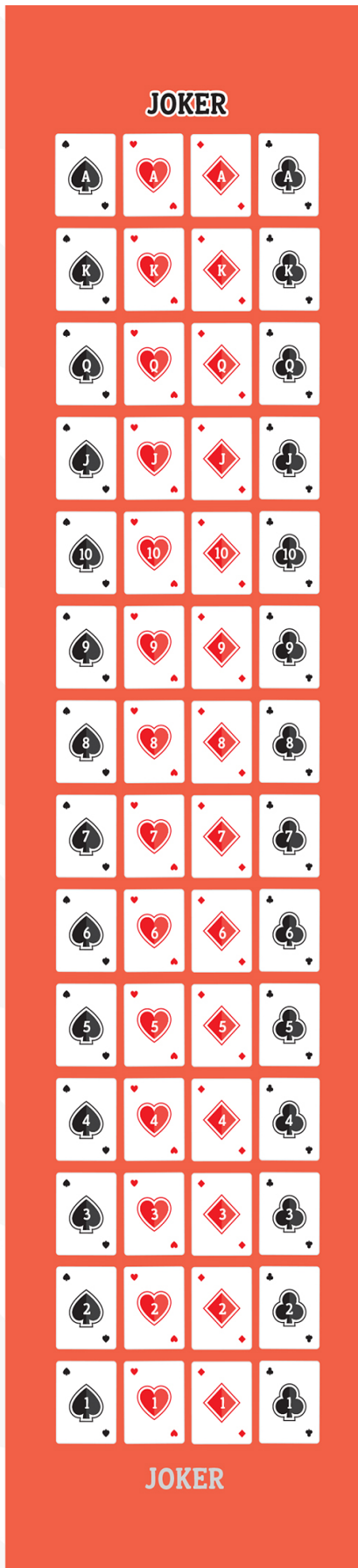
gleefully sits. At several tables this was passed out and West was down four for 800 points for NS.

However, the double passed to East gives East a chance to bid his nice spade suit. If he takes a call, it is not forcing on West to bid again because he already passed his partner's 2D opening bid once. A good East will not let 2D doubled be passed out and will overcall 2S. At one table this is exactly what East did and that was doubled by South again and passed out for down two and 300 points for NS, not a great board for EW, but better than 2D doubled down four.

However, if East does make his 2S bid, that gives South another chance. What is she to do? Does she double again? If so, is that a penalty double or another takeout double? If she doubles again, that puts North in a quandary. If he bids he would have to bid clubs. But should he just bid 3 clubs or should he jump to 4 clubs to show at least 10 HCP? At one table he passed it out as shown above.

However, at two tables he pulled the second double to 3C which was passed out, making five at one table and three at the other table. At three tables, South overcalled 3H and played it there. But because she doubled first and then bid her major suit (rather than overcalling immediately), North should know she's got a big hand and should take her to 4H, regardless of the system they are playing. Only one other pair besides us bid 4H.

Isn't bridge wonderful with so many ways to interpret, bid, and play just one hand?



Chapter 10

Responses to No Trump Openings

Enough about opening. Now we start to delve deeper into the interaction that takes place at a polite bridge table, the actual communication with your partner. Up until now we've been talking about what you tell your partner with your first bid.

In this chapter, you learn about responses—how you, or your partner, take the information imparted by whoever opened, evaluate it, and then communicate back what you have in your hand. This chapter is limited to responding when your partner opens the bidding by telling you she has a pretty big hand: 15 to 17 HCP and no trump distribution.

Basic Arithmetic Prevails

You have two basic goals in bidding in bridge:

- + Bid game if you have it.
- + Stop at as low a level as possible when you're certain you don't have game.

When bidding in a no trump contract, arithmetic is more important than when bidding in a suit contract. In a suit contract, you can take an ace with the two of trump. In no trump, you're stuck with the suit that was led. High cards are much more valuable, because the highest card in the suit led will always take the trick.

When you're bidding no trump you always have 25 points in mind, because that's typically the minimum number of points required to make game in no trump (see [Chapter 6](#)). Remember, however, that when evaluating no trump hands, you don't count distribution points, only HCP. When your partner opens 1 no trump, she's telling you that she has between 15 and 17 HCP, no singletons or voids, and no more than two doubletons. There are some simple rules to start. If you, as responder, have a balanced hand, add up your HCP and make one of the following bids:

HCP	Bid
0-7	P
8-9	2NT
10-14	3NT
15-16	4NT
17-20	6NT

A Discussion of Yes, No, and Maybe

In evaluating your hand to respond to a no trump opening, you may think in terms of three little words: they aren't *I love you*, they're *yes*, *no*, and *maybe*.

Yes

If you have 10 or more points, what should you do? Of course, you bid game by responding 3 no trump. Why? Even if your partner's at the bottom of her bid with 15 points, when added to your 10 you should be able to make game. This tells your partner, "Great! You have at least 15 points, and I have at least 10 points; we should definitely be playing this hand in game."

No

When you have 0 to 7 points, you must pass. Why? Go back to your basic arithmetic. What's the maximum amount of HCP your partner can have when she opens 1 no trump? Seventeen HCP, right? How many points do you need for game? Twenty-five. If you have a maximum of 7, add that to her maximum possible of 17. What do you get? Twenty-four. That's not enough for game. So, you don't want to bid further. You communicate to your partner by your pass that you have 7 or fewer points. You're telling your partner, "Well, it's nice that you have such a pretty hand, with at least 40 percent of the points in the deck, but my hand is too weak for us to make game, so let's stop bidding."

Maybe

If you have 8 to 9 points, you might be saying, why not bid 3 no trump, because 17 plus 8 equals 25? Because when evaluating whether or not to bid with 0 to 7, you were looking to see what would be the best thing that could happen if you were both at the top of your bid. The best thing that could happen was that you wouldn't make game with your total maximum points. So, what's the purpose of bidding?

When you have 8 to 9 points, you look at it the other way. Your partner might have 17, but she might have 15 or 16. And if she has 15 or 16, your 8 points won't be enough for game. If you have 9 and she only has 15, you still won't have enough for game. Therefore, because her hand is undefined between 15 and 17, you must tell her what you have by making an *invitational* bid of 2 no trump. This tells her that you have 8 to 9 points. And it says to her, "Partner, if you're at the top of your bid with 17 points, go on to game. But if you're in the middle or at the bottom, just pass and we should be able to make 2 no trump."

Forget algebra, geometry, and computer programming. When your partner opens 1 no trump, all you need is simple arithmetic. You add your points to hers and decide whether it is *yes*, *no*, or *maybe*.

There is another "maybe" here. That's the 4 no trump bid that you make when you have 15-16 HCP. But it's not "maybe we can make game." It's "maybe we can make six, a small slam." You are telling your partner how many HCP you have and are asking her to pass if she opened with 15 or 16 HCP and to bid six, a small slam, if she opened with 17 HCP, or 16 HCP with a good five-card suit.

Understanding the Captaincy Principle

When your partner opens 1 no trump, in addition to describing her hand to you, she's telling you, "That's it, partner. You now know what I have. You're the captain of this hand. Place the contract where you think we have the best chance."

One no trump is one of the most descriptive bids in bridge by an opener because it severely limits her hand. Most other bids in bridge are slightly limiting, but have a

varying range, and the differences are communicated by subsequent bidding. But 1 no trump limits the hand to what we've discussed. Never could (or should) your partner open a hand 1 no trump without having the precise qualities we've discussed: 15 to 17 points, no singletons or voids, and no more than two doubletons.

Because of this severe limitation, the opener designates responder as the “captain” of the hand. Because you know what she has in her hand, it's up to you to use your knowledge of bridge and your own hand to place the contract. Your partner will be trusting you to either place it in a suit or to leave it in no trump, but at the proper level. You might ask her more about her hand, but in the end, it's up to you to determine where the contract will be played; there is no bid that responder can make that's as limiting as partner's 1 no trump open.

Natural vs. Conventional Bids

A *convention* is a bid that means something different than what it appears to mean. A *natural* bid is one that means what it says. One no trump—meaning 15 to 17 points and a balanced hand—is a *natural* bid. 2 clubs, on the other hand, when it means a huge hand as discussed in [Chapter 9](#), is a *conventional* bid because it doesn't say anything about clubs.

Many conventional bids have been developed as responses to a partner's opening bid of 1 no trump. You only need to learn one of them—the *Stayman*—at this stage. It has become so widespread that it is considered to be standard.

The Stayman Convention

Because your partner can open a hand 1 no trump but still have one or two four-card major suits (spades or hearts), it's quite possible that you may also have at least four cards in one of the major suits. You should be playing this hand in the major suit and not in no trump.

It's conventional bridge wisdom that if you and your partner hold at least eight cards in a major suit combined, you should be playing the hand in that suit and not in no trump. Because you control most of the trumps, you should be able to get one more trick than if you were playing in no trump.

But how do you get this sort of information out of your partner? And how do you find out which suit your partner holds four cards in?

The answer is Stayman, which is a very simple conventional bid. It says, simply, that if your partner opens 1 no trump and you have four cards in a major suit and at least 8 points, you respond with a bid of 2 clubs. This says absolutely nothing about the clubs you're holding in your hand. When you respond 2 clubs to your partner's opening bid of 1 no trump, you are saying to your partner the following:

“Partner, I promise you I have ...

- + At least four cards in at least one major suit.
- + At least 8 HCP.

Please further describe your hand to me.”

That's all it says. You could be void in clubs and still bid 2 clubs if you have a four-card major and at least 8 HCP.

How to Respond to Stayman

If you're the opening bidder and your partner responds 2 clubs to your 1 no trump opening, Stayman requires you to answer her question. If you have a four-card major, you bid it. If she responds 2 clubs and your hand contains three spades, four hearts, three diamonds, and three clubs, your next bid must be 2 hearts.

Now under the captaincy principle, responder knows as much about your hand as she needs in order to place the contract. If she has four hearts and 10 points, with her four hearts and your four hearts, she will bid game—4 hearts. If she has 8 to 9 points without four hearts, she'll bid 2 no trump; if she has 8 to 9 points with four hearts,

she'll bid 3 hearts. Both of these bids say *maybe*. If you've opened with 17 points and she bids 3 hearts, you should accept her invitation and bid game. If you're at the bottom of your bid and opened with 15 points, you would just pass her bid of 3 hearts and play the hand in three hearts.

What if you, as opener, don't have a four-card major? Then Stayman requires you to bid 2 diamonds. Again, this is a conventional bid. It says nothing about the diamonds in your hand. The response of 2 diamonds to a Stayman bid of 2 clubs simply denies a four-card major. You have no choice in this matter. If you're playing the Stayman convention (and just about everybody does), you must respond 2 diamonds if you don't have a four-card major.

Responder then places the contract. If responder has 10 points, she bids 3 no trump (answering *yes*); if she has 8 to 9 points, she bids 2 no trump (telling you *maybe*). And that's where the contract is played unless you have opened the bidding at the top of your bid with 17 points. In that event, you can close out the contract at 3 no trump. Responder has promised at least 8 points, and added to your 17, you should have game. Responder's bid of 2 no trump is considered invitational, inviting you to go to game if you are at the top of your bid.

So, the basics for responder to bid Stayman are the following:

- + At least one four-card major
- + At least 8 HCP

If you're responder and your partner opens 1 no trump and your hand satisfies these two simple rules, you should bid 2 clubs.

The last thing to discuss is what you do if you have at least 8 or 9 HCP but don't have a four-card major. The answer is simple: regardless of where your points are, you bid 2 no trump. A bid of 2 no trump over opener's 1 no trump says the following:

- + I have exactly 8 to 9 HCP, but less than 10 HCP.
- + I don't have a four-card major.

Your partner now knows your hand pretty well. If she opened a 17-point hand or an attractive 16-point hand, she goes to 3 no trump. Otherwise she passes and you play the hand at 2 no trump.

That's all there is to it. And for now, that's all you need to know.

Now, bid these hands as responder after your partner has opened 1 no trump:

1. ♠ 9765 ♥ AQ73 ♦ K763 ♣ 6	2. ♠ 743 ♥ Q65 ♦ 62 ♣ KQJ73	3. ♠ J1086 ♥ 85 ♦ AK864 ♣ 86	4. ♠ J643 ♥ J965 ♦ K3 ♣ 985
5. ♠ J84 ♥ Q93 ♦ K632 ♣ Q52	6. ♠ J753 ♥ J642 ♦ J9732 ♣ Void		

Hand 1: 2 clubs. You have 9 HCP and two four-card majors. It doesn't matter that you only have a singleton clubs. Your 2 clubs bid describes a hand that has at least 8 HCP and at least one four-card major, which is what this hand has.

Hand 2: 2 no trump. You have 8 HCP, but you don't have a four-card major, so you can't bid Stayman. Although you have a very nice clubs suit, you can't bid clubs, because that would be Stayman. Remember, bidding 2 clubs in response to your partner's 1 no trump opening doesn't say anything about clubs! Instead, it's asking your partner to bid a four-card major. You'd much rather play a hand in no trump because no trump tricks are worth more than a minor suit trick.

Hand 3: 2 clubs. You have a nice diamonds suit and your clubs are terrible. But you have 8 HCP and four spades. This is a hand that requires a bid of 2 clubs if you're playing Stayman.

Hand 4: Pass. Even though you have two four-card majors, you don't have enough points to bid. It is better to let your partner play this in 1 no trump. This is a hand where you must be disciplined. I know a lot of players who are tempted to bid 2 clubs

on this hand on the outside chance that they'll find their partner with a four-card major and they'll be able to play it in a 4–4 fit at the 2 level. The problem with this is, what if your partner responds 2 diamonds, denying a four-card major? You can't pass when you only have two diamonds. Your partner might have opened up the following hand:

♠ KQ7
♥ KQ3
♦ 98
♣ AK764

When you bid 2 clubs, she must bid 2 diamonds. Because she doesn't have a four-card major, she must comply with the rules of the Stayman convention you agreed to play. She can't respond anything else, so if you pass, she'll be playing in a 2–2 trump fit and you'll be looking around for a new partner because she's never going to want to see you again. If she bids 2 diamonds in response to your bid of 2 clubs, your only choice is to bid 2 no trump and hope and pray that she wasn't opening up a 17-point hand. If she was, she's going to be in 3 no trump with two chances—slim and none. So, the result of your gamble will probably be that your partner will be playing a hand in 2 no trump or 3 no trump that she could have played in 1 no trump. She might have made 1 no trump but will have very little chance at the higher level. You must be disciplined when you bid. If you have two four-card majors, but not enough points to bid, pass.

Hand 5: Pass. This is the one hand with 8 HCP that you should pass, when distribution is 4–3–3–3.

Hand 6: 2 clubs. When you bid 2 clubs, you know that your partner must respond with a bid of 2 diamonds, 2 hearts, or 2 spades. This hand is terrible, but you want it played in your eight- or nine-card trump fit. So, when you bid 2 clubs, you're forcing your partner to bid one of your three suits. No matter which suit your partner bids, you pass and you're in a better contract for your pair than 1 no trump would be, considering your horrible hand. Sure, she might only have two diamonds, but you have five, so she will be playing in a 5–2 fit with the ruffing power of your void.

Weak Responses

If you have a lousy hand—one with less than 8 points—but a five-card major, it's probably better for the hand to be played in two of the major than to have declarer play it in 1 no trump. Remember that your partner cannot open 1 no trump without at least two cards in every suit. So, if you have a five-card major, you should bid it at the 2 level. This is called a *drop dead* or *sign-off* bid, and your partner must pass. Eight cards is the magic number when determining a trump fit.

So, if your partner opens 1 no trump and you bid 2 diamonds, hearts, or spades, you're telling your partner that you have a weak hand with at least five cards in the suit you bid, so she should pass. This applies whether or not you're playing Stayman.

Invitational Five-Card Major Responses

If a direct bid of a major over your partner's 1 no trump opening is weak, how do you show an invitational or game-going hand with a five-card major? If your partner has at least three cards in your suit, you should be playing it in your 5–3 major-suit fit instead of no trump.

The answer is that you must first bid 2 clubs, and then if your partner responds in your major, you're in good shape. If she responds with 2 diamonds or two of the other major, showing four cards in that suit, you just bid your suit. That shows her you have at least five and at least an invitational hand. Then it's up to her whether to bid again and, if so, what level or *strain* (which refers to *spades*, *hearts*, *diamonds*, or *no trump*).

Game-Forcing Five- or Six-Card Major Responses

If you have 10 points and a five-card major, you should bid 2 clubs; then if your partner denies four cards in your suit, jump to three of your suit. That tells her that you have at least 10 points and five cards in your major. It's then up to her whether to play it in 3 no trump, or four of your suit. If she has three-card support for your suit, she'll bid four of your suit, game. If she only has two cards in your suit, she'll bid 3 no trump.

If you have at least 9 points and a six-card major, you should immediately jump to game in your six-card major.

Interference and Stayman

What if you have a four-card major and your RHO bids 2 clubs? You can't say, "Wait a minute; that's what I was going to bid!" Too bad, too, because that would tell your partner what you wanted her to know. But unfortunately, bridge won't allow you to do that. So, you must have some response. How do you let your partner know you have a four-card major if opponents interfere?

Just about everybody in this situation (when you intended to bid 2 clubs and your RHO took it away from you) plays a double to show that your RHO took your bid. So, since you can't bid 2 clubs, you say "double." This is not a double that tells your partner you want to defend 2 clubs doubled. Rather, in this situation a double of 2 clubs says, "Partner, I was going to bid 2 clubs but this jerk did it before I could."

That's pretty easy. But what if you intended to bid 2 clubs and your RHO bids 2 diamonds? Not too pretty, but never fear, it has come up, and the bridge gods have figured something out. If you want to bid Stayman but your RHO bids a higher-ranking suit than clubs before you can bid, there is a way to handle it: You *cue-bid* RHO's suit. A cue-bid is a forcing bid in a suit in which it's obvious that bidder cannot wish to play. A bid of the opponents' natural suit bid is a cue-bid and forces your partner to bid again to further describe her hand. At a lower level like this, you use it to get more information from your partner.

A bid of your opponents' naturally bid suit is a cue-bid. Clearly, if you're of sound mind, you probably don't want to play the contract in a suit that your opponents felt so good about they wanted to play the contract in that suit—so why would you bid your opponents' suit? The only reason would be to tell your partner something other than suggesting that it might be a good idea to play the hand in this suit yourself.

When using a cue-bid after interference after your partner has opened the bidding 1 no trump, you're telling your partner that you wanted to bid 2 clubs as Stayman, but the intervening bid kept you from it.

You must have at least 10 HCP to make a cue-bid as Stayman because it's a game-forcing bid. You shouldn't do it if you don't have a hand in which you're willing to have your partner play in 3 no trump if she doesn't have a four-card major, or if her four-card major isn't your four-card major. If it isn't, you'll have to bid 3 no trump after she bids her four-card major.

If RHO bids a major suit at the 2 level, and you cue-bid that suit at the 3 level, you're promising four cards in the other major. You shouldn't do this unless you have at least 10 HCP and are willing to have your partner play the hand in either 3 no trump or four of your major suit.

As you can see, interference by your RHO when you are responder causes severe problems. Because of this, it's a good idea when trying to bid Stayman over interference, not to continue unless you have a game-going hand. You're going to be forcing the bidding to the 3 level, and your prospects are not too good if you have a weak hand. If opponents interfere and you have a weak hand, don't try to find the 4-4 major card fit. Just pass and defend. You might find that your results are much better than if you try to play the hand.

So, over interference, you can bid Stayman two ways:

- + If RHO has bid 2 clubs, by doubling
- + If RHO has bid a suit higher than 2 clubs, by cue-bidding RHO's suit at the 3 level

Requirements for bidding Stayman over interference follow:

- + At least one four-card major
- + At least 8 HCP if you are doubling 2 clubs, or
- + At least 10 HCP if you are cue-bidding RHO's suit at the 3 level

Jump Bids

A *jump bid* is one that skips 1 level of bidding, like if opener bids 1 no trump and your first response is 3 diamonds, instead of 2 diamonds.

What if your partner opens 1 no trump and you have an unusual hand? Maybe six cards in a minor suit, but not many points? The jump bid over your partner's opening of 1 no trump can give you some solutions.

Invitational Jump Bids

What would you think a bid of 3 clubs would mean over your 1 no trump opening?

Well, it could mean whatever the partnership agrees that it means. But the way I play it, and the way a lot of the better players play it, is that it means your partner has a *broken* six-card suit headed by at least two of the four top honors (QJ is the minimum). By broken, I mean that she has some honors, but there are some cards missing. Like maybe she has AQ10xxx of clubs, missing the king and the jack. The jump bid in this case is *invitational* (a bid that suggests to your partner that your pair might want to play the hand in game or slam. As the word implies, it “invites” a game or slam try); it is telling you, “Partner, I have a six-card club suit and nothing else. But my suit contains several honors with holes. If you have at least three cards headed by one of the four top honors, then you can probably take at least five and maybe six tricks in clubs; so, if you have stoppers in the other suits we might be able to make 3 no trump.” It's a great way to get to 3 no trump with responder only having 6 points (maybe even as few as 3 if her suit is headed by the QJ), but a suit that makes the contract cold.

Weak Jump Bids

If you bid Stayman—2 clubs—in response to your partner's 1 no trump opening, and then rebid 3 clubs or 3 diamonds over whatever she bids, you're demanding that your partner pass. This bid shows a bad six-card or longer suit and a very weak hand.

Remember that when your partner opens 1 no trump, she's promising at least two cards in every suit. So if you have a six-card suit, you are assured of at least an eight-

card fit between you. If you have a truly terrible hand, maybe it's better to play it in your minor with the ruffing power it will have, instead of forcing your partner to play it in 1 no trump, a contract in which you can give her little or no help at all.

Note: If you have a very weak hand, you can bid Stayman *without* a four-card major. It's just a way of telling your partner that you have a weak hand with a six-card minor and that it's better to play it in the minor. You might get lucky. Your long suit might be diamonds and she might respond 2 diamonds, denying a four-card major. Then you can pass and she'll be playing the hand in two diamonds, your weak six-card suit, instead of the three diamonds you thought you might be forced into if she bid 2 hearts, or 2 spades, or 2 no trump. If you're not that lucky and your suit is clubs or she bids hearts or spades, your rebid is your six-card suit at the 3 level and she should pass because you are describing your hand as weak with a bad six-card suit.

Practice Hands: Jump Bids

Take a look at the following hands, which you open 1 no trump, and decide what you'll do with your partner's jump bid to 3D:

1. ♠ 1054	2. ♠ AK	3. ♠ KQ7	4. ♠ KQ107	5. ♠ A6
♥ AK7	♥ Q107	♥ 643	♥ K752	♥ 64
♦ K742	♦ 875	♦ KJ4	♦ A84	♦ QJ65
♣ AQ8	♣ KQJ65	♣ AQ42	♣ QJ	♣ AKJ83

What if your partner responds to your 1 no trump open with a bid of 3 diamonds and you're playing it as invitational?

Hand 1: This is a tough call because if you get a spade lead you could be down before you get the lead. I'd take the chance and bid 3 no trump because there's a good chance spades will split 4-3-3-3 among the players, and you may not even get a spade lead. Remember, with you holding the king of diamonds, your partner is promising two of the top four honors so at a minimum she will have the QJ, so all you have to do is force out the ace and you could get 5 diamond tricks. If your opponents lead a club, you're in good shape.

Hand 2: Pass. You are probably not going to be able to get more than four tricks in diamonds, if that, because you can't fill in your partner's diamonds. If you bid 3 no trump, hearts may be a problem, and you will certainly lose the ace of clubs. You have four losers for sure: ace of clubs, ace-king of hearts, and the diamonds, and maybe more if your opponents play the hearts correctly.

Hand 3: 3 no trump. Take a chance on a heart lead and *bad split* (a suit that doesn't split evenly between your opponents). For example, if the opponents hold five cards in a suit, a bad split would be if one is holding four of those cards and the other is holding one of them, a 4-1 split or one is holding all five, a 5-0 split. A "good split" would be a 3-2 split. Maybe you'll get a club lead into your ace-queen.

Hand 4: Pass. Even though you have the ace of diamonds for six diamond tricks, there are too many holes in the hand. You could get killed in both clubs and hearts. Forget game and let your partner play it in three diamonds, which should give you a pretty good score.

Hand 5: Pass. You almost certainly are going to get a lead of a major suit, and if it's hearts you're probably dead meat. If you get a club lead, you can run off all the tricks (in other words, to take all the tricks you can without losing the lead) before they get in to cash their major suit tricks, but this hand is too risky.

The Jacoby Transfer

Contrary to what you may be thinking, this is not a new rock group. In fact, this is one of the most ingenious conventions in bridge, and one of the easiest to learn. This is a convention that a lot of rubber bridge players don't play, so you should be prepared to play Stayman only. But this is a great bid, and I'm including it here so you'll know what it is and be able to play it with people who know it.

Have you ever envied Svengali? Have you ever wished you could train someone like Pavlov trained his dogs? In short, have you ever wanted to have total control over someone? The Jacoby Transfer will give you a taste of what Svengali and Pavlov

experienced. Maybe your partner won't drool, but if you play the Jacoby Transfer, you can control exactly what she says by what you say.

What if you heard your partner open with 1 no trump and looked at your hand and saw that you had only 2 points, but six spades? Your partner, by opening 1 no trump, has told you several things:

- + She has 15 to 17 points, no more, no less.
- + She has a balanced hand with no voids or singletons, and no more than two doubletons.

You have a maximum of 19 points between you, your 2, and her maximum of 17. Because you need 25 points to make game, you aren't going anywhere. But you know that the best place to play this contract is in 2 spades because you are assured of at least an eight-card trump fit in spades (because your partner couldn't have opened 1 no trump without at least two cards in each suit; remember, no singletons or voids when you open 1 no trump).

If you pass and your partner plays it in 1 no trump, she could be set; if you could play it in 2 spades, however, you'd have a much better chance of making the contract.

However, if you bid 2 spades, you have two big problems:

- + First, your partner won't know the size of your hand. Do you have 2 points or 10? Does she pass or bid on after you bid 2 spades?
- + Second, if you end up playing in spades, you'll be playing the contract and your partner will put her hand down as dummy. What's so bad about this? Well, everyone at the table knows that your partner has 15 to 17 points. If you're playing in 2 spades, they also know that you don't have much. They can see the dummy and know fairly well what's in each other's hand. Ergo, they can easily defend, knowing that what's not in their hand is probably in their partner's hand.

So, the problems are: How to tell your partner you don't have much, and, at the same time, tell her that you have six spades, and, communicate both bits of information to her in a way that results in her playing the hand so your hand is dummy!

Hard problem? It was until Mr. Jacoby came along with a better idea. The gist of the Jacoby Transfer is that when your partner opens 1 no trump ...

- + If responder bids 2 diamonds, opener must bid 2 hearts.
- + If responder bids 2 hearts, opener must bid 2 spades.

In the previous hand, you would bid 2 hearts, your partner would bid 2 spades and, because your hand stinks, you would then pass and she'd play the hand in 2 spades. Opener has no choice here. If you bid 2 hearts in response to her 1 no trump opening, opener *must* bid 2 spades.

One final caveat, however, before you move on to the next section: Both partners must be playing Jacoby Transfer for it to work!

Remember that when one partner opens 1 no trump, the other partner becomes the captain of the hand. *You have to trust your partner!* The responder knows opener's hand as a specific, balanced 15 to 17 points. Responder's hand is undefined, so responder places the contract. One of the beauties of the Jacoby Transfer is that responder makes the decision. With six spades and 2 points, the contract is played by opener in 2 spades.

Any time you have a five-card major and your partner opens 1 no trump, you can transfer. Even if you have no points, it would be better to play in 2 of your major, with an assured seven-card trump fit, than to force your partner to play in a more questionable 1 no trump.

Responder's Bid After Partner Accepts Transfer

Going on, if you have an invitational hand (8 to 9 points) and five cards in your suit, you bid 2 no trump in response to your partner's bid. That tells your partner exactly what you have. If she has three cards in your suit and is at the top of her range, she goes to 4. If she isn't at the top of her range with three cards in your suit, she closes out at the 3 level. If she only has two cards in your suit and a maximum, she goes to 3 no trump. If she only has two cards in your suit and not a maximum, she passes 2 no trump.

With six cards or more, and a 7- to 8-point invitational hand, you, as responder, bid 3 of your major in response to her 2 bid. With a six-card suit and 10 points, you go to game in your major in response to her 2 bid. With less than 8 points, you pass her 2 bid. Following is a chart showing responder's rebid.

Responder's Hand	Responder's Rebid
Less than 8 points	Pass
Five-card suit, 8-9 points	2NT
Six-card suit, 8-9 points	3 of your suit
Five-card suit, 10+ points	3NT
Six-card suit, 10+ points	4 of your suit

Why is the fact that opener might have three cards in the suit to which responder is transferring so magical in the discussion of Jacoby Transfer? Because responder might be transferring with a five-card suit. At responder's first bid, opener doesn't know how many cards responder has in her suit. Responder tells opener how many she has by her next bid. If her next bid is no trump, she only has five. If she rebids her suit, she has six or more. At that point, the captaincy changes back to opener because she now knows a lot about responder's hand and the decision where to play the hand and at what level is opener's responsibility. Opener knows that responder either has five or six (or more) cards in her suit. After responder's rebid, opener also knows she either has 7-8 points or 10 points. Opener places the contract based on how many points she has (15 to 16, or 17) and how many cards she has in responder's suit. Following is a chart showing opener's third bid.

Responder's Rebid	Opener's Hand	Opener's Rebid
2 no trump	15-16 points; two cards in responder's suit	Pass
2 no trump	15-16 points; three cards in responder's suit	3 of responder's suit
2 no trump	17 points; 3 of responder's suit	4 of responder's suit
3 no trump	Two cards in responder's suit	Pass
3 no trump	Three or more cards in responder's suit	4 of responder's suit

Texas Transfer

What if your partner opens 1NT and you have this hand:

♠ AKJ7432

♥ 73

♦ 98

♣ 76

You want to play in four spades but don't think you can make slam. You could use Jacoby Transfer and bid 2H and then jump to 4 spades after partner bids 2 spades. You have 8 HCP but 3 distribution points, which you can count because you know you are going to be playing in a suit. But a better way to do this is, after partner opens 1NT, just jump to 4H as a transfer to 4S. If you play Texas Transfers, that leaves a bidding system that bids 2H as Jacoby Transfer to transfer to 2S and then a jump to 4S to indicate slam interest if partner is at the top of her bid. Be sure, however, that your partner plays Texas Transfers. I was playing with Mike Shuman, who was a Grand Life Master, in a big tournament and the bidding went 1NT by Mike, 4H by me, Pass by Mike! We were playing in a 2-2 fit and it cost us the championship as we finished second.

Practice Hands; bidding goes 1NT-P-?:

1. ♠ AKJ7432

♥ 73

♦ 98

♣ 76

2. ♠ AKQ432

♥ 7

♦ KJ87

♣ 109

Hand 1: You've already seen this, jump to 4H as a Texas Transfer. You have no interest in slam.

Hand 2: Bid 2H and after partner bids 2S, jump to 4 spades. That tells partner that you have a slam going hand. If he's interested he can go further.

Stolen Bid

What if your partner opens 1NT and you were going to bid 2D to transfer to hearts and your RHO bids 2D himself? The answer is to double 2D. This is not saying to

your partner, “Pard, I think we can set them in 2D.” It is *not* a penalty double. No, this double tells your partner, “Pard, that’s what I was going to bid!.” That’s why it’s called “stolen bid,” because your RHO stole your bid and your double acts as a transfer to 2H, which opener should bid. Not everybody plays stolen bid, so make sure you and your partner are on the same wave length here before you bid it.

Responses When Responder has Two Five-Card Majors

If you have two five-card majors, you may show them to partner in one of two ways. The first is to respond with a call of 2 hearts, as a transfer to spades, then rebidding 3 hearts, showing that you have five cards in each hearts and spades. The problem with this is that opener does not know if you have an invitational hand or a game-forcing hand. If she has two spades and three hearts, does she pass your call of 3 hearts, or bid game? She can’t know. If she has two hearts and three spades, it’s easy because she bids 3 spades to show the 5-3 fit and that puts it back into your hands and you are then able to place the contract by passing if you have an invitational hand but going to 4 spades if you have a game-forcing hand. Alternatively, you could bid 2D to transfer to hearts and then rebid 3 spades showing 5-5 invitational. If you do this, then you could use bidding 2H to transfer to spades and then rebidding 3H to show a game- forcing hand.

A better way to handle the 5-5 major suit situation is for responder to jump to 3 hearts with an invitational hand and to jump to 3 spades with a game-forcing hand. That tells opener everything she needs to know. If she’s 2-2 in the majors she bids 3NT after the 3 spades call.

If she has a minimum, after the 3 hearts call she places the contract by either passing 3 hearts if her hand contains three hearts, or bidding 3 spades if her hand contains three spades. Either way, responder passes. If she’s 2-2 in the majors, she picks whichever major she feels the hand should be played in.

How to Respond With a Weak Hand Holding 5-4 in the Majors

Look at this hand:

♠ K8732

♥ Q542

♦ 98

♣ 63

Assuming that you are playing Stayman and Jacoby Transfers, when your partner opens 1 no trump you could simply bid 2H as a transfer to spades and pass your partner's 2S bid. The downside to this is that opener could have only two spades so she will be playing in a 5-2 fit. That's not disaster, but it's not optimal, either. Further, she might have four hearts and by transferring to spades you have missed a 4-4 fit in hearts.

There is a solution to this, and that is to bid Stayman, 2C, hoping that she has four hearts. If she does, and bids them, you pass and she will be playing her contract in two hearts and a 4-4 fit. If she bids 2D, denying a four-card major, then responder bids 2S (or 2H if she started with five hearts and four spades). While you still might be in a 5-2, at least you have not missed a 4-4 fit in the other major. When you are playing this, opener knows that your bid is drop dead and will know not to bid again.

Smolen

What if you have a game-forcing hand with 5-4 in the majors? Smolen is an advanced convention that many players play to handle this situation. If you have 10 HCP (or a good nine), you bid 2C, Stayman, after your partner opens 1NT. If she responds in your four-card major, you're happy and either invite by bidding three of that major or go right to game. But if she bids 2D, denying a four-card major, you jump to the 3 level in your four-card suit. Basically, you are telling her what your five-card suit is by bidding the other major and if she has three cards in it, she can go to game in that suit. Otherwise, she bids 3NT. The purpose of this is to find the 5-3 fit and allow opener, with the big hand, to play it.

Here are some hands:

1. ♠ Q543
♥ K10762
♦ 54
♣ 86

2. ♠ AK543
♥ K1076
♦ 54
♣ 86

3. ♠ Q543
♥ AKJ76
♦ 54
♣ 86

Bidding goes 1NT-2C-2D-?

Hand 1: 2H. You have a weak hand. If partner had bid 2S, you would have passed. Opener should pass this 2H bid because it is weak.

Hand 2: 3H. You have a game-forcing hand so you jump in your four-card major. If partner has three spades, she should bid 4S. If she does not have three spades, she should bid 3NT.

Hand 3: 3S, similar to Hand 2. You jump in your four-card major, asking partner to bid 4H if she had three hearts in her hand; otherwise she should bid 3NT.

Lots of people don't play Smolen, so be sure to ask your partner if she plays it before you start playing. However, although it does not come up often, it is a very useful tool.

Garbage Stayman

What if responder to a 1NT opening bid has a terrible hand with a singleton or void in clubs? There is a form of Stayman that is available. Take the following hand:

♠ 105432
♥ J874
♦ 98742
♣ Void

That's a real stinkeroo. But it's probably better played in a suit in which you have a fit rather than no trump. So responder may bid 2C and will pass any bid opener makes because opener must respond in a four-card major or diamonds if he has no four-card major. The worst that can happen is that opener will be playing in a 5-2 fit if he denies a four-card major and bids 2D if his hand happens to be 3-3-2-5, something that happens approximately 10 percent of the time.

You may do this so long as you have a singleton or void in clubs and at least five cards in diamonds. If you have a five-card major with this type of weakness you would just transfer to the five-card suit. But absent a five-card suit, you may do this if you have at least one four-card major, one three-card major, and at least a five-card diamond suit. You should have five diamonds because partner may have a 3-3-2-5 distribution with only two diamonds, and you don't want your partner playing in a 4-2 fit in diamonds.

Responses to an Opening of 2 No Trump

As we've seen, an opening bid of 2 no trump shows that your partner has 20 to 21 points and no trump distribution. Stayman applies over a 2 no trump open just as it applies over a 1 no trump open. The only difference is that you need fewer points to respond.

Always assume that when your partner opens 2 no trump she has 20 points. Then add to that the HCP you have in your hand. If they total 25, you should be in game somewhere. That means that you can bid with as few as 4 to 5 points.

The problem is that you don't really have the room to make an invitational bid, so you must make a decision based on your hand and what you know about her hand.

If you have 5 HCP but no four-card major, you respond 3 no trump. Know why? She has at least 20 points in her hand; you have 5. Together they equal 25, game in no trump. The point to remember is that when your partner opens 2 no trump, you should respond with a much weaker hand than when she opens 1 no trump. Against a 1 no trump opening you had to pass unless you had a long major suit or at least 8 points. With a 0- to 7-point hand and no five-card major, you pass. When your partner opens 2 no trump, you should pass only if you have 0 to 4 points. You should bid with 5 points or more.

When you play rubber bridge (a form of contract bridge), which is what you're learning here, always keep the following goals in mind:

- + When bidding, reach game if possible.

- + When it is determined that a game is not possible, stop at as low a level as possible.
- + When playing, maximize the number of tricks you take, whether you're defending or declaring.

Responding to a no trump opening bid makes the responder the captain of the team for that hand, so it's vitally important to know how to evaluate your hand so you may correctly place the contract.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 11

Responses to Opening One- Bids in a Suit

Responding to opening 1 no trump bids (see [Chapter 10](#)) is much easier than responding to an opening of one in a suit. That's because a 1 no trump opening is such a specific bid. You know your partner has between 15 to 17 HCP and no trump distribution. However, when she opens 1 of a suit, all you know is that she has anywhere from 12 (maybe as few as 10) to 21 points (including distribution points) and, if she opens a major, that she has at least five cards in that suit. "Distribution points" means adding points for shortness or length. Often people will add one point for each card in a suit that is longer than five cards, and add points for suits that have less than three cards (see [Chapter 5](#)). When using distribution points you should not do both at the same time. If you are adding points for shortness, you should not add points for length.

When you respond to an opening of 1 no trump, you become the captain of the pair because you know so much about your partner's hand. When you respond to an opening of 1 in a suit, however, you're not in position to take control because your partner hasn't told you enough for you to be able to take control. So, instead of taking control and placing the contract, you must communicate with your partner what you have in your hand. She told you that she has an opening hand, but not the requirements for a 1 no trump open; in return, she's asking you for a description of your hand. This chapter tells you how to tell her what she wants to know.

Reading Your Partner's Strength Quickly

When your partner opens the bidding, she tells you approximately how many points she has. However, if she opens in a suit, her bid isn't as specific as when she opens 1 no trump. Basically all you know about her hand is that she has between 12 to 21 points, and the minimum number of cards in the suit she bids. You don't know her distribution. If she opens 1 club, it could be 4-3-3-3 or it could be 0-1-4-8 (meaning no spades, one heart, four diamonds, and eight clubs). You just don't know. All you know, if she opens a minor, is that she has at least three cards in that suit. If she opens a major, she has at least five cards in that suit. In a nutshell, when your partner opens, this is what you know about her hand:

- + She has at least three cards in the suit if she opens in a minor suit.
- + She has at least five cards in the suit if she opens in a major suit.
- + She has between 12 to 21 points (including distribution points).

Not much to go on, is it? But that's what you've got. And actually, it's quite a lot. You know she has at least 12 points, you can start determining what cards they are by listening to the bidding of your opponents. Now your job is to tell her what you have.

Evaluating Your Hand

As you've seen, when you open the bidding you may count shortness. But in responding to a suit opening, you can't count shortness unless you have a trump fit, meaning that between you and your partner, you have at least eight cards in the suit. You can establish a trump fit quickly by your partner's opening bid. If she opens 1 spade and you have three spades in your hand, you have a trump fit.

When your partner opens the bidding with one of a major, she's promising you that she has the following:

- + At least 12 points
- + At least five cards in the suit bid

So, if your partner opens 1 spade, and you have three spades, you know that she has at least five spades, so you have a fit. As a result, you can use shortness (or distribution points) in determining your first bid, which is your response to her opening bid.

Shortness is only an asset if you can use it to ruff losers. If you're playing in spades and you have four losing diamonds in your hand but dummy has a singleton, you can ruff three of your losers in dummy, but only if dummy has enough trump. Without a trump fit, the shortness isn't an asset because you don't have enough trump to take advantage of it.

When you know you have a trump fit, you may give yourself more points than when evaluating your hand for the purposes of making an opening bid. When you're making

an evaluation to open the bidding, you have no idea if your partner has a fit for you in your suit, so you count your shortage points (or shortness), as I discuss in [Chapter 5](#)—3 points for a void, 2 points for a singleton, and 1 point for a doubleton. But when you respond, you know what your partner has. So, if you have a fit, you can give yourself more points, as follows:

Distribution	Points
Void	5
Singleton	3
Doubleton	1

You Must Bid with 6 Points

If you have at least 6 HCP points, you *must* bid if your RHO passes. If you pass your partner’s bid when your RHO has passed, you are specifically telling her that you have less than 6 points in your hand.

Why are you required to bid with 6 points when your RHO has passed? Because your partner can open a 15- to 21-point hand with an opening bid of only one of a suit.

You’ve already learned that a 20-point hand is opened 2 no trump. However, there are specific suit distribution requirements for a no trump bid, remember? What if your partner has 20 points, but a singleton? She can’t open up 2 no trump. She can’t open up 2 clubs because that requires 22 points. So, what’s she to do?

She can’t lie to you, so she’s left with opening up the hand with one of a suit. Even though you only have 6 points, you must keep the bidding open for her, in the event that she has a strong hand. Look at the following:

- ♠ AKQ75
- ♥ 874
- ♦ AKQJ
- ♣ 7

That's a 21-point hand; but it can't be opened at 2 no trump for two reasons: First, it contains a singleton. Second, it only has 19 HCP. (Remember: you don't count distribution points for no trump bids.) Therefore, she must open 1 spade. But look at the hand; she has seven sure tricks if spades is trump (AKQ of spades and AKQJ of diamonds). If you have three spades in your hand, she probably won't lose a spade trick, so she has nine sure tricks. That means she only needs one outside trick from you for game. Look at your possible hand:

♠ J86
♥ KQ
♦ 8532
♣ 9765

That's 6 points. She has game cold. She's not going to lose a spade trick (unless she has an unlucky or 5-0 spade break), she has four cold diamond tricks, and you give her a sure heart trick. So, when she opens this hand, all she's waiting for is for you to give her an absolute minimum response of a simple raise in her suit and she's jumping to game. If you pass because you don't like your 6 points, your LHO is probably going to pass, too.

Why? Count the HCP. You have 6, your partner has 19. That leaves 15 spread between both of your opponents. Your LHO would have to have 80 percent of the remaining points to have a bid at the 2 level. Although it's possible that your LHO will make an overcall, it's unlikely, and you can't take the chance that you'll leave your partner in the lurch with a big hand by passing.

Just remember, when your partner opens a suit bid at the 1 level and the bid is passed by your RHO, you *must* make a bid if you have 6 HCP—regardless of your estimation of the quality of those points.

Pass

That said, the first call you learn is *pass*. This tells her, "Partner, I really have a lousy hand—less than 6 points. Don't count on me for much help." It's important that you pass at your first opportunity if you have less than 6 points; then if you join the bidding

later, your partner will know that you're just competing to interfere with your opponents, and have no thought of making a very high contract.

Believe it or not, passing seems to be the hardest call to learn and conquer. For some reason, when someone's partner opens the bidding, people feel an almost irresistible urge to respond, no matter how weak the hand. Remain unemotional. If your hand doesn't meet the requirements for a minimum response, pass.

When I was still learning (actually, I'm always learning!), I was playing with one of my partners while one of the best players in Los Angeles, Earle Ziskin, was kibitzing me. My partner opened 1 club. I had 3 points, two clubs, but four spades. I bid 1 spade. After the hand, Earle said, "Tony, you misbid that."

"But I had such a terrible hand," I replied. "I was afraid she was opening up with only 3 clubs. If it's passed out, she's playing in a 3-2 trump fit."

Earle replied, "You don't have your bid. You don't have enough points. Think about what might happen next. You only have 3 points. Someone might have a lot of points and it might be your partner. She might be sitting over there just waiting to hear from you. All of a sudden she makes a jump shift, bidding 3 diamonds. That's a forcing bid. You *have* to bid. What are you going to say?"

I didn't have anything to say to that. I knew I was in trouble in this discussion, so I kept quiet and listened.

Earle continued, "The worst thing that could happen would be that your partner would be playing the hand in a 3-2 trump fit in a one-club contract. So what? She has to have some values to open. She's going to take a few tricks. So, you're down a few in one club. That's not a disaster. What would be a disaster is playing the hand in 3 no trump, doubled, down 3. *That* would be a disaster. One club isn't going to be doubled, so that might be your best contract in this hand."

I've never forgotten that lecture. Don't feel forced to bid when your partner opens a minor and you have a very weak hand with no support for the suit she opens. Just bid your hand. If you pass and the bid is passed out, your opponents probably have the majority of the points between them and have probably missed some sort of partscore, if not game. Maybe they could have made three hearts. If your partner plays it in one club down two, you've probably traded 100 points above the line to keep your opponents from getting 140 below the line. I'll take that any day of the week.

Additionally, if your partner has the aforementioned huge hand, with 20 points, she's going to listen to your response; remember that when you responded you *guaranteed* that you had 6 points in your hand, and might jump to game. When your hand comes down and she goes set, you'd better hope the game never ends, because the conversation afterward isn't going to be a walk in the park on a nice spring day.

Want to know how that conversation will go? Read on:

Partner (dripping in ice): You didn't have your bid.

You (sickly smile): I thought you'd like to know I had four spades.

Partner (venom in her voice): You didn't have your bid.

You (starting to sweat): I didn't want you to be in a 3-2 trump fit.

Partner: You didn't have your bid, and if you make another bid like that, you won't have your partner.

The moral of the story is: *pass*. I think pass is the best bid in bridge. Learn it. Don't forget it.

Describing Strength

You want to tell your partner as much about the strength of your hand as possible in one bid. This is easier if your hand is weak. The most descriptive bid you can make is 1 no trump. This tells your partner two things:

- + You have at least 6 points, not more than 9 points, specifically limiting your hand.
- + You don't have a four-card suit higher in ranking than the suit your partner opened. If your partner opened 1 diamond and you responded 1 no trump, you deny having either four hearts or four spades.

When your partner opens and you have a weak hand, your first obligation is to show a fit. So, if you have 6 to 9 points and at least three cards in her opening major suit, you should simply raise her bid to the 2 level. If your partner opens in a minor, you can't raise her suit unless you have five cards in it. Why? Because she only promises three cards in the suit when she opens a minor (refer back to [Chapter 4](#) for a detailed explanation).

Your next obligation is to tell her whether or not you have a four-card suit higher ranking than the suit she opened. If she opens 1 heart and you have 6 points and four spades without at least three hearts, your response is 1 spade.

With a very weak hand, your *first* obligation is to tell your partner if you have a fit in her major-suit opening bid. So, if she opens 1 heart and you have 6 to 9 points and at least three hearts, you should immediately raise her bid to the 2 level by bidding 2 hearts. This shows her your fit. This is true even if you have four spades.

If your partner opens 1 heart, and you don't have at least three hearts, but you have 6 points with less than four spades, your response is 1 no trump.

Knowing this, respond with the following hands to your partner's opening bid of 1 club:

1. ♠ AK85	2. ♠ 9865	3. ♠ AKQ	4. ♠ K64	5. ♠ 86
♥ Q74	♥ AKQ	♥ 863	♥ K65	♥ KJ972
♦ 854	♦ 832	♦ 9652	♦ Q98	♦ 853
♣ 987	♣ 742	♣ 874	♣ 9653	♣ 872

Hand 1: 1 spade. This is a clear bid. You have 9 HCP and four spades.

Hand 2: 1 spade. Your strength is in hearts, but you only have three of them. Your partner is looking for an eight-card fit. Because she can't open a major suit unless she has five of them, she must open a minor suit with only four cards in the majors. Your bid of 1 spade tells her that you have four spades. If she has four spades, you have an eight-card trump fit, which is what you're looking for.

Hand 3: 1 diamond. Despite your HCP strength in spades, you only have three of them. You do have four diamonds, even though they're weak.

Hand 4: 1 no trump. You have 6 to 9 HCP, but you don't have a four-card suit of higher rank than the suit your partner opened. This bid tells her that information specifically.

Hand 5: Pass. Sure, your hearts look okay, but you don't have enough points to bid. If you bid this hand, and your partner has a very strong hand, she could make a forcing bid, requiring you to bid again, or worse, she could have four hearts and 20 HCP and jump to game, and you could find yourself in a much higher contract than you should be.

Which Suit to Show First

If you have a five-card suit and a four-card suit, which do you bid? Generally, your *longest suit is your strongest suit*. To take the most extreme example, xxxxx is stronger than AKJ10. If your partner opens 1 club and you have five spades, four hearts, and enough points to bid, you bid the spades—even if your hearts are AKQJ and your spades are Qxxxx.

Bidding with Two Four-Card Suits

If you have two four-card suits, the rule is simple: bid the lower-ranking suit first. This is called bidding *up the line*. Conversely, bidding a higher-ranking suit before you bid a lower-ranking suit is called bidding *down the line*.

If your partner opens 1 club and you have four diamonds and four hearts, depending on the strength of your hand, you bid 1 diamond. If you have four hearts and four spades, you bid 1 heart. This allows your partner to bid 1 spade if she has four of them. If you were to bid 1 spade and your partner has four hearts, she would be forced to bid at the 2 level, and she probably wouldn't want to bid a four-card suit for the first time at the 2 level unless she had a very strong hand.

However, if you have a very weak hand that can justify only one bid, if she opens 1C and you have four diamonds and four hearts or four spades but only 6 HCP, you should bypass the four diamonds and bid the major suit in which you have four cards. Many good players will even bypass a five-card diamond suit to bid a four-card major in this situation.

Remember: a new suit bid by responder is forcing on opener. This means that opener must bid again if her partner responds to his opening with a new suit.

Bidding with Two Five- or Six-Card Suits

If you have two five- or six-card suits, you should *not* bid them up the line. Rather, you should bid the higher-ranking suit first, or bid down the line, and then rebid the other if your partner doesn't support you.

Why? There are several reasons. These are suits that demand they both be mentioned. If you bid them up the line, you might have to go to the 3 or 4 level to mention the other at the second bid. For instance, if you have five diamonds and five hearts and your partner opens 1 club, if you were to bid up the line you'd bid 1 diamond. Then if your partner bids 1 spade or 1 no trump or 2 clubs, you have to bid 2 hearts. A new suit bid by responder is forcing on opener for one round, so your partner must bid again. Basically you're asking her to make a choice, and whatever she chooses she has to go to the 3 level.

If, on the other hand, you bid the higher ranking first in response to her 1 club opening, the bidding could go like this.

Partner

1 ♣

1NT

You

1 ♥

2 ♦

If she's got a minimum hand with heart support, she can express her preference by bidding 2 hearts, staying at the lower 2 level.

Another reason to bid down the line for two five- or six-card suits is that this is the only way you can indicate your length to partner. If you bid them up the line, how is she to know how many you have in your first suit? You might only have four. So, if you bid a higher-ranking suit first, like hearts, and then bid a lower-ranking suit at your next opportunity, you might only have four of the lower-ranking suit, but for sure you have five of the higher-ranking suit, which was your first bid suit.

Responding at the 2 Level

To respond at the 2 level to your partner's opening bid of 1 in a suit, you must have the following:

- + At least 10 HCP
- + A five-card major suit, or a four-card minor

If your partner opens 1 spade and you have five clubs and 10 HCP, you can respond with a bid of 2 clubs. Whenever you make a 2 level response to your partner's opening 1 level bid, you're promising her at least 10 HCP.

Bidding 2 clubs over a 1 spade open does *not* deny that you have trump support (which would be at least three cards in spades). So, if you have at least 10 HCP and five clubs, along with three spades, you can, and should, bid 2 clubs first, then support your partner's spades at your next bid. Your first bid shows the strength of your hand, that you have more than a minimum. Don't forget, when you, as responder, bid a new suit, it is 100 percent forcing on opener to bid again; you can't be passed out at two clubs. When your partner bids again, no matter what she bids, you can bid spades to show her that you have spade support.

This information is important to her, because if you just bid 2 spades over her opening bid of 1 spade, she would think that you had a minimum hand, maybe only 6 points, and might pass. But if you show her that you have at least 10 points and at least four clubs first, when she learns that you *also* have three spades, she can better evaluate where to place the contract.

Raising Your Partner's Major-Suit Opening

The one exception to this rule of a 2 level response to partner's opening 1 level bid (that you must have at least 10 HCP and a five-card major suit/four-card minor suit before responding) is if you raise your partner's suit. For example, she opens 1 spade and you respond 2 spades. A raise of your partner's opening major suit bid promises the following:

- + 6 to 9 points
- + At least three cards in your partner's suit

Next to responding 1 no trump, this is the *weakest* positive bid you can make.

Responding 1 no trump is weaker because it denies trump support. Raising her suit promises at least three cards in the suit, and therefore informs her that you have trump support for her, which is information she can use to further evaluate her hand. This is a bid that definitely limits your hand. You can't make this bid with three trump and 10 points. Responding 2 spades to your partner's opening bid of 1 spade tells her you don't have more than 9 points.

Constructive Raise

While a normal raise of 1M-2M shows what is set forth above, some people play "constructive raises." This says that if you as responder raise partner's opening bid of 1 of a major to the 2 level, like 1S-2S, you are promising the top of your bid, 8-10 HCP. If you have minimum, you bid 1NT and then give partner the raise to 2 of the major after his second bid of a new suit. The problem with this is that then partner does not know whether you have three card support or are just signing off with two card support. But opener knows one of two possibilities:

1. You do not have 8-10 HCP, or
2. You do not have three card support.

People who play constructive raises are in the minority.

Raising Your Partner's Minor-Suit Opening

Note that I emphasized that you may support your partner's *major*-suit opening if you have three cards in it. This is definitely not true for a minor-suit opening by your partner. Why?

- + When your partner opens in a major suit, she's promising at least five cards in that suit. So, if you have three, you have the desired eight-card fit.
- + When your partner opens in a minor suit, she's only promising three cards in that suit. So, if you have three and she only has the three that she promised, you're in a dismal six-card fit and disaster is looming.

Because of this, you can't support your partner in a minor-suit opening unless you have five cards in the suit. Occasionally you will be in a fix where you can't respond 1 no trump and only have four of your partner's minor suit; then you're forced to raise her with only four. But try to avoid this. Of course, when you raise your partner's minor suit opening, you're giving her the weakest response possible. If she opened on a three-card suit, and you're raising on a four-card suit, she'll probably pass, unless she opened a strong hand. That's the beauty of the auction. Each bid means something. When she opens a minor, it means she doesn't have a five-card major. If you respond by raising her suit, it means you not only don't have a four-card major, but your hand is weak and her suit is your strongest suit. Even if she only has three, if she's on just a standard opening hand—nothing special—she will probably pass. You shouldn't be in too much trouble playing in a 3–4 fit at the 2 level.

Enough talking, let's bid some hands. Your partner opens 1 club:

1. ♠ 98743
♥ AKQ6
♦ 64
♣ 54

2. ♠ AKQ4
♥ 8764
♦ 863
♣ 85

3. ♠ AKQ
♥ 9754
♦ 872
♣ 984

4. ♠ J865
♥ 76
♦ AJ765
♣ 75

5. ♠ 64
♥ AK98
♦ AJ952
♣ 87

6. ♠ A64
♥ K98
♦ 854
♣ 8754

7. ♠ 876
♥ J86
♦ AJ
♣ 97652

8. ♠ K873
♥ Q985
♦ J1086
♣ 7

Hand 1: 1 spade. Your hearts are terrific, but you only have four of them. You must bid your longest major, and that's spades.

Hand 2: 1 heart. Your spades are terrific, but when you have two major suits of equal length, you bid the lower ranking first, bidding up the line.

Hand 3: 1 heart. You have 9 points and four hearts.

Hand 4: 1 diamond. It's the longest suit, and therefore your strongest. Note, however, that some players will bypass the five diamonds to bid the four-card spade suit because this hand is too weak to make two calls. The advantage of this type of bidding is that if you bid 1D first and partner bids 1H, you are forced to bid 1S which would, to most anyway, indicate a stronger hand than you possess.

Hand 5: 1 diamond. You have enough points to bid twice. Remember that when you bid a new suit it *forces* opener to bid again. So, you bid your 1 diamond. No matter what your partner bids, you can bid your hearts at the 2 level, describing your hand as more than 10 HCP with five diamonds and four hearts. This is a good example of a hand that is worth two bids, and there is no reason to misdescribe your distribution by bypassing the five-card diamond suit to bid the four-card heart suit.

Hand 6: 1 no trump. You have 7 HCP and both major suits stopped once and only have four clubs. You're not promising stoppers in all three unbid suits when you respond 1 no trump, so the fact that you don't have diamonds stopped doesn't preclude you from responding 1 no trump.

Hand 7: 2 clubs. This is pretty clear. You have 7 HCP, no stoppers in the majors, and five clubs.

Hand 8: 1 diamond. You bid suits of equal length up the line. You don't deny a four-card major by bidding 1 diamond in response to your partner's 1 club opening. Partner should also bid her four-card suits up the line, so if she has a four-card major, she

should bid it after your 1D call. If she bids it at the 1 level it is not forcing, so you could (and should) pass then.

Your partner opens 1 heart:

1. ♠ J643	2. ♠ AKJ	3. ♠ 742	4. ♠ K8	5. ♠ Q1065
♥ AK4	♥ 752	♥ A5	♥ 862	♥ 65
♦ 753	♦ 85	♦ J632	♦ Q62	♦ 98
♣ 752	♣ K8653	♣ Q964	♣ J10754	♣ J7642

Hand 1: 2 hearts. Your spades are too weak to not show your very strong hearts support immediately.

Hand 2: 2 clubs. You have 11 points and a five-card clubs suit. You show your hearts support at your next bid.

Hand 3: 1 no trump. You have a minimum hand without hearts support, even though you have the ace. If your partner bids another suit at the 2 level, you can bid 2 hearts, showing a minimum hand with two hearts.

Hand 4: 2 hearts. This is a bare minimum hand, but you do have three hearts. You must tell your partner what you have, and a simple raise of your partner's opening suit only promises three trumps and 6 points. That's what you've got. Any other bid she makes will be her problem, because you've warned her that your hand stinks. But you have an obligation to keep the bidding open with 6 points. Why? Your partner might have opened a 20-point hand with a bid of 1 heart. All she needs to know is that you have 6 points and three hearts and she'll bid game. This is a classic hand where your partner must be able to trust you to bid correctly.

Hand 5: Pass. Only 4 points, no support for hearts. You don't want this to get any higher. You must show your partner your weakness. You might have a 4-4 spade fit, but if you don't, what are you going to do when your partner bids 3 diamonds—a forcing bid—at her next call?

Inverted Minors

This is a bid that reverses the meanings of two bids: a one-over-one raise (e.g., 1C-2C) and a limit raise (1C-3C; a limit raise shows support for partner's suit along with 10-12 HCP), so that 1 minor-2 minor shows a limit raise hand with 10+ HCP and no four-card major. There are various ways to play it but here is the way lots of people play it.

Here are the requirements:

1. After your partner opens 1C or 1D: if 1C you must have at least five clubs in your hand because opener could open with only 3 clubs; if 1D you must have at least four diamonds in your hand (because 90 percent of the time a 1D opening bid has four diamonds. The only time it doesn't is if distribution is 4-4-3-2, which only happens about 10 percent of the time);
2. No four-card major;
3. At least 10 HCP.

Let's assume the bidding goes 1 minor-2 minor; Opener's rebid show the following:

1. 2D over a 1C-2C sequence shows a diamond stopper and no stoppers in hearts or spades.
2. 2H shows a heart stopper, denies a spade stopper, and is silent about the unbid minor.
3. 2S shows a spade stopper, denies a heart stopper, and is silent about the unbid minor.
4. 2NT shows a minimum opener with stoppers in both majors but is silent about the unbid minor.
5. 3 of the opening minor shows no stoppers in any other suit.
6. 3NT 18-19 HCP with all unbid suits stopped.

Responder's rebid after opener bids a new suit at the 2 level:

1. 2NT shows a minimum balanced hand with all unbid major suits stopped.

2. If opener bid 2D over 2C, a bid of one of the majors shows that suit stopped and the other not stopped.
3. If opener bid 2H, a bid of 2S shows a spade stopper but no diamond stopper but is silent about the unbid minor.
4. If opener bid 2S, 2NT shows a minimum hand with a heart stopper but is silent about the unbid minor.
5. 3 of opener's minor denies stoppers in the unbid suits.
6. 3NT shows 13-15 HCP balanced with stoppers in the unbid suits.

Look at this hand when partner opens 1C:

♠ KQ2
♥ 87
♦ 875
♣ AQ754

After your 2C inverted minor bid, partner bids 2H, saying she has hearts stopped but not spades. Since you do not have diamonds stopped, you bid 2S because you have spades stopped and an invitational hand, 11-12 HCP. After you have shown your stopper in spades, you are asking her to bid 2 or 3NT, depending on the strength of her hand, if she has diamonds stopped. If she does not have diamonds stopped, she bids 3C, or however many clubs she thinks she can make.

The main purpose of inverted minors is to see if you should be playing the hand in no trump rather than a minor suit because no trump contracts are more rewarding. Inverting the meaning of the two bids, with the stronger bid at a lower level than the weaker bid keeps the bidding low and enables more communication between the partners.

Reverse Drury

Doug Drury invented this convention because his partner, Eric Murray, kept opening light in third seat and kept going down a lot. Drury designed this method to cater to Murray's excesses. Originally, the opening bidder bid 2 diamonds to show a weak hand

and 2 of the major to show a full opening bid. Then, as always happens, players got their hands on the convention and they dabbled with it and eventually switched the bids so that opener's 2 of a major shows a weak hand and 2 diamonds shows a good hand. This is sensible because it gives the partnership more bidding room. Reverse Drury is now the most common version.

When partner opens in third seat, it's possible that she's opening weaker than the normal 12-point hand. In this event if you had a limit raise and jumped to three of her suit, you could be in trouble. Reverse Drury was created to find out if partner opened a normal opening hand or weak. The requirements for bidding Reverse Drury by the responder to partner's third seat opening bid of 1 of a major are:

- + At least 10 HCP.
- + At least three card support in partner's major suit opening bid.

The point of using Reverse Drury is to allow opener to play the hand in the lowest contract possible if she opened light (less than 12 HCP). With her first rebid, she tells responder if she opened with full opening values or light. She does that by rebidding her suit if she opened light, and by bidding a new suit if she had a full opener.

Rebidding her suit does not promise six cards. Also, bidding a new suit to show a full opener is conventional, and doesn't promise anything more than three cards in the suit. Players have known for a long time that it's wise to open very aggressively in third seat. As a matter of fact, it's not uncommon to open 1 spade on a hand like this one:

♠ KQ875
♥ A74
♦ 984
♣ J10

Bidding 1 spade makes life tougher for the opponents, and it may help you on defense, but it comes with a downside. If your partner has a maximum-passed hand, she may start jumping around, getting you too high. Often, as responder, you will have a hand worth 10 or 11 points in support of your partner's suit. You might like to jump to 3 of the major, but if she has a weak or subminimum opening bid, you may go down. One way to handle this situation is the Reverse Drury.

Reverse Drury is a way to show your good hands when your partner opens 1 of a major in third or fourth seat by bidding 2 clubs. It's a conventional bid that tells your partner that you have a maximum-passed hand with at least three-card support in her suit.

Take a look at the following hands and try to decide when you might be able to employ Reverse Drury:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
		P	P
1 ♠	P	?	
1. ♠ KJ84 ♥ Q83 ♦ Q983 ♣ J3	2. ♠ J72 ♥ AK983 ♦ K6 ♣ 732	3. ♠ J10754 ♥ 3 ♦ AJ84 ♣ Q108	4. ♠ 974 ♥ 64 ♦ AJ43 ♣ KQ97

Hand 1: 2 spades. Make your normal bid. You need 10 good support points for a Drury bid.

Hand 2: 2 clubs. This is the Drury bid. It says nothing about clubs. It says you have better than a normal raise, typically a good 10 points and up. Don't bid 2 hearts. Your partner can pass a Two-over-One bid when you are a passed hand.

Hand 3: 3 spades. The jump raise is still the limit, but it promises at least four card trump support and a singleton. If you don't have a singleton, your hand is somewhat balanced and is better handled by using Drury.

Hand 4: 2 clubs, Drury. You do have three trumps and you have 11 HCP along with a doubleton.

When opener rebids after your partner's Drury bid:

+ 2 diamonds. Opener says she has a full opening bid and is interested in game if responder has a good Drury hand. It is possible that opener has a very big hand

and is waiting to see what responder does next. Opener may have real diamonds, but she may just want to see what responder thinks.

+ 2 of the major. In this case, 2 spades. If opener rebids her major, it shows a weak hand and denies any possibility of game. Responder should pass.

Opener can bid other things besides 2 diamonds or 2 of the major. Other bids confirm a full opening bid, too. I show you how in the following hands:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
		P	P
1 ♠	P	2 ♣	P
?			
1. ♠ AKJ87 ♥ 87 ♦ Q87 ♣ 873	2. ♠ Q9874 ♥ 3 ♦ AK108 ♣ K105	3. ♠ J9874 ♥ AK ♦ 92 ♣ AQ84	4. ♠ KJ98743 ♥ 2 ♦ AK7 ♣ AQ
5. ♠ QJ874 ♥ KQJ ♦ KQ9 ♣ AJ	6. ♠ KJ763 ♥ KQ ♦ Q98 ♣ Q104		

Hand 1: 2 spades. You have less than an opening bid and want your partner to pass. When opener rebids the major, responder always passes no matter how good his passed hand happens to be.

Hand 2: 2 diamonds. Counting distribution, you have better than a minimum. You are willing to go to game if your partner has a maximum hand. If your partner has a minimum Drury hand, she will bid 2 spades and you will pass.

Hand 3: 4 spades. Counting distribution, you have around 16 points and your partner has 10 or more with spades support. Bid game. Don't bother bidding clubs. Why tell the opponents something you prefer they don't know?

Hand 4: 4 no trump. Ask for aces and bid a slam if partner has one or two aces. You have about 22 HCP now that spades have been supported.

Hand 5: 4 spades. Just bid a game. You have a big hand, but East has a maximum of 11 points. When you know game is worth bidding and when you know there is no slam, don't waste time making bids that you don't have to make.

Hand 6: 2 spades. This is a 13-HCP hand, but it's balanced and minimum and it has poor-quality points (queens and jacks).

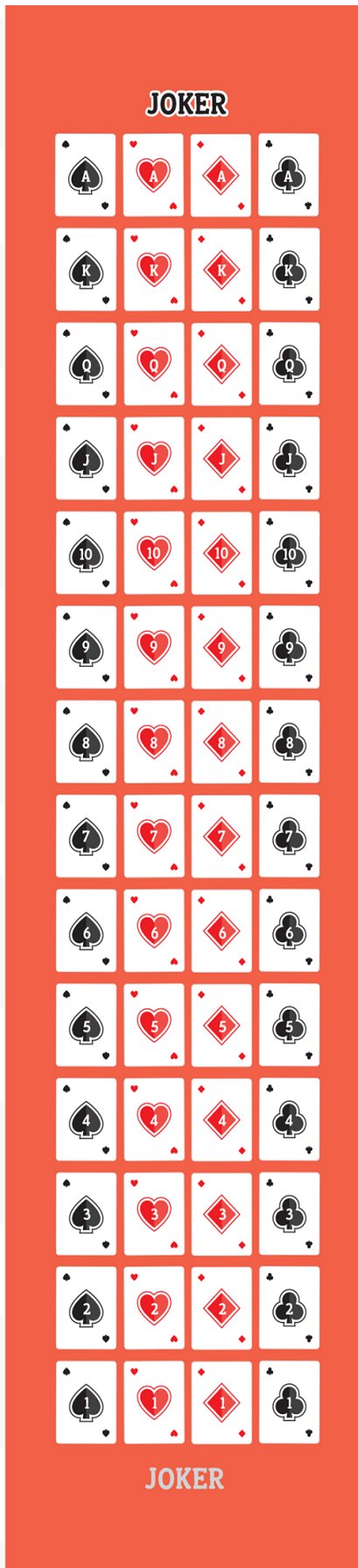
If you have a hand with clubs and no support for your partner's major, you cannot bid 2 clubs because that would promise support for her major. Bid 1 no trump and hope for a sane result. Conventions all come with benefits, but they all have the occasional drawbacks, too.

If your partner uses Drury after you open 1 of a major in third or fourth seat and you have a full opening bid or more, it is usually best to bid 2 diamonds because it tells the opponents very little about your hand. Bid another suit instead of 2 diamonds if you see a reason to do so, but for the most part bidding 2 diamonds is wise.

If your partner opens a major in third or fourth seat and the next player doubles or overcalls 1 spade, you should continue to use Drury. The rule is that 2 clubs is the *only* Drury bid. Note that if your RHO overcalls 1 no trump, the Drury bid doesn't exist. It works only if your RHO passes, overcalls 1 spade, or makes a takeout double.

It should be noted that some advanced players play "two way Reverse Drury." In this, a bid of 2C by responder shows a limit raise with three-card support for opener's suit and a bid of 2D by responder shows a limit raise with four-card support for opener's suit.

Now that you've learned about responses to one-bids, let's move to the next chapter on responses to interference.



Chapter 12

Responses Over Interference

So far we've been talking about bidding when your opponents docilely pass at their turn. Alas, this doesn't always happen. When your opponents are bidding, it changes the meanings of your responses. Let's start by discussing interference.

Interference

When a player opens and opponents bid, that's called *interference*. Opponents are interfering with opener's bidding by bidding themselves.

You have two obligations in responding to your partner's opening bid:

- + Tell her what you have as quickly and accurately as possible.
- + Keep the bidding open for your partner if you have at least 6 points in case she opened at the 1 level with a huge hand. This obligation is removed if you have less than 6 points.

Your first obligation doesn't change when your opponents interfere. Your second obligation does.

When your opponents interfere, you're relieved of one of responder's obligations: the commitment to keep the bidding open for your partner. Why? Because when your RHO passes, you don't know what your LHO is going to do. He might pass, too. If this happens, and you haven't taken a call, the bidding will pass out and partner will be playing the hand in her opening bid. So, if your RHO passes, you must bid if you have 6 points so that your partner, whose hand is basically undefined unless she's opened 1 no trump, will get another chance to bid. She might have opened a 20-point hand at the 1 level because she didn't have anything else to bid. She's just waiting to find out if you have 6 points to place the contract in game.

But when your RHO bids, your obligation to bid with at least 6 points is removed because your partner will definitely get another chance to bid, even if you pass. If you take a bid right after your RHO bids, it's called a *free bid* because you have no obligation to bid.

Free Bid of a Suit at the 1 Level

A free bid of a new suit at the 1 level tells your partner that you have a better than minimum hand. So, with 6 or 7 points, you should pass. If you take a free bid after your RHO bids, you're telling your partner that you have one of the following:

- + At least 8 points with a four-card suit
- + At least 7 points with a good suit

If you pass, you're denying one of these holdings and telling your partner that if she bids again she can't count on much help from you.

Free Bid of a Suit at the 2 Level

A free bid of a new suit at the 2 level promises the same 10 points it promises without interference, but implies game interest. Why? Because opponents have shown a biddable hand and some points. You're telling your partner that despite the fact that opponents may have some points and a good suit, you think the contract should be yours and want to explore it more. This bid is 100 percent forcing on your partner to bid again.

Free Bid of No Trump

A free bid of 1 no trump over RHO's *overcall* promises the following:

- + 8 to 10 HCP
- + A stopper in RHO's suit

An *overcall* is any bid after an opponent has opened the bidding. So, if your pair opens the bidding and opponents make a bid, it's an overcall. If your opponents open the bidding and you or your partner make a bid, it's an overcall.

Therefore, if your partner opens 1 club and RHO bids 1 spade, what would you bid with the following hands?

1. ♠ Q65
♥ K97
♦ 865
♣ Q975

2. ♠ 86
♥ K94
♦ Q842
♣ Q752

3. ♠ 86
♥ K94
♦ Q84
♣ Q9752

4. ♠ K1065
♥ 1094
♦ Q82
♣ J97

Hand 1: 1 no trump. You can properly respond 1 no trump because you have 8 HCP and a stopper in spades. It's not a great stopper, but it is a stopper.

Hand 2: Pass. This tells your partner that you have a minimum hand, 0 to 9 points, without a stopper in opponent's suit. Had your RHO overcalled 1 heart, your pass would also tell your partner you don't have four spades, because with 8 to 9 points and four spades, you should bid your spade suit over RHO's *overcall* of 1 heart. You can't make a simple raise to 2 clubs because your partner might only have three cards in the suit.

Hand 3: 2 clubs. You have 8 points. Even though your partner opened a club, she may only have three cards in the suit, so you need five clubs to make a simple raise. You have five clubs and 8 points. This bid effectively tells your partner that she can count on you for only 8 to 9 points and five clubs.

Hand 4: Pass. You would have bid 1 spade without interference, but your RHO bid it first! Even though you have a good spade suit, you only have 6 points. A free bid of 1 no trump would tell your partner you have a stronger hand. A pass tells her you have less than 8 points. If she has extra values, she'll bid again. Then, if she makes a forcing bid, you can tell her about your spades. (For example, if your partner doubles to get you back in the bidding, you'd bid 1 no trump.) If your partner has a minimum opening hand, and given your weak hand, it would be better to defend opponents in one spade than to bid to a contract where you might have a lot of trouble.

Negative Doubles

At its basics, a negative double is not a penalty double. Rather, it is a double by you when your partner has opened the bidding, and your RHO has overcalled. Your double tells your partner that you have *exactly* four cards in the unbid major and a

certain number of HCP. It also implies support in the other unbid suit, but this is not an absolute requirement.

1 Level Negative Doubles

Let's say you're in third seat and the bidding has gone 1 diamond by your partner, 1 heart by your RHO, and you hold the following:

♠ KQ75

♥ 109

♦ J762

♣ 873

Not wonderful, is it? But you do have four spades and you do have 6 HCP. If your RHO had passed, you would just bid 1 spade and let it go at that. But how does your partner know how many spades you have? You could have five spades, or you could have four spades.

When your RHO overcalls in this situation, the negative double takes care of that problem for you. If you have at least five spades and this hand, you bid 1 spade. But if you have this hand, with four spades, you *double*!

This is a *conventional* bid that doesn't mean what it says. It is not a *penalty double*. You aren't saying to your partner, "Hey, pard, we got 'em. We can set this baby, so I'm doubling!"

No, it doesn't say that at all. Instead, it says, "Partner, I have at least 6 HCP and exactly four spades in my hand. Not five spades. Not six spades. Not three spades. Exactly four spades."

The requirements for a 1 level negative double, that is, a negative double that allows your partner to make a bid and stay at the 1 level, are as follows:

1. At least 6 HCP;
2. Exactly four cards in the unbid major;

2 Level Negative Doubles

The requirements become more stringent as you force your partner to higher levels of bidding. So, look at the following hand:

♠ 1097
♥ KQ85
♦ 73
♣ K1064

Bidding goes like this:

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♦	1 ♠	?

Now, you know you can't bid a new suit at the 2 level without at least 10 HCP. If you were to bid a new suit with this hand at the 2 level you would be lying to your partner. And you don't want to have one of those conversations when she takes action on your promised strength only to find out you lied.

So, what are you to do? Your hand isn't bad and you do have four hearts, which your partner might like to know about. What to do?

Ah, you're probably way ahead of me. Negative double! In this hand, you have four hearts and 8 HCP, exactly what you need to make a negative double which forces your partner to bid at the 2 level. The negative double is a terrific way to tell your partner what you have without lying to her.

You might have more than 6 HCP when you make a negative double at the 1 level and more than 8 HCP when you make it at the 2 level, but you are promising that you have *at least* 6 HCP at the 1 level and *at least* 8 HCP at the 2 level.

Again, I am going to stress that you cannot lie to your partner. If, instead of the previous hand you had the following:

♠ 1097
♥ KJ85

♦ 73

♣ Q1064

... and the bidding went as before, 1 diamond by partner and 1 spade by your RHO, you may not make a negative double because, if you did, you would be forcing your partner to bid at the 2 level and you do not have 8 HCP. Your bid here would be to pass. Partner has another bid so you have no obligation to keep the bidding open. You can't bid a new suit at the 2 level because you don't have 10 HCP, and you can't bid 1 no trump because you don't have spades, your RHO's bid, stopped. So, all you can do is pass.

I know a lot of players who would be tempted to make a negative double with this hand, even though they don't have enough HCP. But I hope you are not one of these. Don't lie to your partner.

Following is a chart showing point requirements for negative doubles:

Level	HCP
1	6
2	8
3	10

To recapitulate,

1. If your negative double will allow your partner to bid your suit at the 1 level, you can make a negative double with only 6 HCP in your hand.
2. If your negative double will force your partner to bid your suit at the 2 level, you must have at least 8 HCP in your hand.
3. If your negative double will force your partner to bid your suit at the 3 level, you must have at least 10 HCP in your hand.

The Reopening Double

Before getting into the reopening double, there's one last item to cover. You may use a negative double to show minor suits if partner, for instance, opens 1H and your RHO overcalls 1S. If your hand is like the following:

♠ 10943
♥ A
♦ KQ109
♣ J1098

A negative double may be used to show two four-card minor suits and at least 8 HCP. This is a perfect hand for a minor suit negative double.

When you add any bid to your repertoire, you give up something. When you play negative doubles, you give up the ability to double some low-level bids by opponents for penalty.

Even a lot of experienced players aren't aware of the fact that the *reopening double* is an integral part of the negative double system. What if, not vulnerable v. vulnerable, in third seat and the bidding goes 1 heart by your partner then 2 diamonds by your RHO? It's now your bid and you hold the following cards:

♠ A86
♥ 95
♦ AKJ86
♣ K42

You could bid 3 no trump, but wouldn't you like to double 2 diamonds? Alas, you can't double it because that would be a negative double, which you can't make because you don't have four spades. So, how can you defend 2 diamonds doubled in this hand? You clearly cannot double because your partner will respond as she has to in the negative double system.

The answer is that if your partner opens the bidding followed by a bid at the 2 level by your RHO, and you pass and your LHO passes, your partner should "reopen the bidding" with a double if she has shortness in the suit bid by opponents and tolerance for the unbid suits. *Shortness*, in this context, means no more than a doubleton. So, if

your partner has two or less of your RHO's suit, she should double. To be specific, here's how the bidding goes.

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>
1 ♠	2 ♦	P	P
?			

In the previous situation, your partner should protect you by doubling when it's her turn. Then you can either let it sit for penalty, which you would do with the above hand, or pull it by either bidding your partner's suit at the 2 level if you can, or making the best bid you have under the circumstances.

This is called a *reopening double* because it's made by the opening bidder, and she's reopening the bidding by doubling since, with two passes to her, if she passes, the bidding will stop. If she doesn't bid or double, the auction is over.

Of course, you might have a legitimate pass, too. You might *not* be passing because you have opponents' suit. You might have the following:

♠ 862
♥ 75
♦ 1096
♣ Q10873

If you have this holding and your partner makes a reopening double, you should just pull the double and support your partner's opening suit, in which she'll have at least a 5–2 fit. Your partner anticipates this. Her double is just inviting you to let it stand for penalty if you have a lot of opponents' suit. If you don't, just retreat to the best contract. If you retreat, your partner will know you passed originally because you don't have much.

Requirements for a reopening double are as follows:

- + A reopening double can be made only by opening bidder.
- + After LHO has overcalled and there are two passes by your partner and your RHO.

- + Opening bidder has two or less cards in overcalled suit.
- + Opening bidder must have tolerance (at least 3 cards) for all unbid suits.
- + Opening bidder's hand cannot be distributional, like 5-5-2-1.

We have covered a negative double when partner opens a minor and RHO bids a major. Those are the easy ones. It gets a little more complicated.

Negative Doubles and Five-Card Majors at the 1 Level

If you have a five-card major and sufficient points you must bid the suit. If you have a four-card major and a five-card major, don't use a negative double to describe this hand, bid the five-card major. Your partner will be relying on you to bid a five-card major at the 1 level if you have it. If you're using negative doubles, bidding the suit at the 1 level over an intervening bid promises five cards unless both majors are unbid. A double promises four cards.

Only One Four-Card Major

If your partner and your RHO have both bid minor suits, and you only have one four-card major, you cannot use a negative double to describe your hand, because a negative double promises four cards in each unbid major suit. Look at the following hand:

♠ KQ75
♥ Q73
♦ 872
♣ 983

Partner opens 1 club, RHO bids 1 diamond. You can't make a negative double. Your only bid is 1 spade. If you made a negative double you would be promising four spades *and* four hearts. Since you don't have four hearts, you can't make a negative double.

To repeat, if the bidding goes 1 club by your partner, 1 diamond overcall by your RHO, you must have *2 four-card majors* to make a negative double. This is also true if your partner opens 1 diamond and your RHO overcalls 2 clubs. You must have 2 four-

card majors to make a negative double if both major suits are unbid. So, your partner must be aware that an auction of ...

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♣	1 ♦	1 ♥

... does *not* promise a five-card heart suit. You bid as if there had been no overcall and your heart bid only promises four cards in the suit.

2 Level Negative Doubles with a Five-Card Major

If you have five cards in an unbid major in this situation, but not enough points to make a suit bid at the 2 level, you can utilize the negative double. Look at the following hand:

♠ 1097
♥ KJ852
♦ 73
♣ Q106

Bidding:

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♦	1 ♠	?

You can't bid 2 hearts because you only have seven points. But you do have five hearts. What to do?

In this situation, I will make a negative double. You don't have eight points, but you do have five hearts. So, you can amend the rule a little to say that you can make a negative double which forces partner to bid your suit at the 2 level in the following circumstances:

1. Four cards in the unbid major and at least eight points, or
2. Five cards in the unbid major and at least seven points.

Upper Bidding Limit for Making Negative Doubles

Negative doubles are generally played through bids of 2 spades. Any double of a bid over 2 spades is for penalty. So, look at the following hand you hold:

♠ 86
♥ KQJ10
♦ A763
♣ 874

The auction goes:

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♠	3 ♣	?

You cannot double the 3 clubs bid here to show that you have four hearts. If you double 3 clubs, partner will leave it in, probably, as a penalty double. *Negative doubles stop after 2 spades*. If you double any bid over 2 spades, you are doubling for penalty.

However, the upper limit for negative doubles is by partnership agreement. Many advanced players play them through 3 spades. I had a partner who liked to play them through 4 diamonds. Whatever you choose, just be sure you and your partner agree.

Partner Opens 1D, RHO Overcalls 2C

Here's your hand now:

♠ Q86
♥ KQJ6
♦ 76
♣ 8742

The auction goes:

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♦	2 ♣	?

Since a negative double over 1C-1D *promises* two four-card majors, you might think that you cannot make a negative double with this hand. You would be wrong. Why can you make a negative double here but not over 1C-1D?

The answer is because you have a bid if you are 4-3 in the majors at the 1 level. You may bid your four-card suit. At the 2 level, however, if you cannot make a negative double you cannot bid your four-card major. So, over this auction, with enough HCP (8) and 4-3 in the majors, you may make a negative double. If partner bids your three-card suit, you pass and she's playing it in a 4-3 fit. Worse things than that have happened in bridge. In fact, Alphonse Moyse Jr. liked playing in 4-3 fits so much that it is named after him, "a Moysian Fit."

That's not all, folks.

As stated, requirements for a reopening double are as follows:

- + A reopening double is generally made by opening bidder.
- + After LHO has overcalled and there are two passes by your partner and your RHO.
- + Opening bidder has two or less cards in overcalled suit.
- + Opening bidder must have tolerance (at least three cards) for all unbid suits.
- + Opening bidder's hand cannot be distributional.

As to the last rule, if opener has a long suit, six cards or more, or is 5-5-2-1, she should either rebid her six-card suit, in the former, or bid her second suit in the latter. Look at the following two hands:

1. ♠ J5
♥ AK10864
♦ 8
♣ AQ108

2. ♠ J75
♥ AQ10864
♦ 8
♣ AK9

Bidding is as follows.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♥	2 ♦	P	P?
?			

How do you, as opening bidder, respond with each?

Hand 1: 2 hearts. This is not a hand with which you should use a reopening double. True, you have a singleton in your LHO's suit. And, true, your partner is almost certainly sitting behind your LHO with a lot of diamonds. But your hand has two shortcomings that make it inappropriate for a reopening double:

1. You don't have tolerance for all unbid suits. Your spade doubleton is insufficient for support if your partner responds to your double with a bid of 2 spades. Remember, your partner might be short in your suit. So, if you double and your partner doesn't want to sit for the penalty double at the 2 level, she has to either support your suit if she has two cards in it, or bid her longest suit. If she has five diamonds but not enough to sit for the double, her longest suit might be spades. She could be 4-1-4-4, so she would be forced to bid spades, and you can't support her.
2. Your hand isn't strong enough. You really only have two fairly certain tricks, your two aces. Remember, you have to take six tricks to set them. Otherwise they're going to get a terrific score, making two or more, doubled!

Hand 2: Double. This is a very good hand with which to make a reopening double for two reasons:

1. You have tolerance for both unbid suits, so if your partner can't support your heart bid you have at least three cards in the unbid suits. The worst that can happen is that your partner will be playing in a 4-3 fit at the 2 level, not a disaster.
2. You have a good hand, with two ace-king combinations. In a defense you have good trick-taking capability.

Remember this: Just because you have an opening hand and shortness in LHO's suit, you don't automatically make a reopening double. Your hand must fit the requirements in addition to shortness and the appropriate bidding after your open.

RHO Bids Your Strong Suit

If you have a very good suit and RHO beats you to bidding it after your partner has opened, what do you do? What if your partner opened 1 club, your RHO bid 1 spade, and you have the following hand?

♠ AK987

♥ K64

♦ 75

♣ 865

You have three possible calls here:

Bid no trump. You can clearly bid no trump here. One no trump would be fine, but here your hand is so strong you could jump to 2 no trump to tell your partner that you have 10 HCP and your RHO's suit stopped twice.

Double for penalty. Your partner opened the bidding, so you know she has at least 12 points. You have 11 points with your doubleton. That's 23 points, plus you have a very strong spade suit, with at least two sure tricks to make the contract. But your partner has power enough to make an opening bid, and you have a good enough trump suit to be playing the hand in spades yourself. Ask yourself, "If my RHO didn't bid, would I think that my partner and I could make one spade?" If so, you should double. This is especially true because you're sitting behind declarer.

Pass. If you're playing *negative doubles*, which you just learned, you can't make a penalty double because a double in this situation means something else. So, you would pass and hope your partner would make a re-opening double, in which you would pass with this hand and accept her double as a penalty double and probably get a big score defending 1S doubled.

To recap, your pass over opponent's interference generally means one of three things:

- + Your hand is too weak for a convenient bid over the specific interference that occurred.
- + Your RHO bid your suit and you're not strong enough to double for penalty or bid 1 no trump.
- + Your RHO bid your suit and you want to double for penalty but can't because you are playing negative doubles and must rely on opener to make the suggestion of a penalty double by reopening with a double.

Your partner should be aware that your pass after interference means one of these three things.

Cue-Bid Limit Raise

A cue-bid limit raise arises when your partner has bid a suit and opponents have also bid a suit. Instead of making a limit raise by jumping to the 3 level, you cue-bid opponents' suit to indicate a limit raise in partner's suit. This works both when partner has opened the bidding and when partner has overcalled. Look at these hands after your partner opens 1H and your RHO overcalls 1S:

1. ♠ Q65
♥ K97
♦ 865
♣ Q975

2. ♠ 86
♥ K942
♦ KQ84
♣ K73

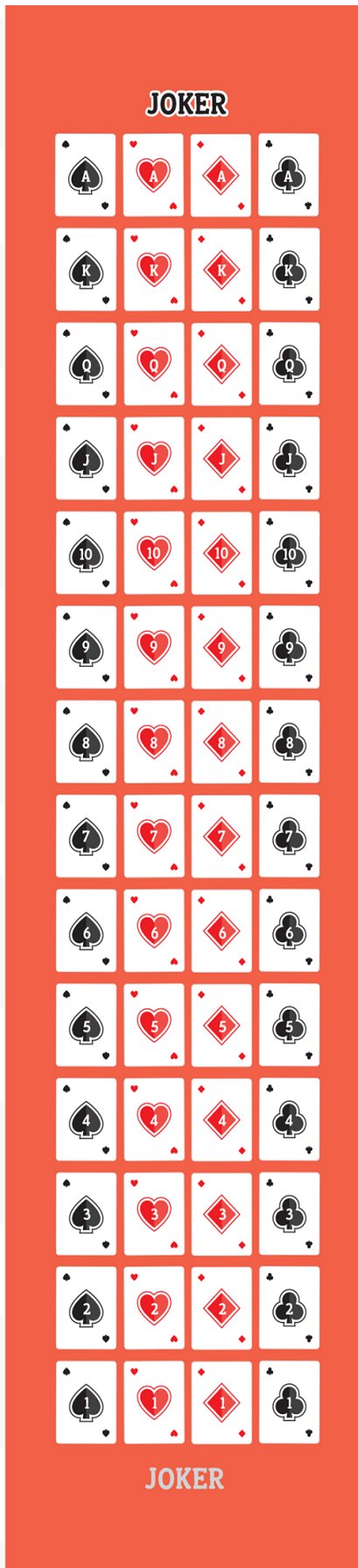
3. ♠ 83
♥ K943
♦ Q432
♣ Q97

Hand 1: 2H, your normal raise showing at least three cards in partner's suit and 6-9 points.

Hand 2: 2S. You cue-bid opponents' suit to show that you have 10-12 HCP and at least three-card support in partner's suit, a limit raise.

Hand 3: 3H, but this is not a limit raise. Rather, it's a weak, preemptive raise. That's one of the reasons that the cue-bid limit raise is so valuable, because it gives you a bid to use preemptively that you would not otherwise have had. You are able to squeeze the bidding without making an ambiguous bid that partner might misinterpret.

In the next chapter, I cover hand evaluation, which includes the law of tricks. Keep reading to learn what the experts know and use!



Chapter 13

Hand Evaluation and The Law of Tricks

In addition to counting HCP and distribution, there are other sophisticated methods of hand evaluation used by many experts and you may use them, too! Here are a couple.

The Losing Trick Count

Here is your hand as West and your partner's hand as East, which was played recently in a club game. The bidding is as it occurred, not as it should have occurred:

West

♠ 9843
♥ A7
♦ A4
♣ 109652

East

♠ AK
♥ 3
♦ KQJ109765
♣ 87

Bidding:

South

1 ♥
P ?

West

P★

North

P
2 ♦ ★★

East

1 ♦ !
4 ♦ ★★★

★ *West should make a negative double here, showing at least 6 HCP and four spades.*

★★ *Limit raise (10-12 HCP) or better (but since North is a passed hand it is clearly not more than 12 HCP). North stretched here (see four hand layout on next page) but with four-card support and a doubleton, this is a reasonable limit raise.*

★★★ *Extra values (16+ HCP) and at least a six-card suit, probably longer.*

High-Card Points aren't the be all and end all in hand evaluation. Another aid in evaluating hands is called *The Losing Trick Count* (LTC). There have been entire books written on it (the best is *The Modern Losing Trick Count* by Ron Klinger), but I believe in keeping the game simple and this explanation is really simple. Klinger goes into it in depth and covers all sorts of hands. But if you learn just what I write here, you will be able to use it effectively.

First, you count your “losers.” For this method, there is a maximum of three losers in every suit. They are offset by high honors. So, if you have a heart suit consisting of the 9,7,5,3, and deuce, you have three losers, the maximum. But if the suit is ace, 7, 5, and 3, you only have two losers because the ace is a winner. With AQ753, you only count one loser because you have two of the top three honors. Q532 would be two losers because the queen is not a loser. But Q5 would be two losers because a doubleton queen is a loser. Q53 is counted as $\frac{1}{2}$ loser. AKJ would be one loser. AKJ432 would still be only one loser. Get the picture? I hope so because that ends the explanation.

After you determine how many losers are in your hand, you listen to partner’s bid. If she gives you a one-over-one raise, she should have 8-10 losers. A typical opening hand has 6-7 losers. A limit raise has eight losers, no more. Any bid that shows extra values, like an invitational jump, or a jump shift, should be evaluated as five losers or less.

After you hear partner’s response, you add her losers to your losers and subtract the total from 24 and that’s the number of tricks you should take. So, if you open with a seven loser hand and she raises your suit, she has at least eight losers, maybe more. That’s 15 losers between you. Subtract that from 24 and the difference is nine. That’s the maximum number of tricks you should take and not enough for game. If, however, you open a major suit with six losers and she gives you a limit raise, that promises not more than eight losers. $8 + 6 = 14$. $24 - 14 = 10$ tricks, so you should bid game.

There is a big caveat here, however. The losing trick count should only be used after you have found a trump fit. If you don’t have at least eight trumps between you, you should not evaluate your hand using LTC.

Here’s the entire hand where using LTC would have found the game:

North

♠ Q652

♥ 8542

♦ 83

♣ AQJ

West

♠ 9843

♥ A7

♦ A4

♣ 109652

East

♠ AK

♥ 3

♦ KQJ109765

♣ 87

South

♠ J107

♥ KQJ1096

♦ 2

♣ K1083

Using LTC, West should count her losers, three spade losers, one heart loser, one diamond loser, and three club losers for a total of eight losers, and realize that with her two diamonds she and partner have a trump fit. Due to East's strong jump, she should place no more than five losers in East's hand (actually it's a 4 loser hand). $8 + 5 = 13$. $24 - 13 = 11$, the number of tricks East should be able to take, so West should easily bid 5D. As it was, West passed and EW missed a cold game.

As to the bidding, however, East could open this hand 2C because she has nine sure tricks, seven diamonds and two spades, which qualifies for a strong 2C opening bid.

Here is Ron Klinger's general guide for how many points an opening bid should indicate:

Points	Description	Expected Losers
7-9	Extremely weak opening	9+ losers
10-12	Weak opening	8 losers
13-15	Normal opening	6-7 losers
16-18	Strong opening	5-6 losers
19-21	Very strong opening	4-5 losers
22+	Game force	3 or less losers

Here's what he says opener should do after a simple raise (like 1S-2S):

7 losers	Pass
6 losers	Invite game
5 losers	Head for game

There is a lot more to LTC than what's set forth here. After you learn what's here and if you like it, I suggest you get Klinger's book and learn more intricacies. However, even if all you know is what you learn here, it can still be a devastatingly effective tool. Just remember this formula:

24 minus (Your losers + partner's losers) = the number of tricks you may be expected to take.

It's that easy.

Here's another actual hand that could have been properly bid using LTC:

North

♠ K532

♥ K9

♦ 874

♣ AJ42

South

♠ AJ76

♥ AJ52

♦ A1096

♣ 9

Here's how the bidding actually went:

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
			P
1 ♦	P	1 ♠	P
3 ♣	P	4 ♠	All Pass

South's jump invites game and shows 6 losers. At this point, South has no idea of the strength of North's hand. But when she showed 6 losers, North, with its 8 loser hand added the total losers, $8 + 6 = 14$ and subtracted from 24 getting 10 tricks they should take and bid game, 4S.

In actuality, however, South has a 7 loser hand and should only raise to 2S. Then when North adds his 8 losers to 7, $8 + 7 = 15$ and subtracts from 24, he gets 9, which is the total number of tricks to expect and it was the total number of tricks that the hand actually made, so he will pass. South misbid because she did not play LTC and fell in love with her club singleton, and the result was down one. LTC works far more often than it doesn't.

One final caveat: You and your partner do not need to both be using LTC for hand evaluation. It's better if you are, but you may use it even if partner does not. You are simply evaluating your hand in order to make a judgement on how many tricks you think you can take and so how to bid. If partner is using it, fine. But if partner is not using it, you may still use it.

The Law of Total Tricks

This is another method of hand evaluation. While complex books have been written about it, the simple theory is that in a competitive auction where the HCP are relatively equally distributed, each side can expect to take the amount of tricks equal to the number of trump the two partners hold. So, if you and your partner are bidding hearts and have an eight card fit and your opponents are bidding spades and have an eight card fit, whoever gets the contract can expect to take eight tricks. While it is not perfect, it happens a lot more often than it does not.

Example Bidding Neither Side Vulnerable

South

1 ♥

West

1 ♠

North

2 ♥

East

2 ♠

At this point, South, if she has a normal 12-14 HCP hand, has to decide whether or not to push to 3H. Of course, she doesn't know if her partner has three or four trump, but if she assumes partner has three, then if she goes to 3H, she will probably be down one. But since the Law of Total Tricks says that either side can make a bid of two, down one would be a better score than letting them make 2S. If she competes to 3H, then, of course, E/W will have to make the same decision. Do they want to risk going down in 3S, or are they willing to take the chance that the Law of Total Tricks will apply and take the small positive rather than risking going down one in 3S?

Now that I've covered hand evaluation and the law of tricks, let's move forward to discussing jump responses.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 14

Jump Responses

Sometimes you open your hand and start looking for your calculator so you can add up all the points you hold; next thing you know, you hear your partner open the bidding! How can this be? You have a lot of points yet she's already bidding. What now?

Obviously you want to describe your good fortune to her as soon and as accurately as possible—but how?

This is where jump bids become useful. In this chapter, you learn how to use jump bids to describe hands that are better than what you can communicate by a simple response.

Limit Raises

A *limit raise* is a raise that shows a hand with trump support and not less than 10 points, but not more than 12 points. It's called limit raise because the bid confines the hand to these parameters. You can make other bids if your hand isn't within these boundaries. This section describes the various types of limit raises.

How do you make a limit raise? You *jump* your partner's suit. A jump is a bid that passes a level available to you.

Limit Raises When Your Partner Opens a Major Suit

What if you have four of opener's major-suit opening—10 points—but don't have a suit to bid at the 2 level? Take a look at the following hand, after your partner has opened the bidding at 1 spade:

♠ KQJ5
♥ A76
♦ J96
♣ 984

Not a bad hand, but what do you bid? If you just raise her 1 spade bid to 2 spades, she'll think you have a minimum and will almost certainly pass. (It's possible that she had to open a 20-point hand with a bid of 1 spade because her distribution didn't

allow her to open it 2 no trump. If she has such a strong hand, she will quickly jump to 4 spades when she finds out that you have at least 6 points.) You're too strong just to reply with 2 spades; what do you bid?

You give her a limit raise. A limit raise in your partner's opening major suit is a bid that says you have the following:

- + 10 to 12 points
- + Three or four cards in opener's major suit

For example, if your partner opens 1 spade, you could bid 2 spades, but that would show a fairly weak hand. If you bypass bidding at the 2 level, and make a bid of 3 spades, instead of 2 spades, it's called a *jump*. If you play that a jump in your partner's opening major suit at your first opportunity is a limit raise, then it shows at least three-card support and 10 to 12 points.

This is a very good bid because it tells your partner so much. It limits your hand to no more than 12 HCP, but promises at least 10 HCP, and it promises at least three-card trump support. It's one of the most specific bids in bridge, even more specific than the opening of 1 no trump. From your limit raise, your partner should be able to determine if she should bid game. If she opened with a minimum, she'll pass and the contract will be 3 spades. With more than a minimum she'll bid game, at least.

Limit Raises When Your Partner Opens a Minor Suit

When your partner opens a minor suit, there are slightly different conditions when you make a limit raise. In the first place, because your partner has opened with a minor, you don't know how many cards she has in her suit. Because of that limitation, a limit raise in a minor suit should promise five cards in the suit. If you give a limit raise with a four-card suit and she has opened a three-card suit, you could find yourself playing at the 3 level on a 3-4 fit—not an attractive prospect.

Furthermore, you should not make a limit raise of a minor-suit opening if you have a four-card major. The requirements for a limit raise in a minor suit are as follows:

- + No four-card major
- + 10 to 12 points
- + Five-card support

If your partner has opened a three-card suit looking for a major-suit fit, and you give her a limit raise in her minor-suit opening, she'll probably either pass your limit raise and play it in 3 of the minor, or try 3 no trump if she has strength in the other suits.

Responses When Your Partner Opens in Third Seat

When you are a passed hand and your LHO passes and your partner opens in third seat, it is possible that she is opening with a hand that has less strength as that which is required for an opening bid in first or second seat. Why would she do this? Because she knows that you and her RHO do not have opening values and she wants to put her LHO in a more difficult position of making an overcall instead of opening the bidding. It is basically a preemptive maneuver to take some of the bidding room away from opponents.

She could, however, have a legitimate opening bid. How do you know? What do you do? If you have a limit raise do you jump to the 3 level to show your hand? But if she opened light, then you might be a trick too high. You might be able to make two in the suit, but not three. The answer to that is Reverse Drury.

The Reverse Drury convention says that if your partner opens the bidding in third seat in a major suit, spades or hearts, and you have a limit raise in that suit, you respond by bidding 2C. That says nothing about clubs. What it says is, "Partner, I have at least three cards in your suit and 10-12 HCP. If you opened light, just bid 2 of your suit. If you have a legitimate open, use your judgement."

If you have a normal raise, 6-9 HCP and at least three cards in her suit, you make the bid you would normally make, a raise of her opening bid to the 2 level. If you have less than three cards in her suit and 6-9 HCP, you respond 1NT as you normally would if

she opened in first or second seat. Here are some hands when the bidding goes P-P-1S-P to you:

1. ♠ Q65	2. ♠ 86	3. ♠ K86	4. ♠ K10863
♥ K97	♥ K94	♥ K942	♥ 943
♦ 865	♦ Q842	♦ KQ8	♦ Q85
♣ Q975	♣ Q752	♣ 752	♣ 75

Hand 1: 2 spades. This is a normal one-over-one raise, 7 HCP and three-card support.

Hand 2: 1 no trump. Again, this is a normal response to your partner's opening bid that you would make if she opened in first or second seat, 7 HCP but only two-card support for her suit.

Hand 3: 2 clubs. You have 11 HCP and three-card support, a limit raise. The bid says nothing about clubs. If she opened light, she will just bid 2 spades and you will pass and probably make it. If you were at the 3 level you could easily be set. If partner opened light, she just rebids her suit at the 2 level, and you pass. If she bids a new suit, it means that she opened with normal opening hand values and is exploring for game.

Hand 4: 3 spades. If you were not playing Reverse Drury, this would be a limit raise. Since you may show a limit raise by bidding 2C, that leaves this jump bid available as a preemptive bid, a bid that shows a weak hand but at least four spades.

Opener's Response to Reverse Drury

If she opened light, she just rebids her suit and you pass. If she opened a normal opening, she bids a new suit. That doesn't say much about the new suit, it's just a conventional response telling partner that she has a legitimate opening hand. It's called a *Reverse Drury* because originally opener's response was to bid a new suit if she opened a weak hand and rebidding her suit if she opened strong. Most people thought it better if those responses were reversed, ergo the name, Reverse Drury.

Jump Shift Responses

As we’ve seen, a jump is a bid that passes a level available to you. A shift is a change of suit. So, a *jump shift* occurs when you make a jump bid in a suit different from the suit your partner opened. For example, if your partner opens 1 club, you could bid any other suit at the 1 level. If you bid a new suit at the 2 level when you could have bid it at the 1 level, it’s called a jump shift. For example, if your partner opens 1 club and you bid 2 diamonds instead of 1 diamond, you’ve made a jump shift. There are two ways to play a jump shift response. A lot of players play them weak; however, most rubber bridge players play them strong. That’s what you’re going to learn here: strong jump shifts.

Strong Jump Responses

A strong jump shift shows a very good hand and is game forcing on your partner. If you open 1 diamond, your LHO passes, and your partner bids 2 spades, that’s a jump shift. She could have bid 1 spade; however, she skipped the 1 level and jumped to the 2 level, and she shifted from your suit of diamonds to a new suit: spades.

When your partner does this, you must keep the bidding open until you’ve reached game, then—and only then—you can pass. The following chart shows what each bid means.

Partner	You	Meaning
1 heart	2 no trump	13 to 15 HCP, balanced hand, stoppers in the three unbid suits, denies four spades
1 heart	3 no trump	16 to 18 HCP, balanced hand, stoppers in the three unbid suits, denies four spades
1 heart	2 spades	16 or more points, game forcing, looking for slam, does <i>not</i> deny four hearts, could be totally unbalanced

When I started playing bridge again after a hiatus of several decades after college, I was playing the game I played at UCLA: Strong Two bids and strong jumps. One day I picked up my cards and saw that I had 22 points. I was ready to open 2 spades—which is game forcing on my partner—but my RHO opened 2 hearts. I was stunned. How

could she have a strong enough hand to open 2 hearts when I had more than half of the points in the deck in my hand? I thought about it a while and decided to pass, thinking that we could get them for a good set. Alas, my opponent was playing Weak Twos, so they stole the bid and we got a terrible result; that was my introduction to modern bridge. Just be aware that if you're playing Strong Twos and strong jump shifts, your opponents might be playing Weak Twos and weak jump shifts. So, when an opponent jumps the bidding and you don't know what they're playing, always ask what the bid means before you assume you know.

You can always ask what an opponent's bid means when it's your turn to bid by asking the bidder's partner. (You must ask the bidder's partner because a bidder isn't allowed to say what his bid means.) He must give you an accurate and complete description of the meaning of his partner's bid. You can't be forced to bid without an explanation of a bid you don't understand.

Weak Jump Shift Responses

The modern trend for advanced players is to play jump responses as weak. This is the way they work showing weak hands.

A weak jump shift is called a *preemptive jump shift* (PJS). There are three requirements for this bid:

- + You should have at least six cards in the suit.
- + You should have less than 6 HCP.
- + You should not have three cards in your partner's suit if she opens in a major.
- + A final corollary to these rules is that you should not bid again unless your partner makes a forcing bid that requires you to bid again.

A preemptive jump shift tells your partner that you have a terrible hand, but a long suit, and asks her not to bid again. Unless she has an unusually strong hand, she should pass, even if she's void in your suit. The exception to this is if she's void and has a six-card major suit of her own, in which event she might rebid her opening suit. Whatever she does after you've made a PJS, she knows that you will not bid again.

Don't try to save your partner. After you've described your hand accurately, you must trust that she wants to play the hand in a contract of whatever she bids in her rebid if it's not a forcing bid. Remember, you've already told her, "Partner, this is my hand and this is my only bid. Anything you do after this is at your own risk because I'm going to pass, pass, pass every time it's my turn."

I tell all my partners, "Don't ever try to save me. I generally know what I'm doing and you must trust me. If you have accurately described your hand to me, let me make the decision." I've been burned more times than I would like to remember by partners who thought they had a terrible hand and that I was in big trouble so they bid something trying to save me, only to end up in a worse predicament than I would have been in.

If you have described your hand and made a bid that says, "I'm not going to bid again," you must trust your partner to know what she's doing. Think of the downside. If you save her and get a terrible result, she's going to have the right to criticize you for taking her out of a less damaging contract. But if you let her go ahead with her bid after you've said you're not bidding again and she gets in trouble, she can't criticize you at all. Maybe that's a selfish way to look at a partnership, but it's realistic. Trust your partnership agreement.

Finally, a word of explanation. Why is a PJS made with a weak hand? The answer is simple. When you and your partner have the bulk of the points in your hand, you want to keep the bidding low so you can communicate. It makes no sense whatsoever to make a jump bid, because you are preempting yourselves. The point of a jump bid should be to crowd the bidding for your opponents, to make it more difficult for them to communicate when they have the bulk of the points. So, when your partner opens and you don't have much, your PJS does two things:

- + It tells your partner exactly what you have; not much.
- + It crowds the bidding for your opponents, who probably have a lot more than you and your partner have. They will have to start their conversation at, probably, the 3 level, when, without your PJS they could have started at the 1 level.

When you have the bulk of the points, keep the bidding low for as long as you can so you and your partner can converse back and forth and tell each other what you have and where you have it.

If you are playing weak jump shifts, there are requirements there, too. Generally it shows a suit at least six cards in length and 5 HCP or less. Look at the following hands and partner opens 1C:

1. ♠ QJ7532

♥ 97

♦ 865

♣ Q9

2. ♠ 86

♥ Q94

♦ J108742

♣ 52

3. ♠ 986

♥ KQJ942

♦ 87

♣ 75

Hand 1: 2 spades. You've got six weak spades and nothing else. You are hoping partner has at least two spades. It tells partner to keep quiet unless she has extra values and spade support.

Hand 2: 2 diamonds. Only 3 HCP and nothing else. This hand looks to be a disaster if your partner has just a normal opening hand unless it's played in diamonds. You've got to tell you partner not to bid again unless she's holding a powerhouse.

Hand 3: 1 heart. True, you've got nothing but hearts, but you have 6 HCP. This is not a hand to make a preemptive jump shift. You might have game if partner opened a 20 HCP hand.

Preemptive Jump to Game

Look at the following hand, after your partner has opened the bidding with 1 spade:

♠ Q10863

♥ 8

♦ Q653

♣ Q104

What's your bid? You have nice spades support for your partner, but there's not much else that looks good except the singleton heart.

Regardless of what your RHO does, this hand suggests a jump to game with a bid of 4 spades. You can make a preemptive jump to game with a hand that satisfies the following requirements:

- + Your partner opened a major.
- + You have five-card trump support for her, or more.
- + You have between 6 to 10 points.
- + You have a singleton or void.

The reason for this is that your partner will have a fair chance of making the contract because you have so many trump between the two of you. If she goes set, it shouldn't be by more than one or two. And you want to stifle your opponents' ability to find the game they might have by communicating with one another. You have only 6 HCP. Your partner might be opening up a minimum with five spades, a singleton, and 12 total points, which would translate to 10 HCP. That means that your opponents would have approximately 24 HCP between them. They might very well have a heart game between them. If you jump immediately to four spades, they don't have the time to communicate.

The prospects in this hand are twofold: You might very well have a game between you and your partner. If not, your opponents might very well have a game between them, and you've kept them from finding it or bidding it. You might have traded 100 points above the line to keep them from getting 120 points below the line and 300—or 500—points above the line. Alternatively, your opponents might bid hearts, which might be one trick more than they can make.

Also by making a quick preemptive strike, you've prevented your opponents from communicating to see if they have enough power between them to double and penalize you for your bid. Any double by them at this point would be a guess, because you obviously have a distributional hand.

Another thing to remember is that your opponents are listening to your bidding, too. If they're knowledgeable players they'll know that your bid is preemptive, so you might

be doubled for penalty. (Especially if your RHO has made an overcall and your LHO has a good hand.) But that's just the chance you take. If you only go down two doubled and they can make game in their suit, you will have made a good bid—a “save” against their game.

The preemptive jump to game isn't strictly limited to a major-suit opening, but it's riskier in a minor suit because you must take all but two tricks. Opponents will be more inclined to double a jump to a 5 level contract than a jump to a 4 level contract.

Jumps to No Trump

Many jump bids to no trump don't fit any of the patterns discussed so far. Generally, all jump bids to no trump show a strong hand.

- + When you're jumping from a suit to no trump, remember that you count HCP only—not shortness points—when evaluating your hand.
- + Remember also, when you bid no trump as a qualitative bid—that is to suggest playing the hand without trump—you designate your partner as captain of the hand. This applies to responses and rebids as well as opening bids.

Jumps to No Trump After a Minor-Suit Opening

A jump shift to 2 no trump after a minor-suit opening by your partner promises the following:

- + Between 12 to 15 HCP
- + No four-card major
- + Stoppers in all suits unbid by your partner
- + No trump distribution

This is a very good bid because you already know that you have more points than they do. If your partner opened the bidding, she has at least 12 points and you know that you have 12 to 15 HCP; therefore, you have at least 25 total points between you. Of course, at this time you don't know if your partner's points are HCP or distribution points, but you'll find that out when she bids.

This bid also tells your partner that you can't have an eight-card major fit between you. Can you figure out why?

Answer: Because your partner opened a minor, she probably doesn't have a five-card major, or she would have opened by bidding it. Because you jumped to 2 no trump over her minor-suit opening, you don't have a four-card major. This shows how you deduce what you have between you by what *wasn't* bid.

If she doesn't have a five-card major, you can't have an eight-card fit unless you both have a four-card major, but your bid denies a four-card major. Therefore, if she doesn't have a five-card major and you don't have a four-card major, you can't have eight cards in a major between you.

You both know that if you have game it will probably be in no trump. This puts it in opener's corner because only she knows whether her points are HCP or distribution points.

Finally, what if you have 12 to 15 points, no four-card major, but an unstopped, unbid suit? In this instance, you must make a two-over-one response to tell your partner what you have. Look at the following hand:

♠ 872
♥ K4
♦ AQ76
♣ K1086

Don't forget—you shouldn't jump to no trump over your partner's minor-suit open if you have a four-card major.

If your partner opens 1 diamond, you don't have a four-card major to bid and you can't jump to 2 no trump because spades is unstopped. In this instance, you should respond 2 clubs. This tells your partner that you have at least 10 points, at least four clubs, and no four-card major. It's forcing your partner to bid again; you'll have a better idea of where to play the contract when you learn more about her hand. When she bids again,

you can tell her that you have more than 10 points. You don't have to tell everything in one bid. It's nice when you can, but sometimes you can't.

Modern Bridge Bidding

Now that I've covered jumps to no trumps, let's move onward to something a little more complicated.

Jumps to 3 No Trump over a Minor-Suit Open of 1

A jump to 3 no trump over a minor-suit open of 1 shows the next level—16 to 18 HCP—and denies a four-card major. There is sound arithmetical reasoning behind this. If you have at least 16 HCP and your partner has at least 13 points, you should probably be able to make 3 no trump (which generally requires 25 HCP between you both). If she has 2 or 3 shortness points—which is a possibility—that still leaves her with at least 10 HCP; this, when added to your 16 HCP, should offer a good play for 3 no trump.

As I said previously, if you don't have a four-card major, and your partner's opening hand doesn't have a five-card major, there's no hope of an eight-card fit in a major. That said, if you're going to be playing the hand in game, it should probably be in 3 no trump. If your partner opened a distributional hand, like 6–5 in the minors, she can jump to game in the appropriate minor because your bid promised at least two cards in each suit.

The following shows the HCP requirements for jumps to no trump after your partner makes a minor suit open of one of the suit:

Response	HCP
2 no trump	12–15
3 no trump	16–18

Today's players have changed the rules on jumps to no trump. Today most people play that a jump to 2NT after a minor suit opening by opening bidder is invitational to

game, showing a balanced hand, no singletons or doubletons, 11-12 HCP, and denying a four-card major. A jump to 3NT shows 13-16 HCP. Here it is below:

Response	HCP
2 no trump	11-12
3 no trump	13-15

Jordan

What if your partner opens a major, say 1S, and your RHO doubles and you have a limit raise in your hand? The Jordan Convention handles that. With a limit raise, you jump to 2NT. That leaves a jump to 3 spades for a preemptive call, which really messes with opponents' bidding because for doubler's responder to bid, he must do so at the 4 level.

Here are some hands with the bidding going 1S-Dbl to you:

1. ♠ Q76
♥ A107
♦ J1053
♣ 742

2. ♠ J1098
♥ Q94
♦ J108
♣ K52

3. ♠ K1042
♥ KQ7
♦ Q842
♣ 75

Hand 1: 2 spades. This is a normal one-over-one raise, 7 HCP and three-card support.

Hand 2: 3 spades. This is preemptive. You don't have much but you do have four pretty good spades; you want to squeeze opponents.

Hand 3: 2 no trump. You have a limit raise.

Splinter

A *splinter* is a bid by responder (generally, although opener may splinter, also) that shows four-card trump support, a singleton or void and opening hand values. It is generally made in response to a major-suit opening, although it may be made in response to a minor-suit opening.

Let's say your partner opens 1 heart and you hold the following:

♠ KQJ
♥ A987
♦ 4
♣ K10987

That's a pretty good hand, don't you think? It's one you'd open. If you didn't have a specialized bid, you'd probably bid 2 clubs, then jump to 4 hearts, depending on your partner's response. However, is there a way to tell partner that you have a singleton diamond? What do you think? Can you think of a way? Maybe kick her twice under the table?

Okay, that's illegal, so you don't want to do that. How do you tell partner that you have an unusual hand here and describe it in one bid?

Give up? The answer, as you might have guessed, is that you make a bid called a *splinter*. I love this bid. How do you splinter?

You make a *double jump* bid and bid your singleton (or void, as the case may be). A *double jump* is a bid that skips 2 levels of bidding. So, if you open 1 club and partner bids 2 spades, that's a jump, but it only skips 1 level—it skips 1 spade. So, a double jump would be a response of 3 spades, because that skips 2 levels of bidding, 1 spade and 2 spades.

So, in response to partner's opening bid above of 1 heart, you bid 4 diamonds (skipping 2 diamonds and 3 diamonds)! That tells partner three things in one bid:

1. You have a singleton or void in diamonds;
2. You have at least four cards in her opening bid, hearts; and
3. Your hand has opening values, at least 13 HCP.

All that information in one bid! The bid is obviously game forcing and it's exploring for slam.

The bid may also be made by opener. Assume you are opener with the following hand:

♠ AKQ
♥ AQ87
♦ 4
♣ K10987

... and you open 1 club. Partner responds 1 heart. You may jump to 4 diamonds promising 4 hearts and a singleton (or void) diamond. This can be a little risky since partner could be responding with only 6 HCP, so it shouldn't be made by opener unless opener has a strong hand with extra values, like the hand above that can play for game against 6 HCP. With the singleton diamond and at least a 4-4 trump fit, this hand re-evaluates to 21 points, giving three for the singleton. When you have at least a 4-4 trump fit, shortness values increase to the following:

Void	5 points
Singleton	3 points
Doubleton	1 point

The problem with the bid is that if you're not used to it, your partner could misinterpret it and pass. Then you're playing the contract in your singleton/void (don't laugh; it has happened to me). That's not much fun. So, if you decide you want to play splinters be sure you and your partner are on the same wavelength.

In a nutshell, here are the rules for splinters as responder (also applicable to declarer when rebidding after responder has bid a suit):

1. Responder has four cards in declarer's opening suit (or declarer has four cards in responder's suit);
2. Responder has a full opening hand, in this case at least 13 HCP (if declarer is making the splinter bid he must have a huge, game-forcing hand to splinter);
3. Responder/declarer also has a singleton or void;
4. Responder/declarer makes a double jump bid in the suit in which he holds a singleton or void.

Jacoby 2 No Trump

This is a corollary to the splinter bid. Let's say you open up your hand and see the following:

♠ AQ98
♥ KQ7
♦ K109
♣ 1086

You're in third or fourth seat and you hear beloved partner open 1S! Wow! Now what? How do you tell her you have an opening hand plus four-card support for her? You don't have a singleton or void so you can't splinter. You can't jump to 4 spades because that would be weak and you probably want to explore for slam (bidding and making a contract for six or seven, see [Chapter 18](#)).

Fortunately, there is a bid for this hand and it's called Jacoby 2 No Trump. When you have this hand and partner opens 1S, you jump to 2NT. That tells partner that you have an opening hand (and here you should have at least 13 HCP; this hand with 12 HCP is just a limit raise). Opener then bids as follows:

1. If she has a singleton or void, she bids it at the 3 level.
2. If she has a good secondary five-card suit, she jumps and bids it at the 4 level.
3. If she just has a minimum with no singleton or void or good secondary five-card suit she jumps to game. That says that she has no interest in slam.
4. If she has no singleton or void and no good secondary five-card suit, but has extra values and wants to explore for slam, she bids 3 of her opening suit, here it would be 3S. That is much stronger than jumping to game.

Here are some hands for responder after partner has opened 1S and RHO passes:

1. ♠ AQ43
♥ Q107
♦ A98
♣ 754

2. ♠ AQ43
♥ A7
♦ KJ104
♣ 865

3. ♠ 742
♥ A5
♦ J632
♣ Q964

4. ♠ AQ43
♥ Q1072
♦ AJ86
♣ 2

Hand 1: 3 spades. This 12 point hand is not strong enough. Opposite a 12 HCP opener it might have trouble making game.

Hand 2: Jacoby 2 No Trump. It's a perfect hand for this bid.

Hand 3: 2 spades. Just make your normal one-over-one raise showing three-card support and a minimum hand.

Hand 4: 4 clubs, a splinter. When you have a hand that qualifies as either Jacoby 2 No Trump and a splinter, it's often better to tell partner your shortness rather than asking for her shortness (she might not have any).

And opener's responses when the bidding goes 1S-2NT? Look at these hands:

1. ♠ KJ1098
♥ AK87
♦ AJ9
♣ 7

2. ♠ KJ1098
♥ QJ4
♦ KQ
♣ 863

3. ♠ KJ1098
♥ 86
♦ AKQ98
♣ 2

4. ♠ KJ1098
♥ AQ
♦ A107
♣ KJ

Hand 1: 3C, telling partner her singleton.

Hand 2: 4S. She opened a minimum 12 HCP hand and has no interest in slam unless partner has a monster. Unless responder has 18 HCP or some drastically distributional hand, she should trust opener and pass.

Hand 3: 4D. Torn between bidding her singleton or her five-card suit, she should bid her five-card suit if it is this powerful. With a less powerful five-card suit, she should bid her singleton.

Hand 4: 3S. This is the most powerful bid she can make. 4S would be very weak. 3S says, "I'm interested in slam. Tell me more about your hand."

Responses When You're a Passed Hand

When your partner opens the bidding in third or fourth seat, it means that you passed at your first opportunity to bid, so you don't have an opening hand. This is called a *passed hand*. When it comes time to bid again, some of your responses remain the same, but some change. You must remember that the standards for opening in third seat are less than they are for opening in first or second seat. Now that you're responder, you must remember the standards you learned for opening the bidding in third seat and follow those standards here.

Your partner could have a perfectly good opening hand—one that she would have opened with in the first or second seat—but then again, she might not. She might be *opening light*.

Opening light refers to when you open a hand with less than 13 points.

A *passed hand* is one that could have opened the bidding but the player passed instead of making an opening bid with it.

When you have 6 to 9 points, your responses are the same: You bid your four-card majors. You bid up the line. And, if you don't have a four-card major and can't support your partner, you bid 1 no trump.

Jump Shift by a Passed Hand

If you are not playing weak jump shifts, when you're a passed hand, a jump shift obviously doesn't mean that you have a hand strong enough to make a game-forcing bid, as you learned earlier in this chapter. If you had an opening hand with the values to make a strong jump shift, you would have opened!

When your partner opens a minor, you make a jump shift when you are a passed hand to show that you have a six-card near-independent major suit. If your partner opens 1 club or 1 diamond and you have the following type of holding in hearts or spades with nothing else, opposite a singleton or void, you should make a jump shift to your long suit:

AQ109xxx

AK10xxx

AJ109xx

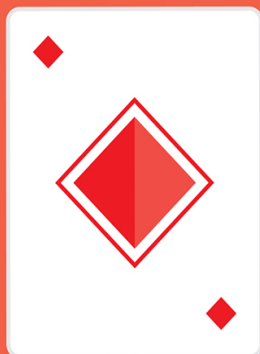
You can make this bid with a hand that is stronger than that allowed by weak jump shifts. This bid invites your partner to pass. If she opened with a minimum 12 to 14 point hand, you'll be better off playing the contract in your suit—even if she has a void in your suit. You are specifically describing a hand that you feel should be played at the 2 level in your suit.

Unless she makes a forcing bid at her next turn to call, you have told her that you intend to pass. It's up to her to place the contract. Your strong suggestion is that she place the contract by passing and allowing you to play it at the 2 level in your suit. Any action she takes after this bid is on her shoulders. You have done the best you can to describe your hand.

You have learned a lot in this chapter. A jump raise in your partner's opening suit is a limit raise showing 10-12 HCP. After a minor suit opening a limit raise denies a four-card major. A jump shift shows 16 or more HCP and is forcing to game. A weak jump shift shows a 6+ card suit, less than 6 HCP and invites partner to pass.

Part 4

**REBIDS,
OVERCALLS,
AND DOUBLES**



After you and your partner have made your initial bids, you continue to communicate and describe your hands to one another. This part shows you how to complete your communication and make a determination whether to play or defend.

If your opponents open the bidding, you still have a chance to bid by making an overcall or a takeout double. You'll find out about overcalls, takeout doubles, and responses to your partner's overcalls and takeout doubles.

Just because your opponents get the contract, you aren't finished. If you don't think they can make it, you can challenge them by doubling! You'll learn how to do this here, along with getting a solid grasp of the risks and rewards of making a penalty double.

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Chapter 15

Rebids by No Trump Opener

As you learned in [Chapter 5](#), when you open the bidding with any no trump bid, you designate your partner as captain of your pair. You have specifically described your hand as one that's balanced and contains a number of HCP within a very narrow range: 15 to 17 HCP for a 1 no trump open, and 20 to 21 for a 2 no trump open.

Your partner has heard you and has responded, either by asking you a question or by describing her hand to you. This chapter tells you how you respond, depending on what's in your hand and the question she has asked.

Rebids When You Get an Invitation

You've opened the hand with 1 no trump, which means that you have a balanced, 15-to 17-HCP hand. Your partner bids 2 no trump. What do you do? This is pretty easy. Your partner has said maybe by making an invitational bid. She has 8 to 9 HCP and a balanced hand. You don't know where her HCP cards are, but you know she has them. This is simple arithmetic. Your partner, who is the captain at this point, has given you a specific instruction. She has said, "Partner, if you're at the top of your bid—17 points, or a good 16 points—bid 3 no trump; otherwise, pass."

Why? If she has 8 points—the minimum she could have—and you have 17 points—the maximum you could have—you have 25 HCP between you; that's usually enough for game. However, even if she's just 1 point below her maximum, when added to your 17 points this only totals 24 points. That's generally not enough for game, so you should pass.

This little game of math works remarkably well. Generally, when I ignore the arithmetic and go to game with a bad 16-point hand, I get burned because I've been set the one trick that the math said I couldn't get. Sometimes you can make 3 no trump with 24 points or less, but the percentages are very much against you.

What constitutes a "good" 16? Even though the 10 is considered an "honor," you only give yourself points in counting the hand for honors of the rank of jack and above. But

8, 9, and 10 have value because they can often take tricks. For example, look at the following holdings:

	<u>North</u>	
	♠ K2	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ Q43		♠ A765
	<u>South</u>	
	♠ J1098	

Which hand is the most powerful? Answer: South, even though South has the fewest points. When you lead your jack of spades, West covers with the queen, you cover with the king from North, and East takes the trick with the ace. After this trick, South's 10, 9, and 8 of spades are all winners.

This shows that when you evaluate a hand—especially when playing in a no trump contract—you should take into consideration your 10s and cards just below honor rank. A good 16 points is a hand that includes lots of 9s and 10s, like the following:

♠ A1093
♥ KJ10
♦ A1095
♣ A10

This hand has only 16 points. Even though you don't have 17 points, you have all four 10s and only two cards below the rank of 9! You should accept an invitational bid of 2 no trump by your partner and go on to bid 3 no trump. This hand is worth a bid of 3 no trump because this is a “good” 16 points. Look at the following hand, which appeared in a national tournament:

♠ A1095
♥ K104
♦ AQ7
♣ J107

This hand has 14 HCP, but many experts opened it 1 no trump because they elevated it to 15 HCP due to the *body cards* (8s, 9s, and 10s are called body cards), which

include three 10s and one 9. The hand contains only four cards that aren't honors or body cards. Compare it with the following hand:

♠ A432
♥ A32
♦ A32
♣ A32

Such a hand is called *aces and spaces*, and it can be a disaster because you only have four tricks: the four aces. You would still open this hand 1 no trump because you must describe your hand to your partner, but you're going to cringe and sweat until the bidding is over, praying that it's not passed out and that you're not stuck playing it in 1 no trump. The previously described hand with the body cards and 14 HCP is far more powerful than aces and spaces. Sometimes you have to be flexible in counting your points and analyzing your hand.

Change the 14 HCP hand above by making the 7 of clubs the queen of clubs, so it looks like this:

♠ A1095
♥ K104
♦ AQ7
♣ QJ10

This is a good 16 HCP, and you would accept an invitation to game by bidding game. In the aces and spaces hand, the invitation should be declined.

Let's look at some maybe hands, where your partner responds 2 no trump to your 1 no trump opening bid:

1. ♠ J32	2. ♠ KJ7	3. ♠ AQ2	4. ♠ A2
♥ J432	♥ KJ8	♥ 543	♥ K32
♦ AQ32	♦ AQ87	♦ KQ6	♦ AQJ54
♣ AK	♣ K87	♣ KQ65	♣ Q65

Hand 1: Pass. Simple arithmetic prevails. You have 15 HCP. By her 2 no trump response your partner has said, "Pard, if you have 17 HCP, go to 3. Otherwise, pass

because I only have 8 or 9 HCP.” With 15 HCP in your hand and a maximum of 9 HCP in your partner’s hand, you have a maximum of 24 HCP, not enough for game.

Hand 2: 3 no trump. You are at the top of your bid: 17 HCP. Even if your partner only has her minimum—8 HCP— $8 + 17 = 25$, which is enough to bid game.

Hand 3: Pass. This is the tempting hand, but it’s not a good 16 points. “Well,” you say to yourself, “I’m only 1 point shy. If my partner is at the top of her bid—9 HCP—we have 25 between us and that’s enough for game.” Don’t succumb to this temptation. You must assume that your partner is at the bottom of her bid—8 HCP—and $8 + 16 = 24$, not enough for game. Better to bid two and make three than to bid three and make two!

Hand 4: 3 no trump. Did you miss this one? You only have 16 HCP, but you have a very good five-card suit that should give you four tricks by itself. When you have a five-card suit headed by at least one of the top three honors, and you receive an invitation from your partner, accept it and take it to game. A good five-card suit is valuable when playing in no trump.

Rebids When Your Partner Gives a Weak Response

When you open 1 no trump and your partner bids a suit other than clubs directly at the 2 level, it’s a sign-off bid and you should pass. She’s telling you that she has a weak hand with five or more diamonds, hearts, or spades, and the contract should be played in her suit.

Rebids When Your Partner Gives an Invitational Response in a Suit

When your partner bids 2 clubs (Stayman), and then bids a suit different than the one you bid, she’s telling you that she has an invitational hand—8 to 9 points—and a five-card suit. Suppose the bidding goes like this:

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1NT	P	2 ♣	P
2 ♦	P	2 ♠	P

Your 2 diamonds bid tells her that you don't have a four-card major. Her 2 spades bid tells you that she has at least a five-card spades suit with 8 to 9 points. Your response should be along the following lines:

- + Pass if you have a minimum hand with three spades.
- + 2 no trump with minimum hand and only two spades.
- + 3 spades if you have at least three spades and 17 points or a good 16.
- + 3 no trump if you have only two spades but a maximum hand with 17 points or a good 16. If she has six spades, she'll bid 4 spades because she knows you should be playing in game in the major suit if you have an eight-card fit. Your bid of 3 no trump tells her that you have a maximum hand but only two spades.

Rebids When Your Partner Jumps to 3 No Trump

If responder has bid 3 no trump, opener *must* pass. It doesn't matter if opener is head over heels in love with her hand, if opener has a long suit (a five-card major or a six-card minor), if she's at the maximum, or whatever. Opener has described her hand to her partner so she knows, within a couple of points, what opener has. Bidding is about trust. You must trust your partner. Responder is telling opener that, based on what she knows about the two hands, 3 no trump is the proper contract—no more, no less. So, when opener hears her loving partner say, "Three no trump," opener should say, "Pass."

Responding to Stayman

When your partner bids 2 clubs, she's asking you if you have a four-card major. If you do, bid it. But what if you don't? What if you have a good four- or five-card minor in clubs? Do you raise her 2 clubs bid to 3?

Not in this lifetime. As I explain in [Chapter 10](#), if your partner bids 2 clubs and you don't have a four-card major, you *must* bid 2 diamonds. A bid of 2 diamonds is conventional and denies a four-card major. It says nothing about your diamond suit. When your partner bids 2 clubs (a conventional bid, saying nothing about clubs) in response to your opening bid of 1 no trump, she's asking, "Do you have a four-card major?" You can answer one of two ways: two hearts or two spades (yes), or two diamonds (no).

If your hand contains two four-card majors, you respond hearts first. If you respond two spades to two clubs, you're showing four spades and denying having four hearts. However, the response of two hearts to two clubs guarantees having a four-card heart suit but does not deny having four spades.

Also, remember that when you open 1 no trump you have designated your partner as the captain of your pair for this hand. So, her first question may be to find out if you have a four-card major. When she discovers the answer to this question, she'll either place the contract, or tell you something about her hand by making an invitational bid. Then it will be up to you to place the contract, but so far you don't know much about her hand, except that she has a four-card major. So, just answer no by saying 2 diamonds and leave the rest of it up to her. Let's look at some hands and see how to respond after you opened 1 no trump and your partner responded 2 clubs:

1. ♠ A32
♥ KJ9
♦ KJ8
♣ K984

2. ♠ A432
♥ KQ6
♦ KQ5
♣ K32

3. ♠ A43
♥ KQ3
♦ KQ92
♣ K98

4. ♠ AKJ9
♥ 5432
♦ A9
♣ A109

Hand 1: 2 diamonds. No four-card major. Your answer is no.

Hand 2: 2 spades. You have one four-card major—spades—so you bid it. This rebid absolutely denies a four-card heart suit.

Hand 3: 2 diamonds. This is a strong hand with 17 HCP. Despite that, you must respond 2 diamonds. Your partner is now the captain for this hand. She has asked one

simple question, “Do you have a four-card major?” That’s all she wants to know. She doesn’t care, at this point, whether you have 15 HCP or 17 HCP. All she wants to know is whether or not you have a four-card major, and your answer is no.

Hand 4: 2 hearts. You have two four-card majors, consisting of a terrific spade suit and a terrible heart suit. You *must* bid your hearts first. That’s your agreement. She has at least one four-card major. It might be hearts. You’d rather play in a 4–4 heart fit with your hearts than a 4–2, or worse, spade suit with your spades, wouldn’t you? If you wouldn’t, you’d better go back and reread the chapters on suit bids and responses. Also, remember that bidding your four-card heart suit doesn’t deny a four-card spade suit. If she then bids 2 no trump (telling you that her four-card major is spades, not hearts), you can rebid 4 spades to tell her that you have four spades as well as four hearts. Because her bid of 2 no trump is invitational, and you have enough to play in game in a suit (your diamond doubleton gives you 17 points in a suit contract), you should bid game. If you bid 3 spades, your partner is allowed to pass.

Rebidding Over Interference When Your Partner Responds

Two types of interference can occur when your partner responds to your opening bid of 1 no trump. Interference can occur *before* your partner bids, or it can occur *after* your partner bids. We’ve already covered how responder handles interference before she bids (see [Chapter 10](#)), but how does opening bidder respond when interference occurs after her partner bids?

Opponents take a chance in bidding a suit after your partner has bid 2 clubs: Stayman. This gives you information about their hands and cards that you wouldn’t have otherwise.

For example, your partner bids Stayman—asking if you have a four-card major—and RHO bids 2 hearts. If you have four hearts, you probably don’t want to be playing this hand in hearts. If you have hearts well stopped and don’t have four spades, you can

respond 2 no trump—telling your partner that she needn’t worry much about hearts if you play the hand in no trump. But you might want to double for penalty. Look at the following auction.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	
1NT	P	2 ♣	2 ♥	
?				
1. ♠ AQ65	2. ♠ A72	3. ♠ 5432	4. ♠ KQ2	5. ♠ 32
♥ 32	♥ AQ	♥ AJ9	♥ 98	♥ AQ65
♦ KJ9	♦ K1073	♦ KJ8	♦ AJ98	♦ KJ9
♣ AQ98	♣ QJ98	♣ KQJ	♣ KQ64	♣ AQ98

Hand 1: 2 spades. You bid what you would have bid had there been no interference. If your partner’s suit is hearts, she can bid 2 no trump or 3 no trump depending on the strength of her hand. If her suit is spades, then you’ve found your fit and she’ll place the contract or give you an invitational bid of 3 spades.

Hand 2: 2 no trump. You don’t have four spades, but you do have the hearts suit well stopped. That’s what this bid tells your partner: “Don’t worry about hearts, pard, because I can take care of them.”

Hand 3: 2 spades. Your spades are terrible, but you do have four of them. If that’s your partner’s suit, you’ll be okay because you’ll be in a 4–4 fit.

Hand 4: Pass. You have a minimum no trump opening, no heart stopper, and you don’t have four spades. Both you and your partner have bid and have nice hands, but this doesn’t mean you have to continue in the auction and play the hand. If your partner doesn’t have any hearts, you could lose six heart tricks off the top in no trump. On the other hand, if your partner just has two aces—the ace of clubs and the ace of spades, or one ace and the king or queen of diamonds—you have a good chance to set a bid of 2 hearts.

Hand 5: Double for penalty. Your hearts are terrific. You’re telling your partner that you have no fear of opponents’ hearts and you’re willing to defend. It will be up to

your partner to decide whether to defend or play.

Response When Partner Jumps to 4NT

If the bidding goes 1NT-4NT, partner is saying she has 15-16 HCP. She's asking you to jump to 6NT if you are at the top of your bid (17 HCP, or 16 HCP with a good five-card suit) and to pass if you are not.

Here, you have learned standard rebids by a no trump opener. Among them, with a maximum hand, you rebid game after an invitational bid by partner. With less than a maximum hand, you play at the lowest level available. Respond to Stayman by bidding your lowest-ranking four-card major or 2 diamonds if you don't have a four-card major. Pass if your partner jumps to 3 no trump. Later, you will learn more advanced methods.

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Chapter 16

Rebids by 1 of a Suit Opener

Opener’s first rebid is the bid that many experts feel is the most descriptive and most important bid in the auction. When you open 1 of a suit, you tell your partner only that you have between 12 and 21 points. It’s with your first rebid that you more specifically describe your hand to your partner.

What Type of Hand Do You Have?

When you open 1 of a suit, you can have three types of hands.

Type	Points
Minimum	12–14
Extra values	15–18
Big	19–21

Extra values refers to a hand that is more powerful than the minimum indicated by your partner’s open. If your partner opens a suit bid at the 1 level, her minimum values are, generally, 12 to 14 points. If she has opened up a hand that has more than 15 points, she has extra values.

Reevaluating Your Hand When You Have a Fit

When you find through the bidding process that you have an eight-card fit in one suit (preferably 4-4, but at least 5-3; a 6-2 fit isn’t that valuable because the two trumps may quickly disappear through opponents leading trump), you may reevaluate the points in your hand. Instead of giving one point for a doubleton, two points for a singleton, and three points for a void, you give three points for a singleton and five points for a void. The reason is that with a fit you know that you will be able to ruff losers in the suits that have the shortness. If you don’t have a trump fit, that means that you won’t have enough trump to ruff the losers. So, the fit in trump makes the shortness more valuable.

Rebidding a Minimum Hand

If your partner (responder to the opening bidder) bids a new suit, even if it's only at the 1 level, you're required to bid again. If your partner doesn't describe a hand with extra values by making some sort of jump response, you have to describe your hand as minimum. This is how you do it.

Partner Responds with a Bid of 1 of a Suit at the 1 Level

If your partner bids a higher-ranking suit than the suit with which you opened and stays at the 1 level, her hand is basically undefined. All you know for sure is that she has at least 6 points and at least four cards in the suit she bid. That could be all she has, but she could have a lot more. Therefore, you must describe what you have to her.

Bidding a Second Suit as a Rebid. Generally, your first choice as a rebid is to bid a higher-ranking second suit at the 1 level, if you have it. When you bid a second suit in your first rebid, you're promising that you have at least four cards in that suit. You're not sticking your neck out much because your partner can't support opener's second suit unless she has four cards in that suit.

A very important rule that you must remember is that *responder may not support opener's second suit unless responder has four cards in that suit*. If you're responder and you only have three cards in opener's second suit, you should not support it. This should be imprinted on your brain.

Supporting Your Partner's Suit. If your partner (responder) bids a new suit at the 1 level after your opening bid and you hold a minimum without a higher-ranking four-card suit, you may support it *only if you have four cards in her suit*. You should not support your partner's new suit response with only three-card support. Why? Because she can bid a four-card suit—you're looking for an eight-card fit. You don't know whether she has four cards in the suit or more. But if your first rebid is to support her suit, you're strongly implying to her that you have four cards in her suit. The only time raising her suit with only three cards in it might be acceptable is if you have a singleton in an outside suit, and have no reasonable rebid.

Rebidding When You Can't Support Your Partner's Suit. If you don't have four cards in her suit, you have three possible rebids:

- + **1 no trump.** You may do this with a balanced hand. It tells your partner that you have no singletons or voids, and probably only one doubleton at most. It also tells her that you have a minimum hand, and implies stoppers in the unbid suits.
- + **Rebid your opening suit.** Rebidding your suit usually implies that you have six cards in it, but sometimes you have no choice but to rebid a five-card suit.
- + **Bid a new suit at the 2 level that is lower ranking than your opening suit.** For example: if you open 1 heart and your partner responds 1 spade, you may rebid 2 clubs if you have a four-card club suit. This bidding sequence would generally show that you had at least five hearts and either four or five clubs.

If you make a rebid at the 2 level of your second suit lower ranking than your opening suit, you are asking your partner to make a choice between the two suits you bid. If you opened a major and rebid a minor she should go back to the major if she has two cards in your major suit, even if she has four cards in your minor suit.

Here's a summation of your rebids when you open 1 of a suit and your partner responds by bidding 1 of a higher-ranking suit:

Your Holding	Rebid
12 to 14 points, a four-card suit higher than your partner's suit	Bid your higher-ranking, four-card suit at the 1 level
12 to 14 points, less than six cards in your suit, less than four cards in responder's suit, balanced hand	1 no trump
12 to 14 points, six cards in your suit	Rebid your suit at the 2 level
12 to 14 points, less than six cards in your suit, a four-card suit lower ranking than your opening suit	Bid your lower-ranking, four-card suit
12 to 14 points, less than six cards in your suit, but four cards in your partner's suit	Raise your partner's suit to the 2 level

An Introduction to the Reverse

In bidding a second suit at the 2 level in your first rebid, you must be careful not to reverse unless you have the points to justify a reverse. A *reverse* is when opener rebids a

suit at the 2 level that is higher ranking than the suit that she opened with at the 1 level. Example: You open 1 club. Your partner responds 1 spade. You bid 2 diamonds. Diamonds is higher ranking than clubs and you have bid diamonds at the 2 level, so you have reversed. If you open 1 diamond, partner bids 1 spade, and you bid 2 clubs, you have not reversed because clubs is ranked lower than diamonds.

A reverse promises that you have at least 17 points and is *forcing* on your partner for one round. In other words, if you reverse, your partner *must* bid again, no matter how weak her hand.

One of my partners, LuAnne Leonard, was trying to explain the concept of the reverse to her boyfriend, who was just learning. When he had a hard time understanding it, LuAnne turned to another of my partners, Marilyn Mitchell, and asked her to explain it. Marilyn gave one of the best definitions I've heard: "It's a helluva hand!" she said.

Now I'm going to give you a caveat. Many rubber bridge players don't know the concept of the reverse. However, playing reverses is very good bidding procedure, so you should learn them and be aware of them. Try to avoid reversing unless you have the proper hand. You will be a better player for it.

Practice Rebidding

Okay, let's look at some hands. You open 1 diamond and your partner responds 1 spade. What's your rebid?

1. ♠ 7
♥ KQJ10
♦ A973
♣ K874

2. ♠ KQ8
♥ 65
♦ AQJ432
♣ J9

3. ♠ 4
♥ KQJ10
♦ AQJ84
♣ AK3

4. ♠ Q1084
♥ 3
♦ AQJ74
♣ AQ6

5. ♠ Q1084
♥ K86
♦ A832
♣ A9

6. ♠ 86
♥ KQ83
♦ KJ107
♣ A83

7. ♠ KQ8
♥ 6
♦ AQJ43
♣ J98

Hand 1: 2 clubs. You should not rebid 1 no trump with a singleton. A new suit here—lower ranking than your first bid suit—shows a minimum, but doesn't deny extra values. It tells your partner to choose between the two suits you have bid.

Hand 2: 2 diamonds. This hand poses a very difficult decision for you. Your spades, although only three, are very good. You would like to have four-card support, but this is a hand with which you could bid 2 spades instead of 2 diamonds and your partner wouldn't have much to criticize. She'll undoubtedly play you for having four spades if you raise her, but you're giving her two of the top three honors, so this will mute most of her objections if she bid a four-card spade suit—which is all she's promising. Either bid would be acceptable and would show a minimum hand.

Hand 3: 2 hearts. This is a classic reverse by you and shows a hand with extra values. After opening 1 diamond, you rebid 2 hearts, a higher-ranking suit bid at the next level. The bid implies that your second bid suit, hearts, is shorter than your first bid suit, diamonds. Here you open with the five-card suit and rebid the four-card heart suit. It's forcing on your partner to keep the bid open for at least one more round.

Hand 4: 3 spades. After you reevaluate your hand by giving yourself 3 points for your singleton now that you know you have at least a 4–4 trump fit, you have 17 points. The jump in your partner's suit shows a hand with extra values (see [Chapter 14](#) for details on jump bids). The bid is invitational only to game. Your partner may pass you.

Hand 5: 2 spades. This is what you were looking for, a 4–4 fit in your major suit. But you only have a minimum hand, so you just make a minimum raise to the 2 level.

Hand 6: 1 no trump. You can't support your partner's spades with only two cards. You can't rebid your diamonds because you only have four. You can't bid clubs because you only have three. You can't bid hearts because that would be a reverse, showing extra values. You may bid 1 no trump. You have a minimum hand, no singletons or voids, and have all the other suits stopped.

Hand 7: 2 spades. The reason you may raise with only three spades is that you have a singleton. This is really the only time when you should consider raising with only three cards in your partner's suit. Absent the singleton you would bid 1NT, although rebidding your five-card diamond suit would be understandable. I don't like rebidding a five-card minor, but sometimes it's the better of two bad bids.

Finally, look at these hands when you open 1 club and your partner responds 1 diamond:

1. ♠ AQ76
♥ 8642
♦ 87
♣ AK7

2. ♠ 54
♥ 7642
♦ AKQJ
♣ A64

3. ♠ 87
♥ AKQ
♦ 87
♣ KQ10983

4. ♠ 94
♥ A6
♦ A953
♣ KQJ103

Hand 1: 1 heart. You bid your higher-ranking four-card suits up the line, so even though your spades are much stronger, you rebid 1 heart. Your partner might have five diamonds and four spades. If so, she'll respond with a bid of 1 spade and you can still find your 4–4 spade fit.

Hand 2: 1 heart. You could support diamonds, but you're looking for a major-suit fit. You must tell her you have four hearts. If you were to support diamonds at your first rebid, you would be denying a four-card major.

Hand 3: 2 clubs. You have a six-card suit and don't have a four-card major; you can bid at the 1 level over her 1 diamond response.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. Your clubs are nice, but she might not have any. Because you have four cards in her suit, and you don't have a higher-ranking four-card suit to bid—and you don't have spades stopped—2 diamonds is your only call. Incidentally, this is *not* a reverse because, even though you're bidding a higher-ranking suit at the 2 level, it's in support of your partner's suit. This takes it out of the realm of reverses.

Your Partner Responds 1 No Trump

When your partner responds to your opening bid of 1 of a suit with a response of 1 no trump, she's denying that she has a four-card suit higher ranking than the suit you opened. If you opened a four-card suit, then you can't have a hand with two doubletons, although you could be 4-4-4-1. In any event, if you open a four-card suit you can't rebid it. If you open 1 diamond and your partner responds 1 no trump, she has denied four hearts or four spades. If she had five diamonds, she probably would have raised your bid to 2 diamonds; therefore, she must have at least three clubs in her hand. If you don't like your chances in no trump after the bidding has gone 1 diamond—1 no trump, you can chance a rebid of 2 clubs if you have four of them in your hand. This tells your partner that you have a minimum hand but don't want to play in no trump and asks her to pick which suit she would like to play at the 2 level: diamonds or clubs.

If you have a balanced hand without any voids or singletons and no more than one doubleton, you should pass her bid of 1 no trump and let her play it there. She's telling you that she has a weak hand. Keep it at a low level before you get into trouble in a contract you can't make.

Your Partner Makes a Simple Raise of Your Opening Bid

If your partner raises your 1 bid to the 2 level, you should pass if you have a minimum opening. Why? You have no more than 14 points in your hand. She has no more than 9 points in her hand. The math is simple, $14 + 9 = 23$. You have little chance for game, so why go on?

Your Partner Responds in a New Suit at the 2 Level

Finally, your partner is showing a hand that's better than the minimum. In all the examples we've seen so far, your partner has either shown a minimum hand by making a simple raise or by bidding 1 no trump, or made an ambiguous bid of a suit at the 1 level that might be minimum—or it might not.

When she responds in a new suit at the 2 level, she's promising at least 10 points—maybe more. If you have a minimum, you have to tell her this. Her bid is forcing on

you to bid again. You can't pass.

Look at the following hands where you opened 1 heart and your partner responded 2 diamonds:

1. ♠ A7	2. ♠ AQ	3. ♠ KJ	4. ♠ A3
♥ KQJ103	♥ KJ865	♥ KQ963	♥ KQ10963
♦ Q7	♦ J42	♦ 84	♦ 874
♣ J1074	♣ Q108	♣ AK93	♣ AK

Hand 1: 2 hearts. You're not strong enough to bid 3 clubs. Your heart suit is good and you show a minimum hand. If you were to bid 3 clubs you would show a hand with extra values, which this hand doesn't possess. It's not a good practice to rebid five-card suits, but the quality of your heart suit here makes a 2 heart rebid slightly better than 2 no trump.

Hand 2: 2 no trump. You could raise diamonds, but a 2 no trump bid is a better description of your hand. It also shows a minimum and allows your partner to pass. At this point you may be asking yourself, "What's the difference between Hand 1 and Hand 2 that allows you to rebid 2 hearts in Hand 1 but says you should bid 2 no trump in Hand 2?" You rebid 2 hearts in Hand 1 because of the quality of your heart suit and the unbalanced nature of the hand. You only have one spade stopper and one club stopper. You bid 2 no trump in Hand 2 because your heart suit isn't as good as it is in Hand 1—you have two spade stoppers, and the hand is more balanced, with only one doubleton. Both bids, however, tell your partner that you have a minimum hand, and this is vital information that you want to convey.

Hand 3: 3 clubs. This is a hand with extra values, unlike Hand 1. When you raise the level of the bidding with a new suit in your rebid, you're showing extra values. This bid is forcing on your partner to keep the auction open to game.

Hand 4: 3 hearts. Again, this shows extra values and at least six hearts.

Here's a summary of what to do if your partner bid a suit at the 2 level.

Your Holding	Rebid
12 to 14 points, a five-card opening suit, less than three cards in your partner's major suit or less than four cards in your partner's minor suit, unbid suits stopped, no singletons or voids.	2 no trump.
Same, but with support for your partner's suit.	Raise your partner's suit.

Here's a summary of what to do if your partner responded 1 no trump.

Your Holding	Rebid
12 to 14 points, balanced hand.	Pass.
12 to 14 points, with a singleton or void.	Bid a lower-ranking four-card suit at the 2 level or rebid your five-card opening suit.
12 to 14 points, less than six cards in your suit and less than four cards in your partner's suit.	Raise your partner's suit to the 2 level.

Rebidding After Your Partner Passes

If your partner passed, what does that tell you? It tells you several things:

- + If there was no intervening bid between you and her, she doesn't have 6 points.
- + If there was an intervening bid between you and her, she might have more than 6 points but your LHO might have bid her suit. However, if she passes after an intervening bid, then either one of two situations exist:
 - + Your LHO bid her suit.
 - + She has less than 6 points.

One thing you can count on is that you probably don't have an eight-card trump fit. It's possible she has three cards in your suit but less than 6 points; although you can't count on it. If she passes, you should assume she has less than 6 points and less than three cards in your suit. If you make these assumptions, you won't get hurt by rebidding based on a false expectation of support when she indicated none. Hope springs eternal, but it shouldn't in bridge. If your partner says, "Pass," take her at her word and don't count on her for anything. If your opponents have bid and it's passed around to you, you should pass—unless you have more than a minimum, shortness in your opponents' suit, or some other reason to bid. The reopening double will be covered later.

How to proceed when you have opened and your partner has passed is an important aspect of the game. Let's look at some minimum hands after the following bidding.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	
1 ♥	P	P	2 ♣	
1. ♠ K43 ♥ AK763 ♦ A6 ♣ 863	2. ♠ AJ75 ♥ QJ872 ♦ A ♣ 984	3. ♠ 86 ♥ AKJ943 ♦ K84 ♣ 74	4. ♠ 98 ♥ J109854 ♦ AQJ9 ♣ A	5. ♠ 4 ♥ KJ9753 ♦ K83 ♣ AO9

Hand 1: Pass. You don't have anything else to bid. You can't rebid your hearts because you only have five, and you don't have a four-card suit to bid. Furthermore, your partner has denied 6 points and probably doesn't have hearts support. If you take another bid you're just going to get in trouble.

Hand 2: Pass. Again, you shouldn't rebid your weak five-card hearts suit. You can't bid spades because that would be a reverse showing at least 17 points, which you don't have. Anyway, if your partner had 6 points and four spades, she would have responded 1 spade to your 1 heart opening. Remember this before you fall in love with your spades. Your partner's pass tells you a lot.

Hand 3: Pass. You might rebid your hearts if you're not vulnerable, but this hand looks like trouble. Your partner doesn't have much help for you and you don't have any outside source of tricks. What are you going to do for tricks, especially if your LHO has the ace of diamonds? You'll probably take five heart tricks only for down three. So, even though you have six hearts and could rebid them, pass would be the prudent move. However, if your 9 of hearts were a 10 of hearts instead, you might be tempted to make a 2 hearts bid. Do you know why? Because you would have 100 honors, four of the five honors in the trump suit, which would give you 100 points above the line if you get the contract in hearts. Even if you were to get the bid and go down two, undoubled, you would break even. Your opponents would get 100 points above the line, but so would you for your 100 honors. However, don't succumb to this temptation. You shouldn't make a bad bid simply because you have 100 honors.

In rubber bridge you get bonus points for having at least four honors in the trump suit in one hand. If trump is spades and you hold four of the five honors, you receive 100 points above the line. This is called *100 honors*. If you hold all five honors, AKQJ10, you get 150 points above the line, called *150 honors*. The honors all have to be in the same hand, but it doesn't matter if they are in declarer's hand or in dummy. You don't have to get the contract to be awarded the bonus. All that's required is that you hold at least four honors in the trump suit in one hand.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. Your six-card heart suit is woeful to rebid when your partner passes, but this distributional hand could be nice if you find your partner with four diamonds in her hand. If it's passed to your partner, it's up to her to make a preference at this point between hearts and diamonds. You will clearly pass on your next turn no matter what she does.

Hand 5: 2 hearts. Your heart suit is not terrific, but you do have six along with a singleton spade and high cards that could be sources for tricks in both clubs and diamonds. Even without much help from your partner you should bid again at the 2 level. However, if they go to 3 and your partner remains silent, let them have it.

There are several points I want you to take from this exercise:

- + **Listen to your partner.** If she passes without an intervening bid, when considering your rebid you should assume she has nothing.
 - + **You should strain to rebid a six-card suit.** This is crucial information for your partner. If she has two of your suit, she knows that with a maximum pass in her hand—5 points—she might be able to compete to the 3 level in your suit; something she'd never do if she thought you only had a five-card suit.
- Furthermore, in a distributional hand you want ruffing power. In Hand 5, you have a good chance of getting two club tricks, depending on the location of the king, regardless of what's trump. You want to be able to ruff spades with your little hearts! This is also a reason to refrain from rebidding a five-card suit unless absolutely necessary.

- + **Count your tricks.** Even if you have a terrific six-card suit—like you do in Hand 3—if you have no outside source of tricks and your partner has no help, you could be in big trouble if you rebid your suit.

What Does Your Partner's Response Mean?

If she responds, she's telling you a lot. First, if she supports your major-suit opening she's telling you a couple of things:

- + She has at least three cards in your suit.
- + She has a minimum hand—not more than 9 points and not less than 6 points—and will probably not bid again unless you force her. Even if she bids another suit, she doesn't necessarily deny support for your suit. She might just be telling you she has another suit or the number of points in her hand, before she tells you she has support.

If she (responder) bids a new suit, it is 100 percent forcing on you to bid again. This means that you may pass your partner's response to your opening bid only in the following three instances:

- + She bids 1 no trump in response to your opening suit bid.
- + She raises your opening suit bid to the 2 level.
- + Your RHO makes an intervening bid.

These things should be going through your mind when you hear your partner bid and it comes back to you to make a rebid.

Analysis of Your Partner's Response

When your partner bids a suit (refer to Chapters 11 and 12 on responses), you'll see what your partner has told you. To recap, if she bids at the 1 level, she's promising only a minimum hand and four cards in the suit she bid. If she bids at the 2 level without a jump, she's showing at least 10 points and five cards in the suit if she bids a major, but only four cards in the suit if she bids a minor. If she jumps, she's showing a more powerful hand.

Let's say you open 1 club and she bids 1 spade. What do you know about her hand? She has at least 6 points and at least four spades. Anything else? You know at least two more things about her hand. What are they?

Answer: her hearts and diamonds are not longer than her spades. Remember, you bid your longest suit in response to your partner's opening bid; if two suits are four cards, equal in length, you bid the lower-ranking suit or *up the line*. If you have two five-card suits, you bid the higher ranking first, or *down the line*. So, you know for an absolute fact that your partner has at least 6 points—at least four spades—and not more cards in each of hearts and diamonds than she has in spades. That's quite a lot to know from one bid, don't you think?

What if you open 1 diamond and she bids 2 clubs? This time she's telling you a little more. First, she is promising you more points, at least 10. Second, she's telling you that she has at least four clubs and that her clubs are longer than her hearts and her spades.

What if you open 1 heart and she bids 1 no trump with no intervening bid? Well, you know three things for sure:

- + She has at least 6 points. She shouldn't bid unless she has at least 6 points.
- + She doesn't have four spades. If she had four spades she would bid 1 spade after your opening bid of 1 heart, with one exception: if she has an absolute minimum hand with four spades and three hearts. In that event she would only have one bid she could make and it should be to support your hearts, so she'd *bypass* her four-card spade suit to bid 2 hearts.
- + She doesn't have three hearts. If she had three hearts, she would support you immediately by bidding 2 hearts, especially if she had a minimum hand.

So, with that one bid of hers, you can forget about trying to find an eight-card fit in a major if you opened a five-card suit!

The point of all this is that bidding requires deductive reasoning—listening to what your partner has *not* bid to determine what she has in her hand. You must take negative inferences.

Analyzing for a Rebid

You shouldn't open if you don't have a rebid. As I said in [Chapter 6](#) on opening bids of 1 of a suit, when considering opening, you should always ask yourself, "What am I going to bid if my partner bids thus and so?" "Thus and so" being the worst response you could hope for with your hand, probably bidding your singleton or void. If you don't have a rebid, you shouldn't open.

When I was a bridge tyke I had heard this maxim. One day I looked at a 14-point hand and didn't see a rebid, so I passed and the hand was passed out. When we looked at the cards, it was clear that we could have made game because my partner had 12 points and we had a fit. They asked me why I didn't open. "I didn't have a rebid," I replied. They all laughed ... and they weren't laughing *with* me.

A 14-point hand always has a rebid. Remember that. And often it's 1 no trump.

Rebidding 1 No Trump

What does 1 no trump rebid by opener tell partner? Several things:

- + Opener has no more than 14 points.
- + Opener has a balanced hand.
- + Opener doesn't have four cards in responder's suit.
- + Partner becomes captain of the hand, just as if opener opened with 1 no trump (which would, of course, show a stronger hand than a rebid of 1 no trump).

You can't make a 1 no trump rebid as opener if you have a singleton or void. If you have a singleton or void, however, you generally have at least two four-card suits; so your rebid would be your lower-ranking four-card suit, if you can't support your partner's response. Let's look at some hands, all of which you open 1 club and your partner responds 1 heart:

1. ♠ AK74	2. ♠ AK7	3. ♠ Q1094	4. ♠ K8	5. ♠ 85
♥ 74	♥ 7532	♥ AK9	♥ Q7	♥ KJ
♦ Q84	♦ 983	♦ 75	♦ KJ32	♦ KJ3
♣ A832	♣ AK9	♣ A942	♣ A10432	♣ AJ10643

Hand 1: 1 spade. You have four spades. When you open 1 club, you generally deny having as many as five spades, so you're telling your partner that basically you have a 12-16-point hand with four spades. She might have bid a four-card heart suit up the line and have four spades, too.

Hand 2: 2 hearts. Sure, your hearts aren't pretty, but you have the correct number—four—so you will be in a 4-4 at worst if you play in hearts.

Hand 3: 1 spade. You certainly have nice hearts support, but you don't have four cards in the suit; so tell her about your spades now. Her hand might be a minimum. She might have four spades. She might have five hearts or more. You just don't know. The best thing to do is to describe your hand as accurately as possible and let her take it from there.

Hand 4: 1 no trump. You can't support hearts. You can't bid diamonds because it would be a reverse. (Didn't I tell you this word would be used a lot during this chapter?) You shouldn't rebid your clubs because you only have five cards in your clubs suit. A 1 no trump rebid says that you have a minimum hand and denies four of your partner's suit.

Hand 5: 2 clubs. You have a six-card suit and nothing else to rebid. Again, this tells your partner you have opened up a minimum hand.

Look at these hands:

<u>You</u>	<u>Partner</u>
♠ 82	♥ AKQJ9
♠ KQ96	♥ 107
♦ J85	♦ K976
♣ Q54	♣ J102

How would you bid it as opener and responder? Before looking at how it should be bid, go ahead and bid it, assuming no intervening bids.

Okay, here's how it went. You opened 1 heart, right? You have 14 points, so you couldn't open 1 no trump. Responder bid 1 spade. That's correct. Responder has 9 HCP and four spades, a perfect bid.

So, what's your rebid? You could rebid your strong hearts, although you only have five. Your better response is what we've been discussing: 1 no trump. You have 14 points, but 10 of them are in hearts; therefore, you let your partner know that you're basically a minimum open with a balanced hand. Your partner clearly can't take another call. Her response was minimum. Unless you make a forcing bid, she has to pass whatever you bid. It was passed out at 1 no trump and that's what it made: exactly 1 no trump.

Rebidding with Better Than a Minimum Hand

When you open a hand with extra values—a big hand—your rebids must communicate the strength of your hand to your partner. You should make a bid that she can't pass.

As explained at the beginning of the chapter, a reverse is when opener bids a higher-ranking suit at the 2 level than the suit she opened with at the 1 level. Example: You open 1 club. Your partner responds 1 spade. You bid 2 diamonds. Diamonds is higher ranking than clubs and you have bid them at the 2 level, so you have reversed.

To repeat, a reverse promises that you have at least 17 points and is forcing on your partner for one round. In other words, your partner should bid again, no matter how weak her hand, if you reverse.

Generally, a reverse also tells your partner that you have more cards—at least five—in the suit you opened and fewer cards—usually four—in the suit to which you reverse. So, in the previous example, you would have five clubs and four diamonds or, rarely, six clubs and five diamonds.

If you play reverses—and most good players do—it causes problems when you have merely an opening hand with a longer, lower-ranking suit. For example, look at this hand:

♠ 98
♥ 75
♦ AK84
♣ KQ983

Normally, from what you've learned so far, this would clearly be a hand that you would open 1 club, because you have five clubs. But—and this is another rule you've already learned and that you should have ingrained in your head—*when you open the bidding, be sure you have a rebid*. If you don't have a rebid, you shouldn't open the bidding. This hand illustrates the latter rule if you are playing reverses.

Here's why: If you open 1 club and your partner responds with 1 heart or 1 spade—which, due to the perverse nature of the bridge gods, she is almost certain to do—given the shape of your hand, you have no rebid! Why? Because you shouldn't rebid 1 no trump when you don't have the other major stopped. You can't rebid 2 diamonds because your hand isn't powerful enough. A rebid in 2 diamonds after your partner responds 1 of a major over a 1 club open would be a reverse showing at least 17 points. You could rebid 2 clubs, but it's not a great description of your hand.

So, in this instance, you should open this hand 1 diamond. Then when your partner responds with 1 heart or 1 spade, you can rebid 2 clubs, showing a minimum hand. This is one of the few times when you may open a shorter, higher-ranking suit instead of a longer, lower-ranking suit, and this generally only applies when you have a minimum opener with five clubs and four diamonds.

Let's look at some hands that we examined earlier. When we first looked at these hands you had opened the bidding with a bid of 1 heart, your partner passed, and your RHO bid 2 clubs. This time, however, let's say that you still open 1 heart, but your partner bids 2 clubs. (Please note that Hand 1 has been altered somewhat.)

1. ♠ K43
♥ AK763
♦ 643
♣ K6

2. ♠ AJ75
♥ QJ872
♦ A
♣ 984

3. ♠ 86
♥ AKJ943
♦ K84
♣ 74

4. ♠ 98
♥ J109854
♦ AQ76
♣ A

What's your rebid?

Hand 1: 2 hearts. You shouldn't bid 2 no trump because you don't have diamonds stopped. This hand is as weak as it can be and still have enough points to open.

Hand 2: 3 clubs. This hand is very weak. You can't bid 2 spades (your other four-card suit) because that would be a reverse, and you are far too weak to make a reverse. Your action in supporting partner's suit here shows a minimum hand and invites a pass.

Hand 3: 2 hearts. You have six hearts and nothing else to bid. Again, this describes a minimum hand.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. Your hearts are terrible, even though you have six of them. You are just asking your partner to take a preference. You're going to pass whatever she does unless she makes a forcing bid.

If you have a minimum hand with a higher-ranking four-card suit over your opening five-card suit, you have four choices when your partner responds by bidding a new suit, and you can't reverse because your hand isn't strong enough:

- + Bid a new suit at the 1 level.
- + Raise your partner's suit at the lowest level.
- + Rebid your own suit at the lowest level.
- + Rebid no trump at the lowest level, but you must have no trump distribution. You shouldn't rebid no trump if you have a void or singleton.

Strong Rebid Jump to Game

If you open a hand at the 1 level and your partner responds in a suit you can support and you have 20 points, you should immediately jump to game. Look at the following

hand:

♠ A1092

♥ AK8

♦ A2

♣ K763

The bidding goes as follows.

<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
P	1 ♣	1 ♦	1 ♠
2 ♦	4 ♠		

The point to remember here is that when your partner gives you a minimum response, you jump to game immediately with this hand. Why? Because all you need for game in a major suit is 26 points. Your partner has absolutely promised you two things by her bid:

- + She has at least four spades.
- + She has at least 6 points.

That's all you need for game in spades. You know that you have at least an eight-card fit in trump and you know you have at least 26 points between you both. (Actually, you know you have at least 27 points, because when you find that you have a trump fit your singleton is reevaluated upward by an extra point.)

When she responds with these promises, you jump to game. This is *not* a *sign-off bid* (one intended to close the auction). With extras, your partner may bid on to slam.

This bid is a strength-showing bid, asking your partner to continue bidding to explore slam if she has the values. When you make this bid, you're promising your partner that you have at least 20 points.

Opener's Splinter

Change the hand above to the following:

♠ A1092
 ♥ AK8
 ♦ A
 ♣ K7632

In this instance after 1C-P-1S-P-? you should bid a splinter, or 4D, showing a singleton or void and at least four-card support for responder's first bid. You have to have a huge hand to do this because responder is only promising 6 HCP and four spades, so you must have a hand that can make game with that kind of support.

Opener's Jump to No Trump

If opener jumps to 2 no trump or 3 no trump after partner has bid a new suit at the 1 level, the requirements are as follows.

Rebid	Requirements
2 no trump	18 to 19 points, all unbid suits stopped
3 no trump	20 to 21 points, all unbid suits stopped

If you make an opening bid, partner passes, and the opponents make an overcall, your bid of 1NT shows a balanced hand, 18-19 HCP, and at least one stopper in opponents' suit, the same hand you would have to jump to 2NT if partner has made a call.

Opener's Jump Shift

If you skip a level of bidding that is available to you and bid a new suit at the same time, you've made a jump shift, and have shown a hand that is between 19 and 22 points. A jump shift that skips a level is forcing to game. Look at the following hand:

♠ A
 ♥ A8
 ♦ K76534
 ♣ AK83

The bidding is as follows.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♦	P	1 ♠	P
?			

You can't jump in no trump because you have a singleton in your partner's suit. You can't reverse into hearts, a two-card suit. A rebid of 2 clubs would show a minimum hand. You want to make a forcing bid to find out more about your partner's hand. What should you do?

The answer is to make a jump shift to 3 clubs. It's 100 percent forcing on your partner to bid. She can't support you unless she has at least four cards in the suit. By this bid, you're telling your partner that you have a big hand but are groping for where to play it. You need more information from her.

The difference between a jump shift and a reverse is that when you reverse you don't skip a level of bidding that is available to you. One club—one spade—two hearts is a reverse; it doesn't skip a level available to you. One diamond—one spade—three clubs is a jump shift, because it skips a level available to you: two clubs. It shows a bigger hand than a reverse.

Both a reverse and a jump shift are forcing, and therefore both could be just short of a Strong Two opening. They are distinguished only because a jump shift must arrive in game, whereas a reverse sequence may stop short, because a reverse is forcing for one round only.

To summarize:

Bid	Points	Result
Reverse	17+	Forcing for one round
Jump shift	19+	Forcing to game

Evaluating Your Partner's Bid Over Interference By Her RHO

If your partner has bid over another bid by your LHO (her RHO), it tells you something different than if she bids 1 no trump over your opening one-bid without interference, it tells you, simply, that she doesn't have a four-card major higher ranking than the suit you opened and that she has between 6 to 10 HCP without a singleton or void. If she bids 1 no trump over an interfering bid by her RHO, however, it also promises that she has a stopper in the interfering bidder's suit.

When you open 1 diamond and your LHO overcalls 1 heart, if your partner responds 1 no trump, it tells you three things: first, she has 8 to 10 HCP; second, she doesn't have four spades; and third, she has hearts stopped at least once.

There is defensive value to straining to support your partner's suit over interference. This is especially true if your opponents are going to be forced up a level if they want to bid their suit again. So, if your partner opens 1 spade and your RHO overcalls 2 clubs, if you raise to 2 spades, your LHO will have to go to the 3 level to bid a suit other than clubs.

You're telling your partner that you are minimum, so you don't have to worry that she'll over-evaluate your hand by this bid. Basically you're just competing, and your partner should know this and shut up if your opponents compete to the 3 level in clubs. Unless she has extra values in her hand, she should let them play at the 3 level. You will have a better chance of setting them at the 3 level than you would have playing a three-spade contract with your weak hand.

Responding to Your Partner's Bid Over Interference By Her LHO

If you open the bidding and it goes 1D-P-1H-1S-? and you don't have at least four hearts to support partner's 1H bid, but you do have three hearts, you may double your RHO's bid. This is not a penalty double; it is a *support double*. What it says is, "Partner I have exactly three cards in your suit (which in this instance is hearts)." What you are

trying to find is an eight-card fit and from her bid you don't know if she has four hearts or more than four.

If she has more than four, then she will rebid her hearts, either at the 2 level or the 3 level (if she thinks game might be possible). However, just because she bid 2H does not mean that she has five hearts. She might have a weak hand and no other bid so she wants to close out in a contract of 2H. If partner responds 2H, it's pretty much a drop dead bid, and not a confirmation that she has five hearts. If you raise her and she only has four hearts, you will be in a Moysian fit (4-3) at the 3 level and the contract might be hard to make.

Most players play support doubles through two hearts or three hearts. That is, if you play it through two hearts and the bidding goes 1D-P-1H-2S-?, a double of 2S would be a penalty double and not a support double. If, on the other hand, the bidding goes 1D-P-1S-2H-?, a double of 2H would be a support double and not a penalty double.

Not everyone plays support doubles. In fact, some very good tournament players do not play them. When I ask a new partner if they play support doubles, I often get the answer "if I remember them." That's not a joke. It's a bid that is often forgotten because it doesn't come up that often. So, if you play support doubles, be sure that your partner plays them, too.

Western Cue-Bid

Some time ago a pair of good players had a hand much like this one:

West

♠ K2

♥ AK974

♦ KJ98

♣ 96

East

♠ 53

♥ 32

♦ AQ10742

♣ AJ4

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
1 ♥	1 ♠	2 ♦	2 ♠
3 ♦	P	4 ♣	P
4 ♦	P	5 ♦	P
P	P		

East played in 5 diamonds and went down one after a spade lead. North took two spades winners, and the defense later got a club trick when the heart suit didn't divide well.

This is a disaster for East-West because West can make 3 no trump. There is no defense to it. How do you think the bidding should have gone? Some players think that West should bid no trump instead of raising diamonds, but that seems like a biased view. For all West knew, slam in diamonds was available.

A convention is available that would have gotten West to 3 no trump. It has many names, but the most popular is the *Western Cue-Bid*. A Western Cue-Bid is almost always made at the 3 level. You use it almost exclusively when your side has found a minor-suit fit or one of you is known to have an exceptionally good minor suit.

The way it works is simple. The opponents have bid a suit but your side is marked with most of the HCP. If your side has found a minor-suit fit, and if it's clear that your side doesn't have a major-suit contract available, you can use a cue-bid of the opponents' suit to say, "I think we can make 3 no trump if you have a stopper in their suit."

On this hand, East could have bid 3 spades instead of 4 clubs. West has a spade stopper and bids 3 no trump. West is not worried about clubs because no one has bid them, and East rates to have something in clubs given he has shown a good hand. Here's how that bidding would go:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
1 ♥	1 ♠	2 ♦	2 ♠
3 ♦	P	3 ♠★	P
3NT	P	P	P

★*Western Cue asking West to bid 3NT with a spade stopper.*

You do have to be careful about the Western Cue-Bid. If your side has agreed on a major suit, the cue-bid is not the Western Cue-Bid. It applies only when your side has no major-suit fit that you can play in.

Here's another example:

West

♠ AJ

♥ 74

♦ A3

♣ AKQ10743

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
1 ♣	1 ♥	1 ♠	P

West has a super hand and wants to be in game somewhere (West could have opened 2C with this hand, but if he did, 3NT would be difficult, if not impossible, to find). If East has a heart stopper, 3 no trump is a likely contract. West might bid 3 clubs, but that bid is only invitational showing about 17 points and good clubs. West has much more than that.

Here is where confusion often sets in. If West bids 2 hearts, that bid should be interpreted by East as a cue-bid for spades. East will not understand what is wanted of him. What West can do on this hand is to bid 2 diamonds, which is a reverse bid. (Recall from [Chapter 14](#) that *reverse* is when opener rebids a suit at the 2 level that is higher ranking than the suit that she opened with at the 1 level.) A reverse is a forcing bid. (Sometimes you have to lie to your partner to achieve the result for which you are looking.) If East raises diamonds, for instance, West can now bid 3 hearts, and that should be interpreted as a Western Cue-Bid looking for a heart stopper.

Here is a more normal example:

West

♠ AQ

♥ 87

♦ AKJ875

♣ J108

East

♠ 874

♥ QJ92

♦ Q942

♣ A9

West

North

East

South

2 ♦

P

3 ♦

1 ♥

3 ♥

P

3NT

P

P

P

South opens 1 heart, and West bids 2 diamonds. West doesn't have enough to double first and so is obliged to overcall. East makes a good raise to 3 diamonds. (Don't forget to raise your partner's overcalls when you have support. A raise does a lot of good.)

West can see six likely diamond tricks, and with South opening the bidding it is pretty sure that if a spade finesse is needed, it will work. So, West bids 3 hearts, asking if East has a heart stopper. He does, and he bids 3 no trump as requested because 3 no trump will make almost all the time. It would take extreme bad luck to go down.

One big advantage of the Western Cue-Bid is that the player with the stopper is the declarer. If you have Kx or AQ or Q10x of your opponents' suit, it is crucial that the opening lead come up to your hand. If you were dummy, the opening lead would come through your hand, and that could cost you the contract.

Here is another example:

West

♠ A8

♥ KQ874

♦ A103

♣ 932

East

♠ K72

♥ AJ92

♦ QJ962

♣ A

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
	1 ♦	P	P
1 ♥	1 ♠	3 ♥	P
3 ♠	P	?	

E/W were not playing cue-bid limit raises, so 3H was a strong bid. Had they been playing cue-bid limit raises, East would have bid 2D, showing a good hand with heart support. This hand is also a good example of why East is not a “passed hand” even though he passed. He had no call because North opened his five-card suit and he could not support clubs if that’s how West responded and he wasn’t strong enough to double and then bid a major suit. He had to rely on his partner to balance if it were passed to him.

East must not think in terms of the Western Cue-Bid in this auction. East and West have found a certain hearts fit, and when you have done that, the Western Cue-Bid doesn’t apply. West is making a cue-bid for a heart slam, and East should make a cue-bid of his own with 4 clubs. The partnership will end in 6 hearts, which will make six or seven depending on where the king of diamonds is.

Bidding Western Cue is not limited to opener. Responder may also bid it when it is appropriate.

There’s a lot in this chapter, standard bids like bidding a lower-ranking suit that shows minimum values, and the principle that you should have four cards to support partner’s suit. You have also learned some advanced bids like support doubles and Western Cue, which can enhance what you can learn from, and communicate to, your partner. The next chapters talk more about rebids.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 17

Rebids by Strong Opener and Responder

This chapter consists of two parts. The first part deals with rebids by a Strong Two opener. This topic is fairly straightforward, so it doesn't need a lot of space. The second part of the chapter covers responder's first rebid.

As with the first rebid by a 1 of a suit opener, the first rebid by a Strong Two opener is very important. And responder's first rebid really completes the first phase of communication between the partners and sets the stage for concluding the final contract.

When someone opens with a Strong Two, this bid determines how much information the opener can give to responder. Initially, responder only knows that opener has a very strong hand. With the opener's rebid, the auction is moved to the next level. Responder's rebid is extremely important because it determines whether or not you're going to play for a partscore, game, or slam.

Rebids by Strong Two Opener in Diamonds, Hearts, or Spades

If you open with a Strong Two in diamonds, hearts, or spades and your partner gives you a negative response of 2 no trump, you let her off the hook if you rebid your opening suit at the 3 level. If you do rebid your suit, your partner may pass. This is the only time that your partner may pass when you open with a Strong Two in these three suits until a game bid is made.

It follows, therefore, that if you bid a new suit, it's forcing on your partner to make another response. For example, suppose the bidding goes as follows.

You

2 ♠

3 ♣

4 ♣

5 ♦

Partner

2NT

3 ♠

4 ♠

?

Your partner must bid. Anytime a Strong Two opener bids a new suit, responder must bid again. This is especially true when, as here, opener made a bid after partner (responder) bid game in her suit.

This bid is called a *two demand*. Unless you rebid your opening suit, you're demanding your partner to keep the bidding open until you reach game.

Following is a hand that shows some of the problems encountered by a Strong Two opener:

♠ A
♥ AKJ832
♦ A7
♣ AK108

Here's the bidding:

You

2 ♥

?

Partner

3 ♦

The first thing to remember here is that when your partner gives you a positive response, which is any bid other than 2 no trump or raising your suit a level, she's making a game-forcing bid. You don't need to worry about her passing you out short of game. You can rebid your heart suit here without thinking that you're allowing her to pass. If you go straight to four hearts, you could find your partner with a void. Your heart suit isn't strong enough for this. A bid by opener of 4 hearts in this situation is weaker than a bid of 3 hearts. Why? Because after a positive response from your partner, a jump to game by a bid of 4 hearts would be a sign-off, whereas a bid of 3 hearts asks your partner for more information.

The better bid here is to bid your four-card club suit. Your partner should know that you may only have four. The problem with this is that it bypasses 3 no trump. However, you could be very uncomfortable if you were to bid 3 no trump and find that your partner doesn't have a spade stopper.

Your partner has told you that she has better than a minimum, however, because she bid 3 diamonds instead of 2 no trump. This told you two things about her diamond suit:

- + She has at least five diamonds.
- + She has two of the top four diamond honors with at least the king.

Those two honors could be king–jack, so you don’t have total control of any suit. In a contract of 3 no trump without a spade stopper in dummy, you could be set by more than one with a spade lead.

So, you’re trying to find a fit. If your partner has two hearts, she should just close out in four hearts. As it happened, because your partner had four cards in your second suit, she supported it by bidding 5 clubs. You know by that that your partner has four clubs because she can’t support your second suit without at least four cards in it. With the strength of your hand and your partner’s initial positive response by bidding a new suit, you should probably bid 6 clubs and try for the slam. (Slam bidding is covered in [Chapter 18](#).)

Here’s how the bidding actually went.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
2 ♥	P	3 ♦	P
4 ♣	P	5 ♣	P
6 ♣	P	P	P

Partner’s hand:

♠ Q83
♥ Q
♦ KQ954
♣ J532

Initially, that looks like a pretty weak 10 HCP, with only one king and no aces. But when you have opened with a two demand, your partner’s honors become much more

powerful. If she has 10 HCP and you open with a two demand, she knows that you must be in game and should be thinking about slam.

Remember, when you bid a new suit—4 clubs—your partner is forced to make another bid. If she had only three clubs but had two hearts, she should probably just bid 4 hearts. But because she had four clubs, she could support your second suit.

After she has shown you a positive response with her initial bid of 3 diamonds, you are well within your rights to make a try for 6 clubs, a small slam. You have 26 points and she has given you a positive response.

Following is the layout of all the hands and how it was played. Again, I suggest you lay the hands out and play it yourself and see how you do.

Dummy

♠ Q83

♥ Q

♦ KQ954

♣ J532

LHO

♠ J10962

♥ 9754

♦ J2

♣ 94

RHO

♠ K754

♥ 106

♦ 10863

♣ Q76

You

♠ A

♥ AKJ832

♦ A7

♣ AK108

Here is the play. L means that card led; ★ means that card won the trick.

	LHO	Dummy	RHO	You
1.	J ♠ L	3 ♠	7 ♠	A ♠*
2.	7 ♥	Q ♥*	6 ♥	2 ♥L
3.	4 ♣	J ♣ L	Q ♣	K ♣*
4.	9 ♣	2 ♣	6 ♣	A ♣*L
5.	6 ♠	3 ♣	7 ♣	10 ♣*L
6.	4 ♥	8 ♠	10 ♥	A ♥*L
7.	5 ♥	Q ♠	3 ♦	K ♥*L
8.	9 ♥	4 ♦	6 ♦	J ♥*L
9.	2 ♦	5 ♦	8 ♦	8 ♥*L
10.	J ♦	9 ♦	4 ♠	3 ♥*L
11.	9 ♠	K ♦ *	10 ♦	7 ♦ L
12.	10 ♠	Q ♦ L	5 ♠	A ♦ *
13.	J ♠	5 ♣	K ♠	8 ♣*L

Because the queen of clubs is favorably positioned and because your partner has the singleton queen of hearts, it makes seven. This is a slam that should be bid, even though you are playing in a 4–4 fit in a minor suit at the 6 level. You get more points by playing a minor-suit slam than a major-suit game.

Rebids by Strong Two-Club Opener

There are only a few possibilities for responses you'll get from your strong opening of 2 clubs. The most common response you'll get—more than 90 percent of the time, actually—is that your partner will bid 2 diamonds, a waiting bid.

What did 2 diamonds tell you? Did you say, “Nothing, Idiot, it was a waiting bid”? If so, go to the corner and put on the dunce cap.

Although it's true that 2 diamonds is a waiting bid in response to a strong opening of 2 clubs, it most definitely tells you something. One of the great things about bridge is that it teaches you to draw inferences from things. This is a good example. You're

saying, “Well, 2 diamonds is a waiting bid, isn’t it? It’s just keeping the bidding open and asking partner to describe her hand further; isn’t that correct?”

Sure, that’s correct. But don’t forget that responder has choices. Although 2 diamonds is the most common response to a Strong Two-club opening, it is not her *only* bid. Remember I said that if responder has a good five-card suit she should bid it? Well, if she bids 2 diamonds in response to your 2 clubs open, what does that tell you about her hand? It tells you that she does *not* have a good five-card she wants to bid. Isn’t that good information for you? Of course it is.

Further Distribution Description

So, the first thing you want to do now is to tell your partner what kind of distribution you have in your hand. Did you open a balanced hand with 22-plus points? Or did you open a hand that has strong clubs? If you opened the former, you rebid 2 no trump.

Making Sure Your Partner Doesn’t Pass Out Too Soon

One thing with which you must concern yourself is the possibility of your partner passing you before you get to your contract. When you open a Strong Two-club bid, you must prepare yourself for what your partner is going to do when you make a rebid. So this gets to the questions of how you bid your hand, and can you bid anything other than a 2 level bid when your partner responds 2 diamonds.

Allowing Your Partner to Quit at the Right Time

If you have opened up a balanced 22- to 24-point hand, you know that you need *something* from your partner to make game—even in no trump—because your points are just not enough. Although it’s rare to hold a Yarborough (4-3-3-3 distribution and no card higher than a 9) when you have at least 22 HCP in your hand, there is a much greater possibility of your partner having a Yarborough than if you open up a hand with 15 HCP or less.

You don’t want to be in game if you don’t have it. That’s the purpose of the no trump rebid. It tells your partner that she has the right to pass if she thinks there isn’t game

between you.

No Trump Rebids

When you rebid 2 no trump, it's like opening no trump. It means *systems are on*.

(*Systems on* means that when you make a no trump bid that's not an opening bid, you're still playing the normal responses that come after a no trump opening, like Stayman, so your partner can bid Stayman to find out if you have a four-card major.)

If you open 2 clubs, your partner responds 2 diamonds, and you bid 2 no trump, and your partner bids 3 clubs, she's asking if you have a four-card major. When you rebid 2 no trump, you are once again making her the captain of the team and leaving it up to her where you play the contract. You are, in effect, inviting her to bid Stayman, if she can. If she doesn't, that tells you something about her hand. When you rebid 2 no trump, she must then evaluate her hand as if you had opened 2 no trump but with a minimum of 22 points instead of 20 to 21 points. This means that systems are on.

Respecting Your Partner's Opinion

When you open up 1 no trump, you have a good hand: 15 to 17 points. But you've learned that when you do this you appoint your partner captain of your hand. You surrender power to her, even though you probably have the better hand of the two of you.

This isn't so difficult to do with a 15- to 17-point hand. But when you have a hand containing 22 points or more, it's much harder to pay attention to what your partner is telling you. You have more than half the points in the deck. You've got the power. Your partner is sitting over there with virtually nothing. Who is she to tell you what to do?

Ah, but you need her because she could have the few points you desperately need for game. And she could very well have a Yarborough or close to one. You must listen to her and respect what she tells you. If you have a balanced hand and have less than 25

points, you need her advice and opinion. You need her help. So, you tell her what you have and listen to what she says she has. If the points she tells you she has in her hand don't total game when added to yours, pass it out at the lowest level possible.

Rebids by Responder

The second part of this chapter focuses on how a responder rebids. When it comes time for you to make your first rebid as responder you have heard your partner bid twice, so you should have a much better idea of how many points she has in her hand and what her suits are. It's up to you to make some decisions.

Partner Opens a Minor, You Bid a Major, and Opener Supports You

The bidding goes, for example, 1 diamond—1 heart—2 hearts. What do you do? A very specific series of bids defines your response:

- + If you, as responder, have four hearts and 10 points or fewer, pass.
- + If you have four hearts and 11 to 12 points, bid 2 no trump. If your partner is at the top of her bid (at least 14 HCP), she goes to game. If she has 13 or fewer points, she closes out in three hearts. This bid of 2 no trump is a very limited bid. It tells your partner specifically the hand you hold. It says nothing about playing the hand in no trump. It is inviting one of two bids: either 3 hearts or 4 hearts.
- + If you have four hearts and 13 to 15 points, bid game (4 hearts).
- + If you have five hearts and 10 points, bid 3 hearts.
- + If you have five hearts and 11 to 12 points, bid game (4 hearts).

This is a standard bid, but my experience is that very few players use it. If you use it you must have a firm understanding with your partner about what the bids mean. But you will find that you will arrive at the correct contract much more often than others who get these types of hands. Look at the following hands when your partner opened 1 diamond, you responded 1 spade, and your partner rebid 2 spades:

1. ♠ A1043
♥ KQ7
♦ J87
♣ 963

2. ♠ A10432
♥ K73
♦ Q105
♣ 105

3. ♠ A1043
♥ K32
♦ K73
♣ J104

4. ♠ A1043
♥ 1043
♦ KQ7
♣ A83

Hand 1: Pass. You have 10 points and four spades. Even if your partner has a maximum hand at 15 points, you don't have enough for game unless you're lucky.

Hand 2: 3 spades. This describes your hand specifically. You have 10 points and five spades. It invites your partner to bid four spades if she's at the top of her bid.

Hand 3: 2 no trump. This also describes your hand specifically. You have 11 to 12 points and four spades. You are asking your partner to bid 3 spades if she has 13 points, 4 spades if she has 14 or more. She can't pass 2 no trump unless she violated your partnership agreement and supported you with only three spades.

Hand 4: 4 spades. Don't get excited and think about slam just because you both have opening hands and a major-suit trump fit. Your partner has told you that she has a minimum hand by her simple raise of your major-suit bid. You have a 4–4 fit and probably a maximum of 29 points. Forget slam and be content with a fairly safe game.

New Minor Forcing

Your partner opens with 1 of a minor suit and you bid a major. Your partner rebids 1 no trump. What do you bid with this hand?

♠ KJ874
♥ 87
♦ AJ8
♣ Q104

- + 2 spades is too weak a bid, and you shouldn't rebid a five-card suit. Opener will pass it most of the time, and that might cause you to miss a game, or be playing in a 5–2 fit.
- + 3 spades is too strong a bid. If your partner has a minimum with only two spades, you could be too high.

So, how can you tell partner you have a five-card spade suit so that if she has three spades (she's already denied that she has four spades by bidding 1NT), you may find your eight-card major-suit fit? A good solution is called *New Minor Forcing* (NMF). It works this way:

- + If your partner rebids 1 no trump, and you have a five-card major with invitational values, you can bid 2 of the unbid minor suit. If the bidding started with 1 heart–pass–1 spade, you have to use 2 clubs as your asking bid.

Your bid promises at least invitational values (10 HCP and a five-card major), and leaves it open that you have more. Your main intent with the NMF bid is to find out whether your partner has a fit for your major.

If your partner has three-card support, she bids 2 of your major with a minimum and 3 of your major with a maximum. If she doesn't have a fit, she shows 4 of the other major if she has it. If she cannot bid a major, she bids 2 no trump with a minimum and 3 no trump with a maximum.

Quiz

Now you're ready to take the following quiz.

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
1 ♦	P	1 ♠	P
1NT	P	?	
1. ♠ J10874 ♥ 32 ♦ QJ7 ♣ KJ8	2. ♠ AQ874 ♥ Q73 ♦ 73 ♣ K73	3. ♠ K10874 ♥ AK ♦ K873 ♣ 98	4. ♠ J9874 ♥ 109764 ♦ A3 ♣ 9

Hand 1: Pass. You have a balanced hand with too few points to worry about game. It's quite acceptable to forget about the spades.

Hand 2: 2 clubs, New Minor Forcing (NMF). You have enough points to invite game. If your partner bids 2 spades, you know she has a minimum opening with three spades;

if she bids 3 spades, you know she has a maximum opening with three spades. You will go to game if she shows a maximum. If she bids 2 diamonds, denying a major holding, or 2 hearts, showing four hearts but denying three spades, you will bid 2 no trump. She can go on to 3 no trump with a maximum.

Hand 3: 2 clubs, NMF. You have game points but want to check whether 4 spades is the right game or 3 no trump. She cannot pass your 2C bid even if she has five of them because your bid is conventional; you might be terribly short in clubs. That's why it's called "New Minor FORCING!"

Hand 4: 2 hearts. This is a rare situation. This is just about the only auction where responder can bid a new suit that doesn't force opener to bid again. This auction occurs when your partner rebids 1 no trump and you are able to show spades and then hearts. You are allowed to bid 1 spade and then 2 hearts when you have five spades and four or five hearts and less than 10 HCP.

Often, players are tempted to use NMF with less than invitational hands. Don't succumb to this temptation, because by making a NMF bid you are promising your partner specific values. If you make it without them, you don't know what your partner is going to do. She might have a big hand and take you to a game or slam, relying on your bid, when you don't belong there.

If your partner has opened 1 club instead of 1 diamond, the NMF bid would be diamonds rather than clubs. That's why it's called "new" minor. You bid the unbid minor suit to show your hand. However, if the bidding goes 1 club–1 diamond–1 no trump, the NMF bid is 2 clubs, even though your partner has bid it. That's terribly ambiguous (are you supporting clubs or telling partner you have five diamonds?), but that's the way it is.

Captaincy

When it comes time for you to make a rebid as responder, you have the advantage of having a lot of information at your fingertips. You know much more about the

potential of your hands than your partner. Your partner's opening bid, as you remember, just got the ball rolling, and probably described a hand that has between 12 points and 21 points (unless she opened no trump).

Your response, unless it was a limit raise or a jump, just told her that you had at least 6 points and a minimum number of cards in the suit you bid.

By her rebid, she described her hand much more specifically to you. She should have told you whether or not she had a minimum, or more, and given you a good indication of her distribution.

At this point you have so much information that you're in control of the hand. It's up to you to tell her whether you want to play in a partscore, a game, or try for a slam.

Opener Shows a Minimum Without Supporting Your Suit

If you make a bid in response to your partner's opening bid, you will basically have one of several types of hands:

6 to 9 points, a minimum. If you're at the bottom of your range—6 to 7 points—you should pass any response by your partner that doesn't force you to bid again. If you're at the middle or upper range of your bid—8 to 9 points—you can give her another bid if she encourages it. Under no circumstances do you have the flexibility to pass a forcing bid, like a reverse. But if the bidding goes like this ...

Partner

1 ♦

2 ♣

You

1 ♥

?

... your partner is describing a minimum to medium opening and is telling you to take your pick between diamonds and clubs. If you feel clubs is a better contract, pass. If you like diamonds, then bid 2 diamonds. Your bid of 2 diamonds is pretty much a drop-dead bid to your partner, and tells her that you don't have much but that you

prefer she play the hand in diamonds rather than clubs. You shouldn't have to worry about her bidding on.

10 to 12 points. This is a good hand with game potential. So, you must be certain that your first response is one that doesn't allow your partner to pass. You can't respond 1 no trump or make a simple one-over-one raise of her suit, because those bids describe minimum hands that invite a pass. Your rebid will be something that tells your partner that you're interested in game and doesn't invite a pass. For instance, if you were to rebid your suit at the 2 level, you would be telling her that you had a minimum hand, didn't like either of her two suits, and were satisfied playing it in your suit at the 2 level. A rebid of your suit would not describe a hand of 10 to 12 points, but would, rather, invite your partner to pass.

13 points or more. This is a hand that you know you want to play in game; therefore, you must make a forcing bid on your partner, either by jumping or bidding game yourself, so that she may not pass short of a bid of game. You have to tell her your strength now because it must be decided whether or not you will be satisfied just playing in game or whether you want to try for slam.

With these as guidelines, refer to the chart later in this chapter showing how to respond to opener's second bid after you have a better idea of what opener's hand is like.

Consider the following auction.

<u>Partner</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♦	1 ♥
2 ♣	?

Partner	You
1 ♦	1 ♥
2 ♣	?

How do you bid the following hands?

1. ♠ K74	2. ♠ K74	3. ♠ K74	4. ♠ K74	5. ♠ KJ74
♥ QJ743	♥ KQ8643	♥ KJ86	♥ KJ863	♥ KJ86
♦ Q74	♦ 74	♦ 87	♦ 87	♦ Q82
♣ 72	♣ 84	♣ J832	♣ 862	♣ J10

Hand 1: 2 diamonds. Your partner has asked you to choose between diamonds and clubs and you like diamonds better because you have three, headed by an honor.

Hand 2: 2 hearts. You have a minimum hand with a six-card suit. You don't like diamonds or clubs especially. Because you have six hearts headed by two of the top three honors, you prefer to try playing in the major at the 2 level. Whatever your partner does next—unless it's a forcing bid, which is unlikely given her minimum rebid in clubs—you're telling her you're going to pass.

Hand 3: Pass. You have minimum, but your clubs are clearly better than your diamonds. Better to play in 2 clubs. Any other bid would mislead your partner into thinking you are stronger than you are. You shouldn't raise clubs just because you have four of them. Your hand is too minimum.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. Your hand is very minimum. It's possible that your partner is 4–4 in diamonds and clubs (or 5–5, or 5–4, or 4–5), but you should assume that she has five diamonds, anyway; it would be better to play a 5–2 fit in her opening suit than a 4–3 fit in her second suit. When in doubt, when partner gives you a choice between two suits, it's generally preferable to pick her first-bid suit.

Hand 5: 2 no trump. You have 11 HCP and good body cards. Two no trump promises your partner that you have the unbid suit—spades—stopped, and tells her that you have more than a minimum. It invites her to bid game if she has anything but a bare minimum.

The following table shows how to respond to opener's second bid after you have a better idea of what opener's hand is like, assuming that opener did not make a forcing second bid.

Opener	Your Hand	Your Rebid
12–14 points	6–9	Pass.
		Support partner's suit at the 2 level.
		Rebid your good six-card suit at the 2 level.
	10–12	2 no trump, if balanced.
		Support partner's suit at the 3 level or bid your six-card suit at the 3 level.
	13+	Bid game in a suit in which you have a fit or 3 no trump.
15–18 points	6–7	Bid a new suit, forcing partner to bid.
		Pass as soon as possible!
		Support partner's suit with a simple raise.
	8–9	Rebid your suit if it has six cards in it.
		Bid game in a suit in which you have a fit or 3 no trump.
	10+	Bid a new suit, forcing partner to bid.
19+ points	6–7	Support partner's suit if possible.
		Rebid a suit in which you have a fit.
		Rebid your own six-card or longer suit.
		Bid no trump at the lowest level available.
	8+	Bid no trump at the lowest level available.
		Support partner's suit.
		Rebid a suit in which you have a fit.
		Jump to 3 no trump.
		Bid a new suit forcing partner to bid.

These bids are based on simple arithmetic. In the bids where your minimum hand and your partner's minimum hand show that you have enough points for game, you must either bid the game or make a bid that forces your partner to bid again. However, when you add your points to your partner's minimum hand and don't get enough for game, you have to let her decide by giving her the information on your hand. At that point you make an invitational bid to her, which tells her that you're above your minimum and if she is also above her minimum you should be in game, but it's up to her to bid it. She knows that if you had a hand that, when added to her minimum hand, would make game, you would either bid game or make a forcing bid. So, if you make a bid that allows her to pass, you're telling her that your hand, when added to her minimum hand, will not make game.

Let's look at some hands.

1. ♠ 10

♥ 8

♦ AQ10754

♣ K10863

2. ♠ A9872

♥ A4

♦ QJ76

♣ AQ

3. ♠ 8652

♥ KJ73

♦ 73

♣ A43

4. ♠ K8

♥ Q9875

♦ Q72

♣ J105

Hand 1 Bidding:

Partner

1 ♥

2 ♠ ?

You

1 ♦

Hand 1: 3 clubs. You have 13 points with a very distributional hand. Rather than rebid your six-card diamond suit, it's better to mention your five-card club suit at the 3 level to show your partner your strength and distribution. Your partner—who has reversed, showing at least 17 points—may not pass a new suit by responder at the 3 level.

Hand 2 Bidding:

Partner

1 ♣

2 ♠ ?

You

1 ♠

Hand 2: 3 diamonds. You've already established a trump fit in a major suit: spades. So, your bid of 3 diamonds is at least game invitational and forcing on your partner to bid again. When you, as responder, rebid a new suit after establishing a fit in a major suit, it means that you have a better than minimum hand and you should consider game, at least. When you have a major-suit fit, there's no reason to bid a new minor suit unless it's to tell your partner something about your hand. Here you have 17 points and are sniffing for slam. Your bid of a new suit is forcing on your partner to bid again.

Hand 3 Bidding:

Partner

1 ♦

2 ♣

You

1 ♥

?

Hand 3: Pass. You have a minimum. Your partner doesn't have four spades or she would have bid them. She must have a distributional hand or she would have bid 1 no trump. You have the *ace third* of her second suit. (Any card followed by a number, like third or fourth, means that you have that card plus that number of cards in the suit. So, ace third means that you have Axx in the suit, king fourth means that you have Kxxx in the suit, etc.) You can't get hurt too much in two clubs and it can't be much worse than two diamonds, even if she is 6–4 in diamonds and clubs. She's basically asking you to take your pick between clubs and diamonds. If you had three little clubs you should take her back to diamonds, because that was her first suit and she probably has at least five of them. But because you have the ace of clubs with two others, I'd leave her in two clubs.

Hand 4 Bidding:

Partner

1 ♦

1 ♠ ?

You

1 ♦ ♥

Hand 4: 1 no trump. Your five-card heart suit is too weak to rebid at the 2 level and your hand is too weak to go to the 2 level without a more encouraging bid from your partner. You know that your partner doesn't have five spades or she would have opened 1 spade, so you don't want to leave her in a 4–2 fit. One no trump describes your hand well here: weak and fairly balanced. This is a bid that says that you might have a little more than the minimum, but not much more, and allows your partner to pass.

Finally, if you are playing Strong Twos, a 2 diamond, 2 heart, or 2 spade opening bid begins a game-forcing auction if responder doesn't bid 2 no trump. After a 2 no trump response, responder must keep bidding as long as the opener bids a new suit. If opener rebids opening suit or 3 no trump, responder may pass.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 18

Slam Bidding

I’ve alluded to slams before. Essentially, *slam* occurs when you bid a contract to take either all tricks but one, which is a *small slam*, or all tricks, which is a *grand slam*. So, to make small slam, you must make a contract to take 12 of the 13 tricks, and then actually do so; to make grand slam, you must make a contract to take all 13 tricks, and do so. This chapter explains how to evaluate your hand for slam and how to bid to slam.

Points Needed for Slam

You look for slam through arithmetic. Basically, the points required for slam are as follows:

Small slam	33 points
Grand slam	37 points

The bonuses involved are wonderful. They are as follows.

Bid	Not Vulnerable	Vulnerable
Small slam	500	750
Grand slam	1,000	1,500

Clearly, these are significant bonuses. The question is, can you make it? This is especially important when you’re vulnerable because if you have a vulnerable game that can’t be defeated, you’re risking at least 600 points to try for the slam.

Two Ways of Looking for Slam

There are two basic ways to explore the specific cards in your hands to see if you can make a slam: One is by the use of Blackwood, which is a way to find out how many aces partner has. A second way to explore for slam is through the use of cue-bids. I cover both of these techniques later in this chapter.

The vast majority of rubber bridge players use Blackwood. If you were to try to use a cue-bid with the average rubber bridge player, however, you’d feel like a pair of brown

shoes at a party for tuxedos.

But before you get to Blackwood, you need to communicate with your partner to see whether the hand has the potential for the use of Blackwood.

Identifying Slam Potential

When you count up the points in your hand and find that you have an opening hand and then you hear your loving partner open the bidding, you will generally think, “Hmmm. I’ve got an opening hand. She does, too. Maybe we have slam!”

Not so fast. Two opening hands only equal 26 points, just enough for a game in a major suit or no trump. You shouldn’t start thinking slam until your partner jumps the bidding.

A jump bid always indicates extra values. So, if one partner opens and responder jumps, that’s when you start thinking about slam. If one partner opens, the other partner responds, and opener jumps, responder may start thinking about slam if she has an opening hand herself.

This is the theory behind jump responses. They make your partner aware that you not only have most of the points between you and her, but that at least one of you has extra values. This alerts her to the fact that you think that game is well within your reach and that you should explore the possibility of slam.

Analysis by Opener When Responder Jumps

If your partner just makes a standard response showing a minimum hand, like responding 2 diamonds over your 1 spade opening, you aren’t thinking slam. It’s when she does something other than a standard bid that your gray cells get working.

If your partner jumps the bidding, she’s showing you a specific number of points in her hand. So, remember what a jump means:

	You	Partner	Meaning
Hand 1	1 ♥	2NT	13–15 HCP, balanced hand, stoppers in the three unbid suits, denies four spades.
Hand 2	1 ♥	3NT	16–18 HCP, balanced hand, stoppers in the three unbid suits, denies four spades.
Hand 3	1 ♥	2 ♠	16 or more points, five spades, game forcing, looking for slam, does <i>not</i> deny three or four hearts, could be totally unbalanced.

Let's say you open a 13- to 15-point hand with a bid of 1 heart. How should you respond to your partner's jump bids set forth above?

Hand 1: 3 no trump. You have a maximum of 30 points between you two. That's not enough for slam, even if you're at the top of your bid.

Hand 2: If you have your minimum, or bottom, of your bid—13 or 14 points—you should pass. However, if you have 15 points (the top of your bid) you should continue, probably with a quantitative bid of 4 no trump, asking your partner if she's at the top or bottom of her bid. You'll learn about quantitative bids shortly in this chapter.

Hand 3: If you're at the bottom of your bid and have three spades in your hand, bid 4 spades. This is a minimum response that denies slam interest, but shows three-card support. Your partner's minimum hand is 16 points. She could have more. So, you must describe your hand so that she can evaluate slam potential. If you're at the top of your bid, you should either bid 3 spades or bid a new suit if you have one with some power.

When your partner makes a game-forcing bid at a level where you can bid her suit short of game, if you jump the bidding to bid game directly, it's a weak bid, showing no slam interest. When she makes a jump shift to 2 spades, your bid of 4 spades directly shows weakness. If you were to bid 3 spades, you would be telling her that you have a good hand and it would be an invitation to slam.

Why? Because the bid she makes requires you to keep the bidding open to game. It allows you to communicate with one another without fear of either of you passing short of game. If you make a jump bid to game, you're telling her that you don't have

anything further to tell her and you're not much interested in anything she might want to tell you. If you make a bid in her suit short of game, you're telling her that you want to hear more about her hand.

If you have more than a minimum opening and responder jumps to anything other than 2 no trump or a limit raise, you clearly should explore for slam. Your more than minimum opening would show a hand of 16-plus points. Any other jump by your partner would indicate that you probably have enough points for slam and you should proceed by going to Blackwood (described later in this chapter). Take a look at the following hand you hold in first seat—a minimum hand that you open 1 club:

♠ 654
♥ A4
♦ K4
♣ KQ6432

Following are your responses to various bids by your partner after you open this hand at 1 club:

Partner	You	Meaning
2NT	3NT	Your partner is showing 13–15 HCP; you have 12 HCP, enough for game. Plus you have a nice six-card club suit. Slam shouldn't even enter your mind because your partner has limited her hand. If, however, you are playing and that partner's 2NT shows 11–12 HCP as many modern players do, you probably don't have enough for game and should pass.
3NT	P	Again, your partner has limited her hand to a maximum of 18 HCP. Add your 12 to that and you get 30, not enough for slam.
2 ♦	3 ♣	You are conveying to her that you have a minimum. She's shown five diamonds and at least 16 points, but you must tell her that your hand is a minimum with a long club suit as its best feature. Now it's up to her to evaluate further.

Following are you and your partner's actual hands:

You

♠ 654
♥ A4
♦ K4
♣ KQ6432

Partner

♠ A10
♥ K2
♦ AQJ86
♣ AJ85

She has 19 HCP and 21 total points. Added to your 14 points, that's 35 points and a club slam is cold. But that's up to your partner to determine after you've told her your hand is minimum and you have a club suit.

Analysis by Responder When Opener Shows Extra Values

The other way you can find slam is when you give your partner a standard response and she reverses or jumps the bidding, showing extra values.

To refresh your memory, your partner opens 1 of a suit, you respond, and your partner reverses or jumps. Opener's bids mean the following:

Opener's Second Bid	Meaning
2NT	18–19 points, all unbid suits stopped
3NT	20–21 points, all unbid suits stopped
Reverse	17-plus points
Jump shift	19–22 points

Again, your responses are based on simple arithmetic. If your response was a minimum 6- to 9-point hand, here's how you should respond:

Opener's Jump Bid	Your Response
2NT	Pass if 6 points. For balanced 7-plus points, you should bid 3 no trump because you should have a game, given your partner's promised minimum of 18 points.
3NT	Pass. You don't have slam because your partner has a maximum of 21 and you have a maximum of 9. That's only 30 points, not enough for slam.
Reverse	If the bidding is passed to you by your RHO, you <i>must</i> make another bid. A reverse is forcing on you for one round. Either rebid your five-card suit, support the suit of your partner that you can, or bid no trump to deny support for both of your partner's suits and to indicate a weak hand.
Jump shift	A jump shift is forcing to game so you must continue bidding if your RHO passes until you have bid to the game level. If your hand stinks, just make the weakest bid you can, supporting your partner's suit for which you have the best support or rebid your own suit if it's adequate.

Blackwood: The Easiest Convention of All

If both you and your partner have communicated to each other that you have good hands, the thought will start to germinate that maybe you can bid and make slam. So far, however, you've just been communicating how many points each of you has in your hand and how many cards you have in the trump suit.

When you start to consider slam, you start to realize that you need to know exactly what cards each of you has, and, specifically, how many aces and kings in which suits.

This is where Blackwood comes into play.

Blackwood is very simple. When your partner bids 4 no trump, she's asking one question: How many aces do you have in your hand? You tell her by bidding suits, as follows:

<u>Bid</u>	<u>Number of Aces</u>
5 ♣	0 or 4
5 ♦	1
5 ♥	2
5 ♠	3

Is that easy, or what?

If your partner then bids 5 no trump, she's telling you that you and she hold all four aces, and she's asking you how many kings you have. Let me elaborate:

- + **She's telling you that you and she hold all four aces.** This is an absolute promise. After bidding 4 no trump asking for aces, she should not bid 5 no trump asking for kings if your pair is lacking one ace. So, if you respond, for example, 5 diamonds (telling her that you have one ace) and she comes back with 5 no trump (asking for kings), you should be able to take it to the bank that she has the other three aces in her hand.
- + **She's asking you how many kings you have.** You answer in exactly the same manner as you answered for aces, only you're up 1 level.

<u>Bid</u>	<u>Number of Kings</u>
6 ♣	0 or 4
6 ♦	1
6 ♥	2
6 ♠	3

Some people play that 5NT asks for specific kings rather than the number of kings. So, if partner bids 5NT while in Blackwood and you have the spade king, your response is “five spades.” This is a bid that is played by a minority of players.

That’s Blackwood. When she has your answers to her questions, she places the contract. If she places the contract somewhere, you should accept her decision and pass. For example, if you agreed that trump is spades and she bids 4 no trump after you bid 4 spades, let’s say you respond 5 diamonds, showing one ace. She then bids 5 spades. She’s saying, “Okay, partner, you’ve told me your holding and we don’t have enough, so let’s just play it in five spades.” You should pass. She knows more about your two hands than you do. You should trust her.

When You Shouldn’t Use Blackwood

Blackwood is a terrific convention if your slam depends on the location of all the aces. But there are two instances when you shouldn’t use Blackwood.

The first is when the bidding has been opened in 1 or 2 no trump. Look at the following bidding:

<u>You</u>	<u>Partner</u>
1NT	4NT

A bid of 4 no trump here would not be ace-asking. When a hand is opened 1 no trump and you look like you’re going to play it in no trump, a bid of 4 no trump is called a *quantitative bid* which means that it is natural, limited, and nonforcing.

In this instance, 4 no trump is quantitative because it isn’t conventional; that is, it doesn’t ask for aces. What, you may be inquiring, is it asking? Good question.

Obviously, there must be some meaning to it, because 3 no trump is game and bidder has bypassed 3 no trump. What it's asking is simple. In this bidding sequence—or any sequence when the bidder goes from any no trump bid directly to 4 no trump—bidder is asking partner to go to slam (6 no trump) if she's at the top of her bid, and to pass if she's not at the top of her bid.

In this situation, you've shown your partner that you have a balanced 15- to 17-HCP hand. She probably has 15-16 HCP herself. So, she's asking you whether you opened a 15-point hand or a 17-point hand. Because 32 HCP should be very close to making a small slam, she's just saying to you, "If you have 17 HCP or a good 16-HCP hand, go to 6 no trump. If you have 15 HCP or a bad 16-HCP hand, pass and we'll play it in 4 no trump." Again, it's just arithmetic.

The second situation in which you shouldn't use Blackwood is if you have a void in your hand and don't need that ace for slam. If you have two aces and a void in your hand, what good does it do to discover that your partner has one ace? If it's the ace in which you have a void, it won't do you any good at all. So, if you have a distributional hand with a singleton or void, you should examine slam potential through the use of cue-bids, which I discuss later in this chapter.

How to Get Out of Blackwood

Sometimes you get in Blackwood and discover that you don't want to be in slam but you want to play the contract in 5 no trump. Look at the following bidding sequence where your partner has only one spade and two aces:

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♣	P	2 ♥	P
3 ♣	P	3 ♥	P
4 ♣	P	4NT	P
5 ♦	P	?	

After your 5 diamond bid she wants to play it in 5 no trump. But if she bids 5 no trump directly you will think she's telling you that you have all the aces between you

and is asking for kings. How can she get it so you can play in 5 no trump?

The answer is to bid the unbid suit. In this situation she would bid 5 spades. This says nothing about spades. It merely asks you to bid 5 no trump, which she will pass.

So, the rule is this: If you're in Blackwood and want to play the contract in 5 no trump, bid the unbid suit, asking your partner to bid 5 no trump. This is obviously a tactic that can only be used by the player who first bid 4 no trump.

Gerber

Gerber is a variation on Blackwood that allows you to ask for aces at a lower level than 4NT. Gerber uses a bid of 4C to ask for aces. When you have agreed on trump and are not cue-bidding, a bid of 4C could be Gerber (I say "could be" because Gerber is such an ambiguous bid that even experts get confused about whether 4C is a cue-bid, a suit, or Gerber). Generally speaking, however, a bid of 4C after you have agreed on trump is often Gerber. If you play Gerber make sure that this is the agreement of which your partner is aware. The reason is that if it is not Gerber, it is probably a cue-bid showing first round control of clubs. So, you must know what systems you are playing so that you don't have this misunderstanding.

If you are using Gerber, the responses are similar to Blackwood:

<u>Bid</u>	<u>Number of Aces</u>
4 ♦	0 or 4
4 ♥	1
4 ♠	2
4NT	3

After that, a bid of 5C asks for kings and the responses are similar.

<u>Bid</u>	<u>Number of Kings</u>
5 ♦	0 or 4
5 ♥	1
5 ♠	2
5NT	3

Quantitative v. Qualitative

When you play Gerber, and your partner opens 1NT, if you have 15-16 HCP and no four-card major with a balanced hand, you jump to 4NT. That is called *quantitative*. That means if opener is at the top of her 15-17 HCP hand bid, she should bid 6NT. If she has 15-16 HCP, she passes 4NT. This is because a Gerber 4C bid is available to ask for aces.

If you have 15-17 HCP with a four-card major and partner opens 1NT, you bid Stayman. If partner bids your four-card major, a jump to 4C is Stayman, confirming that you also have the same four-card major and are asking for aces.

If, on the other hand, partner bids either 2D, denying a four-card major, or 2 of the major that you do not have, a jump to 4NT is quantitative, not ace-asking.

Similarly, if you are playing Gerber and partner opens 1NT and you agree on a suit, a bid of 4C would be Gerber so a bid of 4NT would be quantitative, asking partner to go to six of the agreed-upon trump if at the top of her bid or to just bid game if not at the top of her bid.

Because Gerber is so often ambiguous, I often only play it as a jump from 1NT or 2NT. If after either of those bids a bid of 4C is made, that's Gerber. If 4C is bid after any other bid by partner, it's not Gerber. This is important because often when you play Gerber without that understanding and jump to 4NT, partner thinks it's quantitative, and is justified in so thinking. But you are asking for aces! If you play that Gerber only applies if 4C is bid directly after a jump from 1NT or 2NT, then this misunderstanding is avoided because a jump to 4NT from anything but 1NT or 2NT is ace-asking, not quantitative.

Roman Key Card Blackwood

Blackwood does have a drawback, which the following hand illustrates. You have the West hand and are lucky to hear your partner open with 1 diamond. You bid 1 spade and your partner raises to 2 spades. Depending on what your partner has, you may be able to take as many as 13 tricks. So, you ask for aces and your partner bids 5 diamonds, showing one. What now?

West

♠ AQ763

♥ 4

♦ K2

♣ AKJ10103

East

♠ 10842

♥ AKQ10

♦ QJ83

The player holding this hand bid 6 spades and found that it was too high. The defenders took their ace of diamonds, and even though the spade finesse worked, declarer lost a trick when South had the KJ9 of spades. Bad slam.

A new version of Blackwood addresses problems like this one. It is called *Roman Key Card Blackwood* or *3014*. It works like this: Instead of the 4 no trump bid asking responder for aces, it asks responder how many key cards he has. A *key card* is defined as any of the four aces and the king of trumps; there are a total of five key cards. Here are the responses to 4 no trump:

- + 5 clubs: shows 0 or 3 key cards
- + 5 diamonds: shows 1 or 4 key cards
- + 5 hearts: shows 2 key cards without the queen of trumps
- + 5 spades: shows 2 key cards with the queen of trumps

If your bidding hasn't established a trump suit, then the last bid suit is treated as the trump suit in responding to 4 no trump. For example, if the bidding has gone ...

North

1 ♠

3 ♦

East

P

P

South

2 ♥

4NT

West

P

P

North responds as if diamonds is trump, so the key cards are the four aces and the king of diamonds. If, on the other hand, you have agreed on trump, like 1 spade–pass–3 spades–pass–4 no trump, trump is, obviously, spades, and the key cards are the four aces and the king of spades.

In the previous hand in which West bid to slam and went down, East would bid 5 diamonds, showing one key card. West would know that two key cards were missing and would stop at 5 spades.

When responder bids 5 hearts or 5 spades, the 4 no trump bidder knows about every important card, including the queen of trumps.

When responder bids 5 clubs or 5 diamonds, the 4 no trump bidder isn't sure about the queen of trumps. If she wishes to learn more, she can do so by making the cheapest available bid that's not 5 of the trump suit:

1 ♥

4NT

?

3 ♥

5 ♣

In this case, the bid that asks for the queen of trumps is 5 diamonds. Responder bids as follows:

- + If she doesn't have the queen of trumps, she returns to the trump suit as cheaply as possible. In this case, she would bid 5 hearts.
- + If she does have the queen of trumps, and no other kings, she bids 5 no trump. Otherwise, she bids 6 of the suit, in which she has the king, if that king is lower ranking than the trump suit. If she has the queen of trumps and a king that is higher ranking than trump, she bids 5 no trump and lies about having a king.

Roman Key Card Blackwood is a good convention that isn't widely used yet. If you want to play this convention, be very sure that you have talked about it. Here's one part of the convention that you must follow: Never bid 4 no trump unless your partner knows what suit is trump. A sensible rule to follow is that if you have a fit, that's the

trump suit. If you don't yet have a fit, the trump suit for the purposes of Roman Key Card Blackwood is the last-bid suit. You don't want to ask for key cards thinking hearts is trump and have your partner thinking clubs is trump.

1430

A variation on Roman Key Card Blackwood is 1430. This just switches the responses for 5C and 5D. In 1430, a response of 5C shows one or four key cards and a response of 5D shows zero or three key cards. The purpose for this is that with the stronger response, one or four key cards, at the lower or club level it gives room to ask for the queen by bidding 5D. This is particularly helpful if your trump is hearts. If you play RKC, or 3014, and you bid 5D showing one or four key cards, if you bid the next suit, that's your trump suit and partner would figure you were signing off.

Personally, I prefer 3014 because if you are in a diamond slam, the weaker bid of 5C allows you to sign off in 5D or pass if clubs is your trump suit. If you're playing 1430 and clubs is your trump suit, you really can't ask for the queen because the weak bid bypasses 5C, which is where you probably want to play if you don't have the queen. But a lot of the pros prefer 1430.

Blackwood and Interference

There are two methods of dealing with interference. In the first, if your partner bids Blackwood and your RHO bids a suit, you use a convention called *D0PI* (Double = Zero, Pass = One). If you don't have any aces, you double. If you have one ace, you pass.

So, look at the following two hands:

1. ♠ KQ109
♥ QJ10
♦ 983
♣ QJ9

2. ♠ AQ109
♥ QJ10
♦ 983
♣ QJ9

Your partner has bid 4 no trump, but before you can bid you hear your RHO bid 5 hearts. What do you do?

Hand 1: Double. That tells your partner that you have no aces. It says nothing about your ability to defend and set a contract of 5 hearts by opponents. Your partner won't take this as a penalty double and will just bid her hand as she sees fit, knowing that you don't have any aces.

Hand 2: Pass. This tells your partner that you have one ace. There's no chance of the hand being passed out because your partner still has another chance to bid since her LHO bid.

The second method of dealing with interference by your RHO after your partner has bid 4 no trump asking for aces is to just bid up the line starting with the next available bid. So, in the preceding example, where your RHO bid 5 hearts, a bid of 5 spades by you would say you had no aces. Because it's the next available bid, it would be equivalent to your bidding 5 clubs. If you had one ace, you'd bid 5 no trump. You indicate two aces by bidding 6 clubs. Well, you get the picture. Frankly, I don't like this method because it gets you too high and it precludes your partner from asking for kings with 5 no trump. But it's a method of which you should be aware.

Cue-Bids

The Official Encyclopedia of Bridge (Truscott, Executive Editor, 1994) defines a cue-bid as “a forcing bid in a suit in which the bidder cannot wish to play.” The most easily understood cue-bid is a bid of opponent's suit. Few rubber bridge players use cue-bids. If you were to throw one into your bidding, probably everybody at the table would think you had lost it. In this section, I explain how cue-bidding can be used as a substitute for Blackwood to find out what specific cards partner may hold or to tell partner specific cards you hold.

After trump is established, many people use the convention that a bid of another suit indicates that you have first round control of that suit, with either an ace or a void in

your hand. This doesn't require that you bid opponents' suit. Look at the following bidding:

<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>
1 ♠	P	3 ♠	P
4 ♣	P	4 ♦	

You have already agreed on trump. Your partner's bid of 4 clubs is a slam try, probably telling you that she has a good club suit and asking you to describe your hand further. Your 4 diamonds bid tells her that you either have first round control of diamonds—either the ace of diamonds or a void in diamonds—or a diamonds unbid suit after you have agreed upon a trump suit. Clearly you aren't going to introduce diamonds as a possible trump suit after you've agreed that spades—a major—is going to be trump; so a cue-bid doesn't necessarily have to be a bid of opponents' suit.

There are other types of cue-bids. One of their big advantages is that they force your partner to bid, because she can't pass you out in a bid of opponents' suit or a previously unbid suit after an agreement on another suit as trump. But it can be dangerous unless you have a firm partnership agreement and an understanding about what your cue-bid means.

Making Responder Captain

Look at your hand:

♠ QJ643
♥ 95
♦ 9
♣ AQJ85

Here's how the bidding went:

<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
P	1 ♣	1 ♦	1 ♠
2 ♦	4 ♠	P	?

By this time, you should know what your partner's bid means. Do you remember? Is it a sign-off, or something else?

If you remember what you learned in [Chapter 16](#), you know that this bid by your partner shows a 20-point hand. Why? Because you are only promising her 6 points with your bid. If you have a four-card spade suit and 6 points, you can bid 1 spade to show that you have at least 6 points and at least four spades. But your partner jumps to game! She can only do that if she adds up all the points and determines that from your minimum bid she can make game. And the only way she could make that determination is if she has enough points in her hand to make game. You showed at least 6. So, she must have 20 points in her hand to make this bid. What do you do?

What you do *not* do with this hand is meekly pass. You have 13 points. She has 20 points. $13 + 20 = 33$. How many points do you need for a small slam? 33. How many points do you have? 33. Should you pass your partner's 4 spades bid?

You have two alternatives: One is just to bid 6 spades. The other is to bid Blackwood. Blackwood is the best option because you might be missing at least two aces, in which case you don't want to bid six. You need to find out how many aces your partner has. If she only has one, you don't want to be in slam. Following is your partner's hand:

♠ A1092
♥ AK8
♦ A
♣ K7632

If you passed four spades and laid down your hand, which is cold for six, you won't be able to find a closet far enough away to hide. (It makes seven because the king of spades is *onside*. A card is placed so that if you take a *finesse*, the finesse will be successful. A finesse occurs when you take advantage of a higher-ranking card in your opponents' hand; see [Chapter 22](#) for details.)

Following is a layout of all four hands:

North (You)

♠ QJ643

♥ 95

♦ 9

♣ AQJ85

West

♠ 75

♥ 107642

♦ KQ10842

♣ Void

East

♠ K8

♥ QJ3

♦ J7653

♣ 1094

South (Partner)

♠ A1092

♥ AK8

♦ A

♣ K7632

So, when your partner makes a bid like this, jumping to game after you've made a minimum response, she's not saying, "Pass, partner, I want to play this in game and that's why I bid game." No, she's saying, "I've got a big hand. I want to be sure we play in game because with your minimum bid I have enough in my hand to make game. If you have more than your minimum bid, bid on. Maybe we have slam."

In essence, she's making you the captain of the team again, because you know a lot more about her hand than she knows about yours.

A Slam Try When Your Partner Preempts

What if you look at a huge hand and hear your partner open a preemptive bid? Look at the following hand after you hear your partner open up with a bid of 4 spades:

♠ A

♥ K1032

♦ KQ965

♣ K54

Wow! You were getting ready to open 1 diamond and then reverse into 2 hearts. And you hear your loving partner open the bidding with 4 spades! Are you sniffing slam? You bet you are.

But hold on a minute. What's your partner telling you when she opens the bidding with 4 spades? She's virtually yelling at you, "Partner, my hand is *weak!*" She's got *less* than a minimum opening hand. Does that change your orientation? It should.

Clearly, your bid here is pass. Sure, you have 15 HCP and 17 points if you count your singleton ace. But the singleton ace is in your partner's trump suit. So, even though it's nice that you have the ace of trump, the fact that it's a singleton doesn't make your hand any better at all. In fact, it makes it worse.

Furthermore, your heart suit is pretty weak. If your LHO has the ace, your king isn't worth much. And your club suit only has one trick.

Even if the vulnerability is unfavorable—which would mean that your partner was overbidding her hand by only two tricks—you only have three quick tricks in your hand: the ace of spades, the king–queen of diamonds, and Kxxx and Kxx in hearts and clubs (each is a half quick trick). If that's the case, you might make one overtrick. Pass.

As it was, you were wise to pass. Here's your partner's hand, followed by your hand:

Partner

♠ K10876532

♥ 94

♦ A7

♣ 9

You

♠ A

♥ K1032

♦ KQ965

♣ K54

You lose a club and a heart, maybe two depending on the location of the ace, even with a 2–2 trump split (where each of your opponents holds two trump), which is only a 40 percent chance. Never forget: When your partner preempts, she has a weak hand, even if she's preempting in game.

Investigating for the Correct Slam

When your partner opens and you have a huge hand, you're going to be tempted to jump the bidding immediately to tell your partner and the world that you have a terrific hand. You don't need to do this.

If you know you have a preponderance of the points in the hand, it's much better to proceed slowly so that you can communicate with each other to determine the correct contract. Jumping the bidding squeezes you and takes away bidding space you might need. Look at the following hand after your partner opens the bidding with 1 club:

♠ AK65
♥ AK96
♦ AQ6
♣ KJ

That's a 24-HCP hand, and your partner has opened? You're going to have to be tied down to keep from jumping—nay, leaping! But you don't need to leap or even jump. Your correct bid is 1 heart!

You might be thinking, “One heart? Are you kidding? I've got 24 HCP, my partner opens the bidding, and I just show her a minimum 6-point hand? Are you nuts?”

No, I'm not nuts. Remember that your 1 heart bid is 100 percent forcing on your partner to bid again. You want to find out what she has. Does she have four hearts? Does she have four spades? What does she have? If you jump to something like 3 no trump, for example, how is she going to respond? As long as you make a bid that forces her to bid again, you've done what you want to do. You want to find out about her hand at the lowest level so you know whether you're going to play this hand in clubs, hearts, spades, or no trump. A jump to 3 no trump does *not* force your partner to bid again. Keep in mind that any bid of a new suit by responder is 100 percent forcing on opener to bid again for one round.

So, you bid 1 heart and your partner responds 1 no trump. What do you do?

Now you know what you want to know. Your partner doesn't have four hearts or she would have supported you. Your partner doesn't have four spades or she would have bid 1 spade. Your partner has a balanced hand with no voids or singletons. She has shown 13 points and you have 24 HCP. That's 37 points, enough for a grand slam. You should bid 7 no trump immediately. There's nothing more you need to know.

Maybe you won't make 7 no trump every time with this hand, but you've got the points for it and should bid it. The key to the hand is that you kept your head and didn't jump. You made a forcing bid at the lowest level possible, then determined the correct contract and bid it.

Just remember this rule: *A one-over-one bid* (bidding a suit at the 1 level after your partner has bid a different suit at the 1 level) by responder to partner's opening bid is 100 percent forcing on partner to bid again.

One Way to Invite Slam

Here's your hand sitting South and the auction:

♠ A2
♥ QJ1075432
♦ 9
♣ AK

Bidding:

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
		1NT	P
2♦*	P	2♥	P
?			

**Transfer to hearts*

You've got 3 quick tricks, 14 HCP, 8 hearts, and only 4 losers, a hand with which you could open a strong 2C, and your partner opens 1NT! How do you search for slam? All you want to know is if your partner has the ace or king of hearts. If you jump to

Blackwood, that won't do you any good. Regardless of whether or not you are playing standard or Roman Key Card or 1430, partner's response showing only one ace or key card leaves you in the dark. You only need to know if she has the ace or king of hearts. You just have to trust and assume that her bid includes the ace of diamonds.

So, Blackwood is an imperfect response. So are bids of 3 hearts, which would only be invitational and may be passed, or 4 hearts, which is a closeout unless you play Texas Transfers. And even if you play Texas Transfers (1NT-4D is a transfer to 4 hearts, etc.), there's no way partner can visualize your hand with its eight-card heart suit.

(To digress, people who play Texas Transfers often use the bid of 1NT-2D-2H-4H as showing a stronger hand than 1NT-4D-4H.)

But there is a bid I use in such situations. South would bid 5H after partner accepts the transfer by bidding 2H! What does that mean? Some experts play a jump like this to five of a major as a "Grand Slam Force" with special meanings to all the responses, but that's too complex for what I'm suggesting here. The way I use it with my partners is that a jump to 5 of the agreed major suit (which bypasses game and Blackwood) in this situation asks partner, "How good are your trumps?" Because partner promises at least two hearts with her opening bid of 1NT, if she has two small hearts, she passes. While the question is ambiguous (how "good" is good?), one needs to use common sense in responding. If, however, my partner made this bid and I had the ace or the king, I would bid 6 hearts.

This hand came up in a three table Swiss Teams game and neither table got to the slam because nobody knew this bid. Here are the four hands:

North

♠ KQ84

♥ K9

♦ AQJ107

♣ Q10

West

♠ J10953

♥ A6

♦ K842

♣ J8

East

♠ 76

♥ 8

♦ 653

♣ 976432

South

♠ A2

♥ QJ1075432

♦ 9

♣ AK

Since North had K9 in hearts (along with the spade king and diamond ace, which were no surprise with her 1NT open), she should bid 6, which was cold. This is a bid that you should discuss with your partners and add to your repertoire.

Knowing When Not to Bid Slam

Just as important as finding the proper slam is knowing when you shouldn't bid slam. Staying out of improper slams is probably more difficult than finding the right slam and bidding it. Look at this hand after your partner opens 1 club:

♠ AQ75

♥ KQ73

♦ AQ62

♣ 8

That's 17 HCP. What do you bid? Again, you want to make the lowest bid you can make that forces your partner to bid again. So, you bid the lowest ranking of your three four-card suits: 1 diamond. Your partner responds 1 no trump. What now? Do you have slam?

Your partner has told you that she has a balanced hand that is no more than minimum. Her maximum holding is 14 points. You have 17 HCP. In no trump, your singleton isn't worth anything. Your partner doesn't have four hearts or four spades or she would have bid them. That's the end of the story. You have a maximum of 32 points and that's not enough for slam. Bid 3 no trump, a bid that is a sign-off, and play it there.

Frank Stewart, one of the best bridge writers and players around, gives a good rule that you should follow for any bidding, but especially when considering slams: If you are considering a contract and partner must have just the right cards, forget it!

Sometimes your partner will have a hand that results in your taking all but one trick. But you must trust your arithmetic. If your points don't add up, don't try to project something into your partner's hand that you don't know is there. Don't bid speculative slams.

Deceptive Bidding

Sometimes you lie to everybody. When you really trust your partner, you can fool your opponents and lure them into a foolish double or a foolish act. But it requires total confidence in your partner. Look at the following bidding.

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
2 ♠ (1)	P	2NT (2)	P
3 ♥ (3)	P	3 ♠ (4)	P
4 ♣ (5)	P	4 ♠ (6)	P
5 ♦ (7)	P	5 ♥ (8)	P
6 ♦ (9)	P	6 ♠ (10)	P
7NT Redouble	Dbl	P	P

Here's what it means:

1. I have a huge hand. Keep the bidding open.
2. My hand stinks. Please let me pass.
3. I have a huge hand. Do you prefer hearts or spades? Please bid again.

4. Spades. Please, please, let me pass.
5. Not yet. We have now agreed that spades will be trump. However, I also have the ace of clubs. Do you have any aces you want to bid? Please bid again.
6. No, all I have is minimal support in spades. Please. Let's play this here. My hand is awful.
7. Not yet. I also have the ace of diamonds, at least a first-round stopper. How do you like them apples? Please bid again.
8. I got plenty of nothin'! I hope this will put an end to this foolishness! My hand is terrible. However, I do have minimal support in hearts. Because I have to bid, and because you already know about my spades, I thought I might as well mention it here.
9. Thanks. That's nice to know. Not so fast; I not only have the ace of diamonds, I also have the king of diamonds. Because we've agreed that spades is going to be trump and I'm bidding diamonds, I want you to bid again. I want to hear more.
10. Okay, my spades are better than my hearts and my whole hand stinks. Stop while we have the chance.

Responder's hand was the following:

♠ 8642
♥ Q83
♦ 7632
♣ 64

Seven no trump? Look at declarer's hand:

♠ A
♥ AK
♦ AK
♣ AKQ98754

Declarer never bid clubs as a suit, which was his real suit. He knew he had 7 no trump cold from the start. But he went through the bidding process hoping he could get a double of 7 no trump. If he had just opened at 7 no trump it would have been passed out. But from the bidding, where it looked like his two suits were spades and hearts, he

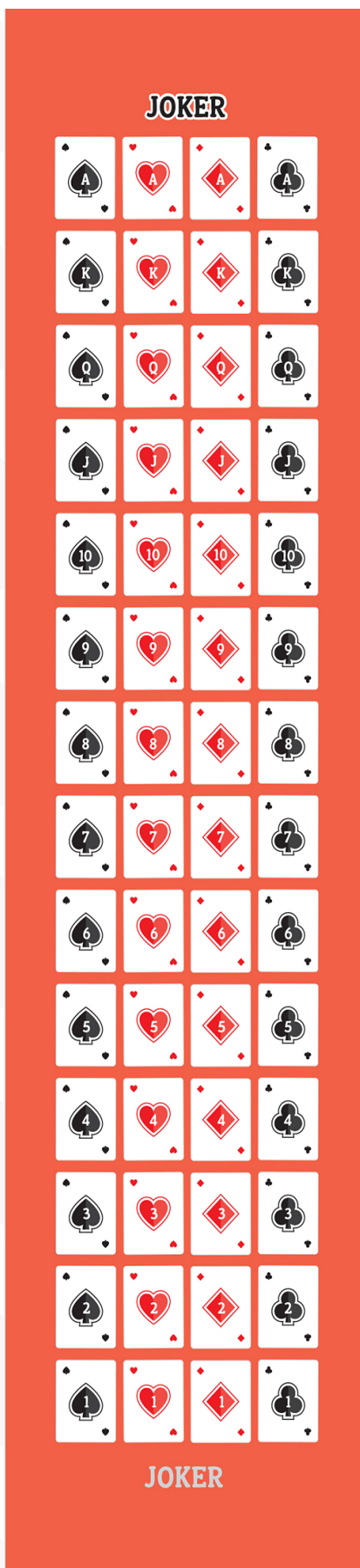
whetted the appetite of his opponents and sucked them into a double of a cold, cold 7 no trump contract. Just because a contract is doubled, doesn't mean that the bidding is ended. If you are so confident that you can make the contract, you can redouble. Redoubling doubles the bonus points you get if you make it. But it also doubles the bonus points for your opponents if you don't make it!

The point of this exercise isn't that it's okay to lie to your partner. On the contrary, you should *not* lie to your partner. The point of this exercise is that both partners had such wonderful trust in one another that they complied with their agreements and continued to bid.

Declarer could bid all these false suits in the sublime confidence that he was in total control of the hand because he trusted his partner to continue bidding and not take some unilateral action to pass him out in one of his one- or two-card suits. He didn't care what his partner had. All the bidding was to create a false impression on opponents. He knew he was in control, that his partner would keep bidding so long as he demanded another bid, and that the final contract was going to be 7 no trump; regardless of the cards held by his partner and regardless of his partner's responses.

And his partner trusted declarer to know what he was doing and continued to bid despite the abysmal cards he held. The result was an awful lot of points. Seven no trump doubled and redoubled is the most you can make offensively in bridge if you are vulnerable.

Generally speaking, you need 33 points for a small slam and 37 points for a grand slam. In Blackwood, a bid of 4 no trump asks partner to respond with the number of aces in her hand. Partner responds to Blackwood by bidding 5C with zero or four aces, 5D with one ace, 5H with two aces, and 5S with three aces. Don't bid a slam if your partner must have specific cards for you to make it.



Chapter 19

Overcalls and Takeout Doubles

Up until now we've been talking about how you open the bidding or respond when your partner opens the bidding. But half the time your opponents open the bidding, and you're in the position of overcalling your opponents' opening bid. An overcall is a bid by either partner after an opponent has opened the bidding. This chapter discusses what you need to overcall and how you do it. It also explains what a takeout double is and how you do that.

Why Overcall?

When opponents open the bidding, you know that at least one person at the table is sitting there with a pretty good hand, and it's not your loving partner. So, when should you overcall, and, a better question, why?

Because we know that you need 12 points to open the bidding and there are 40 total HCP in the hand, that leaves a maximum of 28 points, plus some distribution points, spread among the three other players. If you subtract the points in your hand from that 28, it tells you approximately how many points you can expect from the other two players.

If you have 12 points, that's 24 total points accounted for. This means that there are approximately 16 points left to be distributed between your LHO and your partner. To make game in no trump you need 25 points. You have 12. That means that your partner must have 13 of the 16 remaining points for you to make game.

All this leads up to the question, why overcall? If you can't make game, why say anything?

There are four reasons:

- + **You might make game.** You have to tell your partner what you have. You know what the possibilities and the probabilities are. What you don't know are the *facts*. Tell her what you have and let her tell you what she has. The way to do that is to make an overcall within the parameters upon which you and your partner have agreed.

- + **You might make a partscore.** Don't just roll over and play dead because you think your opponents might have better hands than you and your partner. If you have a bid, make it. You and your partner might be able to make 3 diamonds, for instance. If your opponents can make 2 hearts, but not 3 hearts, you should bid to 3 diamonds. If they bid to 3 hearts and you set them, you score points that you wouldn't have made had you not overcalled.
- + **You tell your partner something about your hand to help her defend the contract if your opponents win the auction.** Without your bid, she has no clue as to what's in your hand and she will probably assume you don't have much. With an overcall at the 1 level you tell her what your preferred suit is and that you have at least 8 points.
- + **You crowd the bidding a little for your opponents.** If they open 1 club and you can overcall one spade with an 8-point hand and five spades, it means that they will have to go to the 2 level to communicate, and that might be difficult.

With those reasons in mind, if you have a hand to overcall you turn the auction into a *competitive auction* (where both pairs are bidding and competing to get the contract), and that makes it more unlikely that your opponents will bid to game than if you were not competing with them.

Suit-Length Requirements

Back when I was on the beginning side of the learning curve, my RHO opened 1 heart and I overcalled 2 clubs with a 10-point hand and a five-card suit. We were vulnerable and the bidding went pass—pass—double—pass—pass—pass. I was down two for a terrible result.

After the hand, my LHO, Arlen O'Hara (who has since become one of my partners), knew that I was relatively new to the game, so she gave me some advice. "I never," she said, "overcall at the 2 level unless I have an opening hand or a six-card suit."

Her strategy sounded good to me, so I adopted it. I called it *Arlen's Rule*. I played by Arlen's Rule for a while, until I learned more specific point and suit-length

requirements for overcalls, which you'll learn shortly. It kept me out of a lot of trouble.

The first question you ask yourself is: how long must my suit be to overcall, regardless of how many points I have in my hand? Answer: *You must have at least a five-card suit to make an overcall.* Look at the following hand, when your RHO opens 1 club:

♠ KQ86
♥ K83
♦ KQ98
♣ 87

Not a bad hand. You have 13 HCP, 14 total points. This is a hand you would clearly open 1 diamond. But your RHO opened 1 club. Can you overcall 1 diamond or 1 spade? Not in this lifetime, you shouldn't. When you overcall, you *promise* your partner you have five cards in the suit you bid. It doesn't matter that you're only bidding at the 1 level. Overcalling isn't like responding to your partner's opening bid. It's more like making an opening bid. But you don't have the luxury of being able to open a three-card minor when you only have a four-card major. So, when you make an overcall you must have five cards, at least, in the suit you bid.

This is a very instructive hand because it illustrates a principle that you should never forget. When your LHO opens the bidding, just because your partner passes doesn't say that she has a bad hand. She just might not be able to bid what she has. In such an event, she will be counting on you to balance, which I explain later in this chapter.

So, your partner's failure to overcall by passing doesn't make her a *passed hand*. A passed hand is one that is below the requirements to open the bidding. If you fail to open you are a passed hand. If you fail to overcall, you're not a passed hand because you might have a hand you could have opened, but not one that you could overcall.

Point Requirements

The point requirements for overcalling are straightforward. You may overcall in accordance with the following rules.

To overcall at the 1 level ...

- + You should have no less than 8 points and no more than 16 points. This is flexible and varies according to your partnership agreement. For example, some people play 7 to 17.

To overcall at the 2 level ...

- + With a five-card suit, you should have no less than 11 points and no more than 16 points.
- + With a six-card suit, you may overcall at the 2 level if you have at least 10 points.

If you overcall at the 1 level with an 8-point hand, however, you should have a very good suit. It would not be wise to bid a poor five-card suit with only 8 points. Look at the following two hands:

1. ♠ J10984

♥ A87

♦ K83

♣ 73

2. ♠ AK1084

♥ J98

♦ 873

♣ 73

Hand 1: What's the point of overcalling one spade? You have 9 points, but your spade suit is terrible. If your partner is on lead, she's going to trust you and lead a spade, even though she might have a better lead in her hand (maybe she has the KQx of hearts and would normally lead the king of hearts). You would be misleading your partner and making a big mistake.

Hand 2: You have a wonderful spade suit. So, even if your partner doesn't have spade support and the opponents get the contract, you want your partner to lead spades so you can cash your two-spade tricks. Further, if your partner has a doubleton, you might get your two-spade tricks plus allowing your partner to ruff the third spade. So, in Hand 2 you have every right to overcall 1 spade.

Let's look at some more hands after your RHO opened the bidding at 1 heart as dealer:

1. ♠ A10964	2. ♣ A863	3. ♥ K983	4. ♥ QJ976	5. ♥ K983
♥ Q4	♥ KQ5	♥ 7	♥ J6	♥ 7
♦ AQ93	♦ 83	♦ 1074	♦ 1097	♦ Q74
♣ 32	♣ A873	♣ KQJ52	♣ AJ4	♣ KJ752

Hand 1: 1 spade. This is a clear hand. You would open it. It's got a five-card major. You have 14 points. No problem.

Hand 2: Pass. You shouldn't make a takeout double this hand because, as you will learn later in this chapter, a double promises tolerance for all unbid suits. You can't tolerate a diamond bid.

Hand 3: 2 clubs. This is a minimum hand to overcall at the 2 level. You have 11 points and five clubs. Your club suit is good enough to serve as a *lead directing call* (a bid made for the main purpose of telling partner what suit to lead if you're defending and she has the opening lead) if your partner is on lead. If vulnerable you should probably pass.

Hand 4: Pass. You have 10 points, but a weak spade suit. Really the only trick you have in your hand is the ace of clubs. Forget it. At equal or unfavorable vulnerability, pass and let your partner carry the ball. With favorable vulnerability, overcall 1 spade.

Hand 5: Pass. This hand is identical to Hand 3 except that your club suit lacks the queen and your diamond suit has the queen; the points are identical. But you should pass this because your club suit isn't strong enough and isn't good enough to serve as lead directing for your partner.

Now look at the following hand after RHO opened the bidding at 1 spade as dealer, and you are vulnerable:

♠
♥ K109873
♦ J98
♣ KJ84

What do you do?

Pass. Remember, on this hand, RHO opened 1 spade. This is a shot in the dark. Against good players the bidding could go as follows.

<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
1 ♠	2 ♥	P	P
Dbf	P	P	P

Result? Down two for 500 points above the line for the bad guys. Even though you have 11 points and six hearts, your heart suit is far too weak to overcall at the 2 level vulnerable (or even nonvulnerable, unless your opponents are vulnerable). Based on the bidding you're going to get the sinking suspicion that the hearts are sitting behind you (in other words, in the hands of the opponent who plays immediately after you) and that you're going to get killed. This is a hand that mediocre players often rush in where good players fear to tread. In the *direct seat* (the seat immediately to the left of the opening bidder) you must always take into consideration the possibility of this type of bidding, to which we have referred earlier, the reopening double. To overcall at the 2 level without opening-hand values, you must have control of your trump suit.

Bridge authority Charles Goren gives a very good rule: *Don't overcall at the 2 level unless you can promise you will not lose more than two trump tricks.* You should adopt that rule. This hand doesn't promise that, even though it has six trump, including two honors.

Second-Position Overcalls

If dealer opens and you're in second position, your overcalls should be disciplined. The reason is that your partner's hand is undefined. If you overcall with a weak hand—8 points—and she's sitting there looking at a 12-point hand, she's going to be thinking game. So, in second seat you shouldn't overcall, even at the 1 level, unless you have at least 10 points. Look at the following hand after dealer, your RHO, opens 1 spade:

♠ 3
♥ AK9863
♦ J96
♣ 832

Like your hearts? You have six of them. And a singleton spade. Are you tempted to overcall 2 hearts? I don't blame you. I know a lot of people who would. Now take a look at your LHO's hand:

♠ J74
♥ QJ1074
♦ Q85
♣ 97

Your RHO opened 1 spade so you know that he has an opening hand. How do you think you're going to fare in two hearts with all those hearts sitting behind you? If you're up against savvy opponents, this is how the bidding will go.

<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
1 ♠	2 ♥	P	P
Db1	P	P	P

You'll probably be set two or three and your partner will be seething. This is the danger of overcalling on a good long suit with nothing else. The two hands behind you are unknown. If you're lucky, your partner will have the holding shown above in your LHO's hand. But there's at least as good a chance that it will be your opponent and you'll be in for a long, long hand.

However, look at the next hand after your RHO opens 1 club as dealer:

♠ 73
♥ QJ106543
♦ A
♣ 1052

What do you think? This is a seven-card suit, but it's not as good a suit as the six-card suit led by the ace-king. The answer is that you have 10 points and long, long suit, and you should overcall 1 heart.

Third-Position Overcalls

You can be more aggressive when you're in third position. You've already heard from your partner and she's passed, telling you that she doesn't have an opening hand. (Remember, when you're in third seat, your partner is the dealer and opening bidder.) You need have no fear that if you bid, her eyes will light up and immediately think of game. It's here that you can bid your 8-point hand with the good suit. This bid tells her, "Partner, I have a nice suit. If you can support it, let me know and we will compete. If you can't support it, this is the suit you should lead if you are on lead."

Additionally, in third position you're in a perfect spot to try to foul up your opponents' communication. So, you have three incentives to make an overcall in third position:

- + Tell your partner you have a good hand, good suit, or both.
- + Give your partner a lead direction.
- + Interfere with opponents' communication.

Fourth-Position Overcalls

You can be aggressive here, too. In fourth position both your partner and one of your opponents have passed. However, it matters who opened the bidding. If dealer opened and your partner passed, she could have a good hand that she couldn't overcall. So, she will be relying on you to make a bid. I'll talk about this shortly when I discuss balancing.

If your RHO opened the bidding in third seat, you know that both your LHO and your partner don't have opening hands. If you bid, you'll be interfering with your LHO's ability to respond to his partner's opening bid. This is another situation where you have an incentive to interfere even though you have a weak hand. This is especially true if you can elevate the level of bidding so that your LHO will be forced to respond at the 2 level. For instance, if your RHO opens 1 diamond and you can overcall 1 spade, it makes it difficult for your RHO to tell his partner he has four hearts with a minimum 6-point hand. If you can overcall 2 clubs it's even better, because that eliminates your LHO's ability to communicate any four-card major he might have to his partner at the 1 level.

No Trump Overcalls

If your RHO opens the bidding and you overcall 1 no trump, it's the same as opening the bidding with 1 no trump. A 1 no trump overcall generally shows 15 to 18 HCP, no voids or singletons, and no more than two doubletons. This is only true if you are in the direct seat (immediately to the left of the opening bidder).

Balancing Calls

A *balancing call*, also called a *balancing bid*, is a bid or takeout double made to keep the bidding open after opponents have opened. It is only made in the *passout seat*, which is the seat immediately to the right of the opening bidder after two passes. So, an overcall in the balancing seat could be a bid to keep the bidding open for one of two reasons:

- + You don't want to let opponents play the hand at a low level.
- + You're protecting your partner in the event she was forced to pass what might be an opening hand because her RHO opened before she could bid.

Determining When to Make a Balancing Call

Look at your partner's hand:

♠ KQ8
♥ K85
♦ KQ98
♣ 873

This is your partner's hand (referred to earlier in this chapter) when her RHO opened the bidding with 1 club. She shouldn't bid, but she has 13 points. She is relying on you to balance if the bidding is passed around to you. If you don't have a five-card suit to bid yourself then you can make a takeout double, which I explain later in this chapter. This doesn't say much about your hand. But you know that your RHO (opener's partner) can't have more than 5 points in his hand or he would have been forced to respond when your partner passed. So, you count the points in your hand, add 5 to it, add 14 to that, subtract that from 40, and you come up with a reasonable expectation of what your partner has in her hand. Take a look at your hand:

♠ A9532

♥ 763

♦ J3

♣ K92

The bidding has gone 1 club—pass—pass to you. What do you do? Following is the way you can fairly reliably determine where the points are in this hand:

You 8 points. You know this for sure because you can see them and count them.

RHO A maximum of 5 points. He passed after your partner passed. If he had 6 points he would have bid.

LHO Probably 14 points. He opened the bidding at 1 of a suit. It's possible he's got a big hand—17 points or more—and is just waiting to jump or reverse, but that occurs less frequently. You can feel fairly certain that he's got a maximum of 14.

Total $8 + 5 + 14 = 27$

Partner $40 - 27 = 13$

That's 13 points in your partner's hand. What does that mean? That means you and your partner have the preponderance of the points. You shouldn't let opponents play this in 1 club unless your partner is sitting there with a lot of clubs.

So, what you do is bid your five-card suit, even though your hand is minimal and your suit isn't great. You know that your partner's hand is going to be a source of some tricks for you, even if she only has two spades, so you aren't taking much risk in bidding a weak five-card suit when you know your RHO has garbage. You aren't selling out at the 1 level when you and your partner have 22 points between you. Moreover, you're protecting your partner. When you bid with this kind of hand in the passout seat, you give your partner the confidence to pass her 14-point hand without a five-card suit when her RHO opens the bidding because she knows she can rely on you to balance to protect her.

Balancing No Trump Overcalls

When your LHO is dealer and opens the bidding and it's passed around to you in fourth seat, your no trump overcall is different than if you make it in the direct seat. As you remember, if you make a 1 no trump overcall in the direct seat, you're promising a

standard 15- to 17-point hand that you would have opened 1 no trump had you been the opening bidder.

But when you're in the passout seat, your no trump overcall can be made with three less HCP in your hand. In the passout seat, your bid of 1 no trump promises 12 to 14 HCP, not 15 to 17.

Overcalling Opponents' Opening Bid of 1 No Trump

If your RHO opens 1 no trump, you know that at least 15 HCP are in his hand. But if you have an opening hand, too, and a good five-card suit, there's no reason why his 1 no trump open should intimidate you and keep you from bidding. The fact that you're sitting behind him makes your hand valuable because you're in a good position to take his high cards with your high cards.

You can overcall an opponent's opening bid of 1 no trump if you have an opening hand and a good five-card suit. If your RHO's hand is a balanced 15 HCP and his partner has a Yarborough, you and your partner have 25 HCP between you and probably some distribution points, too; you could have game. You should bid your hand, even if your opponents open with 1 no trump.

You must be absolutely certain that you and your partner are on the same wavelength on the meaning of a 1 no trump overcall in the passout seat. If she thinks you're showing 15 to 17 HCP when you only have 12 HCP in your hand, you could find yourself in a 3 no trump contract real fast, down two.

Overcalling 3 Level Preemptive Bids

When your opponents make a preemptive bid and it's your turn to bid in the direct seat, you shouldn't bid unless you have extra values. This means that if you have a mere opening hand—12–14 points without a good five-card suit—and your RHO opens 3 diamonds, you pass. You will be relying on your partner to make a balancing bid in the passout seat if it's passed around to her with a subminimum hand of 11 points.

Look at the following hands after a 3 diamonds opening by your RHO:

1. ♠ AK73	2. ♠ AK732	3. ♠ KQ4	4. ♠ KQJ732
♥ KQ83	♥ KQ8	♥ J1098	♥ 94
♦ 87	♦ 87	♦ 87	♦ 9
♣ 943	♣ J103	♣ AK86	♣ KQ84

Hand 1: Pass. You have a minimum opening hand with no five-card major. You'd ordinarily open this 1 club. If your partner doesn't have enough to make a balancing bid or double, you'll be in trouble in three of anything.

Hand 2: Pass. You have a nice five-card spade suit, but what if your LHO has a lot of spades? Do you want to start off at the 3 level with this hand? I don't. Again, it's a minimum opening hand; you don't want to start bidding with a minimum opening hand at the 3 level. Also, you can support your partner on anything she bids, if she bids. Two hands are unknown, your LHO's and your partner's. If the remaining points are evenly distributed between the two hands, it's a crapshoot whether anybody can make a three bid. In that event, I'd rather defend. Wait until you know the lay of the land, which will be after your LHO bids. If he passes, your partner will have the opportunity to bid or make a balancing double. Then you'll be able to bid more confidently.

Hand 3: Pass. This is another minimum opening hand that can support your partner if she bids. Don't go searching for a fit with minimum points unless your partner asks you to do so.

Hand 4: 3 spades. Finally, a bid! This is a good hand with which to overcall a preemptive bid. You've got a nice six-card spade suit, and nice distribution with a singleton and a doubleton. Plus, your clubs will give you at least one trick.

When you're in the passout seat, the rules change. If the bidding has gone 3 diamonds—pass—pass to you, you must protect your partner in the event that she has passed with one of the opening hands above. So, in the passout seat, you should bid with a subminimum opening hand. If you have 11 points, or 10 points with a six-card suit, you should make some sort of call; either bid a suit or double if you can support all the

unbid suits. The rules in the passout seat are that you should bid with the following minimum holdings:

- + At least 10 points and a fair six-card suit (two of the top four honors), bid your suit.
- + At least 11 points and a good five-card suit (two of the top three honors), bid the suit if you can bid it at the 3 level.
- + At least 11 points and 4-4-4-1 distribution with the singleton in the preempted suit, double. Your partner will either bid her longest suit or, if she has a good hand and at least four cards in the preemptive suit, will leave the double in for penalty.
- + At least 11 points and 4-4-3-2 distribution with the doubleton in the preemptive suit, you can double because you can support your partner in anything she bids. If she bids your three-card suit, you can pass.

There is a lot more detail about how you and your partner interact in this type of situation for overcalling Weak Twos in [Chapter 9](#).

Overcalls by a Passed Hand

What if you are dealer and the bidding goes pass—pass—pass—1 diamond. You're a passed hand. What should you do? Obviously you don't have at least 13 points or you would have made a bid.

An overcall by a passed hand shows between 8 to 12 points and a five-card suit. If you're doing it with 8 points, it should be a very good five-card suit. And if you're doing it at the 2 level, you should have a six-card suit and no less than 11 points.

Don't forget, you don't have many values in this hand because you know your partner doesn't have an opening hand, either. Making an overcall when you are both passed hands can be risky business, indeed.

Jump Overcalls

A jump overcall (like 1 club–2 hearts) shows a very big hand, more distributional than for you to overcall 1 no trump. It promises at least six cards in the suit and at least 16 points. Following is an example of a typical hand where you would want to make a jump overcall:

♠ AK10964

♥ AK6

♦ 864

♣ 7

This is a hand that is close to game with no help. If trump splits favorably and your partner has trump support, you have eight tricks.

A jump overcall requests help from your partner in outside suits. You're telling her, "Don't worry too much about my trump suit. If you have help in other suits, let's keep bidding."

If your partner has two quick tricks in outside suits, she should jump to game, even without much trump support. She can jump to game even if she only has a singleton honor in your suit. It's the cards in her hand that are outside your trump suit that you're interested in.

By now, you should be aware that rules change when you're in the balancing seat, and that's true for jump overcalls, too. If you are in the direct seat, a jump overcall is very strong. But in the balancing seat, you should have 14 to 15 points and a six-card suit in order to make a jump overcall.

That said, the modern treatment is that a jump overcall shows a weak hand, similar to a Weak Two and a weak jumpshift. If you play that, a weak jump overcall shows a suit with at least 6 cards and less than six HCP. When you play with a new partner, be sure you discuss how you treat jump overcalls. And, if an opponent makes a jump overcall, ask the overcaller's partner to explain what the jump overcall means.

Defensive Value of an Overcall

To show how valuable an overcall can be in defending a hand, look at the following, which I played recently. My RHO opened 1 heart and I held the following:

♠ 832
♥ K43
♦ AQ983
♣ A4

This is a no-sweat 2 diamonds overcall, so that's what I did. The auction went like this.

<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
1 ♥	2 ♦	2 ♠	P
3 ♥	P	3NT	P
P	P		

My partner was on lead, so she led the 10 of diamonds. Dummy came down with the following hand:

♠ Q4
♥ AQJ953
♦ J5
♣ K63

What a terrific lead by her! I had a strong suspicion that declarer had the king of diamonds with three small diamonds. He was in a terrible position because the lead—which she would have never found had it not been for my overcall—set up my hand totally. My 9 of diamonds became very powerful because she led the 10 and the jack was on the *board* (another name for the hand in dummy, which is exposed) in dummy's hand.

Declarer played low from the board. I ducked (played low, avoiding getting the lead). I was in terrific shape. He had no hope of making this hand solely because of my partner's lead. We had four cold diamond tricks because all he was going to get was his king. I had two sure entries, the ace of clubs and the king of hearts. He held up on taking his king, so my partner led her other diamond, the 6. Dummy played the jack. I covered with my queen and he was forced to take his king. I now had the two top

diamonds out: the ace and the 9. (The king, queen, jack, and 10 had all been played.) He had two diamonds left, but they would fall on my ace and 9, setting up my fifth diamond. That's four diamond tricks plus the ace of clubs and the king of hearts.

The only reason we set this hand was because my 2 diamond overcall told my partner what to lead, and she led her top diamond. The point here is to show the value of an overcall on defending the hand. My partner actually had a Yarborough, so they had 27 HCP between them. We set them because of the overcall. With any other lead they make 3 no trump easy.

Downside of Overcalling

As with anything you do in bridge, there's a downside to overcalling. You give information to your opponents that they otherwise would not have. For example, if you overcall 2 hearts over a 1 spade opening, it gives your opponents a pretty good hint as to where the hearts honors are if they play the hand. If you overcall and your partner remains silent, the honors will be marked (meaning that your opponents will know you have it) in your hand for the missing power. It will make it easier for them to play the hand.

So, while you're giving your partner information, you're giving your opponents the same information. However, it's generally worth the risk to give your partner information she can use on defense.

Takeout Doubles

Previously I have referred to a bid called a takeout double. It occurs, under partnership agreement, when one partner doubles an opponent's bid, asking partner to bid. Your partner has the option of bidding or leaving the double in for penalty if your LHO passes. You are not doubling for penalty. You are doubling to tell your partner that you have values and to ask her to describe her hand. She can't leave the double in for penalty unless she has a lot of cards in the opponents' suit.

Distribution Is More Important Than Points

Generally speaking, a takeout double at the 1 level is telling your partner that you have some values and are short in opponent's bid suit, but that you don't have the requirements to make a bid on your own. For example, you might only have a four-card major, but have an opening hand. You can't overcall on a four-card major, so if the opponents have bid the other major, you can double to tell your partner that you not only have opening or near-opening values, but you also have four cards in the unbid major.

For a normal takeout double, you must be able to support any suit your partner bids. What is *support*? Ideally it is at least four cards, but this is impractical. Sometimes you will have a 4-4-4-1 hand and your RHO will bid your one-card suit, but more often you have two four-card suits and a three-card suit. If you have sufficient HCP, you can make a takeout double with 4-4-3 in the unbid suits because if your partner bids the suit in which you have three cards you can pass and you'll only be at the 2 level. So, playing in a 4-3 fit won't be a disaster. A 4-3 fit is called a *Moysian fit*, named after Alphonse Moysie Jr., who argued in favor of opening four-card majors and raising with three-card support.

You shouldn't double for takeout if you can only support two of the unbid suits. For example, if you hold the following ...

♠ AK43
♥ 872
♦ 94
♣ KQ87

... and your RHO opens 1 heart, you have an opening hand but cannot overcall one spade because you only have four spades. It might appear to you that this is a good takeout double, but it's not because you cannot support your partner if she bids diamonds—you only have two diamonds.

Remember, your partner is forced to bid if your LHO passes your double. She must bid even if it's only a four-card suit. Sometimes, in rare but very uncomfortable

circumstances, you find yourself having to bid a three-card suit in response to your partner's takeout double. Look at the following hand:

♠ 984
♥ 943
♦ J1083
♣ 543

In the prior bidding sequence your RHO opened 1 heart; if you were to double with your four spades and four clubs but only two diamonds, if your RHO passes, your partner might bid 2 diamonds with this hand. What would you do? You'd have to pass. So, you could easily be in a terrible contract with no hope of making it. If you were against good opponents you would probably be doubled and have nowhere to run. So, remember this rule: *In order to make a takeout double you must be able to support all unbid suits.*

Following are requirements for a takeout double:

- + Shortness (no more than two cards) in suit bid by opponent
- + Support for all unbid suits
- + Minimum of 10 HCP

Doubling and Then Bidding Your Own Suit

Another use of the takeout double is to show a big hand. If you have a hand that's too big for an overcall with a good suit, the way you show it is to double whatever your opponents bid; then, regardless of what happens, you bid your suit at your second opportunity. This shows a hand bigger than the maximum hand you need for an overcall. Generally you need at least 17 points and a good five-card suit to employ this strategy.

In a nutshell, the requirements for bidding your own suit after doubling are as follows:

- + At least 17 points
- + A good five-card suit headed by three of the top five honors

Shortness in the suit bid by opponents is not a requirement for this bid.

The reason you double and then bid your suit is so that you have a way to tell your partner the size of your hand, which you can't do with an overcall. Look at the following hand:

♠ AKJ76
♥ 54
♦ A7
♣ KQ54

If your RHO bids 1 club, what are you going to do? Overcall 1 spade? Okay, but what does that tell your partner? You can overcall in this auction with a good five-card spade suit and 8 points. How does your partner know whether you're overcalling a minimum hand or a huge hand?

The answer is that there's no way she can know this unless you have a way to bid big hands in a manner different from an overcall. And that way is to double the 1 club bid first. Then bid your spade suit at your next opportunity, regardless of what your partner bid or what your opponents bid. Your hand is strong enough to bid your spades up to the 3 level. You could have game if your partner has the following minimum hand and if the spades are properly positioned:

♠ 432
♥ 862
♦ 10983
♣ A76

If you were to overcall 1 spade, your partner would undoubtedly pass. Whereas if you've told her that you had a hand that contains at least 17 points, she might make a bid here after you bid your spades. And if the spades split 3-2 and your RHO has the queen of spades, you can make four spades, even with your partner's dismal hand. And it's a hand with which she'd never respond if you just overcalled 1 spade.

Let's look at some hands. Your RHO opens 1 diamond. What's your bid with the following?

1. ♠ KQ109 ♥ QJ107 ♦ 5 ♣ A863	2. ♠ KQ10 ♥ QJ107 ♦ KJ10 ♣ Q84	3. ♠ KQ106 ♥ 74 ♦ KQ106 ♣ AQ8	4. ♠ K7 ♥ QJ107 ♦ A84 ♣ KJ73
5. ♠ K7 ♥ QJ107 ♦ AQJ5 ♣ AK4	6. ♠ AKJ75 ♥ KQJ6 ♦ A8 ♣ 74		

Hand 1: Double. You can support all the unbid suits, plus you have an opening hand.

Hand 2: Pass. You have an opening hand but you shouldn't make a takeout double for a couple of reasons: First, you have too many cards in opponents' suit. Second, you have minimal support in two of the unbid suits. With these deficiencies, the fact that you have a minimum hand suggests that you pass.

Hand 3: 1 no trump. You have enough points for a no trump opener. You have the opponents' suit stopped. You have a balanced hand. A 1 no trump overcall in any seat other than the balancing seat guarantees no trump opening values and a stopper in opponents' suit.

Hand 4: Pass. You have too many diamonds and not enough spades. With a minimum hand you must have support for every unbid suit to make a takeout double.

Hand 5: Double. It is okay to make a takeout double without support for every suit as long as you have more than 16 points. If your partner bids spades (remember, she must bid something!), you will then bid no trump at the lowest possible level. This will tell your partner that you have 18 to 20 HCP, a balanced hand, and opponents' suit well stopped.

Hand 6: Double. This is a classic hand for doubling and bidding your own suit. If your partner responds to your double with a bid of 2 clubs—which is likely because you're short in that suit—you can freely bid 2 spades to show her that you have at least 17 points and a good spade suit.

Doubling RHOs Opening Bid of 1 No Trump

A double of your RHO's opening bid of 1 no trump promises your partner that you have a hand that you could have opened 1 no trump yourself: 15 to 17 HCP, no voids or singletons, and no more than two doubletons.

Two-Suited Hands

You will definitely want to learn and use two very special conventions: the Unusual No Trump overcall and the Michaels Cue-Bid. These two conventions have a lot in common, but they also have enough differences that you will want to study them separately.

Unusual No Trump

When your opponents open with 1 of a suit, there is almost no chance that you will have an opening 2 no trump bid. It is wise to use 2 no trump for something else, and the Unusual No Trump is ideal. If you ever do have 21 HCP and they open, you can make a takeout double and bid strong later. In its basic form, the Unusual No Trump bid works like this: Your RHO opens with 1 heart or 1 spade and you have a hand with 5–5 in the minors. Something like this:

♠ 3
♥ 43
♦ AQ987
♣ KQJ63

If you have the Unusual No Trump bid available, you can bid 2 no trump, which tells your partner that you have at least five cards in both minors. Because their side has an opening bid, it is unlikely that your side will be able to make many games; if your partner likes one of your suits, however, you may be able to raise the bidding fast enough that their bidding gets off track. It is also possible that you can bid 5 of a minor expecting to go down but not down so much that it's a disaster. If they can make 4 spades, vulnerable, for example, it's profitable for you to go down only 300 in 5 clubs doubled not vulnerable. This is known as *sacrificing*.

After many years of using this convention, players learned that it is useful to change the definition slightly. Instead of saying that 2 no trump shows the minors, the better definition is to say that it shows the lower two unbid suits. If they open a major, 2 no trump shows the minors; if they open, say, 1 diamond, however, the 2 no trump bid would show the two lower unbid suits, which are hearts and clubs. Used this way, you will get many additional opportunities to use this convention.

What Do You Need for an Unusual No Trump Bid?

The Unusual No Trump bid is usually used after their side opens with 1 of a suit. You can use it after the opponents have bid two suits, too. Say they have opened 1 diamond and responded with 1 spade. If you have a hand with five hearts and five clubs, the two unbid suits, you can bid 2 no trump here, too. Use caution. Many players, armed with a new convention, go off to war with it and immediately abuse it to the point that it doesn't work. You can get other viewpoints, but here are the basic minimum requirements:

- + **When you're not vulnerable.** Not less than 9 HCP, and if at the bottom of your range, you must have good suits. You can have any upper range of points, but this is the minimum.
- + **When you're vulnerable.** Generally, not less than 12 HCP; if both of your suits are good; however, you can do it with 11 HCP.

You *must* have five cards of the lower two unbid suits to use Unusual No Trump. Many players abuse the bid by using it when they're 5-4 in the two lower unbid suits. Don't succumb to the temptation to use Unusual No Trump with only four cards in one of the suits.

Keep in mind that if you make an Unusual No Trump bid, you will be pushing your partnership to at least the 3 level. If your partner doesn't like your suits, the last word on this from the opponents may be "Double." Further, if you make an Unusual No Trump bid and the opponents play the hand, they will know of your distribution and will be able to use this knowledge to play the hand very well.

Look closely at the following example; no one is vulnerable:

RHO

1 ♠

You

?

1. ♠ 83

♥ 3

♦ QJ984

♣ AQJ53

2. ♠ J

♥ K3

♦ Q8763

♣ AJ652

3. ♠ 8

♥ 9

♦ AKJ74

♣ KJ10974

4. ♠ A72

♥ --

♦ AQJ87

♣ KQJ106

Hand 1: 2 no trump. You have a minimum hand but you have good minor suits. If vulnerable, this is a pass. Having 5–5 in the minors is not, of itself, an excuse to be bidding.

Hand 2: Pass. You have poor-quality suits. Remember, if you bid with this hand, your partner will be declaring at least the 3 level. If she has a poor hand with no fit for you, someone may double and it will be costly.

Hand 3: 2 no trump. 5–5 is necessary, but 6–5 is nicer.

Hand 4: 2 no trump. Your hand is good enough that you intend to bid again.

Don't fall into the trap of making an Unusual No Trump bid and then bidding again when you don't have extra values. You need about 15 useful points to bid 2 no trump and then to consider bidding again. Of course, if your partner shows enthusiasm, you can bid again with less.

How Does Responder Bid?

When your partner makes an unusual 2 no trump bid, it is very important that responder bids what his hand is worth. Here are the basic rules:

- + **Rule 1.** If you don't have a fit, make a minimum bid unless you have a huge hand.
- + **Rule 2.** If you do have a good fit, you should be willing to do more than make a minimum bid in one of your partner's suits. If you have 10 or more points with a nice fit, you can jump to the 4 level, or you can make a free bid if your RHO has

bid something in the meantime. If you have a fit and 14 or so points, you can bid a game. Note that trying to count points isn't a perfect solution here because most of the time you're not trying to make a contract. Often you're simply trying to frustrate your opponents.

All of these themes will come up in the following example, where no one is vulnerable:

<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♠	2NT	P	?
1. ♠ Q1076 ♥ KJ7653 ♦ 2 ♣ 105	2. ♠ AJ874 ♥ 975 ♦ Q87 ♣ 84	3. ♠ 10764 ♥ AJ5 ♦ K986 ♣ J7	4. ♠ Q8763 ♥ 2 ♦ K4 ♣ Q9874

Hand 1: 3 clubs. Remember this awful hand. If you bid 2 no trump and your partner bids 3 clubs, she might have a stinker like this one. If you keep on bidding and she has this hand, there will be trouble. Note that you don't bid 3 hearts. That would show a better suit and a better hand.

Hand 2: 3 diamonds. This isn't a bad hand. You would like a fourth trump, but this is, relatively speaking, an okay hand. It isn't good enough to bid at the 4 level, but it's good enough that if your partner goes to the 4 level you will be safe.

Hand 3: 4 diamonds. This is a nice hand. Your bid of 4 diamonds shows some honest values. Your partner can bid 5 if she wishes. If East had bid 3 of a major, you would have been happy to bid 4 diamonds.

Hand 4: 5 clubs. This is a super hand. You have the king of diamonds and five clubs. It's not hard to imagine what five clubs will make.

The Unusual No Trump has many applications other than the basic one of showing the two lower unbid suits when bid over an opening bid. As you learn more about this

important convention, you will discover that you can use it on far more hands than shown here.

The Michaels Cue-Bid

The Michaels Cue-Bid is a relative of the Unusual No Trump. You use it when an opponent opens with 1 of a minor suit. If you have 5–5 in the majors, you can cue-bid 2 of opener's minor, which states that you have the major suits. The major suits are the powerhouses of bridge, and when you have both of them you can often win the bidding. This can be done by reaching a makeable contract or by causing your opponents to misjudge what they can make. Because you have the major suits and therefore the important suits, the Michaels Cue-Bid is much more important than the Unusual No Trump.

The requirements for a Michaels Cue-Bid are about the same as for the Unusual No Trump:

- + **If you're not vulnerable.** At least 5–5 in the majors and 8 HCP with the points in your suits
- + **If you're vulnerable.** At least 5–5 in the majors and 10 useful HCP

The big deal, if you are going to get good results from this convention, is that responder bids what her hand is worth. Many fine Michaels Cue-Bids go to waste because the partner doesn't bid enough. It is important that the responder to a Michaels Cue-Bid knows to bid a lot when she has a good hand. If responder fails to bid when she should, the Michaels Cue-bidder will not know when her side should be going higher or when it should get out of the auction. In a good partnership, the Michaels bidder knows that when her partner shows no interest, it is likely that she has a bad hand.

So, what would you do with the bid in the following example? Again, no one is vulnerable.

<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1 ♣	2 ♣	P	?
1. ♠ 32 ♥ 94 ♦ J10974 ♣ KQJ9	2. ♠ Q84 ♥ 82 ♦ AJ984 ♣ 743	3. ♠ QJ93 ♥ A4 ♦ Q9653 ♣ 84	4. ♠ AJ87 ♥ 2 ♦ A10874 ♣ J104
			5. ♠ 43 ♥ AQ7 ♦ 983 ♣ AJ764

Hand 1: 2 hearts. Always, when you have equal length in your partner's majors, bid hearts. The one thing you shouldn't do is bid 2 no trump. Forget about playing in no trump and try to get to a low and undoubled contract when you have a dog like this.

Hand 2: 2 spades. Remember that your partner has 5–5 in the majors. If, by some chance, your opponents bid 3 clubs, you can bid 3 spades with this hand.

Hand 3: 3 spades. A jump is invitational. It says you are interested in game. Your bid just shows around 11 support points. If RHO bid 3 clubs, you would also bid 3 spades.

Hand 4: 4 spades. Counting your distribution, you have an opening bid in support of spades. You also have four spades and you have aces and shape. It would be sad to bid just 2 or 3 with this fine a hand.

Hand 5: 3 hearts, even though you have only three of them. Your partner has five, so you know this is good enough support.

As mentioned earlier, it is important to bid Michaels when appropriate (emphasis on “when appropriate”), but you won't get much benefit if your partner doesn't cooperate with you. Here's an example of what can go wrong:

Here's your hand, sitting South:

♠ J
♥ Q
♦ AJ98652
♣ KQ98

Here's the bidding:

Auction:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
1 ♦	2 ♦	P	?

Ah, this is a puzzle. Partner has bid your seven-card suit! But it's a conventional bid, Michaels, showing two five-card majors. What to do?

This was a hand I played with my former partner, Mille Garrison, in a four section, two game event in the 1996 Palms Springs Sectional against some of the best players in the world. Millie was sitting West and I was sitting East.

In this hand, this South passed. It was the last hand of the day. We set it one trick and it gave us a top which was enough for us to win the 64 table event.

<u>North</u>			
♠ AK109654			
♥ A97643			
♣ Void			
♦ Void			
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>	
♠ 73		♠ Q82	
♥ K		♥ J10852	
♦ KQ1074		♦ 3	
♣ AJ732		♣ 10654	
<u>South</u>			
♠ J			
♥ Q			
♦ AJ98652			
♣ KQ98			

Auction:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
1 ♦	2 ♦	P	P
P			

Michaels can be dangerous. People think that if they have a two-suited hand, they should always use it. I don't agree. North misbid. There is no way that his partner could know he had a hand that was 7-6. He should overcall Millie's 1D with 1S and then jump to 4 hearts with his second bid, letting partner choose which suit. And partner, given two singleton honors, should take him back to his first suit. Other tables were playing the hand in 4 spades, making, losing a spade and two hearts. I don't know how they bid it.

If North bid Michaels, then South should bid 2 spades. But, as I said, Michaels is risky for a hand that is 7-6. There is no way that partner could know the shape of that hand. Here, who wouldn't be tempted to pass 2 diamonds with a seven-card suit headed by the AJ, even if LHO did open 1D? However, since his LHO opened with his seven-card suit, there's a good possibility that she's got four diamonds (you know she has at least three), so how many could your partner have? He's already shown an unbalanced hand, so the chances of him having more than one are slim and the chances of his being void are excellent. So, if you think about it, you shouldn't be tempted like this. If partner shows two five-card majors (which is all Michaels promises), make a choice between the two, even if you have two singletons.

Play: I led the 4 of clubs, Millie taking South's king with her ace. She smothered the singleton queen of hearts with her king. While South could get rid of one club on the AK spades, South was doomed to play the hand out of her hand and we got 2 club tricks and 4 diamond tricks for down one. Because Millie had five clubs, she could always take South's diamond lead and force him to ruff and lead into her again. My club 10 backed up by three other clubs was a huge card for the defense, keeping South from getting any club other than the queen.

Michaels may also be used if you have a five-card major and a five-card minor. Look at this hand when your RHO opens 1H:

♠ KJ1094

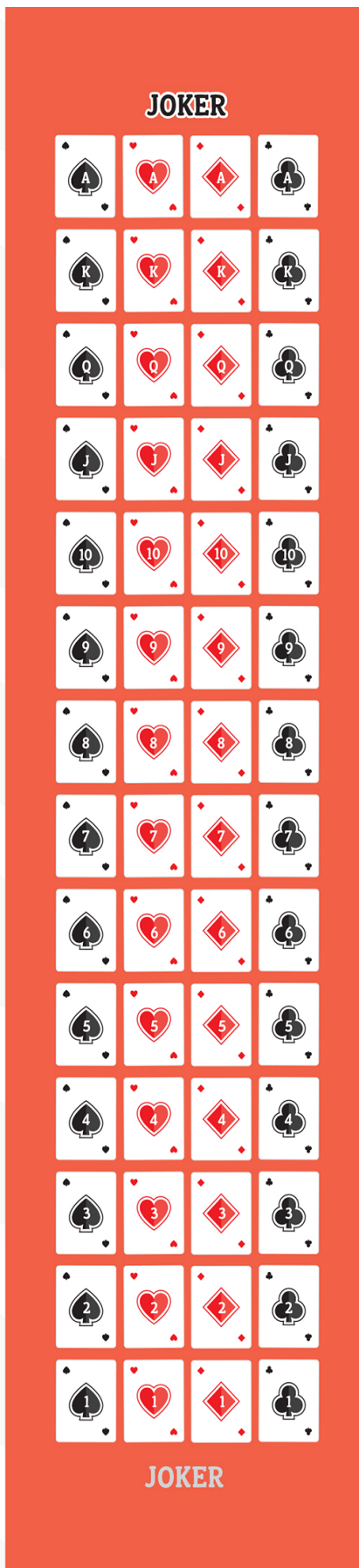
♥ 8

♦ AJ986

♣ 98

You could overcall 1S and then rebid diamonds when it comes back around to you if partner does not support your spades. But a better way to bid it is to use Michaels and cue-bid 2H. That says that you have a five-card (or better) spade suit and an unidentified five-card (or better) minor. If partner wants to know what your minor suit is, she bids no trump at the cheapest level. That requires you to bid your five-card minor if the bid is passed around to you.

Finally, to overcall at the 1 level, you should have at least five cards in the suit and between 8 to 15 points. To overcall at the 2 level, you should have at least five cards in the suit and between 11 to 15 points; with six cards in the suit you need only 10 points. To make a takeout double, you should have support for all unbid suits and at least 10 points. To double and bid your own suit, you should have at least 17 points, a five-card suit, and three of the top five honors.



Chapter 20

Responses to Overcalls and Takeout Doubles

When your partner overcalls, you're in a relatively ticklish position because of the large disparity between her minimum and her maximum. As you learned in [Chapter 19](#), when she overcalls, her upper maximum is 15 points, but her minimum is just 8 points. That's a lot less than the minimum for an opening 1 bid. This chapter discusses how you respond when your partner makes an overcall.

What Do You Know?

When you're the partner of an overcaller, you have a lot of information at your fingertips. First, you know where at least half the points in the hand are located. Opener—one of your opponents—probably has at least 12. Your partner has at least 8. That's 21 points at minimum. So, you can look at your hand and evaluate it with much more confidence than if there had been no bidding.

Furthermore, you know that if your partner bid a suit, she has at least five cards in it. That's very valuable because it means that if you have three cards in her suit, you have at least an eight-card fit.

Responding to Major-Suit Overcall with Support

If your partner made a major-suit overcall and you have three-card support, here's how you should respond based on the number of points in your hand:

6 to 10 points	Make a 1 level raise.
11 to 13 points	Make a limit raise.
14 to 17 points	Jump to game.

Look at some hands after the bidding has gone as follows:

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♣	1 ♥	P	?

Here are the hands to evaluate:

1. ♠ KJ7	2. ♠ J1098	3. ♠ A98	4. ♠ AQ973	5. ♠ J973
♥ 9832	♥ A82	♥ 32	♥ 8632	♥ 3
♦ A87	♦ 943	♦ K832	♦ KQJ	♦ KQJ4
♣ K84	♣ J83	♣ KJ43	♣ 9	♣ 10965

Hand 1: 3 hearts. You make the same bid you'd make if she opened 1 heart, a limit raise showing 11 to 13 points and at least three hearts. If you are playing cue-bid limit raises, you would bid 2 clubs, opponents' opening bid.

Hand 2: 2 hearts. The rules that apply to responding to opening bidder do not apply to responding to an overcall. You do not bid new four-card suits. Don't mess around showing a weak four-card spade suit. You only have one bid, and your first obligation should be to tell your partner that you have a trump fit. The advantage you have in an overcall situation is that you know at least one of your opponents is sitting there with an opening hand—at least 12 points. You want to get to your trump fit as quickly as possible. If you respond with 1 spade and partner has a minimum overcall, she won't rebid her hearts and you'll miss your fit. Your hand is too weak to bid spades and then bid hearts later. A simple raise to an overcall supporting your partner's suit shows 6 to 10 points. You really have no hope for game here, but you want to bid for two reasons:

- + You have safety because of your trump fit, so you can't be hurt too badly if you get the contract.
- + You make it a little more difficult for your opponents to bid because you're raising the level for opener to bid if he has a fairly big hand.

Hand 3: 1 no trump. You have 11 HCP and opponents bid clubs. You can't support her hearts with only two. And you have their clubs stopped twice. A 1 no trump response to an overcall shows 8 to 11 HCP.

Hand 4: 4 hearts. You have a five-card trump support with 14 points and only 6 losers. Again, you don't want to mess around with a 1 spade bid. Get to game without any further communication between your opponents.

Hand 5: Pass. Just because you have diamonds well stopped, that's no reason to bid without a fit. Your partner is limited to 16 points and it is unlikely that there is a game

here. Don't bid to "save" your partner.

Responding by Bidding a New Suit

When you're responding to an opening bid, a new suit bid by you is forcing on opener. However, when responding to an overcall, a new suit bid by you is *not* forcing (although some play this differently so be sure you and partner play it the same way). Before I give you some examples, you should know the reasoning behind this.

When you respond to an opening bid, you're looking to make game, and doing so is a real possibility because you know your partner has at least 12 points. However, when responding to an overcall, making game is much more unlikely because you know that one of your opponents has an opening bid in his hand. While game may be possible, it's not probable.

So, your goal in responding to an overcall is to quickly find an area where you can compete. The requirements for responding to an overcall are similar to responding to an opening bid, but not identical. And it's very important that, if you're going to bid a new suit at all, you do so at your first opportunity.

The requirements for responding to an overcall with a new suit follow:

- + If you're at the 1 level, you should have at least 8 points and a good five-card suit.
- + If you're at the 2 level and have only 8 points, you should have a six-card suit.
- + If you have three-card support for your partner's major suit overcall, you shouldn't bid a new suit unless you have opening-hand values or a good six-card suit. The idea is to quickly find a fit in which to compete. If you have a fit in your partner's major suit you should tell her immediately, because a new suit by you isn't forcing. Otherwise, she might pass your bid of a different suit and you could find yourself in a terrible fit when you could have had an eight-card fit had you just supported her at your first opportunity.

Points to consider in responding to your partner's overcall with a new suit include the following:

- + Your partner may pass your bid, so you must be certain that you will be willing to play the hand in your suit if your partner can't support you.
- + Your partner is going to consider leading your suit if she's on lead. So, it's not a good idea to bid a new suit unless it's a good suit that could give you some defensive tricks if you're on defense.
- + Beware of introducing a new suit if opponents have shown power. If opener's partner has bid a new suit over your partner's overcall, for example, they probably have the majority of the points in their hands. If you were to bid the fourth suit here, you could be getting into a world of hurt.
- + Don't respond to your partner's overcall by bidding a new suit at the 3 level unless you have a good six-card or longer suit and at least 11 points. A "good" suit is one with three of the top five honors with at least the king.

Responding to Your Partner's 2 Level Overcall

When your partner makes an overcall at the 2 level, you know that she either has at least 11 points with a five-card suit or a six-card suit with at least 10 points. Therefore, you know that she's stronger than if she overcalled at the 1 level.

Let's take a look at some hands when partner overcalls at the 2 level. The bidding has gone as follows:

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
P	?	1 ♠	2 ♦

Here are the hands to evaluate:

1. ♠ K4 ♥ 9863 ♦ QJ86 ♣ 964	2. ♠ KQ10 ♥ 10974 ♦ K843 ♣ KJ	3. ♠ 86 ♥ AQJ107 ♦ 96 ♣ 10642	4. ♠ 7 ♥ AK ♦ 108763 ♣ J10974	5. ♠ 7 ♥ AJ5 ♦ Q954 ♣ J10974
--------------------------------------	--	--	--	---------------------------------------

Hand 1: Pass. Even with support, there is little hope of game. Because of the 1 spade bid, your king of spades rates to be of little use.

Hand 2: 3 no trump. Because this hand is balanced and you have spades well stopped, 3 no trump is more likely to make than 5 diamonds.

Hand 3: 2 hearts. You have minimal values but a good suit. It is possible you have game in hearts.

Hand 4: 5 diamonds. Your extra trump, spade shortness, and long club suit should make this a good game.

Hand 5: 4 diamonds (or two spades if you are playing cue-bid limit raises). A limit raise based on your singleton spade and five-card trump suit, which means that opponents will only be able to take a maximum of one trick in their strongest suit. Remember that when you have a trump fit, a singleton is worth 3 points. To make this bid you must have not less than four trumps and not a lot of HCP. Remember, also, that a 2 level overcall by your partner promises a stronger hand than a 1 level overcall. So, this 11-point hand is game invitational if your partner is at the top of her bid.

Responding to an Overcall After a Raise by RHO

When your RHO makes a simple raise of opener's suit over your partner's overcall, he's showing weakness, so you can be more assertive. If you have a good six-card major suit, you can even bid it at the 3 level in this situation. But you must either have length or shortness in the opponents' suit.

Why? Because length would strongly indicate that your partner has shortness. If you're bidding at the 3 level, you can only lose four tricks. You don't want to start right off with two losers in opponents' suit, which is what might happen if you have a doubleton. If you have three or four, it's highly likely that your partner has no more than a singleton.

Look at the following hands and determine how you are going to respond to your partner's overcall. The bidding has gone as follows:

<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
		1 ♣	1 ♠
2 ♣	?		

Here are the hands to evaluate:

1. ♠ 7	2. ♠ 843	3. ♠ 74	4. ♠ QJ
♥ KJ53	♥ A74	♥ KQ532	♥ KJ9
♦ QJ73	♦ QJ73	♦ A64	♦ AQ10986
♣ K873	♣ J98	♣ J103	♣ 74

Hand 1: Pass. You can't support your partner with only one spade. Even though you have all the other suits stopped, you can't bid 2 no trump because you have a singleton in your partner's suit. If your opponents get the contract, you have a good defensive hand.

Hand 2: 2 spades. You have three-card support, even though the rest of your hand isn't too good. But you do have scattered values. You should assume your partner had opening-hand values (even though she might not) and make the bid you'd make if she opened—which is 2 spades.

Hand 3: 2 hearts. Your partner might have three hearts. You're telling her that you have a good five-card or longer hearts suit and some values. But remember that the bid of a new suit by an overcaller's partner is not forcing on overcaller to bid again. So, you might end up playing the hand in 2 hearts and she might not have very good support for you.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. You only have two cards in spades, but they're both honors. But you have a terrific diamond suit, and this might be the only opportunity to tell your partner about it in the event she is on lead. If she rebids spades, you have support for her with your two honors. If she passes, you shouldn't be in too much trouble in two diamonds because you have a six-card suit and three of the top five honors.

Responding to Minor-Suit Overcalls

This is a good time to tell you that there are five basic game contracts (meaning that the final contract is a bid to make game) into which you can enter. They are as follows:

+ 3NT

+ 4 ♥ or 4 ♠

+ 5 ♦ or 5 ♣

Two of these contracts are not favored. Can you guess which two? It's 5 diamonds and 5 clubs, and the reason is that minor-suit games require you to take all but two tricks, which can be extremely difficult. Furthermore, 3 no trump, 4 hearts, and 4 spades give you more points despite having to take fewer tricks.

So, if possible, you should exert every effort to play contracts in hearts, spades, or no trump.

With that as a prologue, your responses to a minor-suit overcall are the same when you have support for your partner's suit and your hand is the minimum 6 to 9 or 10 to 12. That is, with the former you give a simple raise, and with the latter you give a limit raise by jumping a level.

It's good to point out here the difference between responding to a minor-suit overcall and a minor-suit open—and it's a big difference. When responding to a minor-suit open by your partner you don't know how many cards she has in the suit. She could have as little as three cards in the suit. So, you can't respond by raising her suit with minimum support.

But when your partner overcalls in a minor suit, she is promising you that she has at least five cards in the suit. So, you can confidently raise with three-card support.

However, when you have the big hand—14-plus points—instead of jumping to a minor-suit game at the 5 level, you should try to bid 3 no trump if you have stoppers in the other suits.

Responding in No Trump

You have a similar obligation to keep the bidding open for your partner's overcall as you do when your partner opens the bidding, if you have the point-count and suit-length requirements set forth previously. However, if your partner has overcalled at the 2 level, you may pass if your hand is 6 to 9 points without support. You should only bid without support if your hand contains 10 or more points.

Responding to a Takeout Double

If your partner makes a takeout double and there is no intervening bid by your RHO, you should bid your longest suit—unless you have a four-card major—regardless of the number of points in your hand. When responding to a takeout double, you should prefer a four-card major to a longer five-card minor. In case there is a game in the hand, it's easier in a major than in a minor. Your partner's takeout double strongly implies four cards in unbid majors. Even if you have a Yarborough, you must bid. Remember, your partner will not make a takeout double unless she can support anything you bid. So, you can rely on her to have at least three cards in all of the unbid suits.

If you have at least 10 points, you should make a jump response. This shows her that you have at least 10 points and at least four cards in the suit you bid. There are two exceptions to this requirement of bidding in response to your partner's takeout double:

- + If you have a lot of cards in opponents' suit and you think you can set them, you can pass. This tells your partner that you're willing to defend the hand for penalty.
- + If your RHO makes an intervening bid and you have less than 10 points and no five-card suit or no four-card major, your pass tells your partner that your hand is nothing to get excited about.

Look at the following hands after your partner has made a takeout double over her RHO's opening bid of 1 diamond:

1. ♠ A873
♥ Q1083
♦ 8
♣ J1063

2. ♠ K9873
♥ K83
♦ 87
♣ A73

3. ♠ A98
♥ K73
♦ 87
♣ J10873

4. ♠ 986
♥ 8975
♦ 963
♣ 742

Hand 1: 1 heart. You bid your four-card suits up the line. You have less than 10 points, so you just bid your cheapest long suit, which is hearts.

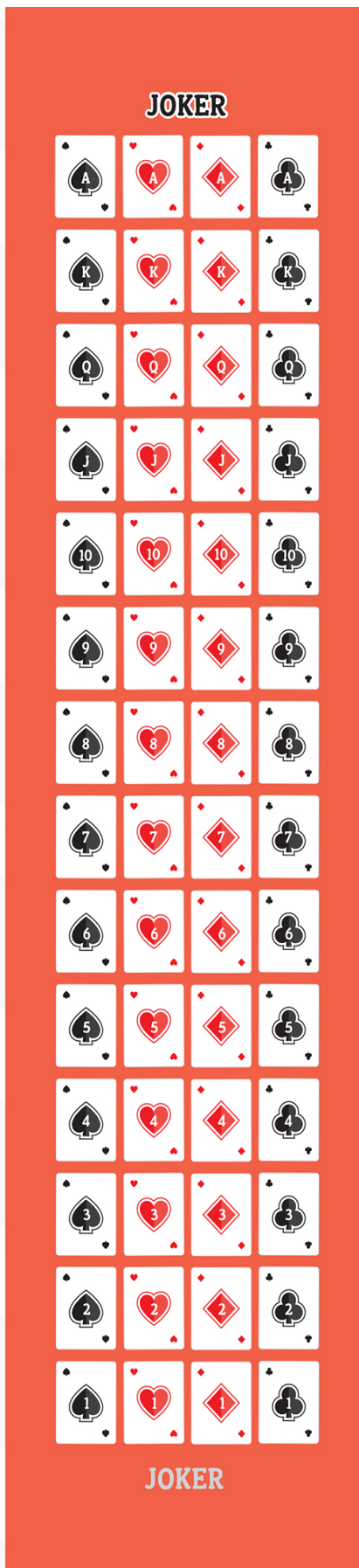
Hand 2: 2 spades. You have more than 10 points and a five-card suit, so you make a jump response to show your points.

Hand 3: 2 clubs. You must bid your longest suit. You're not jumping to go to the 2 level because the only way you can bid clubs over diamonds is to go up a level. This bid, not being a jump, shows that you have less than 10 points and that clubs is your longest suit.

Hand 4: 1 heart. You are forced to bid this stinkeroo hand. The best you can tell your partner is that you have less than 10 points. You're going to pass anything she does unless she makes another forcing bid, like 2 diamonds, which is opponents' opening bid.

With support for your partner's overcalled suit, make a 1-level raise with 6–10 points, a limit raise with 11–13 points, and jump to game with 14+ points. To bid a new suit over partner's overcall, you should have at least 8 points and a five-card suit; at the 2 level you should have a six-card suit. However, if you bid a new suit over partner's overcall, you should realize that it is not forcing on partner and she may pass, so be sure that the suit is good enough to play in without support.

Next up, you'll learn about doubles, defensive bidding, and etiquette.



Chapter 21

Doubles, Defensive Bidding, and Etiquette

In its pure form, a double is a defensive bid. It says to your opponents, “I don’t think you can make your contract, and I’m so confident of that I’m going to double you.”

In this chapter, you find out about penalty doubles as opposed to negative doubles, which you learned in [Chapter 12](#), and lead-directing doubles. I also help you figure out how to deal with a partner who irritates you or whom you irritated, and how to avoid such confrontations.

Penalty Doubles and Redoubles

A penalty double is like a double or nothing bet. If you double for penalty and your opponents don’t make their contract, you get twice the penalty bonus for setting them and more than twice the penalty bonus if you set them more than one trick. If they’re not vulnerable and they go down one, you’d ordinarily get 50 points above the line. If you double them and they go down one, however, you get 100 points above the line. On the other hand, if you don’t set the contract, your opponents get a bonus for making a contract doubled.

If a declarer is really confident, he can redouble. That means, “So, you don’t think I can make it? Oh, yeah? Well, I’m so confident I can make it that I’m going to redouble,” which causes the *doubled* score to be doubled!

Lots and lots of points result from doubles and redoubles. The following table shows how much you can make (or lose!). (Recall that an *undertrick* means that declarer didn’t make her contract, and each undertrick is the amount by which she did not make it.)

Penalties

Not Vulnerable

Undertricks	Not Doubled	Doubled	Redoubled
1	50	100	200
2	100	300	600
3	150	500	1,000
4	200	800	1,600
5	250	1,100	2,200
6	300	1,400	2,800

Vulnerable

Undertricks	Not Doubled	Doubled	Redoubled
1	100	200	400
2	200	500	1,000
3	300	800	1,600
4	400	1,100	2,200
5	500	1,400	2,800
6	600	1,700	3,400

The following table lists the points given for overtricks, or how many tricks declarer took over her contracted amount.

Overtrick Points

Not Vulnerable

Not Doubled	Doubled	Redoubled
Trick value	100 per trick	200 per trick

Vulnerable

Not Doubled	Doubled	Redoubled
Trick value	200 per trick	400 per trick

Trusting Your Partner's Bidding

I've emphasized that you must not mislead your partner. Time and again I've told you how important it is that you be consistent in your bidding and refrain from making

unilateral bids that are inconsistent with your partnership's understandings, just because you might *like* your hand.

Now you'll learn one of the reasons why this is so important. When you or your partner make a penalty double, you are generally doing it as a result of the auction and what you've learned about your partner's hand, as well as the hands of your opponents. Let's say the auction went like this:

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♣	1 ♥	1 ♠	2 ♦
2 ♠	P	3 ♠	P
4 ♠	?		

Your partner has made a bid that has told you that she has at least 10 points in her hand, and you have 10 points in your hand, and your opponents have bid a major-suit game. You would be entitled to think to yourself, "Well, I have 10 points, and my partner has made a free bid at the 2 level, and we've agreed that she can't do this without 10 points. They need at least 26 points to make game. If we have 20 points between us, there aren't enough points in the deck for them to have 26 between them; so there's a very good chance they won't make this contract." Therefore, you say with confidence, "Double."

Now, what if during the play of the hand you discover that your partner doesn't have the 10 points she indicated she had in the bidding, and your opponents make four spades doubled for a big score? You're not going to be very happy, are you? After the hand your conversation will probably go something like this:

You: I thought you had 10 points.

Partner: Well, I had such a nice diamonds suit.

You: How many points did you have?

Partner: I had such a nice diamonds suit.

You: How many points did you have?

Partner: Uh, er, my diamonds were real nice.

You: How many points did you have?

Partner: Uh, well, I had the ace and queen of diamonds and they were nice.

You: You had 6 points?

Partner: Yes, but my diamonds were so nice; I thought you'd want to know about them.

You: I doubled on your having 10 points, which is what your bid said you had.

Partner: (embarrassed silence)

You need feel no guilt about being annoyed. Your opponents received a big bonus for making the contract doubled. You were absolutely correct to take the chance on doubling the contract based on your partner's bid. But your partner didn't have her bid. *Don't lie to your partner!*

Listening to Your Opponents' Bidding

Doubling for penalty is a real art. It requires deductive reasoning and strict attention to the auction. If your opponents have made a preemptive bid (showing a weak hand but a lot of trumps) you have to take into consideration the possibility that one of them will be short in the suit in which you have your power.

If you're sitting there with ace-king-queen of clubs and the ace of hearts, for example, and your LHO opens the bidding at 1 spade; your partner overcalls 2 clubs and your RHO makes a preemptive jump to game, should you double? You look at your hand and think you have four cold tricks. But your RHO has five spades in his hand. It's very likely that his short suit is clubs, because you and your partner have at least eight of them between you both. You might only get one club trick. For sure you won't get three club tricks because the best the suit could split for you is 3-2 in your opponents' hands. This is not a hand to double on because you know that it's distributional, and if they have long spades, they're short in some suits.

They Won't Be as Aggressive the Next Time

Another advantage of doubling, and of getting the reputation that you're not afraid to double, is that it can inhibit opponents' bidding. If you double them successfully, it hurts them, and they'll remember.

When you're playing people who you know won't double you, you feel freer to take chances and bid to questionable games, knowing that the penalty will be minimal if you don't make your bid. But if you're playing someone who has no fear of doubling

and will *hit* (in bridge, the term “hit” is synonymous with “double”) you if you make a chancy bid, you’re more reluctant to take the chance. So doubling has the added benefit of making your opponents more cautious in their bidding.

SOS Redouble

Sometimes a redouble isn’t offensive in nature, it’s defensive. Take this auction:

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
P	1 ♥	1 ♠	P
P	Dbl	P	P
?			

Here’s your hand:

- ♠ Void
- ♥ 987
- ♦ J10984
- ♣ K10987

What do you do? You know that partner is in big trouble. Opponents have utilized the re-opening double to its intended effect. East is sitting behind your partner with all the trump your partner doesn’t have and you are probably going down for a big number. This is where you use the SOS redouble. You are not saying, “I think we can make this, Partner.” Rather, you are telling partner, “I have zero support for you but I do have good support in the two unbid suits. Pick the one that’s best for you and you will be far better off.”

Here are the four hands:

North

♠ A106542
♥ 832
♦ Q32
♣ A3

West

♠ 3
♥ AKQ65
♦ K76
♣ QJ4

East

♠ KQJ987
♥ 97
♦ A5
♣ 652

South

♠ Void
♥ J104
♦ J10984
♣ K10987

After the SOS redouble is passed to North, she should bid her longest of the two unbid suits, diamonds, even though she only has three of them. Despite the fact that South has only 5 HCP, it's much better to be playing in North's best minor suit for two reasons. The first is that the hand won't be doubled and the second is that he has a good chance of making the contract, probably only losing three hearts and two trumps, where his chances of making 1S doubled are slim and none. However, this is another bid that you should discuss with your partner because if there's a misunderstanding and she thinks you are saying you think she can make the contract, you aren't going for a big number, you're going for a huge number if she sits for the redouble.

Lead-Directing Doubles

Lead-directing doubles often come into play after an opening by your LHO of 1 no trump and a conventional bid by your RHO, like 2 clubs, Stayman. Let's say you have a good club suit headed by two of the top three honors or three of the top five, so you want a club lead if they're playing the contract in no trump. You tell your partner what to lead by doubling the 2 clubs bid. This generally only works when opponents are making conventional bids.

Look at this hand:

North

♠ 76
♥ J542
♦ 1096
♣ AK65

West

♠ J85
♥ A1087
♦ KQJ
♣ 1087

East

♠ AQ104
♥ KQ9
♦ A753
♣ J94

South

♠ K932
♥ 63
♦ 842
♣ Q32

You are sitting North and here's the bidding:

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
P	P	P	1NT
P	2 ♣*	Dbl**	2 ♠
3NT	P	P	P

**Stayman*

***Lead-directing double*

With you on lead against 3NT, you would normally lead your spade deuce, which is 4th from longest and strongest. If so, East sails 3NT, taking two spades (because you led into his AQ), four diamonds and three hearts off the top. But since your partner doubled West's Stayman bid of 2C, you know exactly what to lead: your club queen. You take the first four tricks and when East is forced to rely on the spade finesse, it fails and you take your spade king for the setting trick.

A lead-directing double is a double of a conventional bid that says nothing about the suit bid, like 2C for Stayman, or a 2D or 2H bid used as Jacoby Transfer. When you or your partner double such a bid it is yelling, "Please lead this suit!"

Trust Your Partner: Partnership Etiquette

Bridge can be a difficult game on relationships; whether you're playing with a friend, a spouse, a significant other, or someone who doesn't fit any of those categories, bridge tests the limits of a relationship. Why? Because it goes to the essence of your being—the way you think and reason. When someone questions something you did, that person is questioning your intelligence, and the questioning can become destructive.

My experience has been that the area of penalty doubles is where many emotional problems arise. That's why I'm digressing a little here to discuss etiquette and to make some suggestions for getting along.

When you don't trust your partner to know what she's doing and you take some unilateral action inconsistent with what she has done, you are communicating a lack of respect that can, in its most virulent form, destroy a relationship. The following story illustrates what can go wrong.

I was playing in a club championship with one of my best partners. We were good enough to have won a regional championship together. When we first played together, we had a problem because she continually *pulled* my penalty doubles. To “pull” means to make a bid that is inconsistent with what partner clearly intended. So if partner doubles for penalty and you bid another suit when it's your turn, you have “pulled” her penalty double, saying, in essence, “You might think we can set this contract, but I don't.” She, unilaterally, didn't think we could set our opponents; she didn't trust my doubles. I asked her to respect my penalty doubles.

We stopped playing for quite a while, and when we started again she exhibited more respect for my game. The first test of this was in a game where I doubled someone who had balanced. The bidding went as follows.

<u>Me</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♦	P	1 ♥	P
2 ♥	P	Pass	3 ♣
Dbl	P		

My partner thought for a while and finally passed. We set them two for a score of 300. I thanked her for not pulling my double and felt more confident about our partnership.

We continued to play and did well, winning championships. Then we came to a club championship and, with us vulnerable and our opponents nonvulnerable, the bidding went as follows.

<u>RHO</u>	<u>Me</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
1 ♣	1 ♦	1 ♥	P
4 ♥	Dbl	P	

This was my hand:

♠ Q5
♥ KQJ10
♦ K10876
♣ A8

I had three certain trump tricks and the ace of clubs. The only way I could be kept from setting them at least one was if the game were terminated by an earthquake.

My partner started thinking and I started getting worried. Finally, after long thought, she bid 4 spades! My RHO doubled her 4 spade bid. I could do nothing but pass. As my partner played the hand, I saw that she was missing the ace and king of spades, as well as the queen I had in my hand. She was down three. Doubled. Vulnerable. So she took what was going to be a very nice hand for us, setting them at least one for a score for us of 100, and turned it into a fantastic hand for them, down three doubled and vulnerable for 800 above the line for them.

While she was playing the hand, I was talking to myself, “Don’t say a word, Tony. Just start the next hand and go on.” But when the hand was over our opponents started talking and the devil got control of me. I asked, “Why did you pull my double?”

She leaned over the table and castigated me in a voice loud enough for everyone in the room to hear. Although I hadn’t been abusive or abrasive, I felt bad because I had

embarrassed her.

Now I'll stop the story and lay down some rules:

You must trust your partner. If you can't trust your partner's bid, you shouldn't play with her. My double was clearly penalty. She knew that I was a good enough player and that I wasn't going to double unless I had a very good chance of setting them. And, from the bidding, I had to have it in my hand. I couldn't rely on anything in her hand because she hadn't bid!

Sometimes you might pull a penalty double of your partner's if you have bid and you feel that you've made a mistake and your partner has misinterpreted the strength of your hand—especially if you are nonvulnerable and your opponents are vulnerable (commonly called “nonvulnerable against vulnerable” or “white against red”). You have a logical argument if you misrepresented your hand and can say that you pulled it because you felt your partner was relying on something you didn't have.

But here she hadn't bid. She had to trust that I knew what I was doing. Furthermore, we were vulnerable and they weren't. The worst that could happen was that they'd make it, doubled, and would get a bonus of 170 points. But if she pulled it (which she did) and went down three (which she did) because we were vulnerable, they got 210 points more than they would have if she had left my double in and they made it. From a bridge point of view, there was no logic or reason to her pulling the double. As it was, they would have been set at least one, so it was a difference in the score of 900 points.

Don't discuss hands or bids at the table. When you question someone, it challenges their intelligence and ability to reason in front of others, which can be embarrassing and demeaning. I should have waited until the game was over and talked about it on the way home.

Don't be abusive. Don't call your partner names. If you do discuss the hand, limit it to bridge and try to discuss it calmly and logically with the purpose being to avoid

misunderstandings in the future. Don't make the purpose of the discussion to put the person down.

Remember that your partner is trying to do the best she can. If she makes a mistake or a bad play, it wasn't because she is trying to do something personally harmful to you—that would harm the partnership. If she makes a mistake, realize that she probably feels worse about it than you do, so try to minimize it at the time. You can talk about it later if it's important enough to the partnership. The best way to strengthen a partnership is to be supportive when your partner makes a mistake. Instead of criticizing, give her a pat on the back and say, "Don't worry about it."

If your partner criticizes you, realize that bridge is competitive and your partner is competitive. Partners are human. When they see you do something they think is incorrect or—let's face it—stupid, they can react emotionally in the spur of the moment. There are very few saints, and most saints don't play bridge. The Pope might have reacted emotionally to his partner pulling a penalty double in that situation. So I reacted, even though I tried not to do so. When your partner reacts to something like that and asks, "Why did you trump my ace?" try to realize that it's just a human reaction of the moment and that she'll get over it. Turn the other cheek and let her get it out of her system by verbalizing her frustration. If you felt it was offensive or embarrassing, talk with her about it later and express your feelings then by saying something like, "Please don't criticize me during the game. What you said embarrassed me. I'm sorry for what I did, but that wasn't the time to talk about it." Something as simple as that will bring it out in the open and keep it from festering. If your partner doesn't react with compassion and understanding toward you, it may be time to consider taking a vacation from one another—which is what my partner and I did.

Take responsibility! If you do something stupid or wrong or inconsistent with your partnership understanding, take responsibility as soon as possible. I was once playing with Mike Shuman, one of the giants of the game. I opened the bidding and he finally passed me out at 3 diamonds. When he laid down the dummy he said, "I apologize if we have game, partner." Well, that completely disarmed me. What could I say? If we

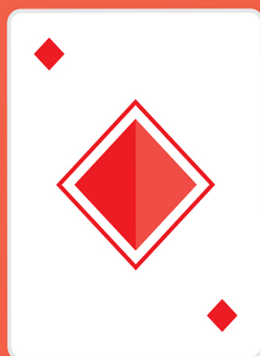
had missed game he had taken all the responsibility, so I didn't have to say, "Why did you pass three diamonds?" There was nothing to criticize. If my partner had said, "I'm sorry," after she saw my dummy and realized that she had pulled a perfectly good penalty double, it would have instantly relieved me of the anxiety I felt at having my wonderful double pulled. There's really not much you can say when your partner assumes full responsibility for a glitch and apologizes. Any partner who doesn't graciously accept such an apology is someone with whom I wouldn't want to play. Taking responsibility is the number one way to make sure a partnership runs smoothly and for a long time. And it's the best way to avoid contentious conversations and arguments at the table.

We made up and continued to play. So another thing to remember is to forgive and forget.

You double for penalty when you think you can set opponents' contract, provided it is not a takeout double. A lead-directing double is generally a double of a conventional bid, asking partner to lead that suit if she is on lead. Be considerate of your partners. She is trying as hard as she can.

Part 5

**DEFENSE, PLAY
OF THE HAND,
AND TWO-
OVER-ONE**



Bidding is one thing, but when it comes down to actually playing a hand, you may feel like a real dunce. Don't let this happen to you! Make sure you read this part carefully.

This part teaches you how to play or defend the hand once the bidding is completed. You'll find out how to play the hand as declarer, along with how to play some basic card combinations that arise again and again.

If your opponents win the contract, you're on defense. You'll learn how to begin your defense of the hand by your opening lead and some common techniques to use after the opening lead. You'll also get some pointers for communicating with your partner by the card you play, without even uttering a sound.

Finally, a popular system called Two-Over-One is introduced.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 22

Declarer Play in No Trump

If bidding is a team effort, playing the hand as declarer is entirely unilateral. It's up to you to play this hand by yourself. Your partner is dummy and can only sit and watch. Feel the pressure?

Your goal in any contract depends on the final contract you make. If you have contracted to make a 1 bid, you must take seven tricks, which means that you can afford to lose six tricks. If you have contracted to make a 4 bid, you must take ten tricks, which means that you can afford to lose three tricks.

The first thing you do is set your goal and realize what your objective is. If you're playing in a 1 contract, your objective is to take seven tricks. It might be nice if you could take eight, or nine, or more, but you don't want to risk your ability to take seven by trying to take eight. Many times good players will try for the overtrick and fail to make their contract as a result. Always keep in mind that your goal is to make the contract. Overtricks are just bonuses. Don't risk your contract to try to make a bonus.

Playing a No Trump Contract

Playing no trump is probably the most challenging task for a declarer, but it's also probably the most fun. In no trump, all suits are equal and high cards dominate. Because all suits are equal, having the lead is all-important in no trump.

Take a look at the following two opposing hands for which you are declarer in a no trump contract:

North

♠ irrelevant

♥

♦

♣

West

♠ 7

♥ 86

♦ AKQJ10987

♣ 75

East

♠ irrelevant

♥

♦

♣

South

♠ AKQJ

♥ AKQJ

♦ 6

♣ AKQJ

You look at your hand and think you should take twelve tricks. West, your LHO, looks at his hand and thinks he should take eight tricks. Who's correct?

He is! He is correct because he is on lead. And in no trump, whoever has the lead is the monarch so long as he retains the lead. He runs his eight diamonds tricks and you must throw off seven of your winning tricks until he runs out of diamonds and has to lead something besides diamonds. Since you have all the winners in all the other suits, you will take the rest of the tricks.

This also points out the fact that a long suit is a strong suit in no trump. Your strategy for winning differs depending on the type of contract you are playing. When you're playing a no trump contract, you count your winners. When you're playing a suit contract, you count your losers (as discussed in [Chapter 19](#)). When your partner lays down her dummy, the first thing you do is to put your two hands together in your mind's eye and count either your winners or losers, depending on the contract.

How to Count Your Winners

In no trump, having the lead is everything. If you have 13 spades, you can't count them as 13 tricks unless you are on lead. If you are not on lead, you have 13 definite losers. Because you have all of the spades and you don't have cards in any other suit, there's no way you can get the lead.

Your opponents could run one of their long suits and defeat your contract before you can take your winners. To run a suit means to take the rest of the tricks in that suit without opponents having any way to stop you. This can occur either in no trump when all the stoppers are gone or in a suit contract when opponents don't have any trump left to stop you.

If your RHO is declarer in no trump and you have 13 spades, however, you have 13 definite winners because you are on lead.

Look at the following terrific hand between you and your partner:

Dummy

♠ 87

♥ 10987

♦ KQ1065

♣ AK

Declarer

♠ A6

♥ KQJ

♦ A87

♣ QJ1098

You have winners galore. You have seven of the top eight hearts. If you get a spade lead and they take out your ace and you then try to set up your hearts by driving out their ace, however, they will run their spade winners and you'll be set before you get the lead back. To set up a suit means to establish it. You can't count any of your hearts as winners because you don't have the ace. They are potential winners, but they aren't sure winners, and that's what you have to count.

In this hand, you have nine sure winners: five clubs, three diamonds, and one spade. You should take them before surrendering the lead to the ace of hearts.

The rule for counting winners is *you only count winners that you can take without surrendering the lead*. So you can't count any card in any suit as a sure winner if you or

your partner don't have the ace of that suit.

Setting Up a Long Suit

One way to play a no trump contract is to try to set up, or establish, your long suit. In analyzing the cards you control, one of the first things you do is count the number of cards you have in each suit and determine your longest suit. For example, you have two suits in which you have seven cards each, if one of them is divided 4–3 and the other 5–2, the 5–2 suit is the one you should choose to develop, assuming equal strength and entries into the hand with the five-card suit. The five-card suit will give you more tricks than a four-card suit.

Tricks in No Trump

When you're playing a contract in no trump, there are two kinds of tricks you can make: high-card tricks and long-suit tricks. The following sections take a closer look at each.

High-Card Tricks

The first is tricks obtained through your high cards. It doesn't take a nuclear physicist to look at a hand with ace–king–queen in one suit to calculate that you'll probably be able to count on three tricks in that suit.

Long-Suit Tricks

One place where skill and fun come into play in no trump contracts is when you have to take tricks by establishing a long suit. When playing in a suit contract, you can usually count on ruffing power for tricks. But in a no trump contract, all suits are of equal power. If you don't have enough high cards to make your contract, you have to set up a long suit so you can take the rest of your tricks with low cards in that suit. Let's take a look at a hand to illustrate:

North

♠ K87
♥ 872
♦ QJ1086
♣ 65

South

♠ AQ3
♥ AQ4
♦ 543
♣ KQ43

Even though you only have 23 HCP between you and your partner, you somehow ended up playing in 3 no trump and you are South, which is declarer. How are you going to make this contract? Count your winners. You've got three spade tricks, one or two heart tricks, and one or two club tricks. Even at a maximum, that's only seven tricks and you need nine.

To make this contract, you will need to set up your long suit—which is diamonds—and establish your two needed tricks there. Looking at the hand in a vacuum, diamonds appears to be your weakest suit; but actually, because you have eight total cards in it and five in dummy, it's your strongest. Remember: *In no trump, your longest suit is your strongest suit!*

With the above hands, you're lucky enough to get a spade lead. You take it in South and immediately lead a diamond from South's hand to North's queen–jack–10. If they take it, it doesn't really matter because you're counting on a 3–2 split. No matter what they return, you lead a diamond again. You might win or lose. Again, it doesn't matter, because you're going to keep leading diamonds until your 8 of diamonds and 6 of diamonds are established, or set up, and become winners because they're the only remaining cards left in the suit.

Entries

When playing no trump, it is essential that you keep entries into the weak hand if it has the long suit. An *entry* is simply a card that allows you to get the lead in that hand. In the referenced hand with the long diamond suit, you had two sources of entries:

- + You had three diamonds in your hand to continue leading up to the dummy
- + Dummy's king of spades

But let's change that hand a little:

North

♠ K4
♥ 872
♦ QJ1096
♣ 652

South

♠ AQ32
♥ AQ4
♦ 54
♣ KQ43

Now you take the opening spade lead in your hand and then lead a diamond, which they take. They return a spade and you are forced to take it in dummy with your king. You lead a second diamond, which they take. Now how are you going to get back to dummy to cash your winning diamonds? Here's how the hand looks after these plays:

North

♠
♥ 872
♦ 1096
♣ 652

South

♠ Q3
♥ AQ4
♦
♣ KQ43

You have no entry into dummy! Your diamonds are good because your 10 and 9 will take the two outstanding diamonds and then your 6 is the only remaining diamond, but you can't get there to cash them. You have admirably established your diamonds, but you lost your entry to cash them.

The rule to remember from all this is: Establish your suit *before* you lose your entries.

Choosing Which Suit to Establish

Sometimes you have suits of equal lengths and have to decide which one to establish. You should attempt to establish the suit in which you could take the most tricks. For example, if you have two suits in which you hold eight cards, but one is divided 4–4 between declarer and dummy and the other 5–3, the suit in which you will probably take the most tricks is the one that is divided 5–3. That is if defenders' cards in those suits both split 3–2 and assuming relatively comparable high-card strength in both suits.

Timing

When you plan your play you not only determine your longest suit, but you know in which suits your opponents have more cards than you do. In those suits, your short suits, you should protect your stoppers. Don't lead those suits yourself because you'll just be helping your opponents establish their suits.

It's essential that you establish your suit before your opponents establish theirs. When playing no trump, it often comes down to a race. Who can establish their suit first: declarer or opponents?

Often it comes down to who is on lead. If you have their long suit stopped twice but you need two leads to establish your long suit, you're going to lose the race. Look at the following hand.

North

♠ 32
♥ AK93
♦ KQ98
♣ 532

West

♠ QJ10984
♥ 65
♦ 763
♣ A4

South

♠ AK
♥ Q2
♦ A104
♣ QJ10986

East

♠ 765
♥ J10874
♦ J52
♣ K7

Opening Lead: Queen of Spades

If you try to establish your six-card clubs suit, you're going to lose this battle of timing. You take the queen of spades led and immediately lead the queen of clubs. East takes it and returns a spade, which you take with your last spade stopper in South. You lead the jack of clubs, which West takes with the ace of clubs and runs his four remaining spade winners. He has established his six-card spades suit before you could establish your six-card clubs suit because you only had two stoppers in his suit and you needed to drive out two losers in clubs. The timing is against you in this hand.

The point is that you should see this after the opening lead and abandon all hope of establishing clubs. You should look to see if there's any other way to make this hand in 3 no trump, and there is. If defenders' diamonds split 3–3, or if the jack is a singleton or doubleton, you can make 3 no trump *off the top* (taking all your tricks before losing a trick to opponents) by taking the following cold tricks:

Two spades

Three hearts

Four diamonds (because they split 3–3 or the jack is a singleton or doubleton and falls, setting up the rest of your diamonds)

How to Play and Win Honors

Honors in a suit consist of the ace, king, queen, jack, and 10. They are the most powerful cards in the suit. Generally, honors are the cards that win the tricks. But an honor, unless it's an ace, is not a sure trick.

If the king is in the hand sitting to the right of the hand with the ace (called “sitting in front of the ace”), the king probably won't win a trick. If the queen is sitting in front of the ace or the king, it probably won't win a trick. Look at the following holdings in spades, for example:

<u>North</u> ♠ A1076		
<u>West</u> ♠ K95		<u>East</u> ♠ J82
<u>South</u> ♠ Q43		

The only winner in this hand is North's ace, because North will play after West and North can take West's king when he plays it if he waits for it to be played. West's king is not a winner because it's sitting in front of North's ace. Similarly, South's queen is not a winner because it's sitting in front of West's king. It's the same with East's jack.

Now let's reverse East and West's holdings:

<u>North</u> ♠ A1076		
<u>West</u> ♠ J82		<u>East</u> ♠ K95
<u>South</u> ♠ Q43		

Now the situation is a horse of a different color. East's king will be a winner because it sits behind North's ace. Unless East leads his king (which would certainly be foolhardy) he shouldn't lose it because if North is dummy, East can see where the ace is and play

the king on a trick where the ace has not been played. Similarly, if South knows the location of the king, her queen is a winner because it is sitting behind East's king.

The bottom line is that you can't count on these cards being winners until you know the location of the missing honors. This leads us into the discussion of how to play honors so they win tricks.

When you don't know the location of the honors that are higher than your honor, you must lead up that honor. To *lead up* to a card means to lead a lower-ranking card in your partner's hand, or in the case of declarer, to lead a low card to a higher-ranking card in your other hand. For example, in the hand just displayed, if you wanted to try to win the queen, you would lead a low spade from North to South's queen. If East has the king, you should win the queen. Because if East plays low, you play the queen, hoping that East has the king. Here, East did have the king so the queen wins. But if East *goes up* (plays a high card when he has a choice of playing high or low because he's not on lead) with the king when you lead low from North, you play a low spade from South. Although East has won the trick, you have set up the queen as a definite winner because you hold the ace and two additional spades in North and the queen and one additional spade in South. You can play the ace and play low from South, then lead a low spade to the queen, which is a definite winner because the king has already been played.

Playing Sequential Honors

If all your cards in a suit consist of honors in a sequence, it doesn't matter whether you lead from the hand that contains the sequence or if you lead up to them because you don't have any other low card to play. If you hold the king-queen-jack *tight* (meaning that those are the only three cards in that suit), even if you lead up to them and your LHO goes up with the ace, you still have to play one of your honors on the ace.

Furthermore, it doesn't matter how or where you hold the sequential honors. Look at the following holding:

North

♠ KJ3

West

♠ ?

East

♠ ?

South

♠ Q65

Unless you have an entry problem in one of your hands, it doesn't matter how you play these honors (king-queen-jack) or how you lead. You're going to take two tricks and lose one to the ace. It doesn't matter if you lead the queen from South, or if you lead low. If you lead low and West goes up with the ace, you will discard low and will still take two tricks.

Leading Up

However, what if you hold KQxx in a suit? How should you play it to maximize your trick-taking power? You can count on this holding for one sure trick because if you lead the king or the queen, it will lose to the ace, but then the remaining card will be the top card out in the suit, a definite winner. But if you lead up to the king-queen holding, you have a chance to win both cards if the king-queen sit behind the ace. Look at the following:

North

♠ KQ84

West

♠ A97

East

♠ J106

South

♠ 532

If you lead from South's hand up to North's hand and West ducks (loses the trick on purpose when she could have won it; more on this strategy later in this chapter), you will win with either the king or the queen. You then get back into South's hand and lead up to North again. If West ducks, you win with the remaining honor. If West goes up with the ace, you play low and your king and queen become sure winners. However, if you were to lead the king from North's hand, it would lose to the ace. Then the queen would be the only winner you would get in the suit because after you

play the queen, East will win the next spades trick with the jack. So leading up to North gets you an extra trick.

Playing Single Honors

Leading up is especially important when you hold a single, nonsequential honor. Look at the following:

	<u>North</u>	
	♠ K4	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ ?		♠ ?
	<u>South</u>	
	♠ 53	

If you lead the king or the 4 from North, you aren't going to take a trick with the king. If you lead the 4 and East goes low, West will win with his lowest spade. Then, any lead that produces the ace will win your king. Obviously, if, instead of leading your 4 you lead the king from North, opponent's ace will win it.

The only way you can hope to win the king is to lead low from South to the king. If West produces the ace, your king will win the next trick. If West goes low, you must play the king, hoping that West had the ace. If he did, you'll win. If East has the ace, you'll lose. When you have this holding you can count on the king as a half trick because you have a 50 percent chance that West has the ace and you'll win the king, and a 50 percent chance that East has the ace and you'll lose the king. (Assuming your opponents have not bid, so you have learned nothing about their hands during the bidding.)

This holding also shows why you shouldn't do two things on opening lead unless you have an awfully good reason for them:

- + You should not underlead an ace. To underlead means to lead a lower card in a suit instead of leading your highest card in that suit. To underlead an ace means you have the ace in your hand, but you lead a lower-ranking card of the same suit.
- + You should not lead an ace.

You shouldn't *underlead* an ace because you make the king good. If either opponent underleads the ace, your king will win if you play it. If you lead your ace, especially if you are East, you just give up the chance of winning the king with it. Remember this axiom: *Aces were created to take kings and queens*. If you lead an ace, it won't take either unless the king or queen happens to be a singleton.

The Finesse

The Official Encyclopedia of Bridge (Truscott, Executive Editor, 1994) defines a *finesse* as “the attempt to gain power for lower-ranking cards by taking advantage of the favorable position of higher-ranking cards held by the opposition.” Say, what? If you know what a finesse is, I guess that's as good a definition as any. But if you don't know what a finesse is, that won't help you much.

An easier definition might be this: A *finesse* is any play that depends on finding a specific card in a specific place. You can play a finesse with both no trump and in a suit.

So if you're South and you make a play that depends on the king of spades being in West's hand, that's a finesse. The best way to define a finesse is to show you one. Look at the following holdings:

<u>North</u>		
♠ AQ		
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ K8		♠ 65
<u>South</u>		
♠ 97		

You are declarer and playing the South hand, and South has the lead. You play West for the king of spades. So you lead the 7 of spades. If West plays the king you take it with the ace, obviously. If West plays the 8 of spades, however, you play the queen, hoping that West has the king. If he does, as he does here, you win the trick with the queen. That's a finesse. In this instance, it works. If the East and West holdings were reversed

and East held the king, the finesse wouldn't work. You'd play the queen and East would take it with the king.

The lead must be up to the cards where you'll work the finesse. If the lead were in North, there would be no way for you to win both the ace and the queen, because if you lead the ace, West will go low and then win your queen with his king. If you lead the queen, West will take it with his king. Either way, you only win one trick. But if you have the lead in the hand with the weak cards leading up to the hand with the strong cards, you can work the finesse.

The ace–queen holding is called a *tenace* (pronounced like “tennis”), which is a holding of two cards, one of which is 2 levels below the other. Examples are ace–queen, king–jack, 10–8. If cards in between two cards have been played, the cards are said to be in a tenace position. So if the king, queen, and jack have been played, the ace–9 is a tenace (because the only remaining card between them is the 10).

The Double Finesse

If you have alternating cards, like the ace, queen, and 10, you should usually finesse twice, no matter what happens the first time. Look at the following:

North

♠ AQ1086

South

♠ 432

If you haven't learned anything from the bidding or the play of the hand, you should first lead low from South and if West ducks (plays low), play the 10 of spades. If that forces out the king from East, you'll be okay because both the ace and the queen will be good. That would mean that West has the jack. If East had the jack, he'd win the trick with the jack, not the king. Because East won with the king, he doesn't have the jack. If he doesn't have it and you don't have it in either of your hands, West must have it. But it doesn't matter because the ace and queen are now good.

If East wins your 10 with the jack, however, the next time you get the lead you should finesse the queen. The reasoning is that the odds favor the honors being split. Of course they won't be split all the time. But with no clue from the bidding you should try the finesse twice.

The Eight- and Nine-Card Finesse

It's often the case that when you're playing a contract—generally a suit contract—you and your partner have eight or nine trump between you. This means that there are either four trump out against you or five trump out against you. You have the ace, king, jack, and 10 between you and your partner's hands. You need to find the queen.

One axiom to remember is that *an odd number of cards tend to split evenly and an even number of cards tend to split oddly*. This means that the odds are in favor of five cards splitting 3–2. And the odds are in favor of four cards splitting 3–1, not 2–2. Surprised? Actually four cards will split 2–2 only about 40 percent of the time, whereas they'll split 3–1 about 49 percent of the time.

So if your ace and your king are in different hands, and your jack and your 10 are in different hands, and you have no clue from the bidding, you should pull a round of trump, leading low to the high honor and then back again. The advantage of this is that it gives you three plays from your opponents. One of them may be forced to drop the queen because it's a singleton or doubleton. If not, then you have to decide whether or not to take the finesse. Look at the following layout.

North

♠ AJ98

South

♠ K10652

You have to find the queen, and there are four cards out against you. If you're in South, you lead the deuce. If West plays the queen (because it's a singleton), you're home free. If West plays low, you play the ace. If East plays the queen (because it's a singleton), you're home free. If East plays low, you've won the trick with the ace.

Now you lead the jack back to South's hand. If East drops the queen (either because it was a doubleton or because he's covering your honor to protect his partner because—not knowing the exact lay of the cards—he might think his partner had 3 to the 10), you're home free. If East shows out and discards another suit, then you've lost this round because West has the queen protected by 3. If East plays low, then you have to decide whether the cards split 2–2 (in which event you should play the king and watch the queen fall) or 3–1 (in which event you should play low and let the jack win the trick).

Playing for the Drop

Instead of finessing, another way to find the queen is to play for the *drop*. To play for the drop means to lead high-ranking cards hoping that a missing high card, lower-ranking than the cards you led, will have to be played because holder is short in the suit. Whichever way you want to go—finessing or playing for the drop—I think you should be consistent. Don't play for the drop once and then take the finesse the next time. Decide which way is best for you and do it every time. If you vacillate between positions, the odds won't work in your favor. If you do it the same way all the time, you'll at least have the odds working for you.

Eight ever, nine never is a famous bridge axiom. It means that if you're missing the queen and you have nine cards in the suit, you should play for the drop. If you have eight cards in the suit, you should take the finesse.

Bridge expert Charles Goren advises to play for the drop when there are four out against the queen, but he doesn't advise you to play for the drop when there are three out against the king. And he has good reason.

Three cards will split 3–0 22 percent of the time, which means that they will be divided 2–1 78 percent of the time. This means that two thirds of the time they divide 2–1, and the king will be protected. Look at the possible divisions you could face in a 2–1 split of three cards:

1. Kx

x

2. x

Kx

3. xx

K

So Goren is correct. Two thirds of the time that the cards split 2–1, you’re going to be looking at a protected king, and your lead of the ace playing for the drop is not going to work.

How to Play the Opening Lead

When you’re declarer playing a no trump contract, how you play the opening lead often sets up whether or not you make the contract. Following are common holdings with which you will find yourself faced time and again:

1. Dummy

♠ Q4

Declarer

♠ A93

2. Dummy

♠ Q104

Declarer

♠ A73

3. Dummy

♠ Q74

Declarer

♠ A93

LHO leads a low spade. What do you play? Your problem is to find who has the king: your LHO or your RHO.

Holding 1: You must play the queen. If you play low—whether or not you win the trick with the ace—your queen will be sitting there unprotected. Opponents will play the king at their first opportunity. Furthermore, your RHO, if he has any smarts at all, won’t play the king even if he has it, knowing that playing it will give you an extra trick if you hold the ace. The only chance you’ll ever have to make this queen good is now, hoping that your LHO underlead the king (a standard play that you will learn about in [Chapter 26](#)).

Holding 2: Play the 10. The hope is that your RHO holds king empty. If so, playing the 10 here will force out the king and you’ll get two tricks in this hand. If your RHO does play the king, you take it with the ace and your queen is good. If the 10 forces the jack from RHO, win the ace and later lead up toward the queen. If LHO had the king, your queen will be a winner.

Holding 3: Play low. If RHO's opening lead was from J10xx, RHO will have to play the king or you'll win with the 9. If RHO doesn't play the king, but plays the jack or 10, you can win with the ace. You still have your queen protected by a second card and can lead up to it. If your LHO has the king, your queen will then win. If he doesn't, you're going to lose it anyway.

The Holdup

When your LHO leads your weakest suit on opening lead, a suit in which you only have one stopper, often you need to hold up taking your trick. This occurs when your LHO leads a suit in which you have Axx, for instance. You have two or three in dummy. You guess that your LHO has at least five, maybe six cards in the suit, and you hope he has no other entries in his hand. Instead of taking the trick immediately with your ace, you play low and allow him to win the trick. He continues and you allow him to win the second trick. Only when he forces you to play your ace with a third lead of the suit do you take the lead. The reason for all this is that you want to be sure that your RHO is out of his partner's suit. That way, if he gets the lead, he can't return the suit to your LHO for him to run his remaining winning tricks in the suit. Look at the following hand:

North

♠ 109
♥ AQ73
♦ Q1075
♣ Q53

West

♠ Q8753
♥ 985
♦ 83
♣ J107

East

♠ KJ6
♥ K106
♦ J92
♣ K642

South (You)

♠ A42
♥ J42
♦ AK64
♣ A98

Bidding is as follows:

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
1NT	P	2 ♣	P
2 ♦	P	3NT	P
P	P		

West's Opening Lead: 5 of Spades

West leads the 5 of spades. East plays the king. What do you do? If you take the ace, you're doomed to being set. You can't take nine tricks off the top. You can take four diamond tricks and your three aces. That's only seven tricks. You need to develop one or two hearts tricks or a club trick. That means that you might have to surrender the lead twice. But if even one of your finesses fails, you're dead. Because you only had spades stopped once, as soon as your opponents get in they'll run off four spade tricks, which will set you one trick. As the cards lay, you'll lose your heart finesse and East will return the jack of spades, which wins. Then he returns a low spade to West's queen, and the hand is history as West plays his two remaining low spades—both of which are good because they're the only two remaining cards in the suit.

So, you must hold up taking your ace of spades and plan on taking your heart finesse into East. The idea is to surrender two spade tricks at the outset. This loses two tricks, but what you want to do is drive East out of spades so he can't get back to West to run his good spades. So, after holding up on two rounds of spades and then taking your ace of spades when East leads them a third time, this is what the hands look like:

<u>North</u>			
♠			
♥ AQ73			
♦ Q1075			
♣ Q5			
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>	
♠ Q8		♠	
♥ 985		♥ K106	
♦ 83		♦ J92	
♣ J107		♣ K642	
<u>South (You)</u>			
♠			
♥ J42			
♦ AK64			
♣ A98			

Now things look a little better. There's no way for West to get the lead again. You take your four diamond tricks and then try the heart finesse, which loses to East. Under no circumstances do you want to take a finesse into West. The heart finesse is safe because if West has the king you can always cover with the ace. When West plays low, you go low and East shows up with the king and wins the trick. But what's East going to lead? He can't get back to West's hand. If he underleads his king of clubs—which is about all that he can do—you won't know where the king is, so you'll go up and take it in your hand with the ace. You'll then take your three remaining heart tricks, and that's nine tricks—one spade, one club, four diamonds, and three hearts. You've made your contract, but only because you held up on the first two rounds of spades!

Ducking

It goes against your grain, but sometimes you have to lose a trick intentionally. This often occurs when you're playing a no trump contract and you have a long suit in dummy with the only entries being in the long suit. Look at the following hand where you are South playing in 3 no trump:

North

♠ 5
♥ AK7643
♦ 106
♣ 9732

West

♠ KQ9
♥ 982
♦ J8754
♣ J10

East

♠ 108743
♥ QJ
♦ Q3
♣ KQ65

South (You)

♠ AJ62
♥ 105
♦ AK92
♣ A84

Opening Lead: 5 of Diamonds

Count your winners. You have six, the ace–king of hearts, the ace–king of diamonds, the ace of clubs, and the ace of spades. But that leaves you three tricks short of your contract. How are you going to make this?

Your only chance is to set up your heart suit in dummy. But you've got a serious entry problem, because you only have two hearts in your hand and no other entry on the board. How do you play it?

This is where you *duck*, which means to lose a trick intentionally, to set up the heart suit. You must lose the first heart trick. So you take the opening lead in your hand with the king of diamonds. Now you lead a low heart to the board. West plays the deuce. You play the 6, allowing East to take the trick! You are hoping for a 3–2 split in hearts. East returns a diamond, which you take with your ace. You then lead your last heart to the ace–king on the board. Hearts split 3–2 as you had hoped, and you can run your five heart tricks.

The only way you could make this hand was to lose the first heart trick by ducking. That took out two of opponents' hearts and allowed you to pull the remaining hearts with your ace and king when you got back in the lead. If you don't duck, you have no way to get back to dummy without losing the lead when you try to take out the last heart. If you lead to the ace on your first lead of hearts and then play the king, you're out of hearts and North still has the 9 of hearts, which will take the next heart lead. Then there's no way for you to get back to dummy to cash your remaining good hearts.

Furthermore, if you lead to the ace and then lead a low heart, you still can't get back because you only have two hearts in your hand and the second heart will go on your second lead. So, you must lose the *first* heart trick.

Here's the layout of the hands after the first three tricks if you immediately play the ace and king of hearts:

North

♠ 5
♥ 7643
♦ 10
♣ 9732

West

♠ KQ9
♥ 9
♦ J874
♣ J10

East

♠ 108743
♥
♦ 3
♣ KQ65

South (You)

♠ AJ62
♥
♦ K92
♣ A84

Now what? You lead a heart and West takes it with his 9. You have no way to get back to the board to cash your three winning hearts. This is what the hands look like:

North

♠ 5
♥ 643
♦ 10
♣ 9732

West

♠ KQ9
♥
♦ J874
♣ J10

East

♠ 10874
♥
♦ 3
♣ KQ65

South (You)

♠ AJ6
♥
♦ K92
♣ A84

Sure you can get the lead again, no matter what West leads, but you can't get back to cash your three little hearts. Now look at the holding after you lose the first heart trick instead of taking it:

North

♠ 5
♥ AK764
♦ 10
♣ 9732

West

♠ KQ9
♥ 98
♦ J874
♣ J10

East

♠ 108743
♥ Q
♦ 3
♣ KQ65

South (You)

♠ AJ62
♥ 10
♦ K92
♣ A84

Now you're in great shape. No matter what East leads, you win in your hand and lead to the ace-king of hearts. When you cash them, your three remaining hearts are good and you have made your contract.

This is a fairly common situation, and it's one a lot of players misplay.

Here's another hand with a similar problem where the correct play is counter-intuitive. Instead of ducking, in order to make the contract you have to discard a card that will win a trick.

This shows two thinking plays outside of the box, one of which allows declarer to make what appears to be a doomed contract, and the other of which allows a courageous, savvy defender to still beat the contract regardless of what declarer does.

North

♠ J62
♥ A832
♦ QJ8
♣ 632

West

♠ Q9873
♥ J976
♦ 102
♣ 75

East

♠ A54
♥ Q105
♦ 964
♣ A1098

South

♠ K10
♥ K4
♦ AK753
♣ KQJ4

South

1 ♦
2NT
P

West

P
P
P

North

1 ♥
3NT

East

P
P

Opening Lead 7S

Offhand, this looks hopeless. East wins the first Spade with her ace and returns the 5. South takes the second spade trick with his king and can only see eight sure tricks, including the spade he just took, before East gets in with her ace of clubs and returns a spade, which allows West to take her three spade tricks and the contract is down 1.

But careful playing can make the contract, assuming West doesn't make a heroic play. When West leads the 7 of spades and East plays the ace, South must discard his king! His now bare 10 and the jack doubleton on the board stop the suit. When East returns the 5, South is not forced to take the trick since he no longer has the King, so he plays his 10. If West takes the queen, dummy's jack stops the suit on West's next spade lead. But the important part of this play is that by requiring three spade tricks at the outset, when East gets in with her ace of clubs she no longer has a spade to return to West and South makes the contract with a possible overtrick.

In order to defeat the contract, however, West must decline the second trick and allow declarer to win the trick with his spade 10. That leaves East with one spade to return

to West's queen when she takes her ace of clubs. But how many Wests will be courageous enough to decline the second trick?

How to Make a Contract When It Appears You Have Too Many Losers

Can you make 4 spades here?

Dummy

♠ KQ74

♥ K63

♦ 95

♣ K1086

Declarer

♠ J10953

♥ A85

♦ A4

♣ A75

Bidding:

North

P

3 ♠

East

P

P

South

1 ♠

4 ♠

West

P

Opening Lead KD

I had this hand in a club game several years ago. After I made four spades, my opponent, a lady who was an experienced and accomplished player, asked what they did wrong since I was the only one to make four spades. I told her that as the cards lay it could not be beaten if it's played correctly. Although this seemed an easy hand to me, it was clear that to the majority of players in that game, it was not.

When you are playing in a no trump contract, the first thing you do is count your winners and then try to figure out where you're going to get the tricks you need to make your contract.

In a suit contract, on the other hand, the first thing you do is to count your losers. If you have too many losers to make your contract, you have to figure out where you're going to be able to get rid of a loser before your opponents take it. Here it looks as if you'll lose one card in each suit. How can you lose only three tricks, making 4? You should be able to see it immediately.

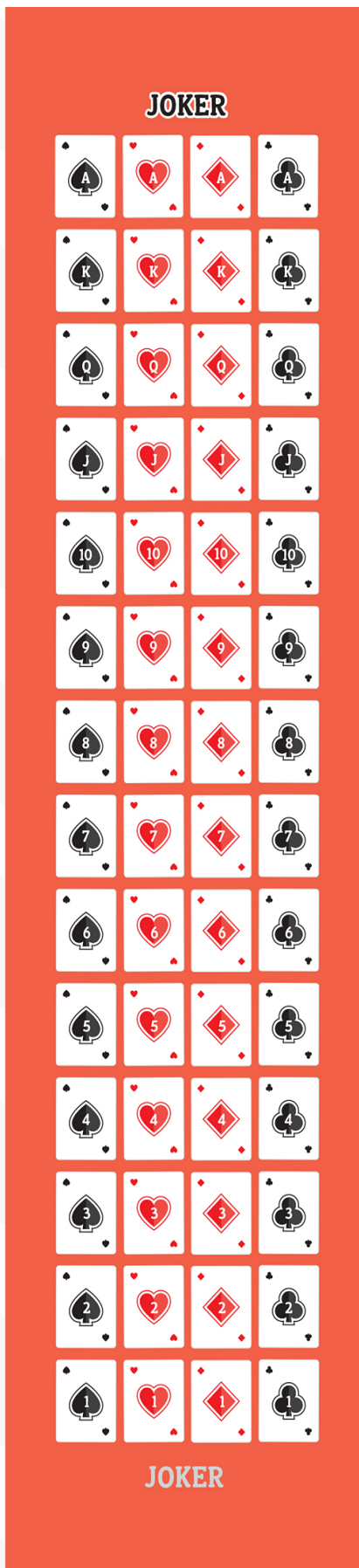
Give up? Win the first trick with the ace of diamonds and force out the ace of spades because you must keep control of the lead after you lose the ace of spades. Do whatever you need to draw trump.

After you lose the ace of spades, you then lose the diamond. It still looks like you're going to lose a club and a heart.

You start with the clubs. Play the king, then lead low to dummy. Play low from dummy. They will get in and lead a heart, which you win. Then you play to dummy's ace of clubs. If clubs split 3-3, you can throw your losing heart in your hand on the last club, allowing you to trump the third heart still on the board. If clubs don't split 3-3, you have to lose a heart in addition to the three you've already lost.

The lesson here is to count your losers, 4, which is one short of the 3 tricks you can lose and still make your contract, and then visualize the best way to get rid of one of those losers, allowing you to take an extra trick with this hand at the first trick. The four clubs on the board and three in your hand should shout at you that if they split 3-3, that's your ticket home.

When playing a no trump contract, you start off by counting your sure winners, a trick you can take without fear of surrendering the lead. Establish your long suit before you lose your entries by ducking and the use of the finesse. You can hold up to protect against opponents' ability to establish their long suit. You can duck and intentionally lose an early trick to set up a long suit in your weak hand with few entries.



Chapter 23

Declarer Play in Suit Contracts

When you're playing in a suit contract, you have a huge basic difference between playing in a no trump contract. That difference is that you have one suit that is all-powerful: the trump suit.

Having a trump suit enables you to take high cards in non-trump suits with low cards in the trump suit if you're void in the suit led. This makes playing a suit contract substantially different from playing in a no trump contract, where an ace that is led will *always* take the trick, and where having the lead is so important.

How to Count Your Losers

If you're playing in a suit contract, you immediately count your losers. How? You must combine your hand and dummy's hand in your mind's eye. Then you gather the high cards in each and see if they will eliminate losers in the other. For example, look at the following spades holding in the two hands:

Dummy

♠ Q65

Declarer

♠ AK43

Declarer has two losers, the 4 and the 3. Dummy has three losers: the unprotected queen, the 6, and the 5. But when you put the two hands together you see that the queen is not a loser at all, but a winner, because declarer has both the ace and the king.

Then you look at the other losers. You see that one of the losers in declarer's hand is protected by the queen in dummy. So that reduces the number of losers in declarer's hand from two to one.

Dummy still has two losers, the 6 and the 5. But you see that they're protected by the ace and the king in declarer's hand. So dummy has no losers when you combine the hands, and declarer has only one potential loser, which may not be a loser if the suit splits 4-3-3-3 and trumps are drawn (meaning that declarer has played enough trump tricks so that neither opponent holds any trump).

You count losers in the combined hands by two methods:

- + Shortness in declarer's hand
- + Missing high cards in both hands

Shortness in Declarer's Hand

Shortness in declarer's hand makes up for dummy's losers in a suit.

Here are examples of counting shortness losers:

Dummy

♠ 6543

Declarer

♠ 87

You would have two losers because declarer can ruff dummy's extra losers after losing her 8 and 7.

However, look at the following holding:

Dummy

♠ 43

Declarer

♠ 8765

In this holding, you would have to count four losers because shortness should only count in declarer's hand, unless dummy has at least the same number of trump as declarer. This rule is alleviated if dummy only has a singleton. Why? Because dummy should have at least three cards in your trump suit if you have bid the hand properly, so you should be able to trump losers quickly if dummy has only a singleton. However, you must be leery of being too sanguine about dummy's singleton, especially if you do not have the ace of the suit and you're up against savvy players.

Any defender of quality, who feels he and his partner have the bulk of the high cards in a suit, when seeing a singleton in dummy will immediately attack trump by leading it. He does this to lessen dummy's ruffing power. So if you don't have the ace, you'll have to lose a trick to get rid of your singleton. This will allow your opponents to lead trump to get rid of at least one trump in dummy.

Another disadvantage in counting shortness in dummy is that dummy's trump might consist of high cards you will need in pulling trump. Look at the following hand:

North (Dummy).

♠ 10
♥ AQ104
♦ AKQ
♣ 107632

South (Declarer).

♠ J95
♥ 86
♦ 987652
♣ AK

Bidding is as follows:

<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>
1 ♣	P	1 ♦	P
1 ♥	1 ♠	2 ♦	2 ♠
5 ♦	P	P	P

North liked your diamond bid, because she had the ace, king, and queen, so she jumped to a very questionable game. You'd like to use your spade shortness in dummy to ruff your losers in your hand, but each time you ruff in dummy, you're taking away a high card that can win a trick on its own. If you were to ruff three spades in dummy with the ace, king, and queen, you'd have two trump losers out against you: the jack and the 10. Clearly, the shortness in dummy doesn't help you much with your spade losers because your trumps in dummy consist of high cards you're going to need to take tricks when you pull trump.

If you pull trump, and it takes three rounds because they're split 3–1, and you find that your clubs don't set up, and you then lose the heart finesse, opponents will switch back to spades and you'll lose at least two more tricks because you're out of trump in dummy.

Moral: Shortness in dummy doesn't help you if you need all or most of dummy's trump to draw trump.

Missing High Cards

When you combine the two hands, the number of high cards that are missing is usually the number of losers you have in the suit.

Look at the following hands and see if you can count the losers:

1. Dummy

♠ Q32

Declarer

♠ KJ8

2. Dummy

♠ 542

Declarer

♠ AQ103

3. Dummy

♠ 432

Declarer

♠ KJ8

4. Dummy

♠ 432

Declarer

♠ AQJ

5. Dummy

♠ 10987

Declarer

♠ J43

6. Dummy

♠ 32

Declarer

♠ K8

7. Dummy

♠ Q2

Declarer

♠ K8

Hand 1: One loser. Combined, you have three cards in each hand and they include the king, queen, and jack. The ace is the only loser.

Hand 2: Three losers. The ace is the only winner. You could lose the others. You can't count shortness in dummy unless dummy is loaded with trump, which it usually isn't.

Hand 3: Three losers. The ace and queen could be sitting behind declarer. You could very easily lose all three tricks.

Hand 4: One loser, the king.

Hand 5: Three losers. You're missing the ace, the king, and the queen, and you have three cards in the suit in declarer's hand.

Hand 6: Two losers. The king is not supported by anything.

Hand 7: One loser. You have the king and the queen and only two cards in the suit in each hand. You'll lose the ace, but will win the next trick.

Trump

Trump is what distinguishes suit contracts from no trump. In no trump contracts, each suit has equal power. In suit contracts, the trump suit is all powerful. The deuce of trump can take the ace in any other nontrump suit. Therefore, how you manage your trumps is important.

However, what you've learned in playing the cards in the preceding chapter on no trump contracts still applies. You must be aware of the position of honors, and you'll still have to finesse occasionally. The difference is that you must manage your trumps.

Drawing Trump

Generally—and there are exceptions to this rule—the first thing you try to do in playing a suit contract is to establish your trump suit, sort of like you established a long suit in the preceding chapter. You're not necessarily going to take all the trump tricks, but you want to get rid of all the trump cards in your opponents' hands so they can't ruff any of your good non-trump tricks with their small trump. Look at the following hand.

North (Dummy).

♠ A853
♥ Q52
♦ J54
♣ Q98

West

♠ 74
♥ J106
♦ AK108
♣ 10763

East

♠ Q1092
♥ 83
♦ Q976
♣ K42

South (Declarer).

♠ KJ6
♥ AK974
♦ 32
♣ AJ5

You're in a contract of four hearts. West leads the ace of diamonds, which he wins. He follows with the king of diamonds, which he wins. He follows that with the 8 of

diamonds, and East covers North's jack with the queen. You, however, can win this trick because you are out of diamonds by now, so you can ruff. This shows you the basic difference between a suit contract and a no trump contract. In a no trump contract, you're helpless when an opponent runs a long suit. But in a suit contract, you can put an end to it by ruffing and taking the trick.

As soon as you get the lead, you should rid the opponents' hands of trump; therefore, you should play the ace and the king of hearts from your hand and then go to dummy to win opponents' last trump with the queen. You can then finesse East's king of clubs and queen of spades, and your contract is safely made. But the important thing is that you don't have to worry about losing one of your club or spade tricks through the opponents' trumping when they run out of the respective suit. That's why you play trump first, and arrange it so you are the only one who holds any remaining trump.

When you bid a contract, you should make sure that you have more combined trump than your opponents. Generally you will have eight or more trump between you and dummy, although occasionally you will find yourself playing a hand with only seven (or fewer) trump between you and dummy.

When Not to Pull Trump Immediately

Sometimes your losers are in your own hand and you're short in that suit in dummy. Let's change the previous hand a little, but you're still in a four-hearts contract, meaning you have to take 10 tricks:

North (Dummy).

♠ A853
♥ Q52
♦ 5
♣ Q9875

West

♠ 74
♥ J106
♦ AK108
♣ K1032

East

♠ Q1092
♥ 83
♦ Q9763
♣ 64

South (Declarer/You).

♠ KJ6
♥ AK974
♦ J42
♣ AJ

You have problems because you have three diamond losers. Neither your club nor your spade suit is going to set up. If you pull trump, how are you going to avoid losing two diamonds? The only way to make four hearts in this hand is for the play to go as follows:

West leads and takes the ace of diamonds. Seeing that the dummy is now void in diamonds, he switches to a spade, and you take East's queen with your king.

If you were to draw trump now, you would be making a fatal error. Instead of drawing trump, you lead a diamond from your hand and ruff it in dummy. You return to your hand by leading a low spade from dummy and take it with the jack of spades in your hand. You then lead your last diamond from your hand and ruff it in dummy. Voilà! You have rid yourself of your two diamond losers and have made two small trumps in dummy into winners. Now you can pull trump. Instead of taking five trump tricks, you've taken seven. Add to this your three spades tricks and the ace of clubs, and you make five. (Your contract was four hearts, but since you took 11 tricks, you made one trick over contract for an overtrick.)

But if you pulled trump immediately after getting the lead with the king of spades, your hand would look like this:

North (Dummy).

♠ A85

♥

♦

♣ Q9875

West

♠ 7

♥

♦ K108

♣ K1032

East

♠ 1092

♥

♦ Q97

♣ 64

South (Declarer).

♠ J6

♥ 97

♦ J4

♣ AJ

Now, what? How do you avoid losing two diamonds, along with the king of clubs, which you have to lose? Sometimes you have to ruff losers *before* you pull opponents' trump. This is the advantage of counting losers in a suit contract. You must know immediately where your losers are and how you're going to handle them before you start your play.

Here's another example of not only not pulling trump immediately, but doing it after taking all your other tricks:

North Dealer

EW Vulnerable

North (Dummy)

♠ A
♥ 652
♦ Q86432
♣ 652

West

♠ K7
♥ 9874
♦ 9
♣ AKJ1043

East

♠ 1098642
♥ AK
♦ AJ5
♣ 98

South

♠ QJ53
♥ QJ103
♦ K107
♣ Q7

Bidding:

West

North

East

South

	P	1 ♠	P
2 ♣	P	2 ♠	P
3 ♥	P	3NT	P
4 ♠	P	P	P

Opening lead: KD

Bidding Commentary: You don't like to open a hand in a major suit lacking the top four cards in the suit, but, on the other hand, East has a six-card major and 12 HCP. It's hard not to open that hand, so East opened 1S.

West's 2C bid showed at least five clubs and 10 points. East's only call is to rebid his six-card suit. West's second response of 3H normally shows hearts stopped, denies support in East's suit, and asks East to go to 3NT with diamonds stopped, which East did. West then correctly went to 4S since she did have two spades and did not have hearts stopped. East should have bid 3S after West showed he had six spades and a minimum hand. Had she done so, West would pass with a minimum hand and realizing that East probably didn't have three-card support.

Play Commentary: South's lead of the king of diamonds was unorthodox without also having the queen. East took the ace of diamonds. If he pulls trump immediately, he is pretty much assured of losing three trump plus two diamonds. He has to ruff his two losing diamonds before pulling trump, utilizing the two trump on the board to trump diamonds, even though one of them is the king. (I have to digress here a bit. As the cards lie, the queen of diamonds is onside, so if North gets in, she will probably take it, making East's jack good, holding the diamond loss to one, for down one. However, declarer has no reason to believe that South's opening lead wasn't a normal lead of top connecting honors. Who would lead a bare king? So declarer will play the hand thinking that the queen is on his left and thinking he has two sure diamond losers unless he ruffs them.)

When you are setting up a cross ruff, you should take your winning tricks immediately. Since you are leaving trump in the hands of your opponents, you don't want them sluffing cards in the suits in which you have winning cards while you are cross ruffing, and ruffing in when you try to take them. As you ruff, one of the opponents will run out of the suit and can get rid of cards in the suit you want to win with your aces and kings. So after East ruffs the 7 of diamonds on the board, he gets back to his hand with the king of hearts, ruffs the last diamond with the king on the board, and gets back to his hand with the ace of hearts.

Still avoiding trump, he plays to the ace and king of clubs, thereby taking all his winning tricks outside of the trump suit. At this point he has taken the ace of diamonds, AK of hearts, AK of clubs (seeing the queen fall from his LHO), and ruffed two diamonds on the board, so he has taken 7 tricks. He knows that South is out of clubs, so he ruffs a heart for his eighth trick, breathing easier to discover that hearts broke. Now he's got 8 tricks. He needs two more and here's the final layout:

North

♠ A
♥
♦ Q86
♣ 6

West

♠
♥ 9
♦
♣ J1043

East

♠ 109864
♥
♦
♣

South

♠ QJ53
♥ Q
♦
♣

Now he can pull trump (having no choice since that's all he has in his hand), and leads the 10. South plays low and North takes her singleton ace. North leads the queen of diamonds. East must trump with the six because he can't afford for South to win anything but the queen or jack. South takes the jack and leads the queen of hearts, allowing East to trump with the four, leaving him with the 9 and 8 of spades to South's queen and 5. East takes the last trick for his 10th, making the contract.

If East tries to pull trump before taking all his sure tricks and getting his two diamond ruffs, he will be down at least 1 and maybe 2.

Discarding Losers on Winners

Another way to get rid of losers is to discard them on winners in a longer suit. Look at the following hand, in which you hold the South hand and the contract is six hearts:

North

♠ J8
♥ A103
♦ AJ1065
♣ A105

West

♠ Q10764
♥ 5
♦ 742
♣ K962

East

♠ A9532
♥ 974
♦ Q983
♣ 8

South (You)

♠ K
♥ KQJ862
♦ K
♣ QJ743

Count your losers. For sure you should lose one spade. You lose no hearts, and maybe the queen of diamonds—a risky slam.

But you're lucky because West leads the 7 of diamonds. East is very coy and plays low, but you have to go up and take it with your singleton king, which gives you a diamond void in your hand. You draw trump and then lead the ace of diamonds from dummy. You discard your losing king of spades, and you make the contract because the club finesse is on.

Why can East play low on West's lead of the 7 of diamonds? He can see that he has the diamond 8, 9, and queen, and dummy has the jack and 10. So the only card that can take the 7 of diamonds is the king of diamonds. Playing the diamond 8, 9, or queen avails East nothing, so he plays low.

Ruffing Finesse

There's another finesse in the preceding hand. Can you see it? You can see the club finesse, but where's the other one?

You have what's called a *ruffing finesse* in diamonds, which is when you trump to cover an honor instead of a higher card of the same suit. It's not relevant to making this hand,

but because it does appear in this hand I'm going to explain it to you because it's a tool you can use to make some contracts. After you draw trump and get rid of the king of spades, the hands look like this:

<u>North</u>		
♠	J8	
♥		
♦	J106	
♣	105	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠	Q107	♠ A9532
♥		♥
♦	4	♦ Q9
♣	962	♣
<u>South</u>		
♠		
♥	J86	
♦		
♣	J743	

Look at your diamond holding. Three honors are still out: the queen, jack, and 10. You hold the jack and 10 in dummy, opposite a void in your hand. So you lead the jack. If East covers, you ruff it. If East plays low, you let it ride, discarding a club, playing East for the queen. If he has the queen, you win the trick. If West has it, you lose the trick.

Again, there's no reason to use the ruffing finesse in this hand because it doesn't get you anything. But sometimes using a ruffing finesse is the only way you will have to make your contract. I mention it here so you'll recognize it when it arises.

Setting Up a Long Suit to Discard Losers

Another way to get rid of losers is to set up a long secondary suit. Look at this hand:

North

♠ 932
♥ AQJ
♦ K8
♣ K9643

West

♠ QJ86
♥ 1093
♦ J96
♣ Q52

East

♠ AK107
♥ K2
♦ Q542
♣ J87

South (You)

♠ 54
♥ 87654
♦ A1073
♣ A10

You ended up in an extremely optimistic contract of four hearts, playing South. You get a spade lead and lose two spades before ruffing the third spade in your hand. You immediately lose a heart finesse. Now your hand looks like this and you can't lose any more tricks:

North

♠
♥ AQ
♦ K8
♣ K9643

West

♠ 8
♥ 109
♦ J96
♣ Q52

East

♠ A
♥ 2
♦ Q542
♣ J87

South

♠
♥ 876
♦ A1073
♣ A10

East returns a diamond, which you should take with your ace. Now what? You have diamond and club losers, even though you have the ace-king of clubs and the king of diamonds. Your only chance is to set up the clubs and hope they split 3-3. So you take out trump (lead and take trump tricks until the opponents have none), leaving you one

in your hand. Then you lead the ace of clubs and the 10 of clubs to the king. Now your hand looks like this:

<u>North</u>		
	♠	
	♥	
	♦ K	
	♣ 964	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ 8		♠ A
♥		♥
♦ J9		♦ Q5
♣ Q		♣ J
<u>South</u>		
	♠	
	♥ 8	
	♦ 1073	
	♣	

You lead the 4 of clubs and ruff it in your hand. You breathe much easier when you see both East and West discard clubs. Now the only two clubs left are on the board in North's hand, and you have a lead to the king of diamonds on the board. You have made a very difficult contract by setting up your 6 and 4 of clubs as the winning tricks, discarding your losing diamonds on them.

Remember the entry problem I mentioned in [Chapter 22](#)? You have it here, too. You have to retain an entry to the board to get back there to make your two little clubs good. That's why you took East's diamonds lead in your hand with the ace, preserving the king of diamonds as your entry to the board.

An even better example of a hand where you set up a long suit to make your contract occurred in the 1995 World Wide Bridge Contest. This hand has the added value of also showing the importance of the duck by declarer. Following are the hands:

North

♠ A6
♥ 8762
♦
♣ Q976543

West

♠ Q953
♥ Q10
♦ Q10432
♣ K2

East

♠ 10842
♥ J43
♦ AK95
♣ J10

South (You)

♠ KJ7
♥ AK95
♦ J876
♣ A8

Bidding:

West

P
P
P

North

2 ♣
4 ♥

East

P
P
P

South

1NT
2 ♥
P

Opening lead: 3 of diamonds

Your partner has a tough decision to make when you open 1 no trump. With only 6 HCP but seven clubs, four hearts, and a diamonds void, she should do something. She decided to bid 2 clubs because she had a four-card major. If you responded in 2 diamonds or 2 spades, she would bid 3 clubs as a sign-off bid and you'd play in her seven-card suit. When you responded with a fit in hearts, she jumped to game because her void now became worth 5 points and her hand reevaluates to 11 points. But it doesn't look easy, does it?

The only way to make this hand is to ruff the diamond in dummy. You then play the ace of clubs and another club, losing to West's king, and breathe a little easier when clubs split 2-2. You now have five good clubs tricks on the board if you can get to them and get the trump out.

West chose to lead another diamond, forcing you to ruff again on the board, leaving you with only two trump there. Now, what do you do? If you lead to the ace and king of trump, opponents are left with the high trump. You will be out of trump on the board and the ace of spades is your only entry, which you will have to use now to get there. Here's the hand at this stage:

		<u>North</u>	
		♠ A6	
		♥ 87	
		♦	
		♣ Q9765	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>	
♠ Q953		♠ 10842	
♥ Q10		♥ J43	
♦ Q104		♦ AK	
♣		♣	
		<u>South (You)</u>	
		♠ KJ7	
		♥ AK95	
		♦ J8	
		♣	

Lead is in North (Dummy). If you play the ace and king of hearts, East will be left with the jack. Here's the layout of the hand if you lead a low heart to your ace and then play the king:

		<u>North</u>	
		♠ A6	
		♥	
		♦	
		♣ Q9765	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>	
♠ Q953		♠ 10842	
♥		♥ J	
♦ Q104		♦ AK	
♣		♣	
		<u>South (You)</u>	
		♠ KJ7	
		♥ 95	
		♦ J8	
		♣	

Now, what? Your only hope in this hand is to make all the clubs good, but you can't lead over to the ace of spades and run the clubs because East will ruff in and then play the ace and king of diamonds and you'll be set. Furthermore, your ace of spades is your only entry to the board.

Instead of leading the ace and king of hearts, lead a low heart and duck, allowing your opponents to win. Now your contract is cold. Here's how the hands look after leading the low heart and ducking, retaining the heart, ace, and king:

<u>North</u>		
	♠ A6	
	♥ 8	
	♦	
	♣ Q9765	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ Q953		♠ 10842
♥ Q		♥ J4
♦ Q104		♦ AK
♣		♣
<u>South (You)</u>		
	♠ KJ7	
	♥ AK9	
	♦ J8	
	♣	

West leads another diamond, which you have to ruff with your last trump on the board. But you get back to your hand by leading a low spade to your king and then pull the remaining trump by leading your ace and king of hearts. You then go back to the board with a lead to the ace of spades and all your clubs are good, making five!

This hand is a very good example of two things you have learned:

- + How to set up a long suit in a trump contract
- + How to use the duck to make a difficult contract

The Crossruff

I don't think there's anything more enjoyable in bridge than to make a hand by crossruffing. What's a *crossruff*? Simply, it's when you have a short suit in dummy and a different short suit in your hand and you ruff back and forth. Look at the following hand:

North

♠ Q
♥ K98754
♦ QJ432
♣ 2

West

♠ K10963
♥ J
♦ 987
♣ Q954

East

♠ A542
♥ 10
♦ AK65
♣ KJ87

South (You)

♠ J87
♥ AQ632
♦ 10
♣ A1063

East–West is vulnerable, you're not. You are South, and the bidding went as follows:

You

1 ♥
P

West

P
P

North

4 ♥

East

P

You've gotten to a major-suit game with only 20 HCP between you and your partner. How are you going to make this? South has three spade losers, three club losers, and a diamond loser. North has a club loser, a bunch of diamond losers, and a spade loser.

You're going to crossruff. Let's say that your opponents lead a spade, which they win with the ace. East switches to a heart, which you win in your hand, and find that you have drawn trump because each of your opponents has a singleton trump. You immediately lead your 10 of diamonds, surrendering your last trick. They switch to a club, which you take with your ace. Now your hand looks like this:

North

♠
♥ K9875
♦ QJ43
♣

West

♠ K1096
♥
♦ 98
♣ Q95

East

♠ 542
♥
♦ A65
♣ J87

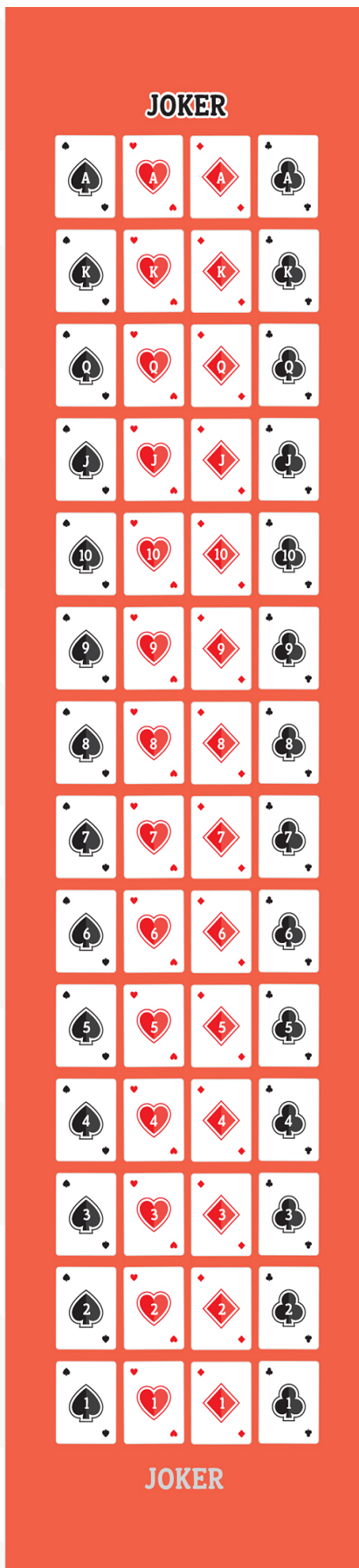
South

♠ J7
♥ Q632
♦
♣ 1063

You have five losers in South—two spades and three clubs. But you are void in both those suits in dummy and have five trump in dummy! Similarly, you have four losing diamonds in dummy, but you are void in diamonds and have four trump in your hand. It's a simple matter to just keep leading a nontrump suit from one hand and trumping it in the other. What a terrific feeling to take all those high honors with small little trump. With only 20 HCP, this hand makes five hearts, solely through the use of the crossruff!

You should have a compelling reason for making this play, which requires two cards well placed rather than just one for a simple finesse of the jack. Perhaps, by the bidding, West is marked with the queen of spades, which would justify this.

When playing a suit contract, count your losers in combined hands after you see dummy. If you have too many losers, see if you can ruff some of them before you pull trump. If you don't need to ruff losers in dummy, pull trump as soon as possible. Look for a way to establish one of the nontrump suits in either hand, then you can discard losers on that suit. Finally, crossruff if you have losers in both hands.



Chapter 24

Defense of the Hand: Opening Leads

After an auction concludes, the declarer's LHO makes the first lead. This is called the *opening lead*. Entire books are devoted to strategies for making an opening lead. In this chapter, you learn the basics of how to make this important move.

Opening Leads Against No Trump Contracts

The opening lead is made by declarer's LHO. So if declarer is on your right, you will make the opening lead.

The opening lead is the most important aspect of defense. There is a lot to consider. Therefore, before you just throw down a card to get the hand started, you should pause and think about how you're going to defend.

In defending no trump, your longest suit is generally your strongest suit. Keep that in mind throughout the following discussion.

Now forget about your hand for a moment. In defending no trump, often you must try to determine what's in your partner's hand and play to her hand.

The first thing you should take into consideration is what you've learned from the bidding. Following are some questions you should consider before making your lead:

- + Has your partner bid a suit?
- + Has she made a double?
- + Have your opponents bid any suits?
- + Did the dummy bid a suit?

Let's take these questions in order.

When Your Partner Has Bid a Suit

If your partner bid a suit freely, you know that she has at least five cards in it. How many cards do you have in that suit? If you have three or more, that suit is probably your strongest asset in defending this hand because you have at least eight cards between you and your partner.

If your partner has bid a suit, you must determine which card in her suit you want to lead. Here are the rules:

- + If you have at least three cards including an honor (commonly called “three to an honor”) lead your lowest card.
- + If you have exactly three cards in her suit but no honor, lead the highest card in her suit.
- + If you have two in her suit, lead the higher card.
- + If you have *connecting honors* (a holding of two consecutive honor cards in the same suit, like the king–queen or jack–10), lead the top connecting honor, no matter how many cards you have in her suit.

What if you have a five-card suit yourself? Should you lead your suit or your partner’s? Answer: If you don’t have a very strong suit, such as a five-card suit with only one honor, *lead your partner’s suit!* Here’s why:

Make your partner happy. If you lead your suit and it’s the wrong lead, your partner’s first question will be, “Why didn’t you lead my suit?” If you lead her suit and it’s wrong, she can’t criticize you. It might sound selfish, but it’s the best way to keep your partnership on an even keel.

From a bridge point of view (yes, we do still think about bridge in our partnerships!), it’s better to lead *to* a suit than to lead *from* a suit. So if you lead to your partner’s suit it will force your opponents to lead to your suit, or will allow your partner to lead to your suit. Furthermore, you know that she has a suit, so you know that leading her suit will help her. Leading your suit could work to your disadvantage because you’re telling declarer where the power is in your suit. Keep that a secret for a while. Because your partner has given you a lead, take it. Interestingly, the selfish lead would appear to be to lead your own suit. In actuality, however, the selfish lead is your partner’s suit because you don’t want to be criticized. Listen, if you think this sounds silly, even the best players in the world think this way. Nobody likes to have their partner yell at them.

Another thing to consider is when no trump was first bid. Did declarer bid no trump after your partner bid her suit, after their pair had been bidding suits? If so, it's a clear indication that declarer has stoppers in your partner's suit. If you lead the suit, one of the downsides you must consider is that you'll be leading right through her into the power in her suit. Let's say that the bidding went like this:

<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>
1 ♥	P	1 ♠	2 ♦
2NT	P	3 ♣	P
3NT	P	P	P

Declarer is telling his partner (and you) that he has no fear of your partner's diamond suit. But what else do you know about this hand from the bidding? You can glean the following information:

- + RHO has five hearts—no more. If he had six hearts he would have rebid them. Because he opened 1 heart, he must have five, but not six.
- + LHO has at least four spades.
- + LHO doesn't have three hearts. If he had three hearts, because he knows his partner has five hearts, he would have placed the contract in four hearts because of the eight-card major fit. Because he never supported hearts, he has a maximum of two hearts in his hand.
- + Your partner has at least five diamonds and close to an opening hand because she bid at the 2 level after opponents had bid 2 suits.
- + RHO has diamonds stopped, at least twice probably.
- + LHO has at least four clubs, maybe five.
- + RHO doesn't have four spades. If he had four spades, because he knows partner has at least four spades, he would have supported spades or placed the contract in 4 spades after his partner bid 3 no trump.
- + LHO has at least 10 points, probably more.

Knowing this, you should have a pretty good picture of the structure of each of your opponents' hands:

LHO

♠ xxxxx
♥ xx
♦ x
♣ xxxxx

RHO (Declarer)

♠ xx
♥ xxxxx
♦ xxxx
♣ xx

Your partner might have the following diamond holding:

♦ KJ10875

Your hand looks like this:

♠ J74
♥ 9642
♦ 94
♣ QJ62

What should you lead? Your partner bid diamonds, so that should be your first choice. However, declarer said he had no fear of diamonds. Despite this, you must trust your partner. She has at least five, maybe six. This is why the opening lead is so important. If declarer only has diamonds stopped twice, he could be using his first stopper on the first lead. So, let's look at declarer's diamond holding:

♦ AQ32

Anybody would be willing to bid no trump over his RHO's diamonds bid with the ace and the queen behind the probable king. But if you start out leading the 9 of diamonds, it starts to set up your partner's hand. So with all this thought, you lead the 9 of diamonds. (Remember: if you have two cards in your partner's suit, lead the higher card.) But you can only make this determination by thinking about what you know about the hands from the bidding and, finally, trusting your partner.

When You Can Lead Something Other Than Your Partner's Suit

Sometimes you don't lead your partner's suit. Two such instances follow:

If you have a strong, self-establishing suit of your own to lead. Let's say your partner bid diamonds and your hand looks like the following:

♠ 974
 ♥ KQJ95
 ♦ 84
 ♣ K83

With this holding you should lead your king of hearts because you'll probably be able to take four heart tricks here, and you have another possible entry with the king of clubs. With this hand you have a good answer when your partner asks, "Why didn't you lead my suit?" But she probably won't ask that. She'll probably say, "Nice lead, Partner!" Here's another hand that exemplifies choosing your own lead regardless of what partner has bid:

Here's your hand as dealer:

♠ K1083
 ♥ 109
 ♦ Q5
 ♣ AQJ64

Auction:

<u>You</u>	<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>
1 ♣	P	1 ♦	P
1NT	P	P	Dbl
P	2 ♥	P	2NT
P	P	P	

As a preliminary that has nothing to do with the point we are discussing, your first rebid should be 1S, not 1 no trump, but that's the way this hand was bid, so that's the way I'm writing about it.

Question: What do you lead? I was your partner in this deal. I haven't supported your suit, clubs; I bid diamonds. I did not double the 2NT contract, which might suggest a lead (although it would be pretty ambiguous; would a double ask for her suit or mine, or would it just say "I think we can defeat this contract; I'm not suggesting a lead?"). But with this hand it does not matter what your partner might suggest as a lead. Even

if partner doubles for a different lead, you have only one lead. This brings up the first basic rule in defending no trump. All the other rules are subservient to this. No matter what partner has done, if you have a better lead than what partner suggests in your own hand, lead it.

Here are all four hands:

North

♠ QJ95
♥ J54
♦ KJ93
♣ K10

West (me)

♠ 2
♥ A863
♦ A7642
♣ 952

East

♠ K1083
♥ 109
♦ Q5
♣ AQJ64

South

♠ A764
♥ KQ72
♦ 108
♣ 873

Unfortunately, my partner thought she should lead my suit, so she led the diamond queen. Her lead had the deleterious consequence of me returning a diamond when I got in since I had no idea of her club holding. She could have four little clubs with her points elsewhere. Then it's too late for the clubs because declarer's three diamonds set up.

It doesn't matter what I hold here in determining what to lead. If she leads the club queen, declarer must take the king. When I get in with one of my aces, I then know to shoot back a club and declarer is history. We get four club tricks and my two aces, minimum, for down 1. Plus, her K10 of spades is well situated for another trick for down 2. Dreaming further, declarer might mis-guess the diamond queen since I bid diamonds for down 3.

Here are the basic rules for leading against no trump. The card you should lead is in bold (a complete list of standard leads is at the end of this chapter):

AKJX

AJ109

KQ109

AQJx

A109x

Here are the reasons. If you lead, for example, the jack from AJ109 and declarer takes the king or queen in his hand and the other isn't on the board, when partner gets in she will lead your suit back through the remaining honor in declarer's hand and you have a very good chance of taking three (or four if you have a five-card suit) tricks unless declarer started with four cards in the suit.

If you are leading the queen from KQ109, partner must drop the jack if she has it. Why? Because a savvy declarer who has AJx will hold up on your queen lead and if you continue, will take two tricks. So partner must drop the jack if she has it if you lead the queen on opening lead. That allows you to continue leading the suit without worrying about giving declarer an extra trick. In fact, with most of these leads, if you have an honor, you should play it on her lead, for the same reason. It sets up the rest of her hand and allows her to continue the suit if declarer ducks.

Another thing to remember about these leads is that if partner leads the queen and you have the jack, you know what she's got. Similarly, if she leads the king and you have the queen, you know that she should be holding AKJx. In both cases, you can freely play your honor on her lead without concern that you're giving up a trick. If, however, partner leads the ace and you have the queen, don't drop it because she should be denying AKJ.

If you have a singleton in her suit and you have a suit you might be able to develop in your hand. If you have a basically worthless hand, however, you should lead the singleton because your partner's hand is your best line of defense, and that's her best suit.

When Your Partner Doubles the Final 3 No Trump Contract

If your partner doubles the final 3 no trump contract for penalty, it's not just for penalty. *A double of a 3 no trump contract asks partner to make a specific lead.* The rules for the specific leads requested by a double follow:

- + If your partner (who doubled) has bid a suit, lead her suit.
- + If you have bid a suit, lead your suit.
- + If neither of you has bid, you should lead dummy's first-bid suit *unless you have a better lead in your hand.* You can use your own judgment here.
- + If you have both bid, you should use your own judgment. But if you don't have a terrific suit, lead your partner's suit.

If no suit has been bid by opponents and neither of you has bid. Look at the following bidding:

<u>LHO</u>	<u>Partner</u>	<u>RHO</u>	<u>You</u>
1NT	P	3NT	P
P	Dbl	P	P
P			

By doubling, your partner is asking for an unusual lead—like a singleton—from your hand. She's saying that she has a long suit that, if you find it, will set the contract. In this instance, you forget all the standard leads and lead your singleton or the shortest suit in your hand.

When Opponents Have Bid a Suit

If the opponents bid suits, you want to stay away from leading any suit bid by declarer for your opening lead unless it's a very good suit and you're pretty confident that your holding is longer than declarer's. Leading declarer's suit—even if it's your best suit—means that you are *leading into strength*. Declarer will have the last play on the trick and will generally be able to take it with a card that allows an extra trick. If you don't have cards in the suit bid by declarer, there's a fair chance that your partner will. And if she does, you'll be leading right through her into declarer's strength.

Generally, you try to lead a suit that hasn't been bid. If your opponents are bidding their suits and end up in no trump, the longest suit you and your partner have is usually the unbid suit.

When Dummy Bid a Suit

Often it's a good lead to *lead through strength*. This means that if dummy has bid a suit, it's sometimes a good lead to lead through that suit. This is especially true if you don't hold an honor in that suit. The reason is that dummy may have a suit with broken honors, like AQxx or KJxx. There is a possibility that your partner holds the missing honors. This is especially true if dummy was not the opening bidder and responded in a major that was not supported by opener. If you're short in that suit, there's a good chance that's your partner's suit.

Leading with Fourth from Longest and Strongest

The standard lead against a no trump contract is to lead the fourth highest card in your longest suit. Look at the following hand:

♠ AQ4
♥ 84
♦ 98642
♣ K109

When you're on defense against a no trump contract, your strongest suit is your longest suit. In this hand, the strongest suit is diamonds, and the fourth highest card in your diamonds suit is the 4. So you should lead the 4 of diamonds.

There's sound reasoning behind this lead, even though both your clubs and spades look like better suits. You want to set up one or two diamond tricks. Diamonds may be split evenly. If so, the other three hands hold 3–3–2 in diamonds. That leaves you with two good diamonds if you get in after they've been led three times. And you have three possible entries into your hand, the ace and queen of spades, and the king or 10 of clubs. This is not counting the possibility that your partner might get lucky and take a trick then lead a diamond. Even if opponents hold all the diamond honors, if they're

split as anticipated, when you finally get in you'll set 3 no trump because you'll get two diamond tricks. You have a good chance of getting two spade tricks and a club trick as well. And this isn't counting on partner for anything.

Counting the Points in Your Partner's Hand

How many points do you think your partner has if you're defending 3 no trump in this hand? The answer: not many. You have 9 HCP in your hand, and your opponents probably have at least 25 HCP. That only leaves 6 HCP for your partner. But that might be enough for her to get in once and lead a diamond.

You must rely on your partner to trust you and lead a diamond when she gets in, regardless of the holding in her hand. She might have five hearts and want to set up her hearts. But she must trust you and return a diamond if you led a low diamond. If she were to switch to a heart, it would destroy your defense and render your good diamond lead valueless. You're probably getting sick of hearing this, but *partners must trust one another*. Following is the entire hand:

North (Partner)

♠ 632
♥ KJ632
♦ 103
♣ Q63

West (Dummy)

♠ 9875
♥ 1095
♦ KJ7
♣ A87

East (Declarer)

♠ KJ10
♥ AQ7
♦ AQ5
♣ J542

South (You)

♠ AQ4
♥ 84
♦ 98642
♣ K109

The bidding went like this:

<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>
1NT	P	2 ♣	P
2 ♦	P	2NT	P
3NT	P	P	P

The play might go like this. You lead the 4 of diamonds, declarer plays low from dummy, and your partner plays the 10, which declarer wins with the queen. Declarer tries a club that loses to your partner's queen.

This is the biggest play of the hand right here. What card your partner chooses to lead determines whether or not you're going to set the hand. She's going to be mighty tempted to switch to a heart—her good, long suit and the weakest suit in dummy—but she must have discipline and trust you. She must play a diamond despite her nice hearts. It doesn't matter how declarer then plays the diamonds because after your partner's lead, he only has one more diamond stopper. When you *get in* (get the lead), you'll take it out and then when you get in again, you'll have the setting tricks in your remaining two diamonds. If your partner were to switch to a heart instead of returning your diamond, however, you wouldn't have enough remaining entries to take out declarer's two diamond stoppers, and he would probably make the hand. Charles Goren says that every time the defense leads a new suit it amounts to losing a half trick on average!

Furthermore, when she switches, it will tell a savvy declarer that she (his RHO) has the heart honors and, if declarer plays low from his hand, you won't have a card high enough to keep the 10 from winning the trick on the board. This gives him an additional winner with the 10 on the board and an additional entry to the board (the 10 he wins with this trick) to finesse through her.

When Leading from a Weak Suit, You Must Have Entries

Your diamond suit is admittedly a weak five-card suit. However, you have entries in other suits that will allow you to get in and set up your diamonds. If you have a Yarborough or a hand without more than one entry, you should *not* lead the diamond

because it will give your partner a false hope that your opponents can be set up. And they can't if there's no way you can get the lead to take advantage of your long suit. So if you were without the ace—queen of spades and the king of clubs you would lead something else, even though, as the cards lie, any other lead would be harmful.

Leading with Top Connecting Honors

Another potential lead is the top connecting honors. But in no trump this is often not a good lead unless they're internal connecting honors—like KJ10x, leading the jack, or a three-card sequence, like QJ10x. Why? Because you give up a possible trick if opponents have the ace, which they probably do.

What would you lead against a no trump contract with the following club holding?

♣ KQ74

You have two choices from the two rules you've learned: do you lead the top connecting honor, or do you lead fourth from longest and strongest? The answer: lead fourth. You give up a potential trick if you lead the king. Your partner might have the ace or jack. If she has the ace, she can take the trick and return it and you might get four club tricks off the top if they split 4–3–3–3. If she has the jack, it will either force out the ace or she can return it to you.

What would you lead from the following club holding against a no trump contract?

♣ KJ104

In this instance, you should lead the top connecting honor, the jack. Why? Because with your king on top of the jack–10, whichever card you force out—be it the ace or the queen—makes the remaining two of the top three honors outstanding, which should result in a trick.

Standard Leads Against No Trump Contracts

The following list shows the standard opening leads when defending against a no trump contract. The standard lead is bold and underlined:

<u>X</u> X	XXX <u>X</u>
<u>X</u> XX	XXX <u>X</u> X
A <u>K</u> Jx	A <u>Q</u> Jx
AJ109	A <u>10</u> 9x
<u>K</u> QJx	K <u>Q</u> 109
KJ10x	K <u>10</u> 9x
<u>Q</u> J10x	Q <u>10</u> 9x
J109x	<u>10</u> 9xx

One lead here is a departure from the norm, so it bears explaining. It's the lead of the queen from the holding of KQ109. Normally you'd think you'd lead the king or the 9, but you lead the queen to ask your partner to jettison the jack if she has it.

If you lead the queen and she has the jack, she'll know that you're leading from this specific holding. Otherwise, the lead of the queen in a no trump defense would promise a holding of QJ10. But if she has the jack you can't be leading from that, so you must be leading from KQ109. She must drop the jack to keep from *blocking* your suit. (You block your partner's suit when your partner has several good cards remaining in a suit but you must take the trick because your only card in that suit is higher ranking than the remaining cards in her suit. This results in partner having no way to get the lead back into partner's hand to allow her to cash her tricks.) Leading the queen has the further advantage of allowing you to continue the suit. If declarer has the ace-jack, he might not take the ace (called "holding up" the ace), hoping you will continue leading the suit with the queen and thereby allowing her to get two tricks—both the ace and the jack. So if your partner plays the jack when you lead the queen, it allows you to continue the suit without worrying about giving declarer a trick he otherwise wouldn't get.

If she holds Jxx in the suit, and you hold the king and follow with the queen, it will be taken by the ace. If you get in again and lead the 10, your partner will be forced to overtake with her jack because it's the only card she has left in the suit. Now you can't

win the 9 unless you have another entry into your hand. But if she plays the jack at your first play of the queen, your remaining cards are all good tricks after the ace is played. Playing the jack when partner leads the queen has the added advantage of allowing the leader to continue leading the suit without fear that opener has the ace and the jack, which would allow her to take two tricks—the jack in addition to the ace—for one more trick than she would get if you didn't lead the king after you led the queen.

One of the purposes of a standard lead is that it tells your partner what you have in your hand. If she sees you lead the 10, for example, she'll know that it promises the 9 and denies the jack. If you lead the king, it means that you have either the ace or the queen and jack along with it. But one thing to notice about these standard leads is that none of them consists of *top connecting honors when you only have two connecting honors*, which is a standard lead against a suit contract (as you'll see shortly). However, top connecting honors of three in a row is a good defensive lead against a no trump contract.

Opening Leads Against Suit Contracts

When you're on lead against a suit contract, your defense is substantially different than when you're on lead against a no trump contract. When defending against no trump, you're trying to set up a long suit. You can be patient to try to develop this suit.

When defending against a suit contract, however, you must take your tricks when you can. Because declarer has the ability to ruff aces and kings, you have to take them before declarer has been able to create a void in his hand, which renders your ace or king valueless.

When defending against a suit contract, however, you have different ways of attacking, only one of which involves setting up a long suit. Setting up a long nontrump suit is a very rare defensive tactic because it relies on declarer running out of trump and you getting the lead to set up your suit. It happens, but not often.

When defending against a suit contract, you often have to take your tricks before declarer can get rid of losers and ruff your winners. If you have the ace-king-queen of a suit, for instance, they would be worth three cold tricks in no trump. If you're playing a suit contract and declarer has a void in that suit, the ace-king-queen are worthless.

The Best Lead Against a Suit: Ace-King

Louis Watson, author of the best book on play of the hand—called, not too surprisingly, *Watson's Classic Book on the Play of the Hand at Bridge* (1971)—says that the best lead against a suit contract is the king from the ace-king holding. This is a great lead for two reasons:

It almost definitely wins you the first trick.

It allows you to get a view of dummy before making your next lead. As you recall, dummy is turned face up after the opening lead. If you are able to lead a card that will take the trick, like king from ace-king, you can see the dummy before you make your second lead.

Unfortunately, it is not often that you're defending against a suit contract and you find yourself in the wonderful position of being able to lead from an ace-king.

Leading Your Partner's Suit

When you haven't bid and you don't have a good lead from your hand, leading your partner's suit is usually a good lead and is generally safe. There are two theories about whether or not you should lead your highest card in a suit.

For years, when I was playing with my first steady partner, Nancy Kelly, and we were playing Standard American and no systems we played that you always led the top of your partner's bid—and it worked wonderfully. Nobody else liked it, but it does give your partner an instant idea of where the other cards in her suit are.

But most experts insist that if you lead your partner's suit, the lead should be as follows:

+ Low from an honor. So if you have Q72 you would lead the deuce.

- + **High from a doubleton.** You're trying to get a ruff and you want to tell your partner that you only have two. Of course, she won't know until the next time the suit is led whether or not you were leading a singleton or doubleton.
- + **A singleton.** This is a wonderful lead because if your partner has the ace, which is more likely if you lead her suit than if you're leading an unbid suit, you're almost always assured that she'll return it and you'll get a ruff. Again, she has to determine whether you led a singleton or doubleton, but if she comes to the correct conclusion, you'll start out with two tricks.
- + **Middle card from three worthless.** This is called *MUD* for *middle-up-down*. It gives your partner *count*, which is an indication of whether you have an even or odd number of cards in the suit led. If you lead a lower or middle card and the next card you play in the suit is higher, it indicates that you have an odd number of cards in that suit. Count tells your partner whether you have an even or odd number of cards in the suit led. Generally, if you have an even number of cards in a suit, you will play a high card first, then a low card. If you have an odd number of cards in the suit, you first play a low card and then one higher. People who play MUD are in the minority, but I'm one of them.

There's one time when you shouldn't lead your partner's suit: when you have a lot of cards in it. If your partner bid hearts, for example, and you have five hearts in your hand, the likelihood is that declarer could be void and your heart lead will just turn the lead over to him without you taking a trick.

Top of Connecting Honors

You learned about this lead in the section on leads against no trump contracts. Against no trump, it's not a terrific lead unless you have a three-card sequence, like queen-jack-10. Top of two connecting honors is a better lead against a suit contract because it sets up a relatively sure trick. Remember, against suit contracts you always must be sensitive to taking your tricks in outside suits before declarer can ruff them. If your first lead is the king from king-queen and if declarer has the ace, you have a good chance of

getting a trick with your queen before he can set up a side suit to rid himself of the loser in the led suit.

Leading a Singleton

The idea here is to create an instant void in your hand so that if the suit is led again before you're out of trump, you can ruff. However, it requires a firm partnership understanding that your partner will return your opening lead when she finally gets the lead herself.

When you're on defense and you're not on opening lead, if you get in you should *return* your partner's suit unless there's a very good reason not to do so.

You don't want to lead a singleton unless it has the possibility of giving you a trick you might not otherwise get. For example, if you have Q74 of trump, a singleton lead really doesn't do you much good because you have the queen protected by two. If you are forced to use a small trump, your queen will fall with the lead of the ace and the king—so you really haven't gained anything. If opponent leads his ace and king of trump (if he has them), your queen will be good. If you've trumped with your low trump first, however, he will capture your queen on his second lead, so you haven't really gained a trick. You only get one trick with your trump either way. That doesn't mean that you shouldn't lead a singleton when you have a holding like Qxx, however. There are several ways you could still get your queen even after you ruff.

Sometimes a lead of a singleton is a good lead; often it's not. If you have only small trump, it's okay because you might be able to take advantage of the trump.

That said, if your partner has bid the suit in which you hold a singleton, it's almost always the best lead you can make for obvious reasons. There's little more frustrating than to lead a singleton, have your partner get the lead while you still have some trump in your hand, and see her lead a different suit. You sit there in helpless anguish while your brilliant lead becomes worthless.

Leading a Singleton Honor

This is a paradox that faces many players. Opponents have the contract and you have a singleton honor. Should you lead it? The answer is, unless your partner has bid the suit, *no*. You're going to have a good chance to win a trick with this card during the play of the hand if your opponents try a finesse. But if your partner has bid the suit, it's a terrific lead. Not only will it set up a ruff in your hand, but it will probably help to set up your partner's suit.

Fourth from Longest and Strongest

You learned about this in the section on leads against no trump, and it's a valid lead against a suit contract, too. It's a good, safe, standard lead.

Cards That Smile; Cards That Frown

On opening lead, the specific card you lead communicates specific information to your partner:

- + **Leading a small card promises an honor in the suit being played, so it smiles.** So if you lead a deuce, 3, or 4, you're promising your partner that you have an honor in the suit, with one exception: if the next card you play in that suit is lower than the one you led (for example, if you lead the 4 and then play the 3), this tells your partner you led a doubleton.
- + **Leading a middle card denies an honor, so it frowns.** So if you lead, for example, the 7, it tells your partner to forget about your having any help for her in this suit.

Leading Suits with Aces Against Suit Contracts

One of the oldest axioms in bridge is *never underlead an ace*. Why? Well, whenever you succumb to the temptation to underlead an ace you see the singleton king come up on the board and you feel like an idiot—which is what I'm trying to keep you from feeling like here.

However, it doesn't matter whether it's a singleton king or a singleton anything else. If you underlead an ace and declarer has a singleton in his hand or in the dummy, and if

your partner doesn't have the king, you won't win your ace on this hand. You've just given up a trick.

To make matters more confusing, you shouldn't lead an ace! If you wonder about not leading an ace, just remember this axiom: aces were created to take kings or queens. As a general rule, you shouldn't play your ace until you can use it to take a king or queen. If your ace happens to be the setting trick, however, you should take it immediately.

So, where does that leave you? It means that against a suit contract below the slam level you shouldn't lead a suit in which you have an ace unless you have the king to go with it. (And, in the event of having an ace-king combination, you should lead the king first.) Even if your partner has bid the suit, you shouldn't lead the ace! There will be more about this a few paragraphs later.

If you lead an ace on opening lead, often you'll set up a king-queen combination for your opponents. If you wait to take your ace when they play one of their honors to try to take a trick, you might get an extra trick (if, for example, your partner has the Jxx in the suit). You certainly will keep them from making both the king and the queen!

So here are the rules relating to opening leads of suits with aces:

- + Don't underlead an ace.
- + Don't lead an ace against a contract below the slam level unless you have the king (then lead the king first).

Now I'm going to explain why you shouldn't lead an ace even if your partner has bid the suit. You hold the following:

♠ AJ4
♥ 75
♦ 8643
♣ J1098

Your partner opens 1 spade. RHO overcalls 2 hearts. By now you should know that you should bid 2 spades with this hand, so you do. And then LHO bids 3 hearts, which

is passed out. It's your lead. Do you remember the first thing you should do before leading? *Think!* What do you know?

1. How many spades does your partner have and how big is her hand? Answer: five with a minimum. If she had six she would have rebid them, even with a minimum hand.
2. How many spades do opponents have? The answer: five. Your partner has five spades and you have three spades. That leaves five.
3. Key question: You have the ace. Who has the king—your partner or your opponents? Because your partner has a minimum, probably 13 points, and you have 6 HCP, opponents have 20 to 21 points. In this situation, more than half of the time opponents will have the king of spades. Why? Because more than half the points outside of your hand belong to opponents, 21 for them, 13 for your partner.

So there are two definite negatives to leading your ace:

- + More than half of the time your lead of the ace will make the king a definite winner for opponents, because by leading your ace you can't take their king.
- + You give them an easy ruff of a spade. Why? Because spades will split one of three ways: 3–2, 4–1, or 5–0. In the first situation, you help them get rid of spades quickly so they may ruff before starting to pull trump. In the second, you give them a void immediately and they can easily ruff before pulling trump. In the third, you lose the ace immediately with a ruff. In the first situation, if you lead the ace and then the king wins for them, they will have a void somewhere, which they can use to ruff a losing spade before you've had a chance to reduce their trump holding.

Leading an ace generally costs you half a trick. This is because if you don't lead the suit in which you have the ace, you might be able to lead trump, drive them out of trump where they have their short spades, and, as a result, end up taking three spades tricks. Often the shortness is in dummy where their short trump is.

In time and as your wisdom grows, you might find an instance when you should lead the ace. But for now you should adopt the following rules:

- + If you have at least three cards in the suit, don't lead an ace on opening lead.
- + Don't underlead an ace on opening lead.
- + If you have ace doubleton, however, the ace can be a very good lead against a suit contract. If your partner has the king and you lead the ace and follow with another card in the suit, she should know you're leading a doubleton and return the suit for ruff, giving you three tricks off the top.

Period. End of story. Incidentally, I have not yet found the wisdom alluded to in the preceding paragraph and follow these rules religiously.

The idea against underleading an ace is only applicable when you're defending against a suit contract. It doesn't apply when you're defending no trump contracts, when the preferred standard lead of your fourth from longest and strongest often requires you to underlead an ace.

Leading Trump

"When in doubt, lead trump," is another ancient axiom of bridge. Sometimes a trump lead is the best lead you can make. More often it's not. It's not a good lead when you or your partner are short in a suit and you'll want to ruff some tricks yourselves. It is a good lead in the following situations:

- + When dummy might be short in a suit and declarer will want to ruff his losers.
- + When you and your partner have a lot of HCP in outside suits.

The question is, how do you know? From the bidding! Following are situations in which a trump lead is advised.

- + If *all* of the following are true:
 - + You and your partner bid to game in a competitive auction.
 - + The ultimate declarer doubles you for penalty.
 - + His partner pulls the double and puts him in game in their suit.

- + You should lead trump because from the bidding you can deduce that declarer has a substantial holding in your suit whereas his partner is short. Ergo, the point of playing the hand will be for declarer to ruff in dummy the losers he holds in your suit. If you get off to a trump lead, you'll be cutting down his ability to ruff.
- + Your partner opens the bidding at 1 no trump, but the opponents end up playing in a suit contract. The reason here should be obvious. Your partner has a good high-card holding and opponents are going to try to ruff or crossruff the hand. You should lead a trump to cut down this ability.
- + If you make a takeout double and your partner leaves it in for penalty. You probably have only one trump and you should lead it.
- + You and your opponents bid only one suit each, each partnership establishing a trump fit between them, and opponents end up in a partscore contract. You'll want to drive them out of trump in the hand where they're short in your suit.

Leading Doubletons

If you're leading a doubleton, you lead the higher card, then play the lower card at your next opportunity. This tells your partner that you only have two. It's called *going high-low*. The lead of a worthless doubleton is one of the least desirable leads in bridge, but sometimes you have no choice.

The when-you-have-no-choice situation can appear if, for example, you're defending a heart contract and hold a hand like the following:

♠ AQ73
♥ Q72
♦ 83
♣ Q843

You don't want to underlead your ace-queen of spades, your queen of hearts, or your queen of clubs. So your least-harmful lead is the 8 of diamonds.

However, except in special circumstances, you shouldn't lead a doubleton when it's headed by an honor, like Kx, Qx, or Jx. You've got an opportunity to win a trick with your honor, so there's no reason to give that up by leading high-low from the

doubleton, unless your partner has *freely* bid the suit. To bid a suit freely means that partner wasn't forced to bid it because you made some sort of forcing bid, like a takeout double.

If your partner has freely bid the suit, the lead of the king from Kx can be very profitable in two situations:

- + If your partner has the ace, a presumable prospect, you should win the king. She'll win your next lead of your remaining card in the suit with her ace and return the suit for a possible ruff by you.
- + If she's lacking the ace, in all probability she'll have the queen or queen-jack combination, so you'll be setting up her hand to win tricks by driving out opponents' ace.

Standard Leads Against Suit Contracts

The following list shows standard leads when you are on opening lead against a suit contract. The standard lead is bold and underlined:

xx

xxx**x**

x**xx**

xxx**xx**x

A**K**x

109x

KQx

K**J**10x

QJx

K**10**9x

J109

Q**10**9x

KQ109

Note the difference between opening leads against suit contracts and opening leads against no trump contracts (discussed earlier in this chapter). In a no trump defense, leading top connecting honors when you only have two connecting honors isn't a good lead. But against a suit contract top connecting honors of two connecting honors is a very good lead.

Note also that when you have the ace–king in a suit, the standard method of playing is to lead the king, not the ace. The only time you don't do this is if your ace–king is a doubleton. If you lead the ace and then the king, you're telling your partner that you're now void in the suit; so if she gets in before trump is pulled, you might be able to get a ruff if she leads the suit. The converse is that if you lead the king and then the ace, you're promising her that you have at least one more card in the suit. However, there are also many players who reverse this and lead the ace from ace–king. If they lead the king and then the ace it shows the doubleton. This is the way I play so always ask your partner how they play it.

Also, note the difference in standard lead when you hold KQ109. In no trump defense, you lead the queen, asking your partner to jettison her jack if she has it. Against a suit contract, you lead the king. Against a suit contract, you're trying to take your tricks before declarer can ruff them, so you're not trying to set up a long suit, as you would be if you were defending a no trump contract. Also, against a suit contract you're not so concerned about blocking and unblocking. Finally, if you lead the king you are telling your partner that you almost certainly hold the queen.

Leads Against Slams

If you're playing against a grand slam and you have an ace, it's probably going to be ruffed. Why would anybody in their right mind make a contract to take all the tricks without an ace unless that ace was of no concern to them?

The only reason the ace would be of no concern to them is if they're void in that suit. If you lead an ace, you're probably going to have it ruffed immediately. If so, you might be setting up a suit for them containing the king and queen, giving them a better chance of making their contract. Don't lead an ace against a grand slam contract in a suit for this reason.

To elaborate a little further on this, they might have to make a ruffing finesse to make the contract if they don't know where the ace is. Look at the following spade holding in a contract of seven hearts by East:

Partner

♠ 76432

West

♠ KQJ109

East (Declarer)

♠ Void

You

♠ A85

If you lead the ace on opening lead, you set up West's spades. If you don't lead the ace and East has a loser, he has to jettison it on West's spades. You're going to set the contract because East will have to take a ruffing finesse and it will lose.

However, against a small slam, many people like to lead an ace, figuring that then they only need one trick—probably not a good idea. Remember, aces were created to take kings and queens. You're not going to take a king or queen if you lead the ace, so even against a slam the lead of an ace is not a good idea unless it's the only trick in your hand and you can't see where you and your partner will take another trick. In that event, you better take your trick while you can. However, that said, one time I was playing in a tournament against Eddie Kantar, a world champion. I was playing in a small slam and he led his ace on opening lead. So I guess that rules are made to be broken.

But it's generally better to keep declarer in the dark as to who has the ace. You'll probably get to take it later and, if declarer doesn't know where it is, he might make a mistake if he has to guess on the location of an honor without knowing who has the ace. Look at the following hand:

♠ 975

♥ 10632

♦ 84

♣ A842

You're defending against a contract of six diamonds and are on lead. Let's look at the entire club holding:

Partner

♣ Q74

West

♣ 532

East (Declarer)

♣ KJ106

You

♣ A98

Declarer is probably going to have to guess the location of the ace and the queen. Without any clue, he'll have to lead from the board into his hand. If partner plays low and he guesses correctly and plays the jack, you'll be forced to play the ace and he'll make his slam. If he guesses incorrectly and plays the king, you win it with your ace and your partner should get the queen and you'll set him.

If you lead the ace at your first lead, however, you take this guess away from him. His king will then be a cold trick, and he'll probably correctly conclude from your lead that your partner has the queen. This illustrates why the opening lead of an ace is generally not a good idea, even against slam bids.

Leads Against Slams When Your Partner Doubles

A double of a slam by your partner should only be made as a lead-directing device. The reward of an extra 50 or 100 points simply isn't worth the penalty of having your opponents make a slam doubled. This is what the doubler, your beloved partner, is asking you to do when she doubles a slam:

- + Lead the first suit bid by dummy if dummy has bid a nontrump suit.
- + If dummy hasn't bid a suit other than trump but declarer has, lead the suit bid by declarer.
- + If opponents have bid no other suit but trump, lead anything but trump.
- + If you or your partner have bid a suit, don't lead it!

When defending a no trump contract, generally the best lead is fourth from your longest and strongest suit. A double of a no trump contract asks for a specific lead. Don't lead or underlead an ace when defending a suit contract unless you also have the king or it is a singleton. A trump lead is often a good opening if you think opponents will need

to ruff losers to make the contract. Leading a low card against a suit contract generally promises an honor in the suit.

JOKER



JOKER

Chapter 25

Defense After the Opening Lead

Defense, for me, is the most fun part of bridge. You have to communicate with your partner, without speaking, through the cards you play. When you click and get together to set a contract, it's just a wonderful feeling.

Play by Opening Leader's Partner to First Trick

The card played by the partner of the player making the opening lead to the first trick can set the tone for the entire defense of the hand. The player making the opening lead—I'll call her opening leader—is doing the best she can by paying attention to the bidding and correlating the bidding to her hand.

But she's leading with only the bidding as her knowledge. After she leads, the dummy is exposed and everyone knows where 26 of the 52 cards in the deck are located—the 13 in their hand and the 13 in dummy. If your partner is on opening lead, your first opportunity to communicate with her is in your play to her lead. There are two ways to communicate with your partner when she makes the opening lead. You can either give her *count* or you can give her *attitude*. Attitude refers to the interest, or strength, you have in the suit your partner led. Count refers to the number of cards you have in the suit your partner led; you're usually limited to telling her whether you have an even or odd number of cards.

Cards That Convey Your Attitude

In [Chapter 24](#), I explained that opening leader can use cards that frown and cards that smile by the denomination of the card she leads. Leading a small card promises an honor in the suit being played, so it smiles. Leading a middle card, such as a 7, denies an honor, so it frowns. However, when playing to your partner's opening lead, you indicate your pleasure or displeasure in just the opposite manner:

- + A small card played to your partner's opening lead frowns because it says that you don't like the suit and have no help in it.
- + A high card played to your partner's opening lead smiles because it tells her that you do like this suit and probably have an honor in it.

Some advanced players sometimes reverse smiles and frowns, with a high card indicating displeasure and a low card being encouraging. There are even more esoteric ways of indicating attitude, but you can learn them later if you want after you get more proficient. I prefer standard carding myself.

Count

Count is the number of cards you have in the suit your partner led, usually limited to telling her whether you have an even or odd number of cards. Some players prefer to have count, rather than attitude, indicated on the first trick. This is the way you indicate count:

- + If your first two cards played to the trick are low to high, you have an odd number of cards in the suit. So if your first card is the 3 and your next card is the 7, you have an odd number of cards in the suit—probably three or five.
- + If your first two cards played to the trick are high to low, you have an even number of cards in the suit. So if your first card is the 7 and your next card is the 3, you have an even number of cards in the suit—probably two or four.

Whether your first play to your partner's trick conveys count or attitude is strictly a function of your partnership agreement. Before you start playing, make certain you have this understood. There is no right or wrong. The important thing is that you agree.

Rule of 11

The Rule of 11 applies when your partner has led fourth from longest and strongest. You, as opening leader's partner, simply subtract the value of her opening lead from 11. That tells you how many higher cards are in all three hands other than opening leader's hand. To help make sense of this, take a look at the following hands:

Partner

♠ ?
♥ ?
♦ ?
♣ leads 7

Declarer

♠ ?
♥ ?
♦ ?
♣ ?

Dummy

♠ KQ96
♥ 1072
♦ J1076
♣ J10

You

♠ A54
♥ 6543
♦ Q92
♣ 863

Your partner leads the 7 of clubs through dummy to you. What's the club holding? Before you look at the answer, try to figure it out. Your partner led fourth from longest and strongest, so you should have knowledge of the configuration of the club holding by using the Rule of 11. Have you figured it out?

Subtract 7 from 11. You get 4. That means that there are only four cards higher than the 7 of clubs in the three hands other than opening leader's hand. That includes your own hand. So you have one card higher than the 7 (the 8). That leaves three cards higher than the 7 in declarer's hand and dummy's hand combined. You can see that dummy has two cards higher than the 7. That means that declarer only has one card higher than the 7 in his hand. Following are the actual hands:

Partner

♠ J107
♥ 98
♦ A43
♣ AK972

Declarer

♠ 832
♥ AQJ10
♦ K86
♣ Q54

Dummy

♠ KQ96
♥ K75
♦ J1075
♣ J10

You

♠ A54
♥ 6432
♦ Q92
♣ 863

Contract: 2 no trump

Opening Lead: 7 of clubs

The Rule of 11 works. I'm not going to explain how or why, but it does. If you can rely on your partner to lead fourth from longest and strongest, you can determine where most of the cards are by using it. Assuming that the one card declarer holds in his hand that is higher than the 7 of clubs is not the ace, when you get in with your ace of spades and return the 6 of clubs, your partner is going to win four club tricks. That's because when she plays her ace and king, the other two honors will fall and the rest of her clubs will be good. Your partnership will be cemented.

Second Hand Low

“Second hand low” is an axiom that's probably as old as the game. It means that when you're defending and the lead is from your right (in other words, you're the second player to play to the trick), you play a low card unless the card led is an honor or there's some other good reason to play high. The reason is that it puts declarer on the guess as to where the high cards are. Your partner will have the last play, and declarer won't know what she has until she plays. If you play high, it simply takes this obligation to guess away from her.

Unless there's a reason to play high, playing high by second hand just gives away a trick uselessly. Look at the following holding with dummy as your RHO and on lead:

<u>Partner</u> ♠ ?	
<u>Dummy</u> ♠ ?	<u>Dummy</u> ♠ 852 (leads deuce)
<u>You</u> ♠ Q76	

Opponents lead the deuce from dummy. If you play the queen, it will probably lose to the ace or king. What's the point of going up with such a high card when declarer has to play behind you and your partner plays behind him? He doesn't know which hand has the missing cards. If you voluntarily play your highest card, it removes the guess from him. If you play high, he *knows* where that card is! It just goes against common sense. Whenever you're second hand, your partner has the last play. Keep declarer in the dark until your partner plays.

This might seem elementary, but you should always put declarer to the guess. The time when most people are tempted to play high as second hand is when they hold an ace, and the king is in the dummy to their left. Look at this holding:

<u>Partner</u> ♠ ?	
<u>Dummy</u> ♠ KJ7	<u>Declarer</u> ♠ leads 4
<u>You</u> ♠ A832	

Declarer leads low to the king-jack. If you go up with the ace, it makes the king a winner for sure. Worse, it takes the guess on the queen away from him. If you play low, declarer must guess both the ace and the queen. If he guesses you for the queen and your partner for the ace, he'll play the jack and your partner will win the queen. You'll end up with two tricks: your ace and your partner's queen. If you play the ace, you take part of this guess away from him and give him a sure trick with the king. If your

partner has the doubleton queen, you'll be giving opponents two club tricks by going up high as second hand, if declarer then plays for the drop.

When to Play High in Second Hand

Sometimes you must go against the second-hand-low axiom and play high. This occurs when you have connecting honors and to play low could give your opponents a deep finesse and a gift trick. Look at the following hand, where you're holding second hand, playing behind declarer:

<u>Partner</u> ♠ ?		
<u>Dummy</u> ♠ A107		<u>Declarer</u> ♠ leads 4
<u>You</u> ♠ QJ7		

Declarer, sitting as your RHO, leads a low spade. You're not sure, but there's a good possibility declarer has the king of spades. If you play low, he could play the 10 of spades, which will win the trick if declarer has the king. Then declarer plays the ace and goes back to his hand for the king and you have lost all three spade tricks.

However, if you play high as second hand here, and go up with your jack, you force out the ace. That way you have a third-round winner in your queen because it's protected by the 7 of spades and you're sitting behind the king.

But there's an exception to this rule, too. If you're sitting with the following, you should not go up with the jack:

<u>Partner</u> ♠ ?		
<u>Dummy</u> ♠ AK10		<u>Declarer</u> ♠ leads 4
<u>You</u> ♠ QJ7		

Why? Because dummy has both the ace and the king. Declarer thus has the ability to finesse twice. In the preceding example the ace and king were in different hands, one in dummy and one in declarer, so the queen-jack may only be finessed once. Here, with the ace and king both in dummy with the 10, declarer can play the 10 and come back and finesse again, so splitting your honors doesn't accomplish here what it does in the prior hand. If you go up with the jack, declarer might be able to figure out that you also had the queen, and he'll just come back to his hand to finesse you again. He has absolutely nothing to lose to come back to his hand and try another finesse, because if you have a doubleton it will fall.

If you don't have a doubleton, but your partner has the queen, he's going to lose it anyway unless it was a queen doubleton. But that's unlikely because why would you voluntarily play the jack if your partner is short in the suit? That would mean you have several cards in the suit. It just doesn't make sense. So, if you play the jack, he's definitely going to come back to his hand and finesse again. In this instance, you should go low and hope that declarer will figure you don't have both the queen and the jack (or you would have played the jack) and will go up with the king. You don't have much to gain by going up with the jack here, and you have a trick to gain if you go low and declarer guesses wrong.

Covering an Honor

Generally, if the person on lead leads an honor, second hand should play a higher honor (called "covering an honor") if she has it in her hand. There are exceptions to this rule, however. Second hand should not cover an honor in the following circumstances:

If the honor is led from a sequence. Consider the following holding in dummy, your RHO:

Hand 1:

Partner

♠ ?

Declarer

♠ ?

Dummy

♠ QJ73 (on lead)

You

♠ K64

Hand 2:

Partner

♠ ?

Declarer

♠ ?

Dummy

♠ J103 (on lead)

You

♠ Q87

In both instances, dummy holds honors in sequence, so if you hold the king in Hand 1, or the queen in Hand 2, you should *not* cover the honor the first time it's led. If your partner can take the trick, she will. If she can't take the trick, you can cover the second honor. You will have lost nothing because the only way you will have a trick in the first hand is if your partner has 10xx. And if she does, you protect her by covering the second honor. In the second hand, if your partner can't take the first trick, you're out of luck in this suit because opponents have four of the top five honors. It's just a matter of time before they capture yours.

If your honor is going to be good if you don't cover it. This occurs when declarer only has a certain number of times he can finesse you, and you have more cards than that to protect your honor. This generally applies when you're playing no trump or trump is the suit that is led. The reason is that if you give away three tricks in a nontrump suit in a suit contract, declarer will probably be able to trump his fourth card. Consider the following:

Partner

♠ ?

Declarer

♠ ?

Dummy

♠ Q5 (leads queen)

You

♠ K743

Defending no trump, or if this is a trump lead, you would be foolish to cover the queen if it's led because you can protect your king. Look what happens. The queen is led. You play low and the queen wins. Then the 5 is led and you go low again. Declarer wins with the jack. Declarer plays the ace. You can discard your third card and retain your king. The only way declarer can get your king is if you voluntarily play it.

Which Honors to Cover

In defending a suit contract, if you're in a situation that calls for you to cover an honor, you should cover *any* honor with your honor. So if the jack or 10 *empty*, meaning it's the top of several unconnected cards, is on the board and the jack or 10 is led, you should cover if you have the king.

Why? Look at the following:

Hand 1:

Partner

♠ J106

Declarer

♠ A982

Dummy

♠ Q5 (leads queen)

You

♠ K743

Hand 2:

Partner

♠ 1096

Declarer

♠ AJ82

Dummy

♠ Q5 (leads queen)

You

♠ K743

Hand 1: If you don't cover the honor, declarer gets two spade tricks he'd never get. Your partner is sitting with the jack and the 10, both of which will be winners if you cover the queen. If you don't cover the queen, declarer will let it ride and your partner can't take it. The queen will emerge as a winner in addition to declarer's ace. If you cover the queen, declarer takes the ace and your partner's jack and 10 are now the two highest cards in the suit.

Hand 2: This is a very common occurrence. If you don't cover the queen immediately, declarer makes three spade tricks because the queen wins, then he finesses the king and the ace wins, too. If you cover, it makes his jack good, but then your partner takes the 10. So if you cover, you save a trick.

Take an Honor With an Honor

Sometimes you duck when an honor is led. Sometimes you don't. Look at this hand which North is playing in 6H:

North

♠ KJ2
♥ QJ984
♦ K98
♣ 82

West

♠ 96
♥ A7
♦ J1072
♣ 109654

East

♠ 54
♥ 10652
♦ Q653
♣ QJ7

South

♠ AQ10873
♥ K3
♦ A4
♣ AK3

When the heart king is led from dummy, this is the crucial time. When I was East on this hand my partner, West, ducked the lead of the king and that made the contract for North. I am holding 10 fourth. If she ducks the king and then takes the next lead with her ace, I am left with the unprotected 10 because the lead of the queen and the jack will capture my 10. If, on the other hand, West takes the king with her ace, I am left with 10xx and North only has QJ left to pull my trump so my 10 becomes the setting trick. This is a common error even good players make, to duck the first lead of an honor and then take the second lead without opponents having to spend an honor to lose to the ace.

Third Hand High

“Third hand high” is another axiom that’s been around since creation. It means that if you’re the third player to play to the trick and your partner leads low, you play as high a card as you can as long as it’s higher than the card played by dummy.

Bottom of a Sequence

You should play the bottom card of your highest sequence. For example, your partner led the 3 of clubs and your RHO plays low, and you hold the following:

♣ QJ75

You should play the jack. If opponents take the trick with the king, it indicates to your partner that you might have the queen. However, if you were to play the queen it would absolutely promise your partner that you did *not* have the jack.

Finesse Against Dummy When You Can

Look at the following holding. This is a situation that occurs again and again. Even good players misplay it:

Partner (on lead)

♦ 3

Declarer

♦ ?

Dummy

♦ K54 plays the 4

You

♦ AJ10

What do you play? If declarer has the queen, he'll take the trick. If declarer's queen is a singleton, you won't ever get your ace. Should you play your ace or play low, hoping your partner has the queen? If your partner has the queen, you can wait until she gets the lead again. She'll lead through the king again, and the king will never win a trick. If you play your ace, you make the king a sure trick. What to do?

Answer: Your partner led fourth from longest and strongest. That means that she has a maximum of five diamonds. You have three. Dummy has three. Declarer must have at least two. That means you should play the 10 because you should still get your ace, even if declarer has the queen.

If you're playing in a suit contract and you think that declarer has a singleton honor, however, you should play your ace. This would occur if, in the above situation, your partner had led the deuce and both you and dummy had four diamonds instead of

three each. That pretty much marks the suit as 4–4–4–1, with declarer having the singleton. In this instance, play your ace while you can.

Unlocking in No Trump

When defending a no trump contract, especially one in game, you are working with fewer HCP than your opponents. When you know your partner is trying to set up a long suit, you sometimes have to *unblock*, which means that you discard a high card, maybe a potential winner, in order to enable your partner to run her long suit. To help you understand this concept, let's look at a hand where you're defending a contract of 3 no trump:

Partner

♠ 9853
♥ 102
♦ Q9843
♣ 85

Declarer

♠ KQ2
♥ AK7
♦ 10752
♣ Q73

Dummy

♠ A1074
♥ 9863
♦ A
♣ AJ104

You

♠ J6
♥ QJ54
♦ KJ6
♣ K962

Your partner leads the 4 of diamonds. Dummy plays the singleton ace. You must unblock by discarding the jack of diamonds when you might otherwise be tempted to play the 6.

If you were to play the 6 on the first trick, then when you subsequently get on lead with your king of clubs you will play your king of diamonds, which wins. Then you

return your last remaining diamond: the jack. That's the only entry into your partner's hand. But if your partner overtakes with the queen, declarer has the suit stopped with his 10.

Following is the layout of the cards if you originally play the 6 and then win the losing club finesse (after your opponent wins the ace of diamonds, he goes to his hand with a heart and then leads the queen of clubs, which you win with your king), after you have cashed your king of diamonds:

<u>Partner</u>		
	♠	9853
	♥	10
	♦	Q98
	♣	8
<u>Declarer</u>	♠	KQ2
	♥	A7
	♦	107
	♣	73
	<u>You</u>	
	♠	J6
	♥	QJ5
	♦	J
	♣	962
	<u>Dummy</u>	
	♠	A1074
	♥	98
	♦	
	♣	AJ10

You lead the jack of diamonds. If your partner lets it ride, there's no other way into her hand to allow her to cash her two remaining diamonds winners. So she has to overtake, which leaves declarer's 10 of diamonds as the highest card outstanding in the suit. He takes your partner's diamond lead and cashes his remaining winning tricks to make the contract. But look at how the cards lay if you originally play the jack of diamonds under the ace in dummy on your partner's opening lead:

Partner

♠ 9853
♥ 10
♦ Q98
♣ 8

Declarer

♠ KQ2
♥ A7
♦ 107
♣ 73

Dummy

♠ A1074
♥ 98
♦
♣ AJ10

You

♠ J6
♥ QJ5
♦ 6
♣ 962

See what a big difference that makes? After you take your king of diamonds, you now lead your 6 of diamonds through declarer's 10. Declarer can't win because if he plays low, your partner will win the trick with the 8 and then pull declarer's 10 with his queen. If declarer plays his 10, your partner wins with her queen and runs her remaining diamonds winners.

To recap: If you unblock on your partner's opening lead by discarding your jack and keeping your little 6, you defeat the contract. If you just discard the 6 on her opening lead, you can't defeat the contract.

As an additional bonus to the discard of the jack instead of the 6, it signals your partner to continue the suit because you have help.

The opportunity to unblock usually arises in the following circumstances:

- + When you have three cards in your partner's suit.
- + When you also have high cards in your partner's long suit, but only one low card.

You must preserve that low card as an entry back into your partner's hand.

What Card to Return to Your Partner

When defending a no trump contract, there's another unblocking rule you should follow when you hold three cards in your partner's suit headed by the ace (commonly called "three to the ace"). After you win the ace, you should lead your highest card back to her. For example, if your original holding was ace–honor–low and you took the trick with the ace, return the honor, not the low card. This has several desirable effects:

- + It leads through declarer and possibly finesses him.
- + It informs your partner where the missing high cards in the suit are located. If you take the ace and return the 10, she should know that you don't have the cards in between the ace and the 10. So she can mentally remove the cards she sees in dummy and the cards she sees in her own hand and place the missing cards in declarer's hand.
- + It unblocks your suit for your partner. If you lead low and your partner wins and returns a lower card than your remaining honor, you win, but can't get back to her.

Return Lead with Four Cards in Your Partner's Suit

When you have four cards in your partner's suit, and you know that your partner has led fourth from longest and strongest, you need not be too concerned with unblocking. That is because you and your partner have the majority of the cards in the suit between you.

When you have three cards in your partner's suit, it's important that you return your highest card, as explained in the preceding section. However, what card should you return when you started out with four cards in your partner's suit?

The answer is that you should return the card you would have led had you been on lead—the card that was originally your fourth highest. Look at the following holding between you and your partner defending a no trump contract:

Partner (on lead)

♣ K10652

You

♣ Q743

Your partner leads the 5; you play the queen, which loses to the ace. Declarer loses a finesse to you. What card do you now play to return to your partner? You return the 3, the card that was your fourth highest in the suit originally. Now, if you have agreed that when you have three cards you return the highest remaining card, your partner knows that you started with either four or two cards in her suit. Why? Because the 3 is the lowest outstanding card in the suit. If you had three cards in the suit, you would have returned a higher card.

Now your partner should be able to determine the exact holding in her suit by looking at dummy and looking at the card you returned. Your partner wins with the 10 and comes back with the king, thereby dropping opponents' remaining jack. What card do you play now? Here's another unblocking situation, and you must be alert for it. If you were to just play low now, you have the 7 and the 4 left; your 7 will take your partner's next lead, which will be the 6. Here's the holding after your partner gets in with the 10:

Partner

♣ K62

You

♣ 74

When your partner leads the king, you have to choose between playing the 7 and the 4. Here's the holding if you play the 4 on her king:

Partner

♣ 62

You

♣ 7

When your partner leads the 6 next, your only remaining card is the 7, which will win the trick. Now you're out of clubs while your partner is sitting across from you with a good club trick in her hand and no entry.

As you can see, this is an unblocking situation. When your partner leads her king, you drop your 7 of clubs and retain your 4. Here's the holding if you play the 7 on her king instead of the 4:

Partner

♣ 62

You

♣ 4

Then when she leads her 6, you play your 4, leaving her in the lead to cash her deuce and set the contract.

Leading After the Opening Lead

Ah, those axioms. Here's another, in iambic meter, that generally holds you in good stead:

When the dummy's on the right,

Lead the weakest suit in sight!

If you get the lead after the opening lead, and you're sitting in front of declarer so that the dummy is your RHO, you have the advantage that you don't have on opening lead of seeing the cards in dummy. In this situation, lead the suit in which dummy is weakest.

Another rule if dummy is on your right is that it's unwise to lead into a tenace composed of honors, like the ace-queen, in dummy. Look at the following holding in dummy after you win the opening trick with your singleton king of clubs, so you can't return your partner's lead:

Partner

?

West

?

Dummy

♠ AQ4

♥ 975

♦ K104

♣ A107

You (on lead)

Not relevant to discussion

If you lead a spade, you take the guess on a possible finesse from declarer and put your partner in a terrible spot. If she has the king, it renders it fairly useless because the queen will win if she ducks and the ace will take it if she plays the king.

If you lead a diamond, it once again removes a possible guess from declarer. You might not know where the ace is. If your partner has it, declarer won't know where it is, either. Why make life easier for him? If you lead a diamond, he'll play low and your partner will have to either play the ace (making the king good) or duck (making the king good).

Hearts is the weakest suit in sight, and that's what you should lead because you're leading through declarer. If he has broken honors, he has to guess what to play with no help from dummy. As an example, look at the actual heart holding:

	<u>Partner</u>	
	♥ A106	
<u>Declarer</u>		<u>Dummy</u>
♥ KJ2		♥ 975
	<u>You</u>	
	♥ Q843	

You lead the 3 of hearts. What's declarer to do? Play the jack? Play the king? Play low? If he plays low, your partner will win with any card higher than the 9. If he plays the jack and your partner has the queen, he's going to lose. If he plays the king and your partner has the ace, he's going to lose. As the cards lay, his correct play is the jack, which will force out your partner's ace. But he has to guess. Make him.

Here's another hand where you have to decide what to lead during the play of the hand. It exemplifies how you must remember the bidding and use logical thinking throughout your defense.

Here's your hand as West and dummy's, which is your LHO:

Auction:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
	1 ♦	P	1 ♥
P	1 ♠	P	2 ♣
P	2 ♦	P	2NT
P	3NT	P	P
P			

North

♠ AQ63
♥ A
♦ AJ10942
♣ 53

West

♠ 10852
♥ Q1054
♦ 5
♣ Q953

You lead the club 3, partner plays the king, and declarer plays low. Partner returns the club 4 and declarer takes the ace. Declarer leads a low heart to the ace and a low diamond back to her king, and follows with the 3 of diamonds, losing the finesse to your partner's queen and partner returns the jack of clubs which you overtake with your queen and take the 9 as the 10 fell from declarer's hand on the lead of the jack. Now, here's what's facing you:

North

♠ AQ6
♥
♦ AJ109
♣

West

♠ 1085
♥ Q1054
♦
♣

You can lead either a spade or a heart. You've got your book, so all you need is one more trick to set the contract. What do you lead? You look at the board and realize that all four diamonds are good. If declarer has the king of spades, the hand is over if you lead a spade. But who has the king of spades? Maybe declarer has both the king of spades and the king of hearts. If so, the hand is over anyway. But if declarer has the king of hearts and not the king of spades, you can only set the contract if you lead a spade.

You shouldn't be tempted to lead through the void because declarer's first call was hearts and her second call of 2C should promise five hearts. Also, if she bid a five-card suit, you can clearly see that she lacks the AQ10. Did she bid a five-card suit headed by only the J empty fifth? While that's not impossible, it's implausible. Further, if she lacks both the king and the queen, would she immediately lead to the singleton ace of hearts? Unlikely because that would give you two heart tricks if you got in.

Another factor mitigating against your leading hearts is that you are undoubtedly giving her two heart tricks because you will be leading into her KJ from your queen. Since you have the queen, that gives her two tricks to take and sluff her two losing spades on. The facts that she bid hearts, that you have the queen-10, and that she immediately led to the singleton ace all mitigate towards the conclusion that she has the king of hearts and that your partner could have the king of spades.

In the actual hand, West led a heart from her queen-10, giving declarer two heart tricks so she could sluff the two spade losers and make the contract. Here's the four hand layout:

North

♠ AQ63
♥ A
♦ AJ10942
♣ 53

West

♠ 10852
♥ Q1054
♦ 5
♣ Q953

East

♠ KJ4
♥ 973
♦ Q87
♣ KJ73

South

♠ 97
♥ KJ862
♦ K63
♣ A108

By leading a spade, declarer either has to finesse immediately and lose the king, or go up with the ace, run the diamonds and then lose the last two tricks. But even if she finesses and loses the king, a savvy East will take the king and immediately return a

diamond, putting her back on the board so she'll still lose two spade tricks and go down 2. A heart lead makes the contract.

This isn't even a thinker. You must lead a spade. If declarer has the king, then she makes the contract. The odds that she lacks the king of hearts (along with the ace, queen, and 10), the suit she bid, are slim and none. So you have little to lose by leading the spade.

The Holdup

I introduced the holdup—the refusal to win a trick—in [Chapter 22](#) as a tool to use as declarer to cut off communication between defenders' hands. It's also useful in defense to keep declarer from getting to the spot where his long suit is located. Look at the following hand:

North (Partner)

♠ K87
♥ J982
♦ 982
♣ 1053

West

♠ AJ3
♥ AK6
♦ 73
♣ AJ842

East (Dummy)

♠ 10952
♥ 543
♦ KQJ105
♣ Q

South (You)

♠ Q64
♥ Q107
♦ A64
♣ K976

West reached an optimistic contract of 3 no trump and your partner led the deuce of hearts. West took your queen with his ace. It's clear that the only chance he has to make this hand is to set up his diamonds and take four diamond tricks. He should take two club tricks and with the three tricks he has with the ace-king of hearts and the ace of spades, that would make his contract.

If he leads low to his king of diamonds and you take it with your ace immediately, he'll get the lead right back on whatever you lead next and will get back over to dummy and run his diamonds.

But if you hold up on his diamonds, it's unlikely he'll be able to get back there after you take your ace of diamonds. Let's look at it. He takes the ace of hearts and leads low to the king of diamonds, which you allow him to take. He then leads the queen of diamonds, which you also allow him to win. When he leads the jack, you're forced to take it because your ace is the only remaining diamond in your hand. Now the hands look like this:

North (Partner).

♠ K87

♥ J98

♦

♣ 1053

West

♠ AJ3

♥ K6

♦

♣ AJ84

East (Dummy).

♠ 10952

♥ 54

♦ 105

♣ Q

South (You).

♠ Q64

♥ 107

♦

♣ K976

So far, he's taken three tricks and you've taken one. He can take two more clubs, a heart, and a spade—maybe two. Unless he can get to the dummy to cash his two good diamonds, he's history. As you can see, there's no way he can now get to the board. By holding up and not taking your ace of diamonds until the third lead of diamonds, you destroyed his transportation to the board and assured the defeat of the contract. Had you taken your ace of diamonds at the first trick, making his contract would have been a piece of cake.

Signals

When a suit is led and you have no more cards in it, you can use the situation as an opportunity to communicate to your partner what you have in your hand, and what you want her to lead if she gets the lead.

High-Card Discard Is Encouraging

There are several methods of discarding to communicate with your partner. The standard way is to discard a high card in a suit you want her to lead. Look at the following holding in your hand:

♠
♥ KQ92
♦ 872
♣ 752

Spades is trump and your opponent is pulling trump. Your partner still has one spade in her hand, so your opponent leads another high spade to pull your partner's last trump. You should use this opportunity to tell your partner about your hand.

A good discard here would be the 9 of hearts, telling your partner that if she gets the lead you want her to lead hearts. Discarding a high card in a suit that wasn't led tells your partner that you like that suit.

Low-Card Discard Is Discouraging

If you discard a low card, you discourage your partner from leading that suit. So if you were to discard the deuce of clubs or the deuce of diamonds, you'd be telling your partner that you don't want her to lead those suits because you don't have much in them. If you discard your deuce of clubs, however, she can't tell which of the other two suits you want led. So if you can discard high without harming your holding, you should make an encouraging discard.

Sometimes, however, it's inconvenient to discard a high card, and it's better to discourage another suit, implying that you like your good suit. Let's assume that the hands look like this:

North (Partner)

♠ ?

♥ ?

♦ ?

♣ ?

West (Dummy)

♠ 8

♥ J32

♦ QJ9

♣ AK

East (Declarer)

♠ ?

♥ ?

♦ ?

♣ ?

South (You)

♠ Void

♥ KQ2

♦ 872

♣ 752

East is declarer and is pulling trump. As mentioned, there's still one out in your partner's hand, so East leads the ace of spades. What do you discard?

You don't want to discard the queen of hearts, because that's an extremely important card that you can't intelligently give up. You can't discard the deuce of hearts because that would be discouraging.

You clearly wouldn't want her to lead a club with the ace and king on the board. However, there's a good way in this hand to tell her to lead a heart without throwing away a good hearts trick: you should discard the deuce of diamonds. That tells her that you don't like diamonds. Your partner can look at the dummy and determine that you clearly shouldn't like clubs much, either. So by discarding the low diamond in your hand, you're telling her that you want her to lead a heart.

Think before discarding!

North

♠ AK
♥ K943
♦ A1064
♣ KJ2

West

♠ Q95
♥ J10
♦ Q92
♣ 106543

East

♠ 1086432
♥ 852
♦ 3
♣ Q87

South

♠ J7
♥ AQ76
♦ KJ875
♣ A9

West

P
P
P
P

North

1 ♥
4NT
5NT
7NT

East

P
P
P
P

South

1 ♦
3 ♥
5S*
6 ♦
All Pass

**Two key cards plus the trump queen*

Opening Lead: 7C

Before getting into a discussion of the bidding and play, put yourself in East's position. North takes the opening lead with the jack and immediately attacks hearts. After leading three hearts, she leads the fourth. You have to sluff. What do you discard?

Bidding: While South could open 1NT with this unbalanced hand, 1D was OK, although it makes a rebid difficult since she doesn't have enough to reverse. I would open it 1NT. South's jump showed 15 to 18 HCP. Since North had 18 HCP, slam was a distinct possibility, so immediately went to Roman Key Card Blackwood. Her response of five spades showed two key cards plus the queen of trump. North's 5 no trump rebid promised all five key cards and asked for the number of kings. When she showed one king, they had all of the aces and kings plus the queen of trump. North took a chance on the grand slam and chose no trump, rather than hearts, because

North's hand was balanced and North knew that the rest of the players would be playing in hearts, so making no trump would give a cold top.

Play: First, East should lead the standard lead, fourth from longest and strongest, the spade 4. It makes no difference on this hand, but underleading a queen when you only hold three cards in the suit is a terrible lead.

Now for the answer to the question that begins the column. Look at dummy on your left and what do you see? You see a five-card diamond suit. But declarer started by running the hearts (your partner discarding the jack and then the 10), even though a 4-1 split could set her. What do you deduce from that? You already know that she has the ace of diamonds from the bidding. The king and jack are on the board. If she had the ace and the queen she would start with diamonds, where she has five certain tricks. Therefore, she must be lacking the queen of diamonds. You know your partner has it. The one card you cannot discard on the fourth lead of hearts is your three of diamonds. Why? Because from the bidding North has no clue about what either hand holds. She is going to have to guess on the queen of diamonds. So you have to save a diamond to play when she leads diamonds. If you show out on her first lead, she knows where the queen is. But when you sluff the diamond, it pretty much telegraphs to him that you do not have the queen. If you have the queen you would not be sluffing diamonds because you would be protecting the queen.

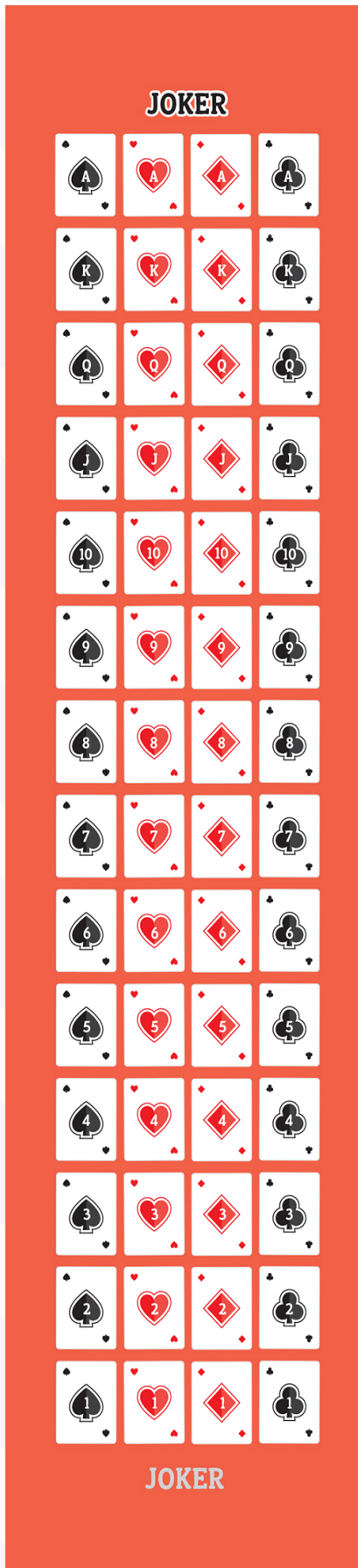
When North saw the discard of the 3 of diamonds it told her that she could lead to the king on the board and finesse back through West, thereby setting up five diamond tricks, making 7 no trump cold. Of course, after you sluff your singleton diamond, when she leads to the king on the board, you show out so she knows your partner holds the queen. That's why you have to keep the diamond.

Another thing that made it so easy after the sluff of the 3 of diamonds was that when you are missing the queen in a situation like this the first lead can be deadly. If, for instance, you lead the ace first and East shows out, you are doomed to lose the queen since you can no longer finesse, having already played the ace. Similarly, if you lead low

from the ace to the king-jack on the board and West shows out, you have lost the ability to finesse. So discarding the 3 of diamonds on the fourth heart lead told North that she could safely under lead the ace to the king on the board and come back through West for the finesse. The singleton might seem like a good card to discard because it is never going to take a trick, but discarding that singleton made the contract much easier for declarer. If East had saved the diamond 3 to play it when North started the diamonds, she still would have no clue as to where the queen was. She would then have to either guess on the finesse or play the ace and king and hope for the drop in a 2-2 split.

So, when you're defending no trump and there is a long running suit on the board that might need a finesse, don't discard your singleton in that suit because you will need to play it to keep from telling declarer the shape of the suit. Maybe she'll guess wrong. In fact, even if you don't have a singleton, you shouldn't discard that suit.

On partner's opening lead, you can reveal that you have a doubleton by discarding your high card on the opening lead and then your low card on the second lead of the same suit. You can signal your partner whether you like the suit or not by discarding a high card for like and a low card for dislike. Sometimes you have to hold up taking a trick to keep opponent from being able to get to the dummy. The Rule of 11 tells you how many higher cards are in all three hands other than opening leader's hand. Be aware when you need to unblock partner's suit by discarding a high card before a low card.



Chapter 26

Advanced Playing and Bidding Techniques

The goal of this book is to quickly teach you how to play bridge and to show you that it's easy to master the basics. But improving at bridge is an ongoing process. Now that you know the basics and should be able to sit down and play a respectable game, I want to introduce you to some slightly advanced elements. I'm introducing these in no particular order. Some are playing techniques, and some are bidding techniques.

The playing techniques are methods you can use immediately when you master them because they only involve you and the way you play your cards. The bidding methods must be used with someone who has the same understanding of them as you do.

Game Tries

When you are in a noncompetitive auction (opponents are passing throughout) and you have an invitational hand there are several ways to ask partner if she is at the top or bottom of her bid. For instance, if the bidding goes 1H-2H-3H, the 3H bid is asking partner to bid game, 4H, if she is at the top of her bid. Her bid shows 6-9 HCP and at least three hearts. If she has four hearts and 9 HCP, she should accept the invitation and bid 4H.

Help Suit Game Try

Sometimes opener has a good hand but three losing cards in one suit, like the following:

♠ AK3
♥ AK10942
♦ 1095
♣ 8

After 1H-2H, she's feeling game but she's worried about losing three diamonds. If you have a diamond stopper, she should be able to make game, so as a game try after your 2H bid, she bids 3D. If you are playing help suit game tries, that does not say that she has a diamond suit. Rather it asks you to bid 4H if you have a diamond stopper, like KQx or the ace or a singleton. Otherwise you just bid 3H and she knows to pass.

So, if your hand is

♠ 98
♥ 8763
♦ AK76
♣ 943

You would bid 4H and it stands a great chance of making. With the following hand:

♠ 984
♥ 8763
♦ 876
♣ AQ

You would bid 3H, telling partner you had no help in diamonds.

Invitational vs. Competitive Bids

It's easy to make a game try when the opponents are not bidding, but when they are competing, how do you make an invitational bid to partner as outlined above? Look at the following auction:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
			1 ♣
1 ♠	2 ♣	2 ♠	3 ♣
?			

Here are two hands:

1. ♠ Q109832	2. ♠ AQ10983
♥ QJ10	♥ QJ10
♦ AJ42	♦ AJ42
♣ Void	♣ Void

In Hand 1, you have a simple overcall. You don't want to sell out to 3C with six spades, even though you are missing 3 of the top 4 honors.

In Hand 2, you have a full opening hand and are interested in game. So what do you call?

Most people would probably call 3S on both hands. But in Hand 1 you want your partner to pass, regardless of whether or not your LHO raises to 4C, since she has just given you a simple raise, promising 3 trump and 6-9 HCP. In Hand 2, you are interested in game. How do you differentiate between the two?

There is a simple way to do this but it should not be confused with a “help suit game try.” That is, bid a new suit. That does not ask for help in that suit. It merely says, “if you are at the top of your bid, go to game; otherwise, just bid three of our suit and I will pass.” If you play this, in Hand 1, you may freely raise to 3S without worrying about partner going forward with minimum support. This is what is called a “competitive raise.” It says, “partner, I don’t think we have game, but we have at least an eight-card trump fit (your partner doesn’t know you have six spades) and I don’t want to sell out to 3 clubs. If they compete to 4C, let them have it.”

In Hand 2, however, because you are interested in a possible game bid, you make a “game try” by asking her about her hand. You do this by bidding a new, unbid suit. In this instance, you would bid 3D. This says to partner, “Partner, I know we have a spade fit. How is the rest of your hand? If you are at the top of your bid, bid game, 4 spades. If not, just close out in 3 spades, or, if my LHO has bid 4 clubs, pass.”

Please note that this bid says nothing about diamonds. (It is not a “help suit game try”.) In this case, the hand actually does have a good four-card diamond suit. But you would make this bid with absolutely nothing in diamonds because its only purpose is to show that you have a game going hand if partner is at the top of her bid.

If you have this understanding, then you may freely overcall 3C with 3S in Hand 1 without worrying about partner bidding 4S, regardless of what your LHO does.

In fact, the actual hand held by partner was:

♠ J654
 ♥ A94
 ♦ 1095
 ♣ K86

So, in response to the 3D invitational bid for Hand 2, she would probably try for game with 9 good points, 1½ quick tricks, and four trump. But with a 3S competitive bid in Hand 1, she would pass, regardless of what her RHO did, relying on the adage “the 4 level belongs to the opponents.” If they overcall 4C, then you’ve done your job in getting them up 1 level into a contract that might be hard to make. In fact, in the actual hand, Hand 1 made 3 spades, losing 2 spades, a heart, and a diamond. I think that Hand 2 has an excellent chance to make 4 spades.

Here’s the four-hand layout:

	<u>North</u>	
	♠ K7	
	♥ 632	
	♦ K843	
	♣ 7432	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ Q109832		♠ J654
♥ QJ10		♥ A94
♦ AJ62		♦ 1095
♣ Void		♣ K86
	<u>South</u>	
	♠ A	
	♥ K875	
	♦ Q10	
	♣ AQJ1095	

Control Your Entries as Declarer

Here’s your hand, sitting South in the third seat:

♠ K4
♥ 5
♦ 987642
♣ A1093

Partner opens 1H in first seat. Regardless of what system you play, Standard American or 2/1, you can only respond 1NT here, even though you have a six-card suit and a singleton. You have 7 HCP, so you must bid. You're too weak to bid your deplorably bad diamond suit.

Partner reverses with 2S (which promises at least 17 HCP and 5-4 distribution, or 6-5 with opening hand values). You have to bid again. But the value of a reverse is that it promises at least 17 HCP, so some of the values you know for bids are now less. For instance, normally a second bid by responder of 2NT promises 11-12 HCP. But since you know partner has at least 17 HCP instead of a maximum of 14 HCP with a normal response, your bid of 2NT will now only need 8-9 HCP. Even though you only have 7 HCP, you do have a six-card suit. And, anyway, you don't have any other response. You can't raise spades since partner probably only has 4 and you clearly can't raise hearts with a singleton. Really your only bid with this hand is 2NT. If your diamonds were better, like AQxxxx, then you could bid 3D, which would generally be a drop dead bid that partner should pass.

But you do have clubs stopped, and your diamond suit, weak as it is, is long enough that it is stopped enough so that opponents shouldn't take more than three tricks in it, if that. So your only bid is 2NT, even though you only have 7 HCP. Partner with a huge hand containing 19 HCP bids 3NT. Here's the four hand layout:

North

♠ AJ106
♥ KQ1074
♦ A3
♣ KQ

West

♠ 852
♥ AJ92
♦ J10
♣ J862

East

♠ Q973
♥ 863
♦ KQ5
♣ 754

South

♠ K4
♥ 5
♦ 987642
♣ A1093

Auction:

West

P
P

North

1 ♥
2 ♠
3NT

East

P
P

South

1NT
2NT
All Pass

Opening Lead 2C

Before I comment on declarer play, I want to say that even though it's standard to lead fourth from your longest suit as an opening lead against no trump, leading low from a jack high four-card suit is generally a destructive lead because the jack will stop a suit and if you lead from it declarer often wins the trick with the 10. If the dummy in this hand had KQx instead of KQ tight, it's a perfect example of how a lead from Jxxx gives declarer a trick she wouldn't get otherwise. Playing low from dummy, she takes the trick with her 10 in her hand. She'd never get that trick if the lead from Jxxx isn't made.

As to declarer play, you count your tricks. You've got three club tricks (because the king-queen is tight on the board, you can't take the opening lead with your 10, so West's jack will end up taking a trick if you try to take all three club tricks), one diamond trick, three spade tricks, and one or two heart tricks. But as the hearts actually lie, you're only going to take one heart trick because if you lead your singleton and West plays low, you have to lead the hearts from the board and you're doomed to lose to the ace and the jack, at least.

So, your only hope to make 3 no trump on this hand is to hope for a 3-2 split in diamonds. It doesn't matter where the honors are. What is important, however, is that you keep two entries to your hand, because you have to lead diamonds three times to set up three diamond tricks, which means you have to get to your hand twice, and you only have two entries.

So, you take the opening lead on the board with the queen of clubs, lead the ace of diamonds and a low diamond, ridding the board of diamonds, which is won by East's queen. Now there is only one diamond out. East returns a club to the singleton king on the board. But you must take this in your hand with the ace, even though you have to drop the singleton king on the board under it, because if you play low so that the king wins on the board, you only have one entry to your hand, the king of spades. Here's the layout at the point East leads his second club:

North

♠ AJ106
♥ KQ1074
♦
♣ K

West

♠ 852
♥ AJ92
♦
♣ J86

East

♠ Q973
♥ 863
♦ K
♣ 75

South

♠ K4
♥ 5
♦ 9876
♣ A109

If you use the king of spades to get to your hand to play another diamond to get the last diamond out, you can't get back to your hand to play the three good diamonds that you set up because you don't have another entry.

So, you have to play the ace and drop the king under it. You lead your third diamond. East takes it and returns a club. West wins the jack and returns a spade, which you win in your hand with the king over East's 9. You've made your contract; four diamonds, three clubs (your 9 held up for the last club trick), and two spades without ever touching dummy's beautiful hearts.

The Strip and End Play

Strip means to take away the opponents' cards that they can safely lead without giving you a trick. These cards are called *exit cards*. *End play* means to put the opponents in the lead in a situation in which anything they lead will gain you a trick. Although this sounds like something you might see in a Madonna movie, the *strip* and *end play* is actually an ingenious way to make an extra trick. One of the hands in which it works is

where you have to find a missing honor, like the queen, and you have the appropriate distribution in declarer and dummy. For instance, a strip and end play would work if your hand and dummy's have mirror distributions of 3–5–3–2. You have a problem of finding the queen of one of the suits and the contract depends on your locating the queen. If you don't take the queen, you'll go set. Do you finesse? Or is there a way to play it so that there is absolutely no guess?

Look at the following hand, which South is playing in 6 hearts:

		<u>North</u>	
		♠ AJ7	
		♥ KQ1072	
		♦ K82	
		♣ 84	
<u>West</u>			<u>East</u>
♠ ?			♠ ?
♥ ?			♥ ?
♦ ?			♦ ?
♣ ?			♣ ?
		<u>South</u>	
		♠ K102	
		♥ AJ943	
		♦ AQ7	
		♣ A6	

You have 11 cold tricks, and the success of the contract depends on your ability to locate the queen of spades. You could guess and leave it up to luck. Or you could play it in such a way that the contract is cold. Obviously, the latter is a better choice. Before you learn how to do it, can you figure out how to play this hand without any possible chance of not making six?

The answer is to execute a strip and end play. It doesn't matter what cards your opponents hold or lead. You can't lose this contract if you play it correctly. You are in total control. Have you figured it out yet?

For those of you who haven't, here's what you do: You pull trump, even if it takes three rounds. Then you take your three diamond winners and the ace of clubs. This leaves you with the following holding:

		<u>North</u>	
		♠ AJ7	
		♥ K2	
		♦	
		♣ 8	
<u>West</u>			<u>East</u>
♠ ?			♠ ?
♥ ?			♥ ?
♦ ?			♦ ?
♣ ?			♣ ?
		<u>South</u>	
		♠ K102	
		♥ 94	
		♦	
		♣ 6	

What now? Well, what you don't do is guess your finesse. Instead, you lead a club, which you will obviously lose. But now look at your situation. Your opponents are out of trump, so they can't lead hearts. If they lead spades, they lead right into you because you can take it in the fourth seat. So a spade lead obviates the need for a finesse. You are void in both diamonds and clubs in both hands at this point, so if they lead either of those suits, you get a ruff and a sluff, throwing off your losing spade and ruffing in the other hand. That way you can trump your losing spade in the other hand.

Look at the situation after they lead a club or a diamond and you sluff the 2 of spades in South and ruff the club in North:

North

♠ AJ7

♥ K

♦

♣

West

♠ ?

♥ ?

♦ ?

♣ ?

East

♠ ?

♥ ?

♦ ?

♣ ?

South

♠ K10

♥ 94

♦

♣

See? Now you can't lose. You lead the 7 of spades to the king. Then lead the 10 of spades to the ace. Now your holding is as follows:

North

♠ J

♥ K

♦

♣

West

♠ ?

♥ ?

♦ ?

♣ ?

East

♠ ?

♥ ?

♦ ?

♣ ?

South

♠

♥ 94

♦

♣

You can ruff the 7 of spades in South, so the contract is made. You can't go set if you recognize a strip and end play and execute it properly.

The key to a strip and end play is to lose a trick at a time when any lead by opponents will either give you a ruff and a sluff or force them to lead into your tenace.

Which leads into another aspect of the strip and end play: placing the lead in the opponent who will be forced to lead into your tenace. Look at the following situation at the end of your playing a spade contract, after you have drawn all the trump:

<u>North</u>		
	♠ 7	
	♥ 543	
	♦	
	♣	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ ?		♠ ?
♥ ?		♥ ?
♦ ?		♦ ?
♣ ?		♣ ?
<u>South</u>		
	♠ 5	
	♥ AQ9	
	♦	
	♣	

How do you make three of the last four tricks? If you play it correctly, you can't fail. Your opponents have no good defense against the correct offense. No matter what they do, if you know what you are doing, you have three of the last four tricks cold if you have the lead in North.

You lead a low heart from the North hand. If East goes low, you play the 9. That leaves West to take the trick and lead into your ace—queen. If he leads a diamond or club, he gives you a ruff and a sluff. He's helpless.

Even if East goes up with the 10 or the jack, you have it cold. Why? Because if East plays the 10, let's say, and you play the queen and West wins with the king, your ace—9 is now in a tenace position because the only card out between them is the jack. So the

ace–9 is now basically the same card holding as the ace–queen had been prior to the play.

The essentials of the strip and end play are as follows:

1. Strip your hand of two nontrump suits.
2. After you've stripped your hand (or with the lead that completes the strip), lose a trick and put opponents into the lead.

The Principle of Restricted Choice

Although it's a little more complicated than this, the principle of restricted choice essentially decrees that if one of your opponents drops an honor the first time a suit is led, you should play his partner for the other honor. I show you by an example.

Following are your cards:

<u>North</u>		
♠ A732		
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠ ?		♠ ?
<u>South</u>		
♠ K10854		

You play the ace, East follows with the 6, and West plays the queen. Assuming you have no clue from the bidding, what do you do? Play for the 2–2 split, or finesse the 10? Even though it's a guess, the correct play is to finesse the 10. Why? Because of the principle of restricted choice.

The theory is that if he has both, he could have played either, but if he only has one he's limited to playing it. The odds favor the proposition that he only has one and if you lead low to South's hand and East goes low (with the 9, which is the only other card out except the jack), you should play the 10. The odds are somewhat like 2–1 in your favor that East holds the other honor in this situation.

The Crossruff

Often you find yourself playing a hand that lacks the high-card strength to make a bid, but because of the distribution you are able to make your contract by crossruffing the hand. Here's a deal where my partner and I were EW in a tenuous grand slam, so we could not lose even one trick. I was sitting East.

		<u>North</u>	
		♠ 654	
		♥ QJ943	
		♦ 2	
		♣ J752	
<u>West</u>			<u>East</u>
♠ 2			♠ AQJ109
♥ AK7			♥ 65
♦ QJ107			♦ AK54
♣ AKQ98			♣ 63
		<u>South</u>	
		♠ K873	
		♥ 1082	
		♦ 9863	
		♣ 104	

Bidding:

<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>	<u>South</u>
		P	1 ♠
P	2 ♣	P	2 ♦
P	2 ♥*	P	2 ♠
P	3 ♦	P	4 ♦
P	4NT	P	5 ♣**
P	5NT	P	6 ♣
P	7 ♦***		All Pass

★ *Fourth Suit Forcing.* This means that partner must take another bid. She cannot pass. Some people play that Fourth Suit Forcing is a game force, which means that neither can pass until game is bid.

★★ *Roman Key Card Blackwood, 0 or 3 key cards.* This is an extension of Blackwood where, in addition to the four aces, the trump king is also a key card, so if you hold 2 aces and the king of trump (which I did), you respond with 5 clubs, which shows three key cards. The responses to a bid of 4 no trump are as follows:

5 ♣ 0 or 3 key cards

5 ♦ 1 or 4 key cards

5 ♥ 2 key cards without the trump queen

5 ♠ 2 key cards with the trump queen

★★★ *No kings.* Since the trump king is a key card, it is not included in this response.

Opening Lead: 10 of Hearts

The hand is relatively cold for 6NT, but only one pair in this game was in 6NT. Some were in 6D, making 6. My partner showed admirable confidence in me when he put me in 7D even though he knew I didn't have the king of spades and he only had one spade for me to make a finesse. Also, it turned out that everything shaped up wrong. Clubs didn't split, the king of spades was offside, and there was a horrible 4-1 trump split. Can you make 7D?

I took the ace of hearts and led a low diamond to my king, then another low diamond to the 10. North discarded the 4 of spades, so I got the bad news on the trump split. I started clubs and South discarded the 4 and 10, so I figured that clubs split badly and that the king of spades was offside. I took the ace of spades and started a ruffing finesse sequence with the queen. South covered and I ruffed. I played the king of hearts and ruffed a heart. That left me with the following holding:

	<u>North</u>	
	♠	
	♥ QJ	
	♦	
	♣ J7	
<u>West</u>		<u>East</u>
♠		♠ J109
♥		♥
♦ Q		♦ A
♣ Q98		♣
	<u>South</u>	
	♠ 87	
	♥	
	♦ 98	
	♣	

Even though South has two trump to my one in each hand, the hand is over. I led the two spades and sluffed two clubs, leaving me with a spade and the trump ace in my hand and a club and the trump queen on the board. So I trumped the spade with my queen and trumped the club with the ace, a high cross ruff that smothered South's two trumps, making 7 diamonds.

Paradoxically, the only way it can make is if the spade king *is* offside. Otherwise the ruffing finesse would not work.

Take Advantage of Opponent's Tell

There is a lot of poker in bridge. You have to be able to read your opponents. Here's a hand where we got to slam only because of my partner's fine forcing bid.

North

♠ J1095

♥ 65

♦ J1082

♣ 943

West

♠ K

♥ 872

♦ AKQ9

♣ Q10865

East

♠ AQ632

♥ AKJ1043

♦ 4

♣ J

South

♠ 874

♥ Q9

♦ 7653

♣ AK72

Auction:

West

North

East

South

1 ♦

P

1 ♥

P

2 ♣

9

3 ♠

P

6 ♥

P

P

P

Opening Lead AC

Bidding Commentary: I opened 1D. This is the only time when you may open a shorter minor, when you have an opening hand but are 4-5 in diamonds and clubs. You aren't strong enough to reverse if you open 1C and then make a 2D call on your first rebid, so you don't really have a rebid if you open 1C and partner responds in a major.

So, here you open 1D and your first rebid is 2C, showing a minimum hand, even though partner will probably think your diamonds are longer or of equal length. Partner had a huge 4 loser hand, so instead of just reversing by bidding 2S, which

would show an opening hand as responder, she jumped to 3S, game-forcing and slam invitational. That gave me the opportunity to go to slam. However, since she jumped, I don't have a forcing bid. I can't bid 4NT because that would require her to respond as if spades, the last bid suit, were trump, since trump had not been agreed upon. If I bid 4H, she will just pass.

We have never discussed what 5H would be here, so I couldn't do that. I took a chance, trusted her, and placed the contract in 6H, even though I had a bare opening bid with three of my points a singleton king (but it was in her second bid suit).

Play Commentary: There are only two things partner had to do to make six. First, she had to trump one spade after getting rid of the singleton king on the board before cashing her ace and queen and before drawing trump. So, she took the king, led a trump to her ace and trumped a low spade, because she could only discard two losing spades on the diamonds, and she had three losing spades in her hand.

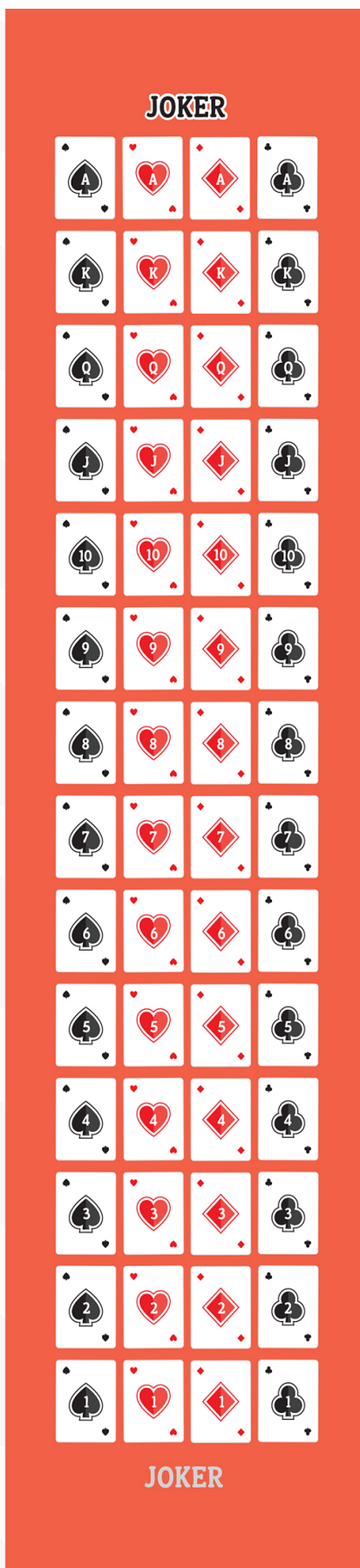
She then led her remaining trump on the board to her hand where she held the K-J. Her RHO hesitated and then played low. My partner didn't hesitate or think. The odds are that four cards will split 3-1 50 percent of the time. (They divide 2-2 41 percent of the time and 4-0 9 percent of the time.)

However, because my partner had played against her RHO often and knew her to be a player of low bridge integrity (I hesitate to use the word "cheater"), my partner knew that her hesitation was a ploy to make my partner think she was hesitating trying to decide whether or not to play the queen. It's a really stupid way to cheat because there's no reason to even think about playing the queen, but my partner told me afterwards that the reason she didn't play the odds and take the finesse was because of her RHO's illegal hesitation. It is illegal because you must play in tempo. While it is okay to think if there's actually a decision to be made, it's not okay to appear to be thinking when there's nothing to think about, in order to mislead declarer. Because of my partner's knowledge of her RHO, she immediately recognized her hesitation as what they would call in poker a tell.

In a nine table game, only one other pair bid slam.

If you're going to play lead-directing doubles, be certain that your partner is playing it, too, and knows that when you make a double of a conventional bid it's only for lead-directing purposes.

Next up, I discuss the very important Two-Over-One System that you'll want to incorporate into your bridge playing.



Chapter 27

Two-Over-One System

In Standard American, which is what this book teaches, if you have a five-card suit and 10 points, and your partner has opened the bidding with 1 of a suit, you may bid your suit at the 2 level. In such event, when responder bids a new suit, opener is required to bid again. It's forcing for one round.

Delving into the Two-Over-One System

A very popular system that's used by a majority of tournament players is called the *Two-Over-One System*. In this system, when a player makes a two-over-one response such as 1 diamond–pass–2 clubs, she promises enough points that the partnership can make a game. Because of this, all subsequent bidding is game forcing, even if it sounds weak.

Take this auction:

<u>West</u>	<u>East</u>
1 ♠	2 ♣
2 ♦	2 ♠

East responds with 2 clubs and then gives a preference to spades. In standard bidding, this sequence shows at least 10 points with spades support. It is invitational. In two-over-one bidding, the rebid of 2 spades shows that in addition to the values of an opening bid promised by the initial response of 2 clubs, it also shows spade support. Although in Standard American, this could be passed by opener.

In two-over-one, all bids after the initial two-over-one response are forcing to game, so the opener must bid again.

The advantage to this is that there's no need for jumping around in the bidding. Instead, you can use the bidding space to find the best fit and then determine whether to play in 3 no trump, in a suit, or in a slam. If someone does jump, it's not because that player has extra points, but because they have some important distributional feature to show.

If you play the Two-Over-One System, however, and your partner opens the bidding at the 1 level and you make a nonjump response at the 2 level, such as 1 diamond–pass–2 clubs, your partner (opener) must keep the bidding open until one of you has bid game. Because this is a game-forcing bid, it can obviously cause a lot of bidding problems. Suppose that your partner opens 1 spade and you hold the following:

♠ 53
♥ KQ97
♦ 94
♣ AJ1053

That's not a bad hand. But you can't bid 2 clubs because it would force your partner to bid to game and, if your partner has a minimum opener, you probably can't make game. You can't pass, you can't bid 2 clubs, and you can't bid 2 spades because (1) you're too strong for such a weak bid, and (2) you don't have three spades, which this response promises. What do you do?

The answer is a bid that was created for the Two-Over-One System—forcing no trump.

The Forcing 1 No Trump Response

To resolve the problem just discussed, you can play that a 1 no trump response to an opening bid of one in a major is forcing for one round, and one round only. The idea is that because you can't go to the 2 level with 10 or 11 points, you have to have a waiting bid that allows you to show your points on the next round.

If you have 6 to 11 points and your partner opens with a major-suit bid that doesn't allow you to make a response at the 1 level, you bid 1 no trump. This is forcing for one round. That is, your partner must make another bid. In an ordinary Standard American auction, a 1 no trump response is generally an invitation to pass because it's describing the hand. If you've opened a minimum, your partner's response of 1 no trump is telling you that you probably don't have game, and you may pass, and often do.

If you're playing forcing no trump, however, and your partner opened and you bid 1 no trump, your partner (the opening bidder) must say "forcing" to tell opponents that your partner is required to bid again. The following hands are examples of hands where you would bid 1 no trump forcing after your partner opens 1 spade:

1. ♠ J4	2. ♠ 3	3. ♠ 8	4. ♠ 7	5. ♠ 2
♥ A984	♥ KQ984	♥ 873	♥ QJ74	♥ 7653
♦ K873	♦ 876	♦ AJ873	♦ 9	♦ 8732
♣ J84	♣ Q872	♣ K874	♣ KJ97863	♣ AQ84

In Standard American, a 1 no trump response to a major usually shows a 6- to 9-point hand. In two-over-one bidding, however, the 1 no trump response can show invitational hands, too.

How Does Opener Bid After a Forcing 1 No Trump Response?

Opener follows a set of rules. If she has a strong or invitational hand, she makes the same rebid she would make in standard bidding. It's when she has minimum hands that her bidding can take a couple of odd twists:

- + If opener has a six-card major, she rebids it.
- + If opener started with 1 spade and happens to have four hearts, she bids 2 hearts.
- + If opener has six spades and four hearts, she bids her stronger major.
- + If opener has a four- or five-card minor, she bids it.
- + If opener has a balanced hand without a six-card suit or a four-card suit, she bids her lower three-card minor. Responder knows that opener may have to bid a three-card minor, so she will treat this suit gingerly.

Once in a blue moon, opener has four spades and five hearts and two in each minor. When she opens 1 heart and you respond with a forcing 1 no trump, she should not then bid 2 spades, because your bypass of spades to bid 1 no trump denies a four-card spade suit. She then has little choice but bid a brave 2 clubs, even though she only has two of them, and hope that nothing bad happens.

If opener has a good balanced hand, she bids 2 no trump with 18 to 19 HCP. If she has a little less, she bids according to the list above and later can bid 2 no trump when she has 17 HCP.

Quiz

Find out if you can solve the following challenge; what is your rebid as Opener?

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
1 ♠	P	1NT	P
?			
1. ♠ Q109874 ♥ 3 ♦ KQ★ ♣ AJ4	2. ♠ AKQ84 ♥ J874 ♦ K3 ♣ 73	3. ♠ KQJ84 ♥ KQ ♦ AJ8 ♣ K84	4. ♠ AJ743 ♥ K3 ♦ AQ82 ♣ 108
			5. ♠ J8763 ♥ AQ ♦ AQ8 ♣ 873

Hand 1: 2 spades, showing a six-card suit and a minimum hand.

Hand 2: 2 hearts, showing four hearts. Don't worry that your spades are so good and your hearts so bad.

Hand 3: 2 no trump. You promise 18 to 19 HCP, so you don't have to worry that this is too conservative. You have exactly what you promise.

Hand 4: 2 diamonds. You don't have a six-card suit or a four-card hearts suit, so you bid your four-card minor.

Hand 5: 2 clubs. Don't bid 2 diamonds. Yes, the clubs are bad and the diamonds good, but bidding clubs leaves the partnership more room to bid. If you bid 2 clubs, you can always get to diamonds if your partner wants to bid them. If you bid 2 diamonds and your partner has good clubs, she has to go to the 3 level.

After opener makes her rebid, responder continues with her second bid, which describes what she really has. Responder can pass opener's rebid, but most of the time she finds a second bid. Here's an auction with some examples of how responder bids

on the second round with the minimum hands shown above in which you responded with a forcing 1 no trump.

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
1 ♠	P	1NT	Pass
2 ♦	P	?	

1. ♠ J4	2. ♠ 3	3. ♠ 8	4. ♠ 7	5. ♠ 2
♥ A984	♥ KQ984	♥ 873	♥ QJ74	♥ 7653
♦ K873	♦ 876	♦ AJ873	♦ 9	♦ 8732
♣ J84	♣ Q872	♣ K874	♣ KJ98763	♣ Q84

Hand 1: 2 spades. Give a preference to spades. You didn't raise the first time, so your partner will expect only two.

Hand 2: 2 hearts. You can show a good suit at the 2 level without implying extra points. Your 1 no trump bid suggested you had less than an opening, or game-forcing, bid.

Hand 3: 3 diamonds. With 8 to 10 points and five cards in your partner's minor suit, you can raise. Be aware that she may have only three diamonds.

Hand 4: 3 clubs. You hate partner's suits, and you have a good one of your own. You do not promise a good hand, just a long suit.

Hand 5: Pass. You have nowhere to go, and you do have four diamonds. If you're lucky, partner has four, too.

Some Problem Hands

Here are some problem hands of a different sort: when the forcing 1 no trump bidder has an invitational hand, a situation that occurs about one hand in five.

<u>South</u>	<u>West</u>	<u>North</u>	<u>East</u>
1 ♥	P	1NT	P
2 ♣	P	?	

1. ♠ 83
♥ AJ8
♦ 873
♣ KQ873

2. ♠ K84
♥ 3
♦ AQ10976
♣ J87

3. ♠ K83
♥ 87
♦ AJ874
♣ QJ7

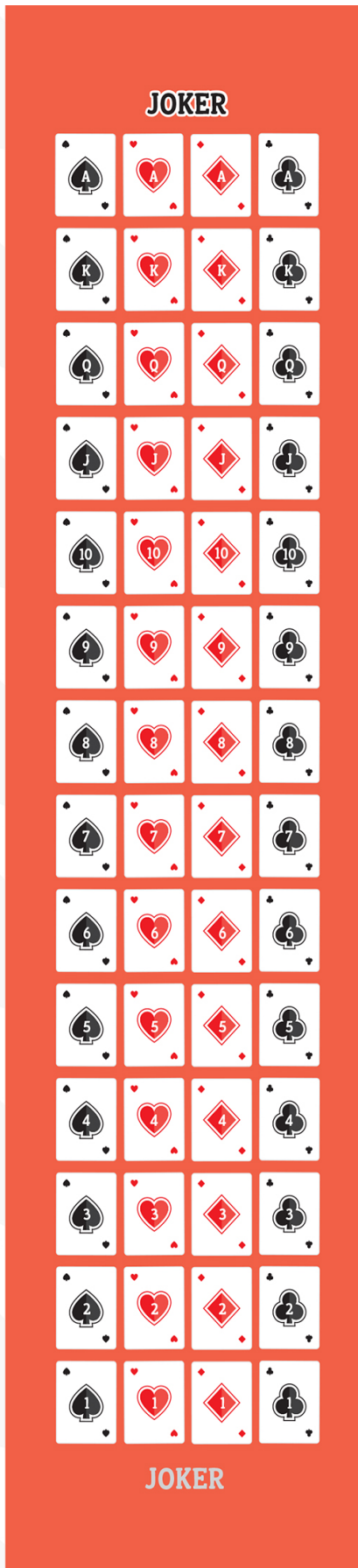
Hand 1: 3 hearts. You have a hand worth a limit raise in hearts, but you only have three-card support. You show a three-card limit raise by bidding 1 no trump and jumping to 3 of your partner's major. It's important that you don't bid 3 hearts with this hand on the first round, because your partner would expect a fourth trump. Don't be distracted by your club support.

Hand 2: 3 diamonds. You aren't strong enough to bid 2 diamonds originally, so start with 1 no trump forcing. Partner bid 2 clubs, and that leaves you room to bid 2 diamonds or 3 diamonds. With a maximum hand and with a six-card suit, you can jump to show this hand.

Hand 3: 2 no trump. You promise around 11 HCP with stoppers. This is an invitational bid.

Finally, what if partner opens a major suit in third or fourth seat when her partner has already passed? Is a 1 no trump response forcing? Some people play that it's semi-forcing. This means that if Partner opens a hand that has a minimum, like 12–13 HCP, she may pass the 1NT response. The reason is that because responder has a passed hand, she probably has less than 12 HCP and game is highly unlikely, so it's best to play in as low a contract as possible. Some play that 1NT is always semi-forcing, but that's a minority. It's better to play it semi-forcing when opening in third seat. The advantage is that the weakness of 2/1 is that it is often better to play a hand in 1NT than in a suit, and if you play 1NT as always forcing in 2/1 situations, you forfeit the possibility of playing in the safer contract.

This concludes our bridge discussion. I hope you've learned some good pointers and are ready to play bridge like a boss.



Appendix A

Guide to Bids and Responses

Opening Bids

Opening Bid	Requirements
1 of a suit major	12–21 points; at least five cards in a major suit; at least three cards in a minor suit
1NT	15–17 HCP; no singletons or voids, and not more than two doubletons
2 ♦, 2 ♥, or 2 ♠ (strong)	At least 22 points; at least five cards in the suit or a guarantee of at least nine tricks if opening a major and 10 tricks if opening a minor
2 ♣	Same as above, or 22–24 points with no five-card suit, except ♣
Weak Twos: 2 ♦, 2 ♥, or 2 ♠	5–10 HCP; if ♦, generally no four-card major; no outside ace or void; in 1st or 2nd seat either 2 of top 3 honors or 3 of top 5 honors; 3rd seat opener can be weaker
2 ♣ when playing Weak Twos	22–24 HCP or 8½ tricks
2NT	20–21 HCP; no singletons or voids; and not more than two doubletons
3 of a suit	A seven-card suit; a suit headed by at least the queen–10; 4–9 HCP; no outside ace; not more than one outside king; when opening in a minor suit, no four-card major
3NT	25–26 HCP; no singletons or voids, and not more than two doubletons
4 in a suit	At least eight cards in length; at least two of the top four honors in your long suit; 4–9 HCP; no outside ace; only one outside king; if opening a minor suit, no four-card major
5 in a suit	Must be ♣ or ♦; eight- or nine-card suit; suit must be headed by at least two of the top four honors; 4–9 HCP; no outside ace; not more than one outside king

Responses to Partner's Opening Bid

Opening Bid	Holding	Response
1 of a suit	0–5 points	P
	6–16 points	1 of a higher ranking four-card suit at the 1 level
	10–16 points plus a five-card major or four-card minor	2 of the long suit
1 of a major	6–9 points with at least three cards in opener's suit	2 of opener's suit
	6–9 points w/o a higher ranking four-card suit or less than three cards in opener's suit; no singletons or voids	1NT
	10–12 points; and three or four cards in opener's suit	3 of opener's suit
	13–15 HCP; balanced hand; stoppers in the three unbid suits; no four-card higher ranking major	2NT
	16–18 HCP; balanced hand; stoppers in the three unbid suits; no four-card higher ranking major	3NT
	16 or more points; does not deny four cards in opener's suit; can be totally unbalanced	Jump shift
	6–10 points; five cards in opener's suit; at least one singleton or void	Jump to game
1 of a minor	6–9 points; no four-card major; five cards in opener's suit	2 of opener's suit
	10–12 points; no four-card major; five cards in opener's suit	3 of opener's suit
1 of a minor	11–12 HCP; no four-card major; stoppers in all suits unbid by opener	2NT
	13–18 HCP; no four-card major; stoppers in all suits unbid by opener	3NT
1NT	0–7 HCP	P
	0–7 HCP; at least five cards	2 of long suit

	in either ♥ or ♠, or six cards in ♦	
	8–9 points; no four-card major	2NT
	8+ points; at least one four-card major	2 ♣ (Stayman)
	10+ points; five-card major	2 ♣, then jump to 3 of your suit if partner doesn't bid your suit; jump to 4 in your suit if she bids your suit
	9+ points; a six-card major	Jump to game in your suit
	10–14 HCP; no four-card major	3NT
	15–16 HCP; no four-card major	4NT (quantitative, not forcing)
	17–19 HCP; no four-card major	6NT
	20+ HCP; no four-card major	7NT
	6–7 HCP; broken six-card minor with nothing outside	Jump to 3 of minor
	Transfers	
	5+ ♥	2 ♦
	5+ ♠	2 ♥
2NT	0–4 HCP	P
	5–10 HCP; no four-card major, no singletons or voids	3NT
	11–13 HCP; NT distribution	4NT
	14–15 HCP; NT distribution	6NT
	16+ HCP; NT distribution	7NT
	5+ HCP; four-card major	3 ♣ (Stayman)
	5+ points; six-card major	4 of your major
2 ♦, 2 ♥, or 2 ♠ (strong)	Five-card suit, king-jack or better	Bid the five-card suit
	3+ points; at least one king; three-card support for your partner's suit	Raise partner's suit 1 level
	0+ points; no five-card suit; less than three-card support for your partner's suit	2NT
2 ♣	0+ points; no five-card suit;	2 ♦

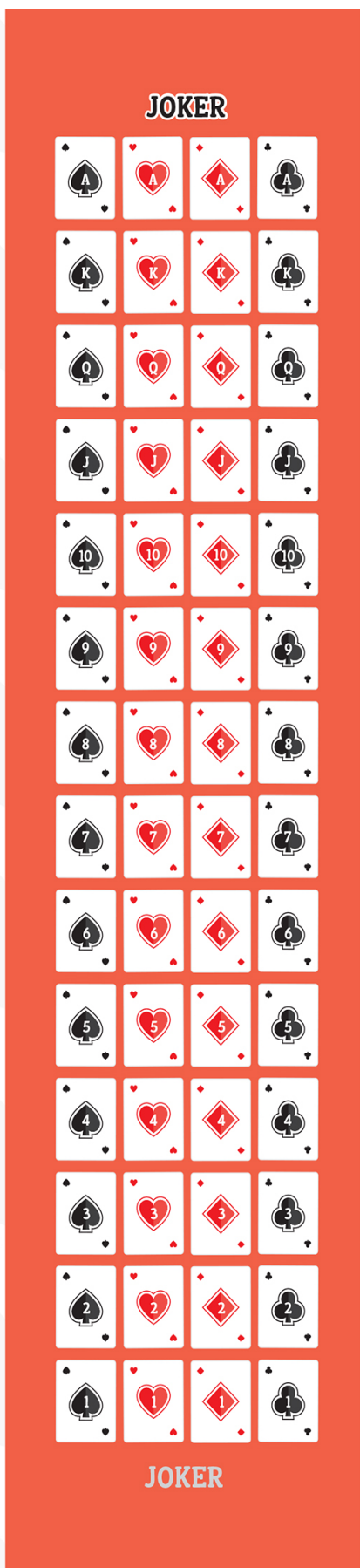
	less than three-card support for your partner's suit	
	4+ points; five-card suit with at least king-jack	Bid the five-card suit at the 2 level
3 of a suit	0–14 points; no support for your partner's suit	P, partner is weak
	7–14 points; support for your partner's suit	Raise partner's suit
	0–6 points	P
	15+ points; a good five-card suit; no support for your partner's suit	Bid your long suit (forcing)
Weak Twos: 2 ♦, 2 ♥, or 2 ♠	6-14 HCP 3 cards in partner's suit; no five-card suit headed by 2 of top 4 honors	Raise partner's suit 1 level
	15+ HCP, no five-card suit	2NT (forcing, asks for a feature)
	15+ HCP, 5+ card suit headed by 2 of top 3 honors or 3 of top 5 honors	Bid the 5+ card suit (forcing for one round)
4 in a minor	Less than extra values	P
	Extra values	Bid game or explore for slam
4 in a major	Less than extra values	P
	Extra values	Explore for slam if your hand justifies it; remember, your partner is weak, even though the opening bid is game

Opener's Rebid After Opening 1 of a Suit

Responder's Bid	Holding	Response
1 of a new suit at the 1 level	12–15 points; four cards in a suit higher ranking than the suit bid by responder	1 of your higher-ranking suit
	12–15 points; less than six cards in your suit and less than four cards in responder's suit	1NT; balanced hand
	12–15 points; six cards in your suit	Rebid your suit at the 2 level
	12–15 points; less than six cards in your suit; a four-card suit lower ranking than your opening suit	Bid your lower-ranking four-card suit at the 2 level
	12–15 points; less than six cards in your suit, but four-card support for your partner's suit	Raise partner's suit at the 2 level
	18–19 points; all unbid suits stopped	2NT
	20–21 points; all unbid suits stopped	3NT
	16–18 points, six-card opening suit	Jump to 3 of opening suit
	17+ points; five cards in opening suit; four cards in higher-ranking suit	Reverse to four-card suit
	19+ points; a second biddable suit	Jump shift to second suit
	16–18 points; support for your partner's major suit	Jump raise partner's suit
	19+ points, four-card support for your partner's major suit bid	Jump to game in partner's suit
New suit at 2 level without jumping	12–15 points; five-card opening suit; less than four cards in your partner's major suit bid or less than four cards in your partner's minor suit bid; unbid suits stopped; no singletons or voids	2NT
	Same, but with support for your partner's suit	Raise partner's suit
	16–18 points; support for your partner's major suit	Jump raise partner's suit
	16–19 points; no support for your partner's suit; unbid suits stopped	3NT

	17+ points; five cards in opening suit; four cards in higher ranking suit	Reverse to four-card suit
	19+ points; a second biddable suit	Jump shift to second suit
1NT	12–15 points; balanced hand	P
	12–15 points; a singleton or void	2 of a lower ranking suit containing at least 4 cards
	12–15 points; six-card suit or a good five-card suit if your hand is unbalanced	Rebid your opening suit at the 2 level
	16–18 points; no singleton or void	2NT
	16–18 points; six-card suit	Jump rebid your suit at the 3 level
	17+ points; 5-4 or 12+ points 6-5 distribution	Reverse to shorter suit
	19+ points; unbalanced	Jump shift
	20+ points; four-card support for your partner's major suit bid	Jump to game in partner's suit
2NT after major suit opening	12–15 points; six-card suit	4 of your suit
	12–15 points; five-card suit	3NT
	16+ points	Bid a new suit (forcing) for a slam invitation
2NT after a minor suit opening	13–17 points; balanced	3NT or 4 in a suit
	18+ points; balanced	4NT (quantitative) or 4 in a suit as a slam invitation
3NT	12–15 points; balanced	P
	12–15 points; a singleton or void	4 in a suit
	16+ points; balanced	4NT (quantitative)
	16+ points; a singleton or void	4 in a suit as a slam invitation
Jump shift	12–15 points; five-card opening suit	Lowest NT bid available
	12–15 points; six-card suit	Rebid opening suit
	16+ points	Jump to 3NT
1 level raise of your suit	12–15 points	P
	16–18 points	Raise to 3 level if a major suit; 2NT if a minor
	19+ points	Jump to game in your suit if a

		major; bid 3NT if a minor
Jump raise of your major suit	12–19 points	4 of your suit (game)
	20+ points	4NT (Blackwood)
Jump raise of your minor suit	12–15 points unbid suits stopped	3NT
	12–19 points unbalanced	4 of suit or new suit or P
	20+ points	Explore slam
3NT after major suit opening	12–15 points	4 of your suit (game)
	16+ points	4NT (Blackwood)
3NT after minor suit opening	12–15 points	P
	16+ points; no singletons or voids	Bid slam or explore slam



Appendix B

Other Bridge Variations

This book has concentrated on how to play rubber bridge, which is by far the most popular version of the game. However, there are other forms of bridge that are just as much fun.

Duplicate Bridge

In duplicate bridge, everybody plays the same hands. Duplicate is played by eight players or more. In tournaments, there are thousands of players. After bidding, the hands are played in the same way, but the cards aren't put in the middle of the table when playing to each trick, as is done in rubber bridge.

In duplicate, each player plays his card on the table in front of him. When the trick is completed, each player keeps the card in front of him, placing it face down horizontally if he wins the trick or vertically if the opponents win the trick.

When the hand concludes, each player takes his cards and places them in a duplicate board, which has spaces for each of the four hands: North, East, West, and South. After a certain number of boards is played—usually between two and five—all boards are passed to the next lower-ranking table.

The players sitting North-South remain stationary. The players sitting East-West move to the next higher-ranking table after the set of boards is played. Players move up. Boards move down.

At the end of the evening all East-West pairs have played the same hands and all North-South pairs have played the same hands. Scoring is based on how your scores on each hand compare with the scores of the other players who played the hands. For example, if you bid and make a small slam but everyone else bids and makes a grand slam on that hand, you get the worst score on the hand: zero.

It's very competitive. One of the big advantages is that winning doesn't depend on the luck of the deal because everyone plays the same cards. If you have a Yarborough,

every player sitting in your seat will have to play that Yarborough. Whoever does the best with it will have the highest score for that board.

Chicago

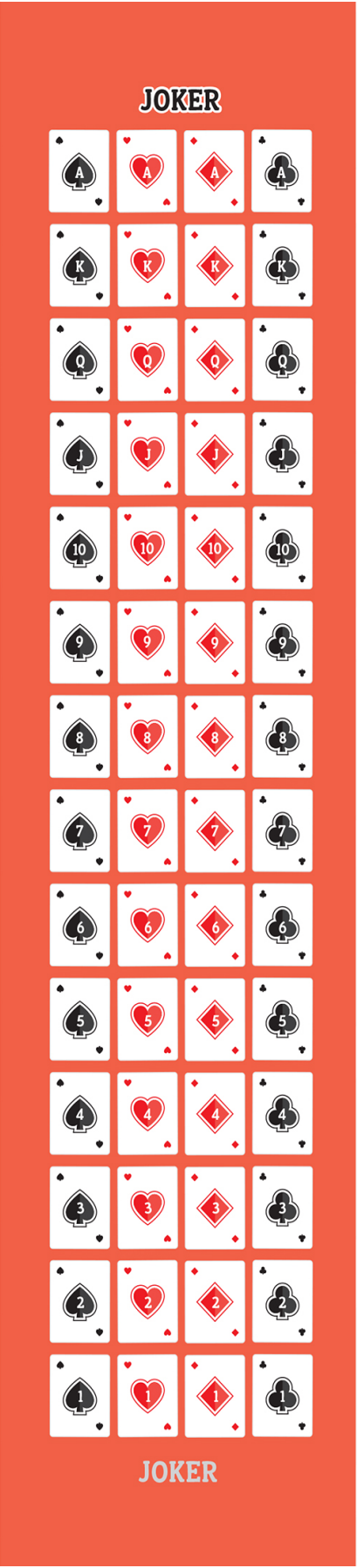
Chicago, also known as four-deal bridge, is a very popular type of bridge that shortens the normal game of rubber bridge. Instead of playing until one pair wins two games—which can last a long time if one pair does a lot of defensive bidding—Chicago consists of one round of four hands, scored as follows:

1. For the first hand, neither pair is vulnerable.
2. For the second and third hands, dealer's pair is vulnerable.
3. For the fourth hand, both pairs are vulnerable.

Cards are dealt and played. The deal rotates to the left, as in rubber bridge. At the end of the fourth round, after each player has dealt once, the scores are added and a winner is determined.

You may play as many rounds as you like, and you may either change partners or not, as you like, after each round.

A nonvulnerable game gets a 300-point bonus above the line. A vulnerable game gets a 500-point bonus above the line. A partscore on the first three hands gets a 50-point bonus. If you get a partscore on the fourth hand, you get a 100-point bonus.



Appendix C

Resources

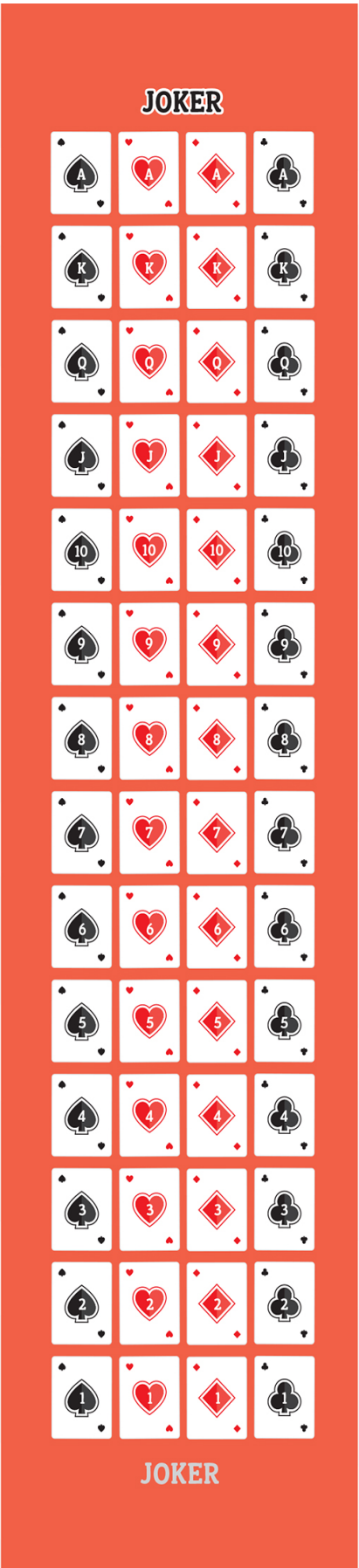
Bridge on the Internet

You can play bridge with live people on the internet without leaving your living room. You can play with people all over the world, and games are available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

Players range from beginners to experts. You can join games on various levels: beginner, intermediate, advanced, or expert. You can also join any table you want and just watch, without playing.

Here are four online bridge games:

- + BridgeBase www.bridgebase.com/bbo/
- + FunBridge www.funbridge.com
- + OKbridge www.okbridge.com/
- + Swan Games www.swangames.com/main/index.html



Appendix D

Glossary

4-3-3-3 Description of a totally balanced hand, with four cards in one suit and three cards in the other three suits.

100 honors Four of the top five cards in the trump suit in one hand. A player holding 100 honors receives a bonus of 100 points above the line.

150 honors All five of the top honors in the trump suit in one hand. A player holding 150 honors receives a bonus of 150 points above the line.

150 aces All four aces in one hand when the hand is played in no trump. A player holding 150 aces receives a bonus of 150 points above the line.

1430 A variation of Roman Key Card Blackwood switching the first two responses. Five clubs shows 1 or 4 key cards, and five diamonds shows 0 or 3 key cards.

above the line Points entered on the scoresheet above the horizontal line for overtricks, bonuses, and penalties. These points don't count toward making game.

attitude A signal to your partner telling her whether you like the suit she led or not. A high card generally indicates you like the suit; a low card generally indicates you don't like the suit and discourages her from continuing it if she retains the lead.

auction A series of bids between the partnerships to obtain the contract.

balancing To make a bid or double at a low level to keep the auction from being passed out after opponents have stopped bidding and there have been two consecutive passes.

below the line Points entered on the scoresheet below the horizontal line indicating the points scored for exactly the number of tricks bid and made.

bid Any call made by a player that predicts the number of tricks the player's pair will take in a specified trump or in no trump.

Blackwood A conventional bid in which the bid of 4 no trump asks partner to respond with the number of aces in her hand. A response of 5 clubs means zero aces, 5 diamonds means one ace, 5 hearts means two aces, and 5 spades means three aces.

block You block your partner's suit when your partner has several good cards remaining in a suit but you must take the trick because your only card in the suit is higher ranking than the remaining cards in your partner's suit, and there's no way back into your partner's hand to allow her to cash her tricks.

board Another name for the exposed hand in dummy.

body cards 8s, 9s, and 10s.

book The first six tricks taken by the declaring side. *Defenders' book* is the number of tricks required to be taken, after which the next trick won by defenders will set the contract.

bypass Failing to bid a lower-ranking suit or a suit at a lower level to, instead, bid a higher-ranking suit or a suit at a higher level when bidding the lower-ranking suit or the suit at a lower level would be the standard bid.

call Any bid, double, redouble, or pass.

Cappelletti A conventional overcall in defense against a no trump opening by opponents. Double is penalty, two clubs shows a one-suited hand, two diamonds shows 5–5 in the majors, two hearts shows five hearts and an undesignated five-card minor, two spades shows five spades and an undesignated five-card minor (*see* Hamilton, Pottage). This name is used on the East Coast and in major portions of America.

cheaper minor A bid of the lowest unbid minor suit available at the time of responder's second call. This is a standard method of making a weak response to a Strong Two-clubs opening bid.

clubs The lowest ranking of the four suits in a deck of cards.

cold To be able to make a contract easily with no chance of failure.

competing To make a bid to contest with opponents without implying to your partner that you're interested in contracting for game.

competition When both pairs are bidding to get the contract.

connecting honor A holding of two consecutive honor cards in the same suit, like king–queen or jack–10.

contract The commitment of the declaring side to win a specified number of tricks with a specified suit as trump or with no trump.

conventional bid A bid with a defined meaning other than the standard meaning.

count An indication of an even or odd number of cards in your hand by discarding high to low to indicate an even number of cards in the suit led, and low to high to indicate an odd number of cards in the suit led.

cover Play by second or third hand of a higher card over the card played by opponent.

crossruff The ability to ruff losers in different suits in the hands of both partners.

cue-bid A bid of opponents' suit that conveys something to your partner other than a holding in that suit.

cue-bid limit raise When partner has opened or overcalled, a bid of opponents' suit shows a limit raise or better for partner's suit.

dealer The person who distributes the cards in clockwise order; the player with the first opportunity to make a call.

declarer The player who is playing the hand with her partner as dummy.

deuce The two card of each suit.

diamonds The second lowest ranking of the four suits.

direct seat The player sitting as the LHO of opening bidder.

discard The play of a nontrump card not of the suit led.

distribution points Points in counting the hand for voids, singletons, and doubletons.

D0PI Double = Zero, Pass = One. A response to Blackwood over interference telling your partner how many aces you have in your hand.

double A call by an opponent of declarer that increases the value of tricks or undertricks made by declarer.

doubleton Any total holding in a suit that is exactly two cards in length.

doubling into game A double of a partial score that, if unsuccessful, will result in opponents getting at least 100 points below the line when they wouldn't have gotten 100 points below the line without the double.

down Any hand that doesn't make the contracted number of tricks; synonymous with set. *See* undertricks.

down the line To bid the higher-ranking suits of equal length first.

drawing trump For declarer to lead trump until the opponents no longer have any trump in either of their hands.

drop-dead bid A bid that asks your partner to pass and allow the bidder to play the hand in the bid made by the drop-dead bidder.

duck To not take a trick when you have a high card that would enable you to win that trick.

dummy The hand that belongs to declarer's partner. Dummy is always played face up on the table.

duplicate The form of tournament bridge where each player plays the same hand as the other players sitting in the same direction (North, South, East, or West). This is accomplished by the hands being dealt into boards and the boards are passed from table to table. North-South remain stationary but the East-West pair moves after each round. Each table is numbered. The boards are passed to the next lower-numbered table and the pairs move to the next higher-numbered table. At the end of the game, each North-South pair has played the same hands and each East-West pair has played the same hands.

empty No support for an honor, as in "jack empty," meaning a holding of a jack with several lower-ranking cards.

end play To put the opponents in the lead in a situation in which anything led will gain you a trick.

entry A card that allows a partner to get the lead into a specific hand by leading to it.

equal vulnerability When both sides have the same vulnerability.

establish To set up a suit in which a player may play the remaining cards as winners without any danger of losing them to a higher card or a trump.

extra values Points in excess of a minimum opening bid.

favorable vulnerability When your pair is not vulnerable and your opponents are vulnerable.

feature An ace, king, or queen-jack in a suit in response to an asking bid of 2 no trump by responder when you have opened with a Weak Two-bid.

finesse Any play that depends on finding a specific card in a specific place.

first seat or position The dealer, the first person to have an opportunity to make a bid on the hand.

first-round control When a card or absence of cards in your hand assures you of the ability to take the trick the first time a particular suit is led. An ace or a void constitutes first-round control in a nontrump suit in a trump contract.

fit When a partnership has the majority of cards in a suit between the two hands.

five-card major A system of bidding in which you can't open the bidding with 1 of a suit in a major suit unless you hold at least five cards in the suit. Also describes a major suit in which you have five cards, as in "I did not have a five-card major."

follow suit Playing a card of the same suit that is led.

forcing bid A bid that forces a player's partner to bid again, regardless of the quality of the holding in her hand.

forcing no trump Because a 2 level overcall is game forcing in Two-Over-One, if responder has enough points but no suit to bid, she bids 1 no trump, which is "forcing" on opener to bid once more.

fourth from longest and strongest The fourth-highest card in your longest suit. A preferred opening lead when defending against a no trump contract.

fourth seat or position The player to dealer's right, the fourth player to have an opportunity to bid in the bidding rotation.

free bid A bid made by a player with no obligation to bid.

game Obtaining 100 points below the line in one hand or a succession of hands before the opposing pair obtains 100 points below the line in the same hands.

game forcing A bid made by a player that requires her partner to keep bidding until the pair has bid a game.

Garbage Stayman Responder makes a 2 club Stayman bid with a void or singleton club and 5 diamonds and at least 4-3 in the majors with 0-7 HCP, intending to pass partner's response and play at the 2 level in whatever suit opener bids.

get in To get the lead.

grand slam Bidding and making all 13 tricks.

Hamilton A conventional overcall in defense against a no trump opening by opponents. Double is penalty, two clubs shows a one-suited hand, two diamonds shows 5-5 in the majors, two hearts shows five hearts and an undesignated five-card minor, two spades shows five spades and an undesignated five-card minor (*see* Cappelletti, Pottage). This name is used in California.

HCP High-card points. *See* entry following **hearts**.

hearts The second-ranked suit in the deck of cards.

high-card points Total points in a hand determined by adding up 4 points for each ace, 3 points for each king, 2 points for each queen, and 1 point for each jack.

high-low Discarding a higher card at your first opportunity, and a lower card of the same suit at your second opportunity, generally to indicate an even number of cards in the suit led.

hit Another term for double. Sometimes called *smash*, *bend*, or *hammer*.

hold up To refuse to take a trick you have the capability to take.

honors Aces, kings, queens, jacks, and 10s.

interference A bid made by opponents of the opening bidder.

invitational bid A bid asking your partner to bid again, but not requiring her to, generally to game or slam if she has a certain number of points in her hand or to pass if

she does not have that number of points in her hand.

Jacoby transfer A response of 2 diamonds or 2 hearts to a no trump–opening bid requiring partner to bid the next higher suit.

jump To skip a level of bidding and bid the same suit.

jump shift To skip a level of bidding and change suits.

jump overcall To skip a level of bidding and bid a new suit after an opening bid by opponents.

kibitz To watch a game as a spectator without being a participant.

Landy A conventional overcall in defense against a no trump opening by opponents. Double is penalty, showing at least 15 HCPs. Two clubs shows two five-card majors. Two diamonds, hearts, or spades shows you have a good suit in the suit bid, almost surely six or more, and the expectation that you can take six or more tricks.

lead The first card to be played to a trick.

lead up To lead to a higher card.

lead-directing double A double, generally of a conventional bid, made not for penalty but to tell your partner what suit to lead if she has the opening lead.

leading through strength An opening lead of a suit bid by dummy or any lead of a suit bid by leader's LHO, or a lead by dummy's RHO through a strong suit exposed by dummy.

LHO Left-hand opponent.

limit raise A jump raise in the suit first bid by partner at responder's first opportunity to bid, showing at least three cards in the suit and between 10 to 12 points.

loser A card that will not take a trick if led.

major suits Spades and hearts.

making Taking the number of tricks declarer contracted to take.

marked card A card that is known to be in a certain hand because of previous play or bidding.

maximum The highest level of a known bidding range.

Michaels cue-bid Bidding the same suit opener bid in the direct seat or after two passes, showing 5–5 in the majors.

minimum The lower level of a known bidding range.

minor suits Diamonds and clubs.

Moysian fit A 4–3 fit in the trump suit between you and partner.

natural bid A bid that indicates a holding in the suit bid or in no trump if no trump is bid; a nonconventional bid.

New Minor Forcing If your partner opens and you respond by bidding a higher-ranking major suit and your partner rebids 1 no trump, and the suit you bid first is a five-card major with invitational values, you can bid 2 of the unbid minor suit. This shows that your 1 level major suit is a five-card suit with at least 10 HCPs. Your bid of the unbid minor suit is a conventional bid that says nothing about that suit; you may bid it even if you are void.

no trump A contract where there is no trump suit.

off the top To take all the tricks you need or can get without allowing the opponents to get the lead.

on Continuing to play a system after an interfering bid by opponents or after your partner has made an overcall instead of an opening bid. *See also* systems on.

onside A card that's in a position that if you take a finesse, it will win.

open The first bid made on a hand.

opening lead The first lead in the play of the hand, made by declarer's LHO.

opening light To open a hand with less than 13 points.

outside suit A nontrump suit.

overcall The first bid made by opponents of the opening bidder.

overtrick Tricks scored beyond the contracted bid.

partial Bidding and making a contract less than game.

partial stopper A card that, in combination with a holding in partner's hand, might stop opponents from running a suit—like Qx or Jxx.

partscore The score received for bidding and making a contract less than game.

pass Declining to make a bid, double, or redouble when it's your turn.

passed hand A hand that doesn't have a bid and doesn't make a bid.

passout seat After bidding has commenced, the position of the player sitting after two consecutive passes.

play for the drop To lead high-ranking cards hoping that a missing high card, lower ranking than the cards you lead, will have to be played because holder is short in the suit, rather than finessing for it.

point count The total of the points in your hand.

Pottage A conventional overcall in defense against a no trump opening by opponents. Double is penalty, two clubs shows a one-suited hand, two diamonds shows 5–5 in the majors, two hearts shows five hearts and an undesignated five-card minor, two spades shows five spades and an undesignated five-card minor. This name is used in Europe. (See Cappelletti, Hamilton)

preempt A weak bid showing a long suit and not many high-card points.

preemptive jump shift A bid and system that promises that a jump shift by responder shows a long suit and a weak hand, generally a hand with at least six cards in the suit bid and less than 6 points in the hand.

pulling trump See drawing trump.

quantitative bid A bid, usually no trump, that is not conventional and asks partner to bid slam if she's at the maximum but to pass if she isn't at the maximum.

quick tricks A high-card holding that generally promises that it will win a trick, like an ace or a king-queen of the same suit.

renege (revoke) Failure to follow suit when you are able to follow suit.

reopening double A part of the negative double system in which the opening bidder doubles at his first rebid opportunity if his LHO has overcalled, partner has passed and RHO has passed, and opening bidder has shortness in the overcalled suit with support for all unbid suits.

responder Partner of the first person to bid on a hand.

response The bid that opening bidder's partner makes.

restricted choice A theory that states that in the play of the hand, if one of your opponents drops an honor, you should play his partner for the other honor.

return A standard lead by the partner of the opening leader, to lead the suit led by opening leader at partner's first opportunity.

reverse When opener rebids a suit at the 2 level that is higher ranking than the suit with which she opened at the 1 level. Responder may also reverse.

reverse Drury When your partner opens one of a major in third or fourth seat, you need a way to show your good hand. If you have a limit raise for partner's major, bid 2 clubs. This is artificial, stating that you have a maximum passed hand with at least three-card support. If partner has opened light, without a full opening hand, she rebids her suit at the 2 level. If she has a full opener, she bids a new suit.

RHO Right-hand opponent.

Roman Key Card Blackwood aka 3014 A variation on Blackwood in which there are five key cards, the four aces, and the king of trump. A response to 4 no trump Blackwood of five clubs shows 0 or 3 key cards, five diamonds shows 1 or 4 key cards, five hearts shows 2 key cards without the trump queen, and five spades shows 2 key cards with the trump queen.

RONF An acronym for *Raise is the Only NonForcing* bid. A response to a Weak Two opening bid in which a raise of partner's opening suit may be passed, but any other bid by responder is forcing on partner to bid again for one round.

rubber The unit of measurement for home or "party" bridge. The first pair to win two games ends the rubber, and the winner is the pair with the most points scored during play of the rubber.

ruff To win a nontrump trick by playing a trump.

ruffing finesse A finesse taken into a void, with the intention of ruffing if the card led is covered by leader's LHO, or discarding another suit if the card led is not covered.

rule of 2, 3, and 4 A system used to determine when to open a preemptive hand. With unfavorable vulnerability you may open by overbidding your hand by two tricks. With equal vulnerability you may open by overbidding your hand by three tricks. With favorable vulnerability, you may open by overbidding your hand by four tricks.

Rule of 11 If partner leads fourth from longest and strongest, you subtract the number of the card she leads from 11 and the result is the number of cards higher than the card led in the three hands other than opening leader's hand.

run To set up a long suit and take all the remaining cards in the suit without fear of losing a trick by opponents playing a higher card or trumping.

sacrifice A bid you make with no hope of making the contract to keep your opponents from making a game, generally to keep them from making a vulnerable game.

safety play To intentionally lose a trick in order to retain an entry.

second hand low A familiar rule in play of the hand, that the hand immediately to the left of the leader should play a low card.

second seat or position Dealer's LHO, the player with the second opportunity to make a call.

secondary suit A long or strong nontrump suit in which you hope to take tricks after pulling trump.

sequence A consecutive series of cards three or more in a row.

set To fail to make a contract.

set up To establish a suit in which a player may play the remaining cards as winners without any danger of losing them to a higher card or a trump.

shortage points Points added to your HCP for short suits. Also called distribution points.

shuffling The process of mixing the cards after each hand.

sign-off bid A bid that indicates to the partner that the bidder does not want any more bidding.

signals Plays of certain cards to communicate a specific holding of cards in your hand.

simple raise To raise your partner's first-bid suit one level at your first opportunity to bid.

singleton A suit that has only one card in it.

slam Contracting for 12 or 13 tricks.

slow shows A metaphor meaning that keeping the bidding low and bidding slowly shows a good hand.

sluff To discard a card in a suit not led because you are void in the suit led.

small slam Bidding and making 12 tricks.

spades The highest ranking of the four suits in a deck of cards.

splinter A double jump shift showing a singleton or void, an opening hand, and promising four cards in partner's suit.

spot cards The cards from 2 to 10. For example, some bridge players will refer to a card as the "9 spot," instead of just the 9.

Standard American A system of bidding and play taught in this book.

standard leads A list of leads that are considered normal and understood as conveying the same information to all players.

Stayman convention A conventional bid where a response of 2 or 3 clubs to partner's opening bid of 1 or 2 no trump asks partner to bid her lowest-ranking four-card major or to bid diamonds at the lowest level available to deny holding a four-card major.

stiff A singleton.

stopper A card in a suit that will take a trick and protect against opponents running the suit.

strain Spades, hearts, diamonds, clubs, or no trump.

strip To take away the opponents' cards in a suit that they can safely lead without giving you a trick.

strip and end play A method of playing a hand to force opponents to lead into a tenace or give declarer a ruff and a sluff.

Strong Two An opening bid at the 2 level that requires a partner to keep the bidding open until game has been bid or opening bidder has rebid his opening suit. *See* two demand.

support Help in terms of the number of cards in the suit bid by partner. If partner has shown a five-card suit, support should be three cards. If partner has shown a six-card suit, support should be at least two cards. If partner has bid a second suit, promising only four cards, support must be at least four cards.

system A method of bidding where certain bids mean certain things.

systems on An agreement between partners that a system they are playing will continue to be played even if opponents interfere or if a bid is made as an overcall or response and not as an opening bid.

takeout double A double of opponents' last bid suit asking partner to bid her longest suit and implying four cards in any unbid major.

tenace A holding of two cards, one of which is two levels below the other.

tenace position When there is only one card outstanding remaining between a holding of two cards.

third hand high A familiar rule in play of the hand, that the partner of the player making the lead of a low card should play the highest card possible in the suit led.

third seat or position The dealer's partner, the player with the third opportunity to make a call.

tight A holding of only the specified cards. *King–queen tight* means you hold only the king and the queen in that suit and no other cards.

top connecting honors A standard lead of the highest of two sequential honors.

transportation The ability to get the lead back and forth between a pair's two hands.

trick The play of four cards, one card by each player, in rotation.

trump The suit in which the hand is played, which for that hand becomes the most powerful suit in the deck.

two demand An opening bid at the 2 level that requires a partner to keep the bidding open until game has been bid or opening bidder has rebid his opening suit. *See* Strong Two.

Two-Over-One system A very popular system that is used by almost all tournament players is one called the Two-Over-One system. In this system, when a player makes a Two-Over-One response (such as 1 diamond—pass—2 clubs) she promises enough points that the partnership can make a game. Because of this, all subsequent bidding is game forcing, even if it sounds weak.

unblock To discard a higher card and retain a lower card to allow partner to remain in the lead and run a suit.

underlead To lead a lower-ranking card than another card you have in your hand.

unfavorable vulnerability When you are vulnerable and your opponents are not vulnerable.

unilateral bid A bid by a player without regard to what the player's partner has bid or not bid.

Unusual No Trump When opponents open at the 1 level, an immediate jump overcall of 2 no trump shows you have two five-card suits: either both minors, if opponents opened a major, or hearts and the other minor, if opponents opened a minor suit.

up the line Bidding the lower-ranking of suits of equal length first.

void A suit in which a player holds no cards.

vulnerable A pair who has won a game and is subject to greater penalties for undertricks and greater rewards for bidding and making games.

waiting bid A bid that communicates nothing about the suit to the partner who has made a strong opening bid, but just keeps the bidding open so partner may make a rebid.

Weak Two A modern bidding convention in which an opening bid in diamonds, hearts, or spades at the 2 level shows a long suit and a weak hand.

Western cue-bid The opponents have bid a suit, but your side is marked with most of the high-card points. If your side has found a minor suit fit and if it is clear that your side does not have a major suit contract available, a cue-bid of the opponents' suit does not show a control, as do many cue-bids. It instead says, "I think we can make three

no trump if you have a stopper in their suit.” So a 3 level cue-bid of their suit asks partner to bid 3 no trump with a stopper in opponents’ suit.

winner A card that will definitely win a trick, used in evaluating your hand after the contract has been made but before you start play as declarer in no trump.

Yarborough A balanced 4-3-3-3 hand containing no card higher than a 9.

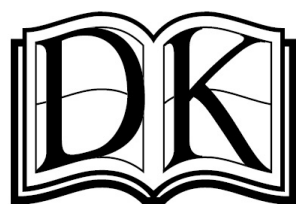
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